Kingdom of Tides

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Explicit

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

Adventure on the high seas. As our hero's travel to the Three Sister's, on an aid mission. Embarking upon a perilous journey to reclaim the throne of Salineas before civil war breaks out. Mermista must either prove herself worthy of her crown to her father, who has lost all faith in her ability to rule. Or retake the throne by force? The Salineas Archipelago Awaits!

Notes

Thank you Bitzy Bee, Pink Storm, Odd Bodkin and Eva Wolf for your comments and all who left kudo's. I am so glad you are all still enjoying the fic. I hope to take you all on yet another rollercoaster of an arc.

Casting Stones

Entrapta

"I found him…he compressed his code into a file packet and transmitted himself out of the Crystal Castle…"

"Download complete, Viral scan is clear, reinitialize Planetary Facilitator…"

"Hordak…" A voice, soft, a pleading whisper floating out to him from beyond this senseless purgatory that surrounded him. A calm, gentle salvation calling him back from the brink.

Consciousness was slow, like struggling to the surface from black water. Slowly, agonizing slowly the darkness warmed to a murky gray and then suddenly. The light was piercing when he broke through, making him groan and wince in pain. It was an unconscious reflex from when he had a living body, he did not feel physical sensations anymore, he did not breathe or eat. Truly he was nothing more than an algorithm now.

A squeal of delight echoed from nearby. Making him turn to greet that familiar sound of joy. As relief and happiness washed over him, when he saw his most treasured friend.

Entrapta was hopping on her toes, before the massive crystal pillar within Galius's main control room.

"You made it!" She clasped her gloved hands together, amber eyes bright with joy. As she gazed fondly up at him, all the fear and tension of the last few days draining away as relief flooded through her.

"I did…thanks to you." Hordak nodded, surveying his holographic body once more. Whole and unblemished by the corruption,

outfitted in his light weight armor that still adorned his body that was pulled into the Sky Tree.

"Brother!" Wrong Hordak's deep voice boomed from the entrance to the control room. The clone rushed across the platform, a huge grin spreading over his once somber face.

"We must speak and prepare a contingency plan if I ever become compromised again." Hordak was all business in moments, glancing to both of his most trusted companions. "We can not ever give in to faulty reasoning again." He chastised, not singling Entrapta out for what she had done. But he was also directing his disapproving glare straight at her as he said it. "You were reckless and could have endangered the whole planet." His pale glowing green eyes quickly softened from anger to merely stern as he held Entrapta's confused gaze, watching her once bright smile crumple into a tight grimace.

Then she huffed, blowing air up into her long bangs in frustration. Her eyes growing moist as guilt and anger waged a war inside of her. She cared deeply for Hordak but his unwavering sense of duty could also be infuriating at times. He wasn't a soldier, a tool to be discarded when he could no longer be of use to the cause. He mattered too and deserved to be saved.

"I couldn't let you go…" She breathed in a trembling voice many moments later. The residual fear and despair she had endured for days, was still heavy in her breathless reply. It sliced through tension between them like a knife. Piercing Hordak's heart in ways he only experienced for her. He hated to see her hurting, despised that his callous disregard for her feelings, once again wounded her.

"Entrapta…." Hordak felt for her. He was not without sympathy for the grief she would have to go through if he was ever to be deleted. But he struggled with it, Etherians were just so emotional. While he was governed by logic and solid reasoning. His emotions had always been stunted, flashing briefly in fits of rage, frustration and….devotion…Hordak's eyes softened even

more, reaching for Entrapta. Who looked so terribly upset, refusing to look at him. Casting her body away from him, shoulders hunched and holding herself. As if the weight of her emotions was crushing her.

"I am grateful…truly. " His voice was tender once again, luring Entrapta to look up once more. She smiled softly, finding Hordak gaze was once again gentle and searching for forgiveness for being so angry.

"I have much left to do to make sure Etheria will be safe and secure in the future." He nodded to her, then directed his firm gaze towards Wrong Hordak.

His eyes held Wrong Hordak's, [We must speak, brother] He communicated to him, with a silent determined stare.

Wrong Hordak merely nodded in understanding. The hive mind may be gone, but the clones' connection to each other was still incredibly strong.

Beatrix

Taking a deep breath, she reached towards the wall full of First Ones glyphs. Amazed at feeling the pressure of the wall against her skin. She was alive again…she could touch, smell and hear the world once again. Slowly closing her eyes she basked in the calm, clarity that now reigned deep inside. Her thoughts were so clear, her emotions no longer burdened by hate, resentment and bitterness.

She had been reborn…purified…given yet another chance to do things right…

She was whole…yet not quite herself…she still held all the terrible memories of her previous life. She could review each moment, the harsh upbringing upon the tundra, the fear of being alone so young, left to fend for herself on the streets of Skara. The prejudice, the injustice and silent loathing she endured at Mystacor. By the other students and the sorcerer's because of her race. The endless struggle to prove herself to her superiors. Her rising ambition for power, for control over a life she never felt safe living. She moved through each memory with a detachment, as if they were just old recordings and not truly connected to her.

Beatrix sighed, pulling her hand away from the wall and proceeded towards the Beacon's main control room. She had sensed the Crystal Castle had intruder's as soon as she regained consciousness. So now she had ''guests' to deal with.

Swift Wind

The surge of magic that exploded through him was beyond intense. It felt just like before when the sword transformed him. The light and pressure washing over his whole body. His muscles felt electrified but there was no pain, all his senses were cast into a realm of pure awareness. He could smell, he could hear, he briefly saw beyond the realm of reality to the endless tapestry of magic that weaved through Etheria. As his body was transformed by the primordial magic of the universe.

Rearing and crying out in exhilaration as he became one with the planet once again. The artificial runestone horn upon his forehead armor was overwhelmed by the magic, melting to the floor. As his true golden horn thrusted out from his forehead, the magic shone from the tip. The piercing beams of light illuminating the room like

a star exploding outward. As the leather headpiece clattered to the floor. His eyes flaring a divine blue. Majestic multi-colored wing's spreading from his flanks. The feather's now holding thirteen hues of color. His hide sparkled a slivery-white, as his mane grew longer, turning a radiant orange as it flowed with power. Hooves twinkling gold, as he kicked this front legs in the air. The room was bathed in divine light, blinding the clones and making them cower in terror. As Liam stood staring in shocked wonder up at him from a nearby power conduit. Clutching his now empty leather pouch, as he had just finished locking in the last data crystal.

When the radiant light faded, the room was purged of the corruption. The crystal pillar's hummed with magic, glowing softly in a pure white. Casting the cavernous room in a gentle, dim light.

"That was intense…" Swift Wind, breathed in awe. As he began cantering around the room and tossing his flowing mane to release the last of the magic energy still pent up in his muscles to a manageable level.

"Welcome to Crystal Castle…how may I help you." Beatrix seemed to float into the room. The long, elegantly glowing pale blue robe, accented by First Ones glyphs hiding her softly treading feet. A glittering cape, resembling stardust fluttered behind her, as she raised her arms in greeting to the group within the Control room.

Swift Wind stopped suddenly before the tall, arching doorway, as she appeared out of. Blinking in disbelief as to how similar she looked to Light Hope. Yet her sharper features were different…he recognized her…maybe…her true identity needled at him.

"Who are you?" Liam confronted her.

Beatrix took a moment, as a slow benevolent smile spread upon her thin lips. "I am the Sorceress of the Crystal Castle." She introduced herself with a small cordial bow.

The clone soldier's turned to each other, passing looks of confusion between them.

The lead clone tapped his com device in his ear. "What happened to the Planetary Facilitator?"

[Hordak is activated within Galius…his code is clear of corruption.] Entrapta's voice responded.

"We have a new program running Crystal Castle." The lead clone advised.

[Odd…] Entrapta muttered, through the device. Followed by the rapid clicking of a keyboard. [Fascinating…] her voice filtered out several minutes later.

[Hordak seems to have transferred all his command protocols over the Beacon to her…I can activate my purge program..it should reset the system…is the Castle still infected?]

[No, the Bird Horse cast a wave of magic that cleared the corruption." The clone advised.

[She-Ra's back…then…] Entrapta muttered, [Is the program a threat?] Entrapta asked, her voice cautious and somewhat distracted as someone else was speaking to her in the background.

"Not at this time." The clone advised.

[Then return to the Sky Tree and bring your wayward brother's with you. I will endeavor to explain what has happened.] Hordak's voice broke through the frequency, taking command away from Entrapta.

The clone merely nodded, pointing at the two clones still kneeling on the floor.

"Take them into custody." He instructed. The other clones moved swiftly, pulling the kneeling clones up to their feet and locking

their wrists behind their backs in metal restraints without any struggle.

“What about Kronis!” Liam exclaimed in sudden fright.

Beatrix’s emerald eye’s became distant. “There are no other life signs within the Castle.” she advised, crisply.

“He probably already escaped, I doubt he cared about anyone but saving his own skin. After making this mess. ” Swift Wind grumbled, finally able to speak his own assessment of the clearly rather shady tech master.

“I don’t believe that, he was just as worried about Adora as the rest of us. We had the best intentions…things just went sideways.” Liam rushed over to the clones, trying to convince the guards to let them go.

“It is fine…” The first clone offered Liam a small resigned smile.

“We must return to the flock.” The second sighed heavily.

“But what are you going to do to them?” Liam scrambled to rush ahead of the troupe of clones now escorting their prisoner’s out of the room.

“That is none of your concern.” The leader of the soldier’s, lightly pushed Liam aside.

“But…” Liam relented, intending on following them out of the ruin. When a sudden flash of light illuminated the room behind him. He spun around to find Spirit once more. The horse was huffing and stomping his hooves in frustration. Trapped once more in the body of a simple horse.

“Adora…!” Liam exclaimed, rushing to a random doorway to continue his hunt for her.

“She is gone.” The Sorceress announced, clasping her hand before her calmly.

“Where did she go?” Liam spun around, his heart was now slamming in his chest. Kronis was gone…Adora was gone…the clones were gone…he was all alone…

The sorceress merely shrugged her shoulder's.

“I…guess I should just continue to Mystacor then..” He bowed his head in resignation.

“Why are you headed there, young man?” The Sorceress asked, her voice gentle.

“I want to become a Stone Mason…I made the portable runestone Spirit had on his head…before he melted it…” Liam grumbled, scratching the back of his head nervously. As Spirit slowly approached him, silently offering to carry him to the floating island. He could sense through their link that Adora was now very far away. He was incapable of aiding her, but he could still help Liam get to where he wanted to be.

The sorceress was silent for a long time, eyes cast downward in contemplation. “I was a Master Stone Mason in my previous life… you seem interested in Rune Stones?” She moved towards the melted remains of his Portable Rune Stone. Crouching down and lightly poking the now hardening puddle of Goddess Stone upon the floor. “I could teach you my craft here, what better place to learn the secrets of the First Ones, then in one of their ancient temples.” She turned and offered him a warm, inviting smile.

Liam was suddenly hopeful again. “Yes! I would like that…” He agreed.

Spirit snorted, he did not recognize this woman’s appearance but her scent was very familiar. He tossed his head, intending on staying here until he could determine if she was friend or foe. He closed his eyes and probed the link he still had with Adora. Feeling her many miles away, exhausted, confused and determined but alive and whole. He was thankful.

Double Trouble

The shapeshifter was sitting cross legged before the roaring hearth in the dorm room back on Mystacor. Several of Beatrix's Stone Mason journal's were scattered around his bent knees. He was lightly rubbing the amulet with his thumb as his yellow eyes scanned a design inside the journal.

"Kitten….I think you solved who created this little trinket." he muttered, leaning forward and closing the journal before gathering it up and heading out of the door.

"Micah…I only have a few protection amulets on hand." Elys was deep in conversation on a communication pad, propped up on his desk when DT rushed into his study in disguise as Lyr. The elderly sorcerer raised a finger and pointed to one of his plush armchairs for the bee hybrid to take a seat.

DT's disguise shifted as soon as they sat down, back into their preferred chameleon shape.

"On such short notice, I am unable to make more. Amulets are complex and intricately crafted; they take time to create. But I do have more simple items such as shield Talismans and I could get you several different types of charm scrolls your soldier's could use. But you would have to teach them how to activate them." Elys nodded, glancing over at an open leather bound book that held an inventory chart. Tucked up tight to his chest behind the pad.

"Fine…I'll take what I can get. Can you send an envoy to Bright Moon with the supplies?" Micah inquired. "I hope to send out the recon teams in the next few days, before giving the order to apprehend the spies."

"Right away, my king." Elys sighed and cut the channel. Before turning to DT with an impatient frown.

"I found our Mysterious Crafter of this amulet." DT grinned triumphantly.

"Who is it then?" Elys crossed his arms and stood up. He had preparations to gather and ship out the magical item's Micah wanted.

"A Master Stone Mason called Beatrix!" DT jumped to his feet, rushing to the old man's desk and slamming the journal down to the open page he was looking at earlier. That showed a floral amulet with several rune stones embedded in the pedals.

"I highly doubt a dead person could craft that amulet in the future." Elys arched a disbelieving eyebrow.

DT's jaw dropped for but a second, before clamping shut. Raising an inquiring eyebrow needing the doddering old man to continue his explanation.

"Beatrix…was once Light Spinner, who became Shadow Weaver… who is now deceased." Elys explained, deflating into his chair once more.

"Is she really dead though…" DT challenged, the sorceress was known for being very cunning and manipulative; her death could just be part of some grand scheme.

"Yes, she vaporized herself with dark magic inside the Crystal Castle just a couple months back." Elys sighed. "She was a truly exceptional Stone Mason, she was brilliant but dangerous. I was more than happy to let her transfer to the Sorcerer Guild. When they finally showed interest in welcoming her within their ranks. I

had hoped they would be able to tame her wild spirit or at least refocus her ambition towards more meaningful magic than Rune Stones. But her obsession with the First Ones only got worse."

"Well…honestly…" DT flapped their arms in exasperation, as they were confronted with yet another 'dead' end so to speak.

"I don't have time to hypothesize any more theories with you about this trinket, right now. But do I dare ask if you have figured out the purpose of the blood craft within the Rune Stones." The old man stood again and shuffled towards the door.

"Yes…" DT pulled out the amulet from his black jumpsuit and touched the dark bluish-green topaz stone that was now in the center. Transforming into a young childlike version of a Horde clone. With long lavender hair that hung loose down their back, with very familiar, very human amber eyes.

"Who is that…" Elys gripped the sides of the door in sudden fear. The child looked like some Etherian, Horde clone hybrid.

"I have no idea, but each one of these stones holds a life." DT touched another stone, a reddish-orange tanzanite gem, with blue facets. Their body morphs fluidly into a blonde magicat kitten that they already knew quite well.

"By the Stars….that amulet defies all the law's of our magic." Elys gasped, in horror, yet he was still highly fascinated by it. The amulet's mysteries just kept going deeper, becoming more compelling the more they uncovered. It truly was a lotus, its secrets unfurling like a flower.

DT transformed back into themselves, eyes downcast in grim contemplations. Wondering if Finn knew the true purpose of this amulet? Or if the child believed it was just to transform into a Thaymorian? Either way, DT had concluded that he held the lives of the future heirs of Etheria in his hands. They had to keep this amulet hidden…they had never before been the bearer of such an important task. It thrilled them as much as it terrified them.

Instinctively, DT tucked the amulet away in their jumpsuit. Yellow eyes resolved to protect it with their life if needs be. Sighing and shaking their head in amazement at how selfless they had become.

The Crimson Waste

The sudden dry heat that slammed into them as they appeared in the barren waste was alarming. It sucked the air out of all of their lungs instantly. Glimmer gasped and clutched her chest, stumbling a few steps away from the others. Both Catra and Adora collapsed upon the sand. With Melog hovering nervously behind them. Scorpia was the least affected, holding Perfuma close with a pincer as the Plumerian Princess' knees had gone weak and she was wilting against the Scorpaini's carapace.

The sun was hanging low on the horizon, it was now only a few hours away from sunset. A dark silhouette loomed beyond the sand dunes, that was the edge of the massive canyon that held the Valley of Lost far within.

"Ok…where are we?" Scorpia scanned the flat landscape of endless sand cautiously. Catching sight of bleached bones, jutting out of the dunes not too far away. Warning her that the Crimson Waste was deadly to most who ventured here.

"I barely know this Kyle…I can't do a pin point teleport on someone I don't know…this is as close as I could get to their location." Glimmer explained, leaning over her knees, gasping for air. Slowly acclimating to the intense heat.

"Adora…where's She-Ra….we need She-Ra.." Perfuma exclaimed in alarm when she noticed that Etheria's Champion was gone.

Catra held Adora against her chest tenderly, as the blonde's head lolled against the magicats shoulder. She was dressed once more

in her white long sleeve shirt with the silver and gold bracer's on her wrists.

"Just get me to Max, I'll transform then." Adora mumbled, barely getting the words out before falling asleep.

Melog grew in size and then crouched down behind them. Catra and Glimmer worked together to get Adora mounted over Melog's shoulder and then Catra climbed on behind. Wrapping an securing arm around Adora's stomach and pulling her close, to keep her settled.

Scorpia pulled out a Tracker pad from her utility belt and tapped the screen.

"Ok…the communication signal is this way!" She pointed to the south west and then started off at a crisp jog. Perfuma nodded, her eyes determined not to hold them up as she jogged after Scorpia.

Glimmer groaned in dread, glancing hopefully over to Melog. "You got room up there for one more?" She asked with a hopeful smile.

Melog chirped and grew in size again.

"Get on Sparkles." Catra chucked a thumb over her shoulder to Melog's back end.

They had only traveled over a few dunes before a huge sand cloud churned up in the distance.

"What's that?" Glimmer pointed.

Scorpia had slowed her jog, allowing Perfuma to catch up. The Plumerian Princess did not have the year's of conditioning, Scorpia possessed as a Horde soldier to run for extended periods of time.

Now they stood a few meters away from Melog staring at the cloud warily.

“Don’t know…” Scorpia muttered, pulling out her tracker pad once more. She wasn't even winded, but Perfuma was puffing, sweat beading over flushed skin.

“It's one of the transports…heading back to Scorpania with the Eternian prisoner’s and Peekablue.” She continued, raising her pincher tip to her ear to activate her com’s.

“Transport team, Report.” Scorpia commanded, her voice was way too loud then it needed to be.

Catra’s ears twitched as she eavesdropped on the conversation, tail thumping in agitation against Melog's flank.

[Force Captain, Grizzlor here. We got Peekablue, he is undergoing medical treatment. Seven live prisoner’s, three deceased and one escaped into the desert, also one allied casualty.] Was the response.

Catra’s ear’s dropped low, as she held Adora’s waist more firmly against herself. The blonde was currently slumped over Melog’s shoulders fast asleep. Snoring fitfully, with drool collecting in the corner of her mouth pressed against Melogs neck. Pooling against the Alien feline's fur. There was no mention of the kitten Peekablue had with him. Her fear and anxiety was spiking again.

“Ok, I am sending you our co-ordinates we are just a few miles north of your route. Adjust course and pick me up. ” Scorpia instructed, before turning towards Melog.

“Well, that’s my ride. I gotta get back to the base and get Peekablue all patched up. I got a rescue mission to the Dark Edge.” Scorpia chucked a thumb towards the now steadily increasing cloud of dust heading their way.

“I’m going with you.” Perfuma reached out and clasped a pincer, staring up at Scorpia. Her eyes full of determination that broached

no argument.

Scorpia smiled fondly down at her. “It’s going to be dangerous.”

“Danger.” Perfuma laughed, “Tera, the Blacksmith. Laugh’s in the face of danger, bring it on!” She smirked smugly.

Scorpia nodded, with a soft, nostalgic laugh. “ Then Linda D’ream will be right there, to provide the muscle.” She flexed, causing Perfuma to coo and clutch her powerful bicep in awe. Then Scorpia walked up to Melog and handed her Tracker pad to Glimmer.

“Those were inside jokes…am I right? ” Glimmer snickered, very curious to hear the story behind those nicknames.

Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck and blushed.

As two orbs screamed overhead.

“That’s Yin and Yang…” Catra watched the two assault Golem’s speed overhead, then hang a sharp bank to the left and zoom back to them. Hovering in the sky above them.

“Looks like Kyle sent an escort.” Scorpia commented.

“Ok, then. Be safe.” Catra leaned down and gave Scorpia a quick side hug around her broad shoulders with one arm.

“You too, Wild Cat.” Scorpia clutched her back with one arm, in a firm squeeze before letting go.

Melog sprinted after the two golem’s leaving Scorpia and Perfuma behind to wait for the transport. That was already coming into view over the next dune, hovering on a cushion of air as the bulky vehicle sped down the sand at top speed towards them.

Melog was quick to accelerate into a full gallop across the open sand. Their large paws cushioned by the loose ground. As they pounded over the barren landscape, dotted by clusters of cacti and dried up tumbleweeds. Their dark maroon fur glowed in the half light, molten colored mane blazing like an inferno.

The shadow of the sandstone canyon's walls began to loom on the horizon. As they cleared the open desert and descended down a loose gravel trail. Heading down the canyon's steep slope and into the expansive valley below. The sun was sinking into the dunes beyond the rough canyon walls. Casting the sky in brilliant colors, as they closed in on the smoking remains of the Eternian's camp.

Catra's stomach clenched in dread at the burnt ruins of the camp. It was a warzone...bringing back painful memories. Of her first battle as Horde Solder, when her strike team had sacked Thaymor. That had her trembling and uncomfortable in her own skin.

The invader's had not gotten too deep into the canyon before getting intercepted by the Strike team, or they had been headed back out from the Valley of the Lost? How did they track and capture Peekablue…was the kitten alright?

Then her worries were derailed as Catra felt the pull to sing, as the last rays of the Sun burned upon the edges of the valley. She glanced over her shoulder, as she felt Glimmer's hands tightened on her hips. The Queen of Bright Moon was anxious, feeling the presence of her source about to ascend into the sky. For the last few days, as dusk descended Catra and Glimmer's voices would mingle if only for a few minutes. As Catra said farewell. While Glimmer continued her serenade of greetings to Etheria's largest Moon, Elidor.

Two sides of a coin, they shared the duality of light magic. The Sun…and the Moon…

But this evening, both sources would feel their Rune Bearer's absence. Neither of them had time to pay their respects. Focused on getting to Max as quickly as possible.

“This way!” Kyle darted out of the fringe of smoldering tents, past the burnt out wreckage of war machines. Waving his arms frantically, to flag them down in the semi-darkness of dusk.

Melog slowed their gait to a steady jog, following Kyle back into the destroyed camp.

“We waited for you…” Kyle began, as they closed in on a small campfire set up in the open area between flattened tents.

Rogelio was squatting by the fire, poking it with a stick rather violently.

“I never lost hope…” Kyle offered Catra a small ghost of a smile.

As Glimmer dismounted, darting for the fire to warm up. As soon as the sun disappeared, a deep penetrating chill settled over the dessert and she was freezing. She had not dressed for colder travel, wearing a light lavender sleeveless tunic tied around her neck and lilac leggings. Her sparkling gossamer cape provided little protection against the cold.

“Adora…we’re here.” Catra shook Adora’s shoulder gently.

“Ok….I’m up…I’m ready….” Adora slurred out groggily, slipping off the side of the giant cat and stumbling rather drunkenly towards the campfire.

Catra quickly scrambled after her.

“For….for….the…Ho…ner of Gayskull…” Adora mumbled, raising her arm over her head as she lurched forward.

“Is she alright?” Kyle inquired nervously. Wincing as he watched Adora nearly tumble right into the fire.

“She’s had a very big day.” Glimmer offered with a sympathetic smile. Which was a horrendous understatement, to say the least.

As Catra darted to Adora's side, catching her and swiftly guiding her gently around the fire and towards a simple gray body bag that lay just behind. The magicat’s brow was furrowed deeply with worry, knowing Adora was in no state to summon She-Ra. But also understanding that would never stop the blonde from trying.

Rogelio was somber, almost stoic as he walked to the front of the bag and began to unzip it. He had walled up all his emotions as the day had gone by. Since he was unable to change Max’s death and needed to stay strong for both Kyle who had been bawling and inconsolable for most of the day and Levi who had become a seething ball of rage.

As the bag unzipped, revealing to both Adora and Catra. Max’s gruesome remains, that had been left to rot under the desert sun all day.

Adora gasped, falling to her knees and squeezing her hands over her mouth. Her blue eyes blurring with tears. As Catra gagged at the foul stench of decomposition that wafted out of the hot plastic. Her own eyes flaring wide in horror, as her hands balled into tight fists. Melog’s fur turned black, their mane and tail turning a smoky blue as her breathless despair and profound rage washed over them.

“Can you save him?” Kyle asked, his voice was soft but hopeful. Slowly approaching them, his hands clasped nervously against his stomach.

Catra sniffled, as tears burned her eyes. Her ear’s fell and her tail wrapped around her waist.

Max had just been alive a few days ago…he had given her the pouch to carry Melog…he had been kind and sweet…he had forgiven her…he did not deserve to die this way!

Why was this life so cruel…to people who least deserve it…

Adora was quick to reach up and clasp her wrist, needing to steady herself as much as Catra. The Magicat’s fists slowly

uncurled at the blonde's grounding touch, threading her finger's with Adora's.

As they were both now trembling with far to many overwhelming emotions.

"I don't know…." Adora breathed, uncertain. She knew the immense amount magic she had used back at the Crystal Castle had drained her in every way.

Glimmer hovered near the fire, sensing that this was a private moment between the bunkmates. She did not need to intrude… and honestly she would rather not see the gruesome remains. One look at Melog confirmed how devastated Catra was at seeing Max's body.

"Where's Levi?" Catra glanced up in alarm, scanning the camp in desperation. She must be completely broken right now?

"She left hours ago…" Kyle began as Rogelio growled and pointed out beyond the camp to the south.

"Where did she go?" Adora's heart suddenly leaped into her throat in dread. Catra's eyes widened as she too began to comprehend where that hot headed, reckless woman would have gone.

"She's going after that Beast Guy who did this to Max." Kyle groaned, scrubbing a hand down his face.

"Ok…We need She-Ra….right now! " Adora nodded and stood up. Her blue eyes fierce with resolve.

"Adora…you're exhausted…I don't know if you can just keep summoning all that magic so close together. You could get hurt… or worse…? " Catra turned her stricken gaze upward, searching Adora's eyes for assurance. That she would be ok. Finding only the firm sense of duty and obligation glaring back down at her, through Adora's steel blue eyes. Which meant that she would do it, no matter the cost to herself.

“I have to try!” Adora growled, as Catra’s body flared with blue flame. Overwhelmed by grief and dread that this was going to turn out for the worst. Terrified that she was going to lose her and unable to make her stop!

Melog moved in close, brushing up against Catra’s back and sitting down on their powerful hunches. Their eyes burning with the same intense blue flame.

Catra had no time to debate the repercussions with her true love.

As Adora bowed her head, stubbornly forcing herself past the foggy exhaustion clouding her mind. She reached deep inside herself for that celestial spark of magic, seeking to draw it out… bathe her hands in that healing light.

Instead she felt the sudden impact of a broom handle across her forehead.

“Did you learn nothing from the Crystal Castle. You can not heal the dead, silly girl…” A low croaking voice chastised her.

Adora snapped her eyes open, finding herself sprawled on her back on the sand. Having collapsed into an unresponsive heap as soon as she reached for the magic.

Catra was kneeling beside her, holding her hand. Her cheeks were wet and rosy from crying.

“What happened.” Adora rubbed her head, ruefully.

“You’ve been unconscious all night.” Glimmer responded tenderly, giving her shoulder a small squeeze.

Adora turned to her other side, finding Glimmer’s face was also wet from crying. Giving the Queen a wide eyed, shocked expression.

“You were barely breathing…I couldn’t hear your heartbeat…” Catra’s voice was breathless and weak. From dealing with hours of fear, thinking that perhaps this time…this time she was going to lose her for good.

Adora turned back…overwhelmed by how relieved the magicat now looked. Her heart is heavy with guilt at putting her and Glimmer through all of that fear and misery yet again. She slowly raised a shaking hand and cupped Catra’s cheek, who instantly turned her face into her palm, seeking comfort.

“You are such an idiot…will you ever learn!” She growled lowly, as Adora sat up with a painful grunt.

Everything hurt…with that bone deep aching that always accompanied summoning She-Ra.

Razz was sitting beside Max’s body, shaking her head slowly.

“I can at least make him whole, poor boy.” She sighed, digging her hand into a pocket of her old pink dress and scattered sparkling dust over his body.

“Razzle…Dazzle.” She muttered, as the corpse flashed briefly. His shredded remains, flowing back together as if his flesh was made of fabric and thread. Becoming seamless and whole once more.

Rogelio had been sitting on the sand close to the body, merely nodded and then slowly, carefully rezipped up the body bag. Silently accepting that there was nothing to be done, that he would be burying another bunkmate soon.

Kyle clutched Rogelio’s arm and buried his face in his bicep, as he heaved great trembling sobs.

“Come with me, dearie. “ Razz crooked her wrinkled finger towards Adora, her owlish gaze stern.

Adora nodded and sluggishly climbed to her feet. Obediently shuffling after Razz, as the old woman led her out of camp.

Ever Widening Ripples

Chapter Notes

Thank you Chimylove and Pink Storm for your comments and everyone who had left kudo's.

Scorpania

Jitsu sat on the edge of his bunk, glowering at his currently locked door. He had been given his freedom, but it was still limited. He had two guards at his side at all times while out of his room. When he was locked inside they were stationed out in the hall. He had only been free of the prison for little more than a day or two. The days were growing cold and the ex-Horde were starting to move themselves back into the operational parts of the fortress. The forge was back up and running, heating the central core of the base. Which had now been converted to a living compound, where his own quarter's were located.

He spent his waking hours up in a small observation room, in the primary operations tower of the fortress. Scouring over old video feeds from across Etheria. From during the last days of the Ethtian Horde and local feeds from within the Fortress itself during Primes occupation. He couldn't offer his new allies the location of the Eternian base, since he had been sent ahead of the rest of the infiltration teams to track down the Shard of Kaydak. Tri-clops had been going to take him back to the base when he had the crystal in his possession back on Mystacor. Now he was listening to taped conversations between the Eternian's hidden base and undercover operatives throughout Etheria. Jotting down notes and descriptions of his old comrades in arms that he recognized from the com chatter and glimpsed during the video recordings. Proving his loyalty to this new regime. Letting it slowly settle in that he was a full traitor now. There was no going back. Whatever waited for him in the future he had chosen his side.

Soon the recon and apprehension operations would commence and Lord Skeletor plan’s here on Etheria would begin to unravel.

He still had no weapons, having to depend on Scorpania’s soldiers to protect him. Which did not ease any of his dread each day. He was not naïve enough to think Lord Skeletor would just let him live. Tri-clops' attempt on his life had been thwarted. But the cyborg’s failure would only spur another would-be assassin to succeed. So to carry Lord Skeletor’s favor, in hopes of earning not only the Necromancer's elusive praise but also grand rewards as well.

Jitsu felt naked without a weapon, defenseless…vulnerable. He had no trust that these young soldiers stationed to guard him were prepared for any of Skeletor’s elite warriors…let alone a high ranking assassin he knew would be ordered to finish him off behind enemy lines. Honestly, he had to admit. That he may have been better protected locked up in that cell then now.

It was only a matter of time before he was taken out. Chuckling bitterly, Jitsu sighed, slapping his knees with his bare hands. After his weeks of integration and incarceration. He was left with nothing, stripped of what remained of his armor. His sword and dagger’s were gone, even his golden gauntlet melted to slag back on that floating island. All he had left that was his now, was raw burned skin, healed and scarred along the arm where his gauntlet used to be. Along with long scars from claws crossing over his chest and shoulders. Memento’s of his lost pride and confidence as a warrior. He had been torched, bloodied and bruised and not given the honor to die in battle. He had become worthless and discarded like refuse. But perhaps, this was his chance to start again to make something worthwhile of himself. To once again be a force of good, like he once was while serving in the Eternos army. He had hope, as faint as it was, it was something to work towards.

He had formed a strange, somewhat antagonistic relationship with his two fellow prisoner’s. He wondered idly how Hoove and Karati were faring now that he was gone. They were rival soldier’s and

had fought a few times over the years when Emperor Flogg and Lord Skeletor's plans overlapped. On one back water world or another. A sharp rap on his door pulled him away from his wandering thoughts.

"Morning, sir. It's time to get going." A young female voice called into his room.

Jitsu heaved a deep breath and with a resigned grunt stood from the low cot. He was dressed now in a white military tank top and gray pants. Simple black combat boots on his feet. It wasn't the clothes that he was used to wearing, but they were functional. With an acknowledging grunt, Jitsu stood and quickly pulled back his long dark hair into a high ponytail. Tying it tight with a hide cord. Before leaving the room to tend to his duties for the day.

The dull green metal halls inside the sprawling fortress, reminded him very much of the interstellar prison he had been trapped in for several years. Before Tri-clops had broken him out. It was very apparent that the inner structures of this Stronghold was a piece meal assembly of ancient Horde warships. With its long, narrow corridors threading through several compact bulkheads. The hatches sealing and purging the compartments as they pass. Keypads and small operation screen's set up before the intersections of hallways. Slender, oval reinforced windows along the outer bulkheads are all designed for enduring the pressure of deep space. The fact that all these high tech spaceships were grounded and cut apart to form some desperate terrestrial base. Just to continue to wage Primes war of conquest was rather humorous and oddly depressing.

How long had Hordak and his battalion of clone troops been exiled here on Etheria? How did they even get here? If the planet was cut off from the rest of the Galaxy in some shadow dimension over a thousand years ago?

Jitsu was so distracted by his wandering thoughts, he didn’t notice the guards were leading him somewhat off course. Until he realized too late that he had obediently followed them into some storage room, in the very bowel's of the base. The naked blubs of the over head lights, hung from tin roof high above. Swinging abruptly on rusty chains that creaked, every time the vents roared with hot hair. The pale glow traveling aimlessly over the poorly lit room, looming with far to many shadows. Cluttered with walls of crates and equipment, no windows...no escape beside the one narrow doorway they had led him through.

“Why did you take me here?” He was instantly on alert, hands raised to defend himself. Quickly taking stock of his location and the stacks of crates and maintenance equipment scattered throughout the cluttered utility room.

“Lord Skeletor is very disappointed in you, Jitsu.” A smooth, deep voice floated like oil upon the air towards him.

Jitsu’s battle instincts jolted inside of him instantly. As the two soldier’s now flanking him unlatched their stun batons activating them. Jitsu's eyes slid quickly between them, as he adjusted his stance to defend himself.

“I haven’t given them anything…” He lied, pretending to be caught off guard by the assassin. Who was still hiding somewhere in the clutter.

“I doubt that…or you would still be locked up.” The voice was low, barely a whisper. “I have been spying on you and this sad excuse for a kingdom for some time now. I know what is really going on. ”

Jitsu clenched his teeth, scanning the crates in a valiant attempt to pinpoint where the warrior was hiding. He needed to keep this assassin talking until he could figure out where they were hiding or even better who he was fighting.

Unfortunately he didn’t recognize the voice at all. Even worse he wasn’t given anymore time to stall, as the two soldiers attacked.

Defending himself from two assailants wasn't difficult. Jitsu’s hand to hand combat was flawless. As he quickly disarmed both of them with several precise chops. Sending their baton’s clattering to the floor, he quickly kicked them out of reach. Then moved behind the smaller, shorter soldier grappling them into a rear naked choke. The helmet loosened and fell off, revealing a sweet featured fox hybrid. It took less than a minute for Jitsu to cut off enough oxygen to render the poor kid unconscious. As soon as he felt her knees buckle he dropped her boneless to the floor. Then moved into a defensive stance as the second soldier engaged.

“Well, done. This fight may prove to be entertaining…” The deep voice cheered, followed by a slow sarcastic clap.

Jitsu’s blood was pumping and his muscles were alive with adrenaline. As he circled the last soldier. This fight already proved to be far more interesting than any he had engaged in for a long time. Since he used more tactical kata's to subdue and render his opponents unconscious then just simply killing them outright.

The soldier of course was Horde Trained so his attacks were easily seen and countered. Turning this fight more into a dance. As Jitsu evaded and struck, taking every opening. To block his strikes and then swiftly sweep out the soldier’s legs. Moving effortlessly in, to grapple them into a scarf-hold on the ground. Before the soldier could pick himself up off the floor.

Jitsu was leaning his full weight upon the man’s chest, arms locked around the man’s neck. Glaring down at the visor helmet in contempt. Jitsu snarled and quickly ripped the helmet off and tossed it aside. Wanting to see the man’s face and ascertain why they were suddenly attacking him.

Were these two traitor’s to Scorpania? Or had Skeletor’s warrior done something to them.

Jitsu scanned the young man’s face. The soldier was barely an adult, he had a scar running down the right side of his face from temple to chin. Gasping in alarm, when he caught sight of the blinking activation light of the control chip embedded in the back of the boy’s neck.

“You're chipping them…” Jitsu snarled, scrambling back up to his feet to allow the boy to stand up. Only to deliver a savage right hook to his chin, knocking him out cold. Primes control technology had been adapted and was polluting the seedy underbelly of the Tri-solar system for decades. Mostly used by would-be overlords who wanted an easier way to control the masses of the planets they sought to conquer and control. It was a sly, cunning plan to regain control of Etheria. Most definitely not concocted by Skeletor. Who never cared about putting any effort into controlling the populace of the planets he invaded, he only wanted to steal their magic relics and now these shards. This desperate attempt at damage control smelled of Evelynn. No doubt, Skeletor was growing impatient with Evelynn's lack of progress reclaiming the shard and finding the Portable Rune Stone.

“Lord Skeletor wanted you dead…but Evelynn seems to think you could still be useful…as long as you are on a leash, that is….you know how enamored she is with owning pets.” The faceless assassin cooed.

Jitsu had barely gotten his bearing after knocking the last soldier out before a dart pierced his neck from behind. Jitsu grunted and then dropped instantly to the floor. As the poison paralyzes him in seconds.

A tall, well muscled figure crouched high above within the metal rafters of the roof. Dressed in all black leather armor with a short charcoal capulet draped over their broad shoulders. A cowl with a hood hides their face, only their eyes are visible. Staring down at him with a satisfied gleam of a predator who had just conquered their prey. They quickly tucked the blow gun away in their utility belt, tapping the com device in their ear.

“Jtisu has been contained, Master.” The deep, raspy, almost irreverent tone the assassin used to address their owner’s title. Was like a submissive whisper spoken quietly to a lover.

[Good, chip him. He will be under my control now. Soon I will bring this whole wretched back water of a planet to heel. I am tired of this slow subterfuge. The relic and the crystal shard will be mine very soon.] Evelynn’s smooth voice echoed from within the assassin’s hood.

Crimson Waste

As the sun struck the horizon, burning the edges of the canyon walls. Alighting the dark sky above in brilliant flame. Catra’s voice ascended into that dawning sky. There were no words, just her melancholic tones floating softly through the warming air. A mournful dirge, ascending towards the rising sun. Empathic magic of love and loss, falling heavy upon everyone who listened.

Adora followed the shallow footprints of the ancient immortal far from camp. Never lifting her head from watching her travel worn leather boots trudging across the pale sand. Her tired eyes take note of how the dawn absorbed the darkness that once surrounded her and within moments faded to nothing. As the early morning took hold upon Etheria.

It was a new day…but it brought no joy. Only a grim reminder of the struggles ahead and her most recent failures.

She couldn’t do this anymore….jumping from one crisis to another with no end in sight. She was tired of fighting, tired of losing people she cared about…just tired…

Her body was sore, her mind clouded by exhaustion and far too many emotions to sort out.

All the strength she once laid claim to as She-Ra was gone, she now felt powerless. Vulnerable and weak, as if she was made of the most fragile glass seconds away from shattering completely.

All of the turbulent emotions she kept under control. Walled up and denied existence behind that armor of duty and responsibility. Was once again exposed, raw, shredded and bleeding. She was barely holding herself together.

"Sit, Dearie." Razz's tender voice broke through her brooding.

Adora glanced up briefly, finding the old woman sitting on the sand, patting the ground in front of her. Adora deflated to the ground in a heap, releasing a long, drawn out breath as she crumpled.

"You have been through a lot over the last few days." Razz observed, reaching down and clasping Adora's hands in hers.

Adora nodded, her chin jerking up and down heavily. As she bit her lower lip to stop it from trembling, she wanted to cry but refused to break down in front of Razz.

"I thought I'd figured it all out…my magic. " She finally breathed out, clamping her mouth shut to hold back the wretched sob that wanted to break free.

Razz's eyes filled with empathy for what she was going through. Sensing her disappointment and unearned blame. At not being able to save Max.

"Why are Sheana and Despara still sealed inside the bracers?" Adora whined softly, pulling her hands free of Razz's grasp. She felt her restraint crumbling, she needed to distance herself, from the old woman's compassionate touch before she broke down. Digging her fingers into the sand instead. Needing to find a tactile distraction, from the merciless ache she was enduring within her heart, body and mind.

Razz sat quietly, her gaze was soft, full of tenderness and compassion.

“Why wouldn't they come to my aid!” Adora shouted in exasperation. As she turned and punched the ground at her side. Her eyes burned with bitter fury. “ Why couldn’t I bring Max back…” Adora swallowed hard, sniffing and wiping a finger under her dripping nose as tears began to fall from her eyes. “Sheana healed Kyle…when he was dying. The magic came when I needed it to bring Catra back…when she died…” her voice faltered into a choking sob as the grief washed over her.

Razz tutted. “They were not dead, dearie.”

Adora scoffed and rolled her eyes, angrily.

Razz remained a patient, silent companion as Adora continued to work through her burdens and her struggles.

“I have done everything they wanted, everything you wanted… I’ve been training and learning…about the magic…about the past, about She-Ra. I am a part of the magic now…I was able to transform before…why not now…” She shuttered, digging her fingers down deeper into the loose sand. Clenching her teeth as she clamped down on the anger she now felt towards Sheana and Despara for denying her their power.

“They promised to be patient and restrain themselves until you are strong enough to wield them.” Razz finally responded, with a small understanding smile.

“I just transformed into She-Ra!” Adora waved an arm outward violently in the vague direction of the Whispering Woods.

“And you were still not strong enough to wield that much magic.” Razz arched an pale eyebrow. “You are paying the price for it now, are you not?”

Adora groaned and flopped backward onto her back to glare up at the warming sky. Refusing to verbally agree that Razz was right.

She felt just as sore and utterly exhausted as she did after channeling the magic from the heart.

"Unlocking a box and wielding the powers within are two completely different things." Razz sighed, leaning forward and patting her hand in sympathy.

"Fine…then I have to get stronger!" Adora shouted, punching the sand with both outstretched arms before abruptly sitting back up. Confronting Razz with her hard gaze, full of steel, blue eyes glaring in fierce determination. To do everything she needed to, to succeed.

"Good, girl." Razz nodded, "Then let's begin again."

Adora cleared her throat and rolled her shoulder's already knowing what was coming next.

Razz grabbed her hand and pressed it to the warm sand, staring up at her with a penetrating stare. "Can you feel the magic. It surrounds us, binds us to the weave of the planet. Close your eyes and …reach for it. "

Adora nodded, she had experienced this lesson first hand as Mara. When Razz was teaching her so very long ago. So Adora closed her eyes and focused upon the tickling sensation of the granules of sand shifting under her palm. Then suddenly she felt a pulse, striking her skin. She gasped, as the throbbing began to beat a steady rhythm against her skin.

It felt like a heartbeat…it was soothing and warm against her hand.

"I can feel it…" She whispered in awe. The steady rhythm, was a strong pulse throbbing against her skin, absorbing into her as every beat. Strengthening her as she tapped into the very Heart of Etheria.

Razz's smile was tender as she lowered her gaze downward, tears pricked her eyes. Watching the glowing motes of magic swirl

around Adora's hand. In the very same, loving way they had for Mara so long ago.

"Good…very good. Adora." Razz whispered, cupping Adora's wet cheeks. As the young woman finally gave into the grief, allowing herself to mourn the loss of yet another member of her family. Razz pulled her in, holding her close as she cried unrestrained into the old woman's shoulder.

"It's not fair…It's not fair…" Adora muttered brokenly, grieving Max.

"It never is dearie." Razz closed her eyes, silently mourning Mara.

"I'm going after Levi." Adora announced, when Catra found her later that morning. Scavenging through the debris around the campsite, looking for clues or tracks to point her in the right direction.

"Then I'm going with you." Catra's response was crisp and clipped.

Adora glanced up briefly, with a thankful smile. Catra offered her a small smile in return, giving her shoulder a quick squeeze of solidarity.
"Well, neither of you are going anywhere without me!" Glimmer's firm voice invaded their sweet moment. As the sparkly queen strode into their midst, carrying three travel packs. One was already hanging on her back, while she held the other two out to them in either hand.

"Rogelio and Kyle left on a skiff, they took Max's body with them. They were going to bury him at the Red Memorial on their way back to Scorpania." Glimmer explained, as Catra and Adora took the packs. "They left us these, saying they're fully packed with medi kits, a sleeping bag, water and ration bars…can't wait to try one." Glimmer cringed lightly.

“They grow on you.” Adora shrugged, adjusting the straps of her pack.

“No…they really don’t.” Catra leaned in and whispered roughly in Glimmer’s ear.

As Melog padded up to them.

Between Adora’s tracking skills and Catra’s keen eyesight. They found a set of fresh boot prints headed south east from the camp. By late morning they were mounted back on Melog, moving at a steady pace back towards the edge of the canyon and into the open desert beyond. Levi had a good day and a half, head start ahead of them, but Melog was covering the distance quickly. Their steady gait churned up the sand as they ran. Their rear paws kicked it up into the air, as their long powerful legs pounded the ground.

Adora had fallen asleep again, before they reached the edge of the canyon. Slumped over Melog’s broad shoulder, snoring loudly. Cata kept her steady, by holding the sides of her hips. Her focus solely on Adora, as her thoughts wandered through childhood memories…silently grieving Max. While Glimmer held onto the Magicats waist from behind with one arm, her staff was at the ready in her free hand. Eyes constantly scanning the flat dessert, alert and ready to protect her friends. They were all now shielded from the sun by tan cloaks. With the hoods pulled up, but it provided little protection. As the sun rose high, burning in the clear blue sky. The heat of the day was quick to ascend into a muggy, intolerable temperature. They would have to find shelter, Melog was already panting and they would not be able to carry them for much longer. Catra was panting and her whole body felt uncomfortably hot and sticky. A low snarl, rumbled from deep in her throat as she remembered how gross traveling by foot in the Crimson Waste had been a couple years back. She was quick to scan the horizon, searching for landmark’s she could use to steer

them to some shade. As Glimmer unlatched her pack's flap and pulled out a pair of Horde issue binoculars.

Adora found herself standing upon the edge of the canyon wall. Watching Melog jogging into the distance, carrying Glimmer, Catra and herself upon their powerful back. The heat of the morning sun was hot on her face, as it glared from the horizon of rolling dunes. Adora found that her muscles still ached, overused and strained from using She-Ra's magic. Her arms and legs felt hard and tight. Unable to stand any longer she crouched down upon the cliff. Listening to her heart, that was racing. As she watched Melog disappear out of sight over a final rise in the far off distance. Quickly swallowed into the embrace of endless desolation that was the Crimson Waste.

She could not help the feelings of depression and grief, not just at losing Max and being useless when she was needed most. But at being abandoned, as she watched Melog fade away into the shimmering horizon.

The illogical connection that she was dreaming, only came into focus. When two very familiar toddler's padded up to her through the dried up, scrub grass that lined this cliffside.

*" **We are sorry…that we could not aid you.** " Sheana sniffled, settling herself down beside Adora and kicking her pudgy legs over the side of the sheer edge of the cliff. Wearing a sky blue dress that hung loosely over her tiny body.*

*" **The Nameless One had been feeding on us, while you were trapped in your memories.** " Despara sighed, mimicking Adora's crouching posture behind Sheana. Dressed in a similar dress as Sheana but deep maroon. The short haired toddler crossed her arms on top of Sheana's head. So she could see over the edge of the cliff to the endless sand below.*

*" **We used all the magic we had left to purify the Crystal Castle, we honestly had nothing left to give you. It will take a long time for us to absorb enough magic for you to transform again."** Sheana reached up and clutched Adora's hand, assuring her that she wasn't weak or not ready to wield them. Then wiggled her butt, dislodging Despara's arms from top of her head. Despara sighed and moved to sit on the other side of Adora.*

*" **But you still need to become stronger, or our magic will continue to tax your mind and body and exhaust you….If you wield us for too long, as you are now…we could kill you.** " Despara explained, her amber eyes firm and unyielding. Needing her vessel to take her warning seriously.*

"I remember…I had to do a-lot of strength training to increase my stamina to wield the sword of protection." Adora nodded, folding her hands between her knees as she glanced tenderly towards the very small and weakened avatar's of her magic.

*" **We trust you…** " Sheana smiled sweetly, as she stood up and pressed a soft kiss to Adora's temple before shimmering away.*

*" **We care for you…and will never allow you to put your own life in danger needlessly.** " Despara explained, before timidly pressing a quick kiss to the very same spot on Adora's other temple. Shimmering away with her counterpart.*

"I care about you too." Adora whispered sadly with a slight understanding nod and faint smile.

Adora groaned in her sleep, huffing out a quick breath. Her body shifted restlessly for a moment before falling unconscious again. Catra sighed and brushed her claws tenderly down the blonde's loosened ponytail. Then returned her hand to Adora's hip to keep her balance on Melog's back. As they headed towards a massive cluster of old bones, that had several tarps stung along the

exposed rib cage. It was an old bandit camp, a way station used by smuggler's before entering the Canyon's. Her two cronies from Huntara's old gang had led her and her troops to it. As they had hauled Mara's old ship back to the Valley of the Lost a couple years back. She was grateful the tattered tarps were still secured to the bones. Temporary camps such as these never last long in the elements.

Whispering Woods

Soon as they descended deeper into the earth, down the narrow damp shaft. The Pixie had flipped up the visor on his helmet so he could see better. As they were quickly encased in total darkness. The only light cast from the lamp shining like a small flickering star from the pixies stump.

"Where are you taking me?" Kronis groused for the hundredth time. Feeling rather unsettled and claustrophobic now that they were so deep underground. His anxiety at being buried alive only intensified as he glanced around the sunless walls, held back from crushing them only by the flimsy webbing of million's of thin fibrous roots. Thicker roots twisted along the floor of the natural tunnel, causing them to raise their legs or crawl over top to avoid being tripped.

"What does it matter, Kin of the Betrayer." The Pixie called back with a small amused laugh.

Kronis groaned and rolled his eyes. "At least tell me the name of my capture?"

"Loo-Kee." The pixie answered, poking the tip of his short sword into Kronis's shoulder blades to emphasize that he was still in control.

“Kronis.” The Tech Master responded, moving a little faster at the sudden prick of the sword against his skin.

What seemed like hours passed in silence. As the pixie led him ever deeper into the planet at blade point. Kronis bided his time, by memorizing their route down this endless set of tunnels. Soon the dry earth became damp, as droplets of water dripped from the roof. The air was dank and moldy, with the scent of rot heavy in the air. Wherever they were, they were near water and lots of it.

It was the thread thin circuitry, glittering from beneath the webbing of the roots along the wall that caught his attention. Crawling over the sides of the tunnel and beneath their feet. Kronis was instantly curious and moved towards the wall, pulling the roots aside to get a better look.

“What did they do…” he muttered in disbelief, eyes narrowing with grim curiosity.
“The First Ones wired the planet…weaponized the magic and nearly destroyed the universe a thousand years ago.” Loo-Kee answered, leaning his sword against his shoulder. Surveying the wiring running through the tunnel, bitterly.

“Mara saved us…she saved the whole universe.” the little pixie continued.

“Mara?” Kronis asked, genuinely intrigued now with the tale Loo-Kee began eagerly. His description of Mara and her heroism, spoke that he had known the previous She-Ra. That they had been friends a very long time ago.

They walked until utterly exhausted, then made a modest camp for the night. Several hours later Loo-Kee nudged him awake and they continued their journey. They traveled in silence for a long time afterward, as the tunnel narrowed. Forcing them to crawl and shimmy their way through the roots and over wet rocks. The ground was damp, seeping into Kronis’ very bones. Making him clammy and cold, his mood souring as they struggled forward ever deeper into the earth. In time the soggy earth dried out,

becoming warmer. Loo-Kee led him to the edge of a cliff, the unknown dark abyss that lay beyond was impenetrable.
“I am not going down there.” Kronis pointed and scoffed.

“Yes, you are.” Loo-Kee commented with a wiry grin. “It is up to you how you go down though.” The pixie shrugged, pointing his sword at Kronis’s stomach and forcefully backing him up towards the edge. “Climb down or fall down? Your choice.”

Kronis scowled. “I doubt that Aion would like me dead.”

“The woods will not allow you to die, the roots will catch you. It will be a rather uncomfortable fall, as you are grabbed and tossed downward like a rag doll.” Loo-Kee chuckled, “I believe I would like to see that, watching you flop around like a plaything would be highly amusing. I think.” Loo-Kee jabbed at him again, his brown eye's twinkling with malicious amusement.

“Nope…No…I’ll climb, I’ll climb.” Kronis acquiesced, falling to his knees and cautiously pulling himself over the edge. The toes of his boots, blindly testing the springy roots webbing down the side.

“Nasty little gremlin…” Kronis grumbled, as he slowly felt his way down. Groaning in disgust as the slimy roots curled and latched onto his wrists and ankles keeping him secure as he descended. Until finally, after an arduous climb downward along the mud encrusted roots of the shaft. Kronis found himself at the bottom of the pit, standing upon a ledge in front of the mouth of an underground cave.

Loo-Kee stood at the mouth, peering inside expectantly. As he seemed to be waiting for permission to enter.

Kronis peered into the cave, noticing that at the very depths a glowing emerald light pulsed. The inner walls had sparkling green moss like lichen clinging to the stone. The moss thickened the further inside it grew.

“Is this Aion inside then?” Kronis asked.

“This is their lair…but it is rude to just enter uninvited!” Loo-Kee squawked and scrambled after him. When Kronis just took off down the dark tunnel.

Kronis could hear movement from the depths of the tunnel. The rustle of a mammoth body and the scraping of scales against stone. It slowed his pace significantly. Allowing the little pixie to take the lead.

The tunnel twisted as Kronis followed. Opening at the bottom into a large cavern.

The light from Loo-Kee’s lamp exaggerated the shadow’s within. Elongating them to an almost grotesque degree. Outlining the strange, monstrous beast now rising out of the gloom before them. The ground trembled as its mammoth body moved over the irregular stones along the cavern floor. It’s multi toned scales glinted like precious metals, hidden beneath a outer armor of rough cracked chitin that looked like the bark of an oak tree.

Aion was immense. In the dim half-light cast by Loo-Kee’s lamp. Kronis estimated that the snake was at least a hundred feet long, easily filling the entirety of this cavern. The strength coiled in the muscles of the serpent's body was enough to drain all the blood from Kronis’s face. Then he saw the beast's enormous eyes, glaring down at him. Beneath a flared hood like the cobra species of snake-men back on Eternia. The glowing green orbs were luminous, like ghostly specters in the night. Holding him firmly in their gaze and stealing his breath.

Kronis was dizzy, falling under the serpent's hypnotic spell. Quickly broken, when the snake focused its hypnotic gaze upon the pixie instead.

“This is the meddling Tech Master, The Woods, warned me about?” Aion regarded the tiny creature. There was power in the low rumble of the beasts voice, echoing all around them.

“Yes, He will help…he has no choice but to.” Loo-Kee advised, his warm brown eyes cooling into a stern resolve as they slid away from the snake to stare at Kronis. Brandishing the sword and jerking the tip at him for emphasis.

Kronis narrowed his yellow eyes, from listening to the Pixies' many war tales as they traveled. He understood that the pixie was a warrior, sharpened and steeled by a thousand years of guarding Etheria's many ancient secrets. He did this great serpents bidding, as a vassal or a friend he did not know. But either way, if he chose to argue or try to escape he would find the end of that sword embedded into his guts without any hesitation.

So he regarded the monstrous snake with the utmost respect. Turning a bowing curtly, in the best courtly gesture he could muster.

“Aion…I presume.” Kronis offered the snake a curt acknowledgement.

“You are correct. I am the Guardian of Earth Magic and the protector of the Whispering Woods.” The snake’s voice boomed in the demi light of the cavern.

“Kronis…I am just a humble Tech Master of the Maker Guild.” Kronis offered with a soft, non-threatening smile.

Aion laughed, his voice causing the whole cavern to tremble violently.

Loo-Lee squealed and widened his stance to remain upright. While Kronis was taken off guard and stumbled backward onto his butt. “Please, do not pander me with your lies. Eternian. I have eyes and ears all across this planet. I have been watching for a long time, your people’s scheming and treachery is not different today as it was a thousand years ago.” Aion sighed.
Kronis’s jaw dropped in alarm. He had no cover story to fall back on, no way to pass himself as a fellow Etherian into this snake's good graces and perhaps gain his freedom. He had no choice but

to be candid and truthful with them. The odd feeling of freedom that washed over him was strangely welcoming.

"You will follow me, then." Aion nodded, turning their bulk and slithering back down the tunnel. Kronis and Loo-Kee followed cautiously behind.

Aion led them into the depths of his lair, in which they found a creepy mass of black tendrils. Curled and writhing as it nestled into a large earthen hole that looked oddly like a natural cradle. The black vines were wrapped tight around a much smaller body than Aion's, but still enormous, forming an almost egg shape.

"I found a young wymling burrowing into the core of the planet. It was gravely wounded….So I brought it back here, I am tending to it as best I can. It holds a fragment of the deep magic, threaded to Vasuki but tainted. Tragically suffering from an unquenchable appetite to devour life. So I have bound it here in the very depths of the woods. Life is plentiful here, so I am able to sate it's hunger enough to keep it calm. But I fear it will not remain sedate for much longer. When it begins to feed again. The quantity of life it will seek to devour will be far greater than just this planet. "

"Then why didn't you just let it die? If its own life is to be nothing but suffering and it could pose that much of a threat to all life in the universe. Why keep it alive?" Kronis thrust an accusing arm towards the writhing creature, cocooned inside the earthen cradle.

"It is but a child. Life is a gift, given. What right do I have to take it away? I will never refuse to aid one of my wounded kin. I, unlike you, have hope that perhaps its hunger can be managed if not purged entirely. " Aion defended, appalled by the Gar's inability to show compassion.

Kronis crossed his arms and narrowed his eyes in disdain.

"I have need of a Tech Master. A control collar has merged with the young wym's body…the containment field that had once

imprisoned it. Has been damaged and become like a second skin upon its body. I need you to deactivate it. It serves no purpose now, but to make the wymling suffer more." Aion commanded, as they curled their gigantic form around the earthen cradle. Illustrating very obviously that they would defend this child if Kronis ever tried to harm them.

"How will you control them, then?" Kronis blurted out in alarm.

"I do not seek to control them." Aion admitted, in a disgusted tone.

Kronis and the Guardian of Earth stared at one another for a long time. A silent battle waging between them.

"Then you will doom us all…" Kronis growled under his breath, casting his eyes downward. Submitting to the Wyrm begrudgingly, as Aion merely stared him down. With glowing emerald eyes that held a fierce predatory shine.

"I have no choice." Kronis muttered, glancing down to the pixie who offered him a brief nod of acknowledgement and a small smirk.

With a grunt, Kronis adjusted his heavy utility belt.

"After I free them from the collar, then will I be set free?" He inquired about the terms of his indenture to this forced task. Intending on getting off the planet and as far away from Etheria as possible.

"Yes, you will be set free." Aion promised.

Kronis pulled out a set of picks from a pouch, as he moved closer to the writhing mass of tendrils. Yellow eyes grim but now driven to succeed.

Shifting Sands

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments and everyone who left Kudos. This update is a week late....life happened. Anyway, here you go. Enjoy.
> "Auncle" I saw it in a comic years ago and I could not remember where. But I believe it was written and illustrated by Astravaganza. Lover her stuff, go check her comic's out. So cute and fluffy and hot!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Crimson Waste

The heat was oppressive, sucking all energy out of them. Catra was curled up next to Adora in the heavy shade provided by the tarps. That were strung up tight over their heads, tied to the tips of the dried out ribs bones of some ancient beast. Long dead, the carcass was picked clean by the predator's that roamed the waste. Left to dry out, the cracks slowly filled with micro sediments from the blowing sand. The bones slowly turning to stone from a thousand years under the merciless sun.

Glimmer kept herself occupied by fiddling with the tracker pad Scorpia had given them. Leaning against one of the empty crates, scattered under the tarps. Once filled with rations and water long since used up by passing mercenaries and merchants.

"Com'on…why won't you work…damn you…" Glimmer cursed, smacking the side of the pad in frustration.

"What are you trying to do, Sparkles?" Catra inquired in a low rasp, slowly waking herself out of her languid half asleep haze.

“I want to send Bow a message but this thing is on the fritz…all I get is static.” Glimmer tossed the pad to the sand and huffed in disappointment. Leaning back against the wooden crate, flipping up her hood and raising a leg up to lean her arm over her knee. Her loose dessert cloak nearly swallowed her whole, hiding her from Catra’s scrutiny as she pouted.

Catra chuckled, crawling over to Glimmer. Ducking her face low to peer into Glimmer's hood, revealing the dower expression on the Queen's bowed head.

“Most of the Waste is a dead zone.” Catra started to explain, offering Glimmer an playful smirk before pressing a claw between the Queen's eyes. Before ducking away to retrieve the tracker pad.

“When the Horde moved in to set up outposts, to occupy the Valley of the Lost. So we could take Mara’s ship. We also setup, signal booster tower’s. Over certain more strategic areas of the desert. " The magicat finished, settling down beside Glimmer with the pad.

“That explains how the rebel pad’s started getting reception when we went on missions into the Waste later that year, to kick Horde Ass.” Glimmer cast her a smug look.

“Yeah, well…you guys being able to communicate was just an unfortunate side effect.” Catra stuck out her tongue, in retaliation.

Glimmer giggled, as Catra leaned back beside her against the stack of crates. Typing in a few command codes. The screen quickly cleared up, as the call started to go through.

“How’d you do that?” Glimmer smiled softly and chuckled.

“I just routed the pad’s communication through the Horde Relay station in the Valley of the Lost. Looks like it’s still functional.” Catra shrugged.

"Thanks, Horde Scum." Glimmer bumped her shoulder and gave her a quick kiss on the cheek.

"Ah…Whatever." Catra scoffed, as she blushed and wiped the kiss off with her wrist. Faking that she found Glimmer's affection disgusting, even though deep down she liked it.

"Where are you guys! Did you get to Max in time…How's Adora?" Bow's frantic voice echoed out of the pad, well before his face appeared.

"We're still in the Crimson Waste, tracking down Levi." Glimmer responded, glancing over to Catra. Finding the feline scratching at the sand with her claws, her tail thumping against the ground anxiously.

"Adora's alright, she figured out her magic. So we got She-Ra back, but she is really tired right now." Glimmer spun the pad so Bow could see Adora sleeping nearby, all curled up against Melog. Completely covered by her tan cloak with the hood pulled up looking like a lump of sand, huddled against the giant lion's belly.

"That's great!" Bow exclaimed.

"But we lost Max." Glimmer finished, in a sad, resigned breath.

"Aw, geez. I'm sorry…" Bow's bright cheerful tone became soft and consoling instantly. As he turned his gentle, empathic gaze towards Catra, silently offering her support.

Glimmer sighed and leaned her head softly against Catra's shoulder, turning the screen to face the magicat. Knowing Bow would want to speak to her.

"Catra…I'm really sorry you couldn't save him." Bow's expression was concerned, his warm brown eyes softened even more with sympathy for the grief and sorrow she was going through.

Catra was avoiding his consolation, averting her gaze towards the ground, a low growl issued from her throat. Her chest ached and

a her eyes were burning with tears, the last thing she wanted was her grief being broadcast back to Bow!

“Yeah, well. He was a soldier, he knew the risks. Arrows.” Catra snarled. “ I am more worried about Levi. She’s gone after the Beast who killed him. I just know she is going to do something stupid and get herself killed, if we don't get to her in time. “

“Where are you right now?” Bow was instantly in action, typing keys on his own tracker pad.

“Just out beyond the canyon’s of the Valley of the Lost.” Glimmer responded, mercifully turning the screen back to herself.

“Alright, I got a lock on your pad’s signal. I am going to fly Darla over to you.” Bow nodded, latching the pad onto his belt before dashing out the utility room he had been rummaging in. Heading straight up to the command deck.

“We are trying to be stealthy here, Arrow boy. Flying a huge spaceship around the desert is not very incognito. “ Catra rolled her eyes.

“Brojee and Caz, have been retrofitting a skiff. Would that work better?” Bow turned halfway down a corridor, heading in a new direction.

“As long as Entrapta hasn’t super charged this one up, I’m willing to ride on it.” Catra advised, shivering at the memory of nearly dying hundreds of feet up in the air. As ‘Darla’s little sister’ rocketed them across Etheria to Mystacor at ridiculously unsafe speeds.

“Nope, it's just a simple skiff with a few upgrades, nothing explody.” Bow chuckled, with a nervous shudder himself at remembering the harrowing ride to Mystacor.

“Ok, well. I can plan Darla’s course across the mainland through Plumeria and then head south to the Red Shore. Come up to the southside of the canyons and dock her at the Valley of the Lost,

then head out on the skiff to get you guys. I should arrive at sundown, that work?" Bow offered, as they watched him sit in the command chair. His finger's already flying over the controls mounted in the arms.

"We can't move till dusk anyway." Catra shrugged, getting comfortable in the shade.

"See you soon." Glimmer gave him a fond, grateful smile. She could always count on Bow to have their back.

Bow nodded and cut the communication.

"I'll take, first watch, try and get some sleep." Catra offered, quickly standing up and moving to the edge of the shade just inside the protection of the tarp. Settling herself down on the sand, leaning herself with a tired sigh against a curving rib bone.

"I think you need it more." Glimmer argued. Half heartedly, as she curled up under her cloak. Neither one of them had slept much. If at all last night, too busy worrying over Adora.

"I couldn't sleep even if I wanted to, Sparkles." Catra commented, keeping her eyes out on the desolate landscape spreading out beyond their shelter. She was suddenly all worked up again. Her mind spinning over far too many worries concerning this Eternian. Plotting out every worst case scenario that may arise when they find Levi. Needing to regain some control the only way she knew by strategizing their next move. So that no one else got hurt or worse killed.

When Catra heard the deep breaths of Glimmer, accenting the faint snores of Adora. She slowly uncurled herself from the entrance and ducked further inside under the heavier shade. Picking up Scorpia's tracker pad and then retreating back to her post at the edge of the tarp. Bringing up the map, watching the red blip on the screen was the transport moving further and further away. As she settled back down in the hot sand. She had grilled Kyle last night about the kitten that was with Peekablue,

wondering if he had seen them or even found any tracks that might show that the kid had gotten away from the Eternian's. Kyle just shook his head, that he hadn't seen a kid. Their intel was that the Eternian's just had Peekablue if a kitten was with him, they were not anymore.

"Where are you…" Catra sighed, thumping the back of her head against the dried out rib bone behind her. Worry about the kitten's whereabouts and well being eating at her anew.

Mystacor

Double Trouble glared at his communication pad in annoyance. It had been nearly a week with no response to any of their messages. Where the hell was Peekablue! The shapeshifter sat at his desk in their hidden lair deep inside Mystacor, tapping a long, elegant finger rapidly against the polish wood surface of the desk. Agonizing over calling the absent Prince yet again, only to receive radio silence. DT wasn't getting paid to keep tabs on the Golden Girl and Kitten. He had been blackmailed into it, so why the hell were they getting so upset? About the absent Prince...In all the years they had been a spy for hire, they always managed to keep a professional distance with their employer. But working for Catra…becoming fascinated by her complexities as they delved into her character. Coming to understand her insecurities, her doubts and fears that she fought against each day. The confusion and heartache that motivated her to become so bitter and cruel. The obsession for glory long denied her. That twisted her, drove her to gain power, to win...to prove that she was better then everyone else. It had changed them…for the better or worse they were still undecided. But for the first time in a long time, they became attached, they began to care. If Catra was happy...in the end they knew that would never happen unless she was honest with herself. They wanted her to break free of the hate and fear controlling her, the self imposed suffering that was slowly crushing

her. Wanted her to realize the truth of her toxic flaws and come to terms with it, move past it. Perhaps in time heal and find true happiness at least contentment. Realize that she wasn't the monster she believed she was, that she had a good heart, it was just wounded. For that to happen, they knew from experience. She needed hear true telling of her inner demon's. Bluntly and with no sugar coating to ease the jagged pill of who she needed to swallow. Honestly, in retrospect. DT realized their words had been rather cruel...for that they would apologize when the time was right.

Double Trouble sighed, bracing their pointed chin on a raised palm, resting their elbow beside the black screen of their pad. Yet again, DT had to conceded they had become attached to Finn at least. Begrudgingly though, DT had to admit they were worried about Peekablue too. It was honestly driving them insane not knowing what was going on. Their relationship with Peekablue was more Freniemies than anything else. But they still didn't want to see them hurt…or worse dead… and the little kitten, that sweet, brave little soul…they deserve to have their mother's back. To grow up in that loving home they remembered.

DT had been working obsessively at uncovering the mysteries of the amulet. It was a much needed distraction to keep their mind off their incessant anxiety about Peekablue and Finn. But once again, they were stuck with a complex puzzle they had no idea how to solve. They understood the reason the amulet was crafted as a lotus, rebirth. The fact that it was conjured through blood craft to hold the d.n.a of Etheria's royal heirs and taken into another dimension…another timeline. From one that was in the process of being wiped out…couriered here by a kitten, who obviously had the power to traverse the crossroads of worlds between the dimension's. But why was Finn made to hide? As a Thaymorian? Why had Peekablue taken them under their protection and whisked them away? The Shard of Kaydak was a highly dangerous and volatile relic. But wouldn't the little kitten and that cursed object have been better protected here by all the Princesses, by their own mother's? Peekablue was never one to divulge his plans, at least not all of its complex parts. Which was

incredibly frustrating not only to them but to Sweet Bee as well… Sweet Bee!

Double Trouble quickly keyed in the id of Sweet Bee's communication pad. Waiting all of two seconds before a haggard and worn out looking Antrineed answered. Her red head scarf that held her curly strawberry blonde curls away from her face was absent. Leaving her naturally voluptuous hair to cascade around her face in wild waves. Her face was smeared with dirt, as if she had just survived a fire fight not too long ago.

"Where is he!" Sweet Bee shouted. Her brilliant green eyes were frantic, yet also burning with a seething fury.

"I was about to ask you the same thing, Sweetie." DT groused, back to square one. They quickly assessed the busy looking dockyard she was currently in. Lined with crates and baying animal's tied up to the back of wooden carts. The hustle and bustle of various sea hybrid merchants and fully armored Scorpania soldiers moving along the docks, peeked their interest. The masts of grand sailing vessels, thrusting proudly into the radiant blue sky. All docked in massive pier's further down the coastline. The eclectic assortment of huge heavily armored Horde frigates and the sleek, wooden Salinean's Schooner's was not lost on them. Sweet Bee was no doubt in Sea Worthy.

"I'm kinda busy right now, DT. If this can wait till later, I'll call you back." Sweet Bee's eyes slide sideways. Narrowing in scrutiny, as the shuffle of numerous feet whispered out of view.
"About to steal a ship I see…well, fine. Have fun…then. Tootles." DT cut the feed with a swift tap on their screen. Left once more to their festering worries.

Anticipating even more aggravation, they gave a half-hearted grunt and keyed in Peekablue's id one more time.

Startled when the pad actually activated, showing Finn squatting behind a set of barrels upon a dock as well. The kid looked just as

haggard as Sweet Bee. With light bruises from poor sleep under his tired blue eyes.

“Finally!” DT growled, as relief washed over them. “What is going on kid?”

“Sorry, Auncle. Been sorta running for my life for the last few days. “ Finn whispered.

“Is Peekablue there.” DT cut right to the point.

“Sorry…he got captured.” Finn’s dark ear’s sank low and tears welled up in their sky blue eyes.

“By who?” DT blurted out…shaking their head in regret as the obvious answer dawned upon them. “Eternian’s.” They finished in a bitter sigh to themselves.

“Yeah, Beastman and a troop of Snakemen. I was scared and alone for a bit as I crossed the dessert. Then I was being hunted by Whip Lash, then chased through the streets of the Valley of the Lost by some bounty hunter’s, but I was saved by a couple of Mom’s old bunkmates..who are pirates…! Who took me to a bar! “ Finn’s eyes widened in exhilaration. “Uncle Hawk was there, I guess they were meeting with him to discuss smuggling cargo from Sea Worthy into Salineas. Anyway, I have a bounty on my head so...." Finn trailed off, glancing to their right as some one moved in beside them. "But Uncle Hawk smuggled me out by hiding me in a barrel, in the cargo of a merchant caravan headed to Sea Worthy. ” Finn explained in one huge breath. Panning the screen over to show the red haired rouge crouching nearby.

“Finn, my lad. Our ride is here.” Sea Hawk never took his eyes off whatever was ahead of them. DT, caught sight of a sail boat in the background pulling into the dock behind them.

“Kay, gotta go. Bye.” Finn cut the call.

“Wait…where are you going!” DT shouted in exasperation at a blank screen. They hated cliff hangers.

Sea Worthy

Finn ducked their head up over a stack of mesh lobster traps beside the barrel. The smell of spoiled fish was heavy in the air. Forcing the kitten to breathe through their mouth. Just ahead was the beach, littered with even more barrels, nets and traps for fishing out in the open water of the sea. The beach had sturdy looking wooden row boats, scattered along the shore. While several more row boats were just coming ashore with loud, boisterous fishermen. All different types of Sea Hybrids, from urchins to squids. The Bay was very busy with several different kinds of fishing trawlers, tugs and sloops. The vivid colors of the many sails on all the tall ships was a glorious sight to behold. Filling the kitten with a thirst for adventure!

"What boat are we going to steal, Uncle?" Finn asked. The eagerness in their hushed voice was very obvious.

Sea Hawk turned briefly, regarding the young kitten with a charming smile and a sly twinkle in his warm brown eyes. Pulling on the tips of his mustache, roguishly.

"That one." Hawk pointed to the Salinean's sloop with a single main mast and flanking wing shaped sails. The brilliant red sails were currently sagging. Since it was out of the wind, and docked at the fishing pier just down the beach. These smaller, less guarded pier's were used by the local fishermen and leisure sailor's from near Sea Worthy. So they were not as busy and clogged with cargo as the commercial pier's further down the dockyard. Making it easy to slip aboard and set sail with out drawing the attention of the crowds or the authorities.

"We need a boat that can be manned by a two person crew, something small, something sleek…I can get that baby to 85

knots easily as soon as we are in the open water. " Sea Hawk boasted with a confident grin.

They crept slowly across the cluttered beach, ducking behind stacks of crates and scattered row boats, as they moved towards the water.

Oblivious of their shadow, that had been tailing them since the Valley of the Lost.

Whiplash watched them from the rooftop of a worn down boat house a little further down the beach head. Laying low on his amble stomach on the other side of the peak. A pair of chunky binoculars pressed to their face.

"Where are you going now?" He muttered, they had been tailing them for the better part of a week. Long since missing the rendezvous, Beastman had threatened him with, in three days time. At this point, Whiplash knew he had to apprehend the kitten without back up and get them and the shard up to the Northern Reach all on their own. Why Lord Skeletor wanted the kitten, Whip Lash no idea...it just complicated things. It would be so much easier just to take the Shard and kill the kid outright.

A clattering uproar behind him. Jarred his attention away, snapping his head back to see what had happened. His warrior instincts kicked in that he may be under attack. Finding his makeshift ladder of crates and barrels he used to get onto the roof had fallen over and lay scattered upon the wooden deck of the pier. Catching sight of that strange cloud of sparkles that had always accompanied every mishap he had endured thus far in his hunt. Whiplash's eyes narrowed in scrutiny as the sparkles faded away…wondering if perhaps he had been cursed by some dark magic? Not only had he barely escaped several heavy object's landing on his head while chasing down that kitten in The Valley of the Lost. Several very important items from his pack had gone missing, like his communication earpieces, more rations than he knew he had eaten. At first he had thought the items were just misplaced, but over time he came to realize they were just gone.

By the time Whiplash had refocused himself on his targets with the binoculars they were gone.

“Dammit!” He snarled, punching the roof. The weathered wood shattered under his fist, instantly trapping it in a hole. He had to wiggle and twist his large hand to free it, now his knuckles were bleeding and his wrist was sore.

Whiplash thumped his forehead against the roof, moaning in frustration. Certain now that he was truly cursed.

While Whiplash was distracted. Sea Hawk had led Finn to an overturned row boat close to the water’s edge. Swiftly, the red haired rouge lifted one end of the boat and slipped underneath. Finn followed suit, ducking under the other end.

Quickly disappearing from sight.

Hawk crab crawled the boat into the water, so he was the same height as Finn. They were so low to the ground and concealed amid the many other boats currently banked along the shore. The crowds of fishermen never noticed them, sliding the boat into the water. Wading into the bay with the row boat over their heads. Hawk angled the bow into the waves, slowly sinking the boat beneath the water. A pocket of air remained trapped under the boat. Between the wooden slates used as seats and the upside down hull of the boat allowing them to breathe. Finn grinned in amazement up at Sea Hawk from their position at the rear. Having hooked both arms over the rear cross bar, used as a seat to keep themselves secured, scared about being pulled away by the undertow.

“This is so cool….” They gushed. “How did you ever figure this trick out?”

“I…it’s a long and rather harrowing story. Perhaps I shall regale you with it sometime. ” Hawk laughed nervously, remembering a narrow escape many years ago after setting Admiral Scurvy’s ship on fire. Diving overboard intending to cut smoothly into the

ocean. To escape the flames and the murderous crew intent on ending him. Instead he had misjudged his leap, tripping over the railing headfirst into a poorly rigged wooden life boat and flipping it over. They both landed in the water and sank, concealing him from the crew currently shooting to kill. Their rifle's lead ball's exploded harmlessly into the water above his head. It had been a perfect blunder of a getaway that afforded him at least a year of ambiguity from Scurvy's crew, since they all thought he was dead. Then his luck had run out in Sea Worthy, during a boy's night out with Bow and Swift Wind...thankfully it had ended well enough.

Finn scrunched up their face in disgust, the submerged sand beneath their bare feet was slippery and hard to grip with their toe claws. Every time they pushed their toes into the mud to stride forward their feet would slip and slide. Their struggle was soon over. As the ground gave way to nothing as the water suddenly became deeper. Finn's shorter legs were now kicking uselessly. Basically treading water under the boat, as Sea Hawk was left doing all the work to propel their makeshift submarine forward. While Finn hangs onto a rear back bar to keep their head above water. As Hawk navigated them towards the pier several more miles ahead. This stealthy plan to steal a boat by sneaking up onto it and boarding from the sea side was brilliant! No one walking along the pier would ever see them. Finn was instantly impressed by their uncle's guile and ingenuity. They didn't see the absurdity of the plan…just yet. As several fishermen and commoner's along the shore near the water's edge. Had curiously watched an overturned rowboat crawl into the water, float for a time and then sink out of view.

The sudden thump of the bow striking something, jarred Finn from their awkward hold around the wooden cross bar. With a yelp they were rocked backward into the water.
"Where here." Hawk turned with a proud grin, that evaporated instantly. Once finding the kitten floundering in the deep water beneath the boat. "Already disembarked I see, good lad." Hawk released the boat. Allowing it to slowly float up to the surface. As Hawk swam downward. Grabbing the struggling kitten by the back

of their red ascot and hauling them upward towards the larger wooden hull of the sail boat above their heads.

They climbed up a set of notches, grooved into the rounded hull and then crawled aboard the stern, soggy and bedraggled. Sea Hawk was in motion in seconds, unfurling the main sail and securing the jib to the mast. Before Finn even got their bearings. It seemed stealing sailboats was a common occurrence for their uncle at this time. The rebel pirate had the boat underway in moments and soon they were headed towards the mouth of the bay. Skimming across the waves on the tip of the keel, as the sails caught the wind. The Sloop seemed to soar over the water, the slender fin underneath the hull cutting through the waves effortlessly.

Finn slung off their now sodden pack and leaned it against the back rail, shaking out their hood from their tan cloak. Eek sneezed and reappeared on their shoulder. Fanning out their wings to dry them. Finn grimaced as they pulled off their cloak, giving their whole body a quick shake, attempting to fling most of the sea water off their fur. Knowing that if they didn't that they were going to be rather uncomfortably itchy if the salt dried in their thin fur coat.

“I need you to climb the mast and be my lookout.” Hawk tossed them an old, dented spyglass over their shoulder. Directing them up the mast with a pointing finger, as he manned the wooden tiller.

Eek leaped into the air, flying away to the riggings. Finn merely nodded as they caught the telescope, scampering from the back deck, over the central cabin to the stern. To the huge mast rising up near the bow. Their speed and agility while climbing was incredible. Hawk smirked with pride at his crewmate, as the kitten swiftly reached the top of the mast. Hanging by one set of hand claws, their foot claws digging into the mast to maintain their balance. They pressed the spyglass to their right eye and scanned the rather clogged bay of ships ahead.

Sea Worthy was a busy port, normally. But never is it this clustered? The cargo ships and Fishing trawlers seemed to be stuck and unable to leave. All of them were in the process of turning around and coming back into port to dock.

Slowly, Finn scanned the view over the mighty decks and sails of a fleet of Salinean Galleon's and Carracks out at sea. Massive Horde warships had formed a blockade just in front of them, at the very mouth of the bay. It looks like the two sides were in a stand off. The dented hulls of the Horde warships showed a recent battle. Yet the Salinean vessels had no damage…as if the Horde had refused to fight back?

"We got a blockade ahead!" Finn cried, lowering the spyglass.

Sea Hawk nodded, eyes narrowing in contemplation.

A sudden explosion rocked the water, sending a bloom of foam and debris several miles into the air from within the Commercial dockyard to the north. Finn instantly brought the spyglass back up. Finding a Horde Warship under attack. Three Antmen were standing on the uppermost deck tossing makeshift bottle bombs at the skeleton crew left on board after it docked. The bombs weren't powerful enough to bust a hole in the heavy metal sheeting of the lower deck. But the explosions had set fire to the cargo left stacked before the gang plank. Sending the crew scrambling to see what the hell was going on. Some of the more level headed soldiers rushed for fire extinguisher's set in cradles along the deck, while other's screamed and ducked for cover.

Finn scanned down the wide plank, finding a lizard man and a Bee Hybrid sprinting onboard. Each one wields glowing rapier's similar to Sea Hawks. Quickly engaging in combat, as two smaller Antmen retreated inside the ship through the command hatch under the black mainsail. The largest of the Ant hybrids dashed down the side stairs, heading for the forward laser cannon.

"What's going on?" Hawk shouted up.

“I think, Sweet Bee’s trying to steal a Horde Warship…” Finn declared, their tone distracted as they watched the skirmish onboard intensify.

Reinforcements from the dockyard were quick to engage. Several strike team’s of Scorpania Soldiers rushed up the gangplank. Jumping aboard just as the ship began to veer away from the pier and the plank fell away into the water. The stabilizing rotor’s spinning to life, as the back engine roared. The massive propeller that jutted out from the lower bulkhead on the stern, spitting up a stream of water as the ship jerked forward suddenly at full speed.

“Whose winning?” Hawk inquired anxiously.

Finn was quiet for a moment, taking in the battle. Whopping and then cringing at the ebb and flow of the nautical combat. The larger Antman was targeting the soldier’s with the cannon, blasting the cargo and sending a few crew off the side with the debris. As Sweet Bee and the Lizard man engaged the rest. Slicing through their stun baton’s and backing them up against the side rails. Forcing them to jump overboard. Then just when Finn thought that perhaps Sweet Bee and her crew had the upper hand. The Cannon mysteriously exploded, sending the Ant man screaming and careening over the bow.

Sweet Bee was in flight in a second, diving over the front of the boat to catch the ant hybrid mid fall. As the vessel had now become a giant ball of flame.

“Uncle…I think our escape mission just changed to a rescue.” Finn shouted down to Sea Hawk.

“On it!” Sea Hawk pulled the tiller sharply, guiding the Sloop in a wide arc across the bay. Heading at top speed back towards the commercial docks.

As they closed in on the inferno, Hawk called Finn back down from the mast. As Finn rushed up to him, Sea Hawk instructed

him briefly how to guide the rudder, by moving the long pole that was the tiller. Then the nearby lever's and secured ropes on hooks that adjusted the riggings to move the boom back and forth. It wasn't much more difficult than driving a skiff and Finn had done that a million times, growing up in the Crystal Kingdom. Then Hawk leaped to the forward deck as the sloop came alongside the now slowly sinking Horde ship. The bow was starting to rise out of the water as the immense weight of the back engines was pulling it under. Sweet Bee was hovering over the flames, frantic to find a place to land on the now fire clogged decks.

Hawk pulled out his rapier and clamped thee blade it into his teeth. He leaped from the hood of the cabin and began to climb the riggings. Just as the upper deck at the stern of the Horde vessel was starting to go under the waves.

Sweet Bee spied the sloop and dived, dropping off Thorne on the lower deck with a grateful smile towards Finn.

"Perfect timing, Kit." She declared, before shooting off into the sky only to dive down into the towering flames now consuming the bow. As Tung Lashor leaped over the side through a wall of flames, hitting the main deck with a forward roll.

"Swing me over, lad!" Sea Hawk shouted, as he hung from an upper rigging near the top of the mast.

Finn pulled a lever on the side of the tiller, swinging the boom towards the flames at the upper deck of the Horde Vessel. Terrified that the main sails were going to catch on fire. As Sea Hawk swung over the flames, disappearing to the sinking chaos on deck. Soon the crew and soldier's that had yet to abandon ship. Began leaping overboard into the sea, swimming towards shore as fast as they could.

Finn swung the boom away from the floundering Horde vessel, catching the wind. The sails billowed and then went taunt. The redirection of the sail's carried the sloop away from the Warship. But Finn was quick to swing the boom again and turn the boat

back towards the now almost sank ship. The sharp, spear-shaped forward deck was still above the waves. But the entrance on the upper deck of the stern, the Antmen had used to get down to the command center, was under the water. The remaining air from the engine compartment, churning up massive bubbles and oily foam to further obscure the water. Finn darted their gaze around the now empty bow finding no sign of Sea Hawk.

Sweet Bee was hovering over the churning water, searching desperately for any sign of Leif and Needle.

As the bow silently slipped under the surface, Sweet Bee finally stopped hovering and landed despondently on the deck of the sloop.

Finn kept circling as the bow disappeared into the depths of the bay. Refusing to give up, their fingers clenching and releasing the thick wooden pole. Claws cutting grooves into the handle, fluffily golden tail lashing anxiously behind them. Dark ears in constant motion valiantly attempting to hear even the faintest sounds of their uncle breaking the surface. As the agonizing minutes continued with no sign of Sea Hawk or the other's.

Sweet Bee had gone to the aft railing, staring in disbelief at the now still water. While Tung Lashor stood beside her, placing a comforting hand on her back. Thorne had retreated to the forward mast, hiding behind the thick pole. As he silently wept for his lost brothers..

"Ahoy, there!" Sea Hawk's exhausted shout echoed from the water several more agonizing minutes later.

Finn was quick to leap toward the aft railing, pulling the spyglass from his pants pocket and extending it. Tung Lashor yelped as the boat suddenly jerked right, with no one manning the tiller. He rushed to the back deck and took over. As Finn scanned the water in wide sweeps.

“Starboard.” Finn pointed out to the sea. Spotting Sea Hawk and the two ant hybrids clinging to a flimsy piece of wood.

“Aye, Aye!” Tung responded. Slowly moving the pole.

In moments they found Sea Hawk hanging onto a piece of wooden flotsam, kicking his knee length black boots to keep the chunk of wood afloat. That looked like a piece of crate from the earlier cargo explosion. Needle and Leif were sitting on one end of the broken boards. Heads bowed, antenna drooping despondently. Thankful to be alive, but upset about losing the boat.

They quickly got them aboard.

Sweet Bee ushered the two Antmen below deck into the center berth of the Sloop. As Finn rushed to Sea Hawk’s side, wrapping their small arms around the man’s waist tight. Hawk patted their head affectionately, as Finn slowly pulled away. The rogue pirate slumped to the deck completely exhausted. Leaning his arms over his raised knees, taking long deep breaths.

“That was amazing!” Finn crawled into view between his raised knees. blue eyes wide in wonder, clearly idolizing the man’s death defying heroics.

“All in a day’s work for a hero.” Sea Hawk chuckled, masking his surprise that he survived yet another daring rescue. With smug bravado, that this kind of daring do was normal for him.

“Thank You, Sea Hawk. You truly are a hero. ” Sweet Bee knelt beside him. Offering him a warm smile of gratitude.

Sea Hawk raised his head with a smug smirk towards Sweet Bee. Tossing his wet bangs over his black bandana roguishly.
“The Star Sister’s were right, you are nothing but trouble.” He commented with a rueful chuckle.

Sweet Bee rolled her eyes and laughed softly, admitting that they may be right.

“We are going to need a bigger boat.” Sea Hawk huffed, slowly rising back up to his feet. As the tiny sailboat closed in once more unto the blockade.

“I may have an idea.” Sweet Bee paced towards the stern, pointing out toward a regal looking Salinean Galleon near the edge of the opposing fleet. The sheen of the wooden decks had a gloriously lush hue, illustrating how much care the crew put into cleaning and maintaining the ship. The sails on the mizzen and foremast were hanging low, while the main mast sail was completely unfurled. The pearl white sail, had the royal crest of a golden open clamshell emblazoned upon it. Brazenly flaunting that it was flagship of the King’s fleet. That was occupying the open water’s before Sea Worthy.

Sea Hawk took in the massive tall ships with shock. Surveying the fleet with new eyes. There were several well armed Galleon’s amid the larger Carrack cargo vessels. It looked like the King was here in full force to invade Sea Worthy and not doubt take the supplies Scorpania had stored in a warehouse along the commercial docks. Mermista was not going to like this new development in her father's vendetta against the ex-horde.

“We’re going to need a full crew. ” He regarded her seriously. More than ready to steal the King’s flagship and spite the pompous old fool. Who had been treating his dearest Mermista so unfairly.

“My crew is waiting just south of the city. When I’ve commandeered a proper ship I’ll send up a flare and they will board under the cover of night.” Sweet Bee answered, her eyes twinkling with excitement.

“So taking that Scorpania vessel was what?” Sea Hawk crossed his arms, figuring out that it had never been Sweet Bee’s true target. Her crew was far too big and honestly untrained to serve on something as high tech as a Horde War Ship.

“Payback.” Sweet Bee snarled, then sighed. “It was supposed to be a distraction…I was going to ram it into a Carrack near the flagship. Sinking the Horde ship was always the plan. Then most of the crew of the flagship would deploy lifeboats, board the Carrack to help speed up the evacuation. My crew and I would sneak over in the chaos and hijack the Royal Galleon. The warship sank a bit too early. ” Sweet Bee eyes were glowing with pride at the unexpected but successful retaliation.

Sea Hawk had no idea what that was about. What grudge did Sweet Bee have with Scorpia? Either way the fierceness in her stare was rather disconcerting.

He vowed then and there to make sure he didn’t piss her off. She was a loose cannon…more then capable of mass destruction, perhaps worse than he was?

Chapter End Notes

Also, the row boat idea came from Pirate of the Caribbean.

Requiem

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comment I love reading them! Also thankyou to all who left Kudo's. I have not been very good at updating regularly lately and I do not think I will be for the time being, got to much on the go. But I will still be updating when I can.

Catra sat slumped against the stark white rib bone, her chin resting low against her breast. Exhaustion and the sweltering heat dragging her down into a dreamless slumber. It was the strange awareness that someone was near, finger's brushing lightly against her cheek. Trying to wake her…that drew her back from that senseless purgatory her body and mind had forced her into. Desperate for just a little bit of peace, after enduring so much stress and sorrow.

"Catra…" A voice, urgent and desperately pleading. Echoed just beyond her hearing, as if slightly muffled from behind some kind of barrier.

It was well past mid-day and the intensity of the sun was beating down upon the desert relentlessly. The clear blue sky allowed the full brunt of the heat to turn the rolling landscape of sand dunes into a piercing reflective shimmer. As she groggily blinked awake, only to groan and slam her eyes shut against the painful glare of the shiny sand.

"Catra…." The voice whispered again, more insistently.

Catra grumbled with disgruntled acknowledgment. Pulling up the hood of her tan cloak to shield her eyes and squinted into the desolation. Still half awake and barely coherent, she noticed a weird effervescent sheen standing just outside their shelter. It had a vaguely human shape, like living glass reflecting the world around it.

“Catra…come on…wake up!” The shape shouted in exasperation.

Catra’s ear’s shot up, as her eyes widened in surprise, her mind finally registering the firm, yet gentle voice.

“Max…what the hell!” Catra shot to her feet, glancing behind. Finding both Glimmer and Adora still fast asleep. Curled up under their cloaks, thankfully unaware of her unwilling nap and not keeping proper guard over them. Yet, Melog was watching her from the deep shade at the back of the makeshift shelter. Catra sigh in relief, the giant alien cat always had her back. Melog glowing blue eyes were keen and aware of the same ghostly presence standing just outside. Their broad nose twitched as they sought to sniff the apparition's scent, long whisker’s quivering with curiosity. She noticed molten crack like stripes upon their dark fur was a vivid blue, along with their flickering mane and tail? That now resembled a halo of blue light more than a flame. Snapping her eyes towards her own body she found her own blue flames covering her body once again.

“Soul Pyre…” She muttered.

“Levi’s in trouble! You gotta save her…” Max pleaded, his shimmering form pointing to the west. “I’ll take you to her, but you need to hurry!”

Catra nodded, rushing to Glimmer and shaking her awake rather violently.

“Wha…no…ok…what…” Glimmer startled and a slew of alarmed, nonsensical words escaped in a rush of breath. As she rocked herself up to a half sitting position. Calling her staff into her hands out of instinct, her soft indigo eyes unfocused and bleary.

“I gotta go, Sparkles.” Catra was already digging into one of the pack’s Kyle had given them.

“Go where!” Glimmer scrambled to her feet, gripping her staff tight.

“I don’t know yet.” Catra admitted, lamely.

Glimmer gasped when she noticed the blue aura around Catra.

“Seriously, what the hell is going on.” She exclaimed anxiously.

Catra rubbed the back of her neck with a small, lopsided smile of acquiescence. One of her upper fangs poking the side of her bottom lip. It was a damn cute expression, that had Glimmer blushing. Quickly ducking her head and lowering her gaze, as her cheeks began to heat up. As she found herself once again, very enamored by the Magicat’s easy charm. This wasn’t the first time she had found herself looking at Catra differently. A strange mix of admiration and allure, that left Glimmer feeling both guilty and excited at the same time. It was confusing so she pushed it aside, focusing on the new crisis before them.

“I glow sometimes…when dead people decide to talk to me.” The hybrid shrugged, her comment was blunt and rather nonchalant about the whole thing.

Glimmer merely blinked to utter confusion and awe.

“Dead…people talk to you?” She breathed.

“Yeah, well. Max is here.” Catra waved a hand vaguely at the desert beyond the tarps. “Levi’s in trouble and I need to go….Now!”

“Then I’m going with you!” Glimmer moved quickly to gather her pack. Completely non-pulsed by the revelation of a rather eerie aspect of Catra’s magic.

“NO!” Catra shouted in alarm. “I need you to stay here and watch over Adora!”

“But…urgh!” Glimmer growled in frustration. “You're running off alone into a dangerous situation…again! I don’t like you not having back up!”

“I can take care of myself.” Catra growled, hackles raising and ear's pinning back. Then sighed knowing Glimmer was obviously upset over her sneaking off into Arxia without her. They had been an investigative duo all over Mystacor for days. She would be pissed too if her best friend left her behind like that, not giving her a chanced to protect her. Finally, pulling out an old Horde badge out of the pack and clipping it to the breast of her cloak. She quickly tapped it to activate the homing signal as she jogged over to the tracker pad. That had been discarded in the sand near the crates, bringing up the map that now had three red dots blinking. The transport was the furthest away now, with Rogelio and Kyle’s skiff closer to their location and finally Catra.

“So Bow can find me.” She tossed the Tracker pad back to Glimmer.

Glimmer caught it, frowning at the screen. Knowing that Catra would do as she pleased and there was nothing she could do to convince her otherwise. But at least she wouldn’t be lost in the desert.

“Ok…but..I need you to keep in contact. If you get into trouble I want to be able to blink to you in a moment's notice.” Glimmer compromised, already digging into the smaller pockets of another pack. Pulling out a set of com’s and tossed one ear piece at Catra. Before tucking her’s into her ear.

“I promise to stay out of trouble. I don’t want you leaving Adora!” Catra caught the com, debating if she was going to even wear it. No doubt, Glimmer would be listening the whole time, monitoring her for danger. If she heard even the slightest kind of disturbance that she didn’t like. Then she would blink to her side to save her. As much as she appreciated having such a caring and devoted friend, she also hated it. At least right now. There were lots of bandits wandering this desert. Huntara had also reported weeks ago. That the monster’s from Beast Island that had crossed to the mainland had flocked to the Crimson Waste for some reason. The last thing she wanted was for any of them to pray upon a helpless Adora after dark. Who was too exhausted to defend herself.

“Adora’s not going anywhere, she is incapable of getting into trouble! You on the other hand are an expert at it! ” Glimmer waved an frustrated arm at the comatose blonde. Reading Catra’s reluctant grimace at the com in her hand. Knowing damn well the stubborn, obstinate, cat was debating taking the com. Too full of pride to want help.

“You're not invincible, Catra. This guy gutted Max with one swipe! You are going to need back up! ” Glimmer continued to rant.

“I won’t let him touch me!” Catra snarled back. “Have a little faith.”

“Catra…please, wear the damn com. For my own piece of mind.” Glimmer grumbled, crossing her arms and glaring stubbornly at the magicat.

“I will not leave Adora’s side till Bow gets here, ok.” The Queen promised.

Catra rolled her eyes and groaned. “Fine.” She had no time to keep arguing. The Queen of Bright Moon could be so overbearing and protective. She was fully capable of handling single combat… with someone bigger and stronger then she was. She had fought and conquered much deadlier foes than this guy anyway. Catra stuffed the com in her ear, mounting Melog as the giant cat padded up next to her and they were gone. Sprinting full speed over the glittering sand, Catra hunched forward over Melog’s shoulder. Her cloak snapping in the hot wind, ducking her head into Melog’s neck to protect her eyes from the cloud of churned up sand.

Glimmer stood at the mouth of the shelter, watching them disappear over a dune far in the distance.

“Be safe.” She whispered.

Dusk was settling in, as the last of the sunlight faded from the horizon. Catra had not sung her farewell, needing to be silent, needing to be stealthy. The sand had slowly been reseeding to more rocky, dried clay terrain. In the semi-darkness now descending around her. She noticed the odd cactus here and there, but also clumps of yellow grass were struggling to survive on hard packed earth.

The nocturnal sounds were coming alive around her, making her heart pick up and her ears flicker as she kept a close eye on the shadow's looming around her. As her eyes began to shine with her night vision.

It was long past dark, the greater Moon's were high overhead, the expanse of starlight seemed endless. As the dessert began reseeding, slowly being absorbed by….a sprawling savannah!

"Serenia…" Catra gasped, as Melog slowed their gait to a stand still at the edge of a sheer cliff. That overlooked the endless flat grassland below.

(Home….) Melog offered, in a hushed voice.

Catra merely nodded. As they both overlooked a grand prairie of wild grass far below. Clusters of Baobab trees sprouted from the golden fields sprawling towards the far off horizon. As the warm wind howled up from the lowland, carrying an array of scents.

Catra raised her chin, sniffing the air with a slowly broadening smile that showed off all her fangs. As nostalgia and comfort washed over her. The mixing scents of small animals greeted her, awakening her instincts. Her pupils dilated, as Melog chirped with excitement. The giant cat's lips, quivering over sharp fangs as they were overcome by the thrill of nearby prey.

Then the heavy iron scent of blood overwhelmed her. Catra snapped her gaze towards a rocky outcropping several miles to the north. The looming silhouette of slender standing stones or

perhaps crystal formation's, since the peeks were sharp and not rounded. Dominated the flat grassland in the distance.

Melog caught the scent as well, lowering their broad head to sniff the ground inquisitively searching for the musky scent of the animal that blood belonged to.

“Let’s go, Melog!” Catra instructed, as Max’s shimmering figure hovered expectantly in the air just beyond the drop off to the valley below.

Melog nodded and began to navigate down a narrow trail of loose, cracked clay into the savannah below. The animals' sounds went silent as the odd, clicking and low howls of monster’s erupted from deeper within the grassland. Causing Melog to slow their gait, scanning the field of golden prairie below cautiously.

“Scorper’s…or Pooka?” Catra breathed, her heart now slamming in her chest with rising fear. The horror stories told in her youth, ringing a dire warning in her thoughts.

(Bow just got here with the skiff. We’re on our way! “ Glimmer’s voice broke into the com line that had been silent for hours. Jolting Catra with a yelp. As soon as she got her heart rate and breathing under control again she responded.

Tapping the earpiece lightly, before snarling into the darkness in aggravation at being startled.

“Great, how’s Adora.” Catra asked, keeping low on Melog’s back in case they were spotted as the cat moved into the savannah. The grass wasn’t tall enough to conceal them and Melog was choosing speed over stealth right now. She sent a question through their link, wondering if they were capable of making them invisible. Melog responded with a sharp shake of their head.

(I don’t know if that is a power I am capable of right now, or perhaps it may have been lost along with my wild magic.) They admitted sadly, in Catra’s mind.

Catra grimaced, accepting Melog's change was more like a rebirth. They no longer had any Krytis magic to draw upon, they were now linked only to her magic, to Etheria.

"Awake and pissed that you took off without her." Glimmer responded, the soft roar of the skiff's engine humming in the background.

Catra gave a resigned sigh.

"Catra…do not do anything reckless till we get there!" Adora's frantic voice invaded the com line.

"I'm not planning too." Catra growled back. "But I can smell blood, so I may not have a choice in a few minutes."

"Wait…where….guys!" Bow alarmed shout was accented by the familiar chime of Glimmer's teleport. Suddenly two women were standing before her a few meters away in the tall grass. The lavender sparkle of Glimmer's magic fading into the night.

"Subtle!" Catra snarled, as Melog came to a sudden stop. Causing Catra to clutch onto their shimmering blue mane to remain seated on their back.

Adora jogged over to Melog. Paying Catra a narrowed look of frustration, as she mounted behind her. Glimmer blew out a burst of air from rounded cheeks. Before approaching more slowly, shaking her staff sternly at the hybrid in silent reprimand.

"Shut it! We have all been through far too many deadly situations when we separate. I am not taking any chances anymore." Glimmer stated, firmly. Reminding each of them silently about their last time splitting up during the final battle with Prime.

Catra nodded, having to admit that as a member of the Best Friend Squad. They all had a track record of getting into some really tight pinches. Glimmer was only being cautious. Their plan's always went sideways, no matter how hard they tried. Leaving them to improvise on the spot to get out alive.

The giant cat broke out into a full sprint as soon as Glimmer and Adora were mounted. Rushing full speed across the open grassland. Their large paws churned up the earth and tossed dried grass into the air behind them. Forming a cloud of fine debris to slowly descend behind them.

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra's waist more tightly, leaning in near her ear. She had noticed the blue aura around Catra's body.

"You're glowing…" Adora whispered loudly in her ear.

"Max, is leading us to Levi." Catra whispered back, scanning the darkness ahead seeking to keep track of the phantom hovering ahead just above the grass.

He was leading them towards the pillars in the distance, that jutted out of the savannah like sharp spears.

Adora finally noticed the crystalline standing stones…they were glowing an ominous shade of scarlet. Turning the bare ground and clumps of grass that surrounded them an eerie amber color. As if the ground surrounding the pillar's was bathed in blood.

The tracker pad in Glimmer's pack suddenly started blaring a warning klaxon. It screamed into the night, jolting all of them with a burst of adrenaline.

"Shut it off!: Catra spun around, alarmed and frightened, causing her to shout and be just as loud as the klaxon.

"Right…right…" Glimmer recalled her staff and swung her pack around to her hip and quickly dug out the pad from the main compartment. Her eye's flying wide in surprise.

"The energy reading in the center of this crystal formation is off the charts! " She exclaimed, just as she tapped the screen to silence the alarm. A low howling erupted from the center of the

crystal formations, growing louder and more intense within seconds. Followed by the strange chittering of monsters hidden in the tall grass just beyond the structures, that they were slowly approaching.

Adora was quick to summon Despara's sword into her hand. The blade emitted a somber amber light that cascaded over Melog's flank. Illuminating the savannah around them for a good few meters.

Melog padded forward a couple more steps before, instinct kicked in. They crouched low, stomach brushing the ground, hiding within the tall grass. Catra, Adora and Glimmer were quick to dismount. Slipping off Melog's flanks to lay flat in the tall grass. In a brief flash of moonlight, Glimmer blinked her staff into her hand. As Catra ignited her flames upon her claws.

"Levi's this way…" Max shimmered just ahead.

"Max, what happened…" Catra hissed, all her instincts were screaming danger.

"Lots of bad, ok…you need to save her!" Max pleaded, his spirit flashed in agitation.

Glimmer noticed the shift in the light, blinking in awe as she briefly caught sight of a silhouette just in front of them. It is familiar, just like when her mother had appeared to her during the battle with her chipped father.

Then Melog growled low in their throat, as the grass parted just ahead of them. The coils of a massive gray serpent reared up around a crystal pillar. A large bulbous head, smooth and round. With a massive collar of frills circling the fringe of the head. Two curved, dark horns protruded from the side of its head. With what looked like wide eyes, staring blankly out at the grassland beyond.

"That serpent was from Beast Island…" Adora whispered, her voice low and husky with dire warning. As adrenaline surged

through her muscles at the memory of how swift and deadly they had been. If it hadn't been for Entrapta's mechanical beast… Michelle. None of them would have made it off that cursed island. The benign almost cute looking mask the serpent wore, peeled away to reveal a sinister black head. With glowing purple slits for eyes, atop a long, sharply angled snout. It opened its boney maw, filled with sharp teeth and howled menacingly into the night.

Catra's ears folded back, tail tucking between her legs. The unearthly call clenching her chest and sucking away her breath. As the sound seemed to invoke a primal fear inside of her.

Shrill caw's echoed from neighboring pillar's as several dark shapes leaped up to the peaks of the formations. A singular red eye dominated their faces, scanning the grass for the intruders. Large predatory mouths full of sharp fangs, dripping with saliva screamed into the night answering the serpents call.

"What are those…" Catra snapped her head to the side, eyes wild in fear.

"Pooka…" Adora groaned back. The most deadly predator's on Beast Island.

As yet another serpent coiled itself around a crystal pillar at the back of the formation.

"Let's just get Levi and get the hell out of here. Before it gets any worse." Glimmer, flicked her wrist vaguely towards the mirrored silhouette that was Max.

"Right…take us to her…Max." Catra inched forward, crawling low to the ground. With Adora and Glimmer flanking her and Melog in the rear.

They circled around, giving the crystal formation a wide berth. Catra and Adora kept a close eye on the monster's currently taking residence inside the circle of crystal pillars.

Glimmer’s eyes went wide in shock, as she caught sight of the last vestiges of a swirling vortex of scarlet energy collapsing into itself.

“You…guys…you guys…” She hissed, pointing to the center of the formation as she set down her staff and pulled the tracker pad out of her pack. Staring at the screen, face growing pale with fear and disbelief.

Both Catra and Adora glanced over their shoulders, shock and awe washing over them as they watched the portal wink out of existence at the center of the crystal pillars.

“A portal…how…?” Adora gasped, her eyes narrowing in scrutiny. As another memory took shape in her mind. Angella had shown her…the moment she first appeared on Etheria as an infant. The Sorceress of Grayskull had taken her through a portal surrounded by crystal pillar’s very similar to this. But it had been in Meadow Lands…at least that was what she had assumed? From the field of grass and wildflowers that had surrounded it. No where on the mainland had looked like that. Until now?

“Well, at least we know what we're looking for now.” Catra growled, reaching behind and snatching the tracker pad out of Glimmer’s hands. Her finger’s danced over the screen as she sent the data they had collected thus far to Entrapta. Before activating the camera, sending the genius princess a video of the crystal formations and the last remnants of the disappearing portal. Tagging a quick text on the link that they would call her soon and not to call them.

Before handing Glimmer back the pad. Catra's communication with Entrapta had been fast and efficient, showing how competent she was as a soldier...as a leader. Capable of gathering intel and commanding the situation almost effortlessly.

The more Glimmer saw the magicat in action, the more impressed she was. She was a natural born leader, taking charge when it counted and always in control.

Adora had shown very similar qualities during the rebellion. But she seemed much more comfortable following order's than giving them.

As soon as the portal disappeared the Pooka leaped off the crystal peaks, chittering nervously as they disappeared into the tall grass. The two serpents hid their true heads beneath their fleshy shields, uncurled from their pillar's and slithered away into the darkness. An anxious hush overcame the savannah at their departure. As the animals once calling out in the open grass now fell still. As the new apex predator's unleashed upon Serenia once more returned to their hunting grounds.

"She's over here…" Max called, waving his arms frantically. His glass-like silhouette standing atop a pile of large stones just beyond the crystals.

With no further threat looming, Catra stood up and dashed for the rocks. Melog darted past, running alongside the magicat.

Adora was quick to follow, both Sheana's shield and Despara's sword now at the ready in each hand. Glimmer sprinted after them, staff in hand. Alert and still on edge, her eyes darting to every shadow and hiding place among the tall grass and the circle of crystal pillar's.

Catra rounded behind the stones, only to come to a sudden halt. At the crumpled body of Levi, curled up into a tiny nook between some boulder's. Her clothes were shredded and soaked with blood. The exposed skin across her torso was mauled horribly. She had deep bite marks upon her thighs, the puncture wounds oozing blood streamed down what was left of her shredded pant legs. A long angry slash ran down the left side of her face, narrowly missing her eye. No doubt she had been attacked by those monster's, out matched and out numbered she didn't stand a chance.

Catra was quick to pull out the med kit from her pack, unwilling to give up on her outright. The magicat, crawled into the nook

sniffing the air, that was heavy with the scent of iron. Her ear's swiveled forward to listen for any signs of life. A heart beat or even shallow breath.

"You touch me…I'll break your hand." Levi moaned angrily, as Catra drew near. Cracking her one good eye open. To glare threateningly at the cat girl.

Catra chuckled, if Levi had enough life to spit threats she was going to be alright.

"Ok, fine. " Catra nodded, just as Adora rushed into the nook. Hovering over Catra's shoulder, blue eye's igniting with magic at the heavily wounded Levi.

"I go this…I'll heal you." Adora released both the sword and the shield back into their bracer's. Calling the magic from Sheana's rune stone into her hands, that began to glow with a warm golden hue.

"Touch me with that filthy Magic and I will kill you!" Levi snarled, kicking out with both of her legs. Intent on hitting Adora in the face as she was now looming over her, far to close. Catra growled and raised a warning arm against Adora's chest, pushing her back. As both women jerked backward at the sudden assault, falling on their butts and crab crawled out of range. As Levi kept kicking out with her legs franticly, intent on landing at least one good hit.

Glimmer stood nearby, with her back to them. Keeping watch on the dark grassland. She didn't notice right away the antagonistic encounter between the old bunk mates. Her indigo eyes snapped to Melog who was standing beside her. As his mane and tail flared a furious red for a moment, then settled down into a flickering yellow flame slowly returning to a blue halo. It was then she glanced over her shoulder, briefly to make sure they were all right.

"For Fuck's sake!" Adora growled, rising to her feet and storming off a few feet away to cool down.

“What happened?” Catra asked, barely keeping her cool. As Levi struggled out of the nook, dripping blood all over the ground. She got herself settled on a flat rock near the pile of boulder’s with much groaning and whimpering of pain. Before reaching towards Catra, beckoning her impatiently to give her the med kit. Catra obliged handing it to her as she stood up, the blue flame around her body growing luminous. Casting the pile of stones around them into a soft, somber light.

Levi was quick to clean the wounds and begin to apply compresses to her thighs and lower chest. Wrapping a long strip of gauze around her head, bandaging the slash on the left side of her face. It was a crude triage, but it would work for a little bit.

“I can send a message to Rogelio and Kyle, that you're alive.” Catra sighed, “You want a pickup? Both them and the transport are nearby?”

Levi ignored her offer, leaning over her knees and staring vacantly at the ground.

“I tracked the Beastman here…I wasn’t going to engage at first. I had just wanted to find out where he was going. But the bastard opened a portal, so I had no choice. I jumped him, all I had was a stun baton and my quarterstaff…It was never a fair fight…then he started to make all these weird sounds and out of nowhere those monster’s attacked me. He got away…” Levi finished, grunting in fury. Shoulder's hunched and her one good eye glaring at the ground in frustration.

“You need more than a med kit, Levi.” Catra advised, making the decision for her. As Glimmer passed her the tracker pad once more. With a few quick keystrokes, she handed the pad back to the Queen. “I got Kyle and Rogelio inbound they will take you back to the base so you can get proper medical treatment.”

“No Shit!” Levi snarled, sarcastically. A seething rage, burning the depths of her good eye. Then with a sigh, she closed her eyes nodding in resignation, she was pretty banged up. She could feel

the ache in her chest from several cracked ribs, the penetrating throb of all the gashes and bites all over her body. Her left eye was swelling closed and she was dizzy and light headed from blood loss, struggling to remain conscious.

"I could heal you." Adora offered, her temper having cooled down enough to approach her again.
"I'd rather bleed out thanks." Levi grumbled, avoiding Adora's stricken gaze by lowering her chin to stare in exhaustion back at the ground. Staying awake through sheer spite alone.

"Whatever…" Catra huffed, her eyes scanning around Levi. Searching for Max, finally finding his mirrored form standing just behind Levi. He had the saddest expression as he looked down upon Levi.

"I guess you didn't save Max." Levi sniffed, bowing her head even further and hiding her tears under her long fringe of dark hair.

"No…He was already dead." Adora admitted shamefully from nearby

Levi nodded, a shaky breath escaping.

"I knew I shouldn't get my hopes up." Levi laughed bitterly.

"I'm sorry…" Adora approached her cautiously, gaze bowed and blue eyes watery with fresh tears.

"Yeah, well. You've never been there before, when I needed you. Why would you be there now." Levi accused scathingly.

"Hey…that's not fair." Glimmer spun around to Adora's defense. She didn't know this girl at all, but she already didn't like her.

Adora's lips thinned in frustration, her eyes glassy with guilt and hurt. With a curt nod, the blonde turned on her heel and walked away. Once again bowed even further by her failures.

Catra heaved a huge sigh clamping down on her seething rage, curling and uncurling her fingers into tight fists at her sides. Struggling to control her own rising temper towards Levi. The girl was grieving and angry, but she had no right to cast all the blame upon Adora. Who had been struggling for days with Max's death and the limitations of her magic. Her anger cooled to grim understanding and acceptance that Levi needed compassion right now. Not another round of chastising over her poor behavior.

"Max…is here, If you have anything you wanted to say to him before he passes on." Catra moved in close and crouched before Levi. Speaking softly for only her to hear.

"I'm not going anywhere." Max declared, sitting down beside Levi on the large stone. His expression was hard, clear eyes staring at Levi with unbridled devotion.

"Figures, the doofus would stick around to watch over me." Levi sighed, her voice wavering with grief. As her shoulders hunched forward, with the weight of her despair.

Catra stared at Max in horror at his proclamation.

"You can't just stay in the living realm…not without consequences." Catra cautioned. Angella's warning about a spirits tether fraying if they stayed in the Living Realm echoing in her mind. If he didn't pass into the Eternal Realm he may become lost…trapped, left to wander Etheria forever.

Max only smirked his hand moving to grip a long, slender tether of silver light. That was attached to the center of his chest. Falling away and fluttering in the air towards Levi's own chest, connecting to her heart.

"I'll be just fine, Cat." He professed with complete certainty.

Catra grunted, knowing damn well it was a false promise. But she couldn't force him to cross over if he didn't want to…could she?

Her eyes darted around for a moment, searching for Angella...perhaps she may have crossed over to guide him as she had for the other cadets? When she saw no sign of the Immortal, a cold dread settled into her stomach. Glancing briefly at Glimmer, heart heavy with the guilt of the secret she bore.

'What is going to happen to him?' Levi asked, a concerned frown shadowing her face.

"He is tethered to you right now but in time that connection will weaken and fray. If it breaks before he crosses over to the Eternal Realm, his soul will be lost here on Etheria. Forever." Catra explained, not pulling any punches.

"Max…I want you to go…" Levi glanced up, long enough to see the worry on Catra's face. Her eyes now wide with fear, darting her gaze about in desperation as if she looked hard enough she would see him.

Max's heated glower towards Catra was scalding. Catra couldn't help but cringe under the force of his accusing stare.

"That was low, Catra…" He growled, "It's my choice to stay, she didn't need to know the risks."

Catra huffed in frustration, refusing to look up at him.

"She is out of her mind and until she stops trying to seek vengeance on my behalf I am sticking with her." Max announced, crossing his arms over his chest stubbornly.

"Max says you were out here trying to kill the Eternian, not track him back to their base." Catra turned to her with an accusing, impatient look. Needing her old bunk mate to come clean and tell them the truth.

Adora returned when she overheard. To hover over Catra's back, glowering down at Levi with her arms crossed.

“Are you out of your mind!” The blonde ranted, “You could have died tonight!”

“Maybe I am.” Levi countered, unwilling to meet either of their fearful gazes.

“Going after him all by yourself was a death wish.” Catra commented somberly under her breath. Bleakly understanding Levi, she had felt the very same way back on the Velvet Glove. She had lost everyone and everything that had mattered to her. So she had made peace with her death then, knowing she had done that one good thing and saved Glimmer, warned Adora about Primes plans.

Levi groaned and raised her chin, staring up at the lonely starlit sky her lips trembled as misery and grief washed over her anew.

“Max is not going to let you throw your life away, Levi.” Catra continued, her voice low and full of compassion for what the girl was going through. Glancing over to Adora briefly, her mismatched eyes shining with gratitude for what the blonde had done. That she also refused to allow Catra to die, she had come for her, saved her, stuck by her…through the hard times until she came to her senses once more. Began to move forward, began to heal.

“So, What? You want me to promise that I’ll just go home…” Levi’s voice broke, unable to finish as a sob tore threw her. “Without you..” She breathed out in a hushed growl. “I can’t do that…I can’t…” She shattered at that moment, wailing miserably into the night. Catra was quick to tenderly pull her off the rock and into her arms. Holding her gingerly, as Levi curled into her chest. Hiding her sorrow from the other’s. As Max’s spirit held her from behind, cocooning her trembling body in his ghostly aura. Refusing to let go as well.

Adora lowered her eyes, grief and regret tempering her anger. Glimmer understood the loss of a loved one, a few silent tears

rolled down her cheeks. As she continued to keep watch on the grassland beyond the crystal formation.

Rogelio and Kyle arrived just before dawn. Levi climbed on board the skiff without saying a word. Catra and Adora watched her settle down beside the body bag on the forward deck, with heavy hearts. The feline held Adora's hand tightly, as the blue aura finally ebbed as the skiff pulled away. Melog's coat turned inky black as their mane and tail shifted to a gray smoky mist. Glimmer was standing on the top of the rock pile, humming softly as the moons departed the sky and the flames of the sun began to glow upon the far off horizon.

It was then Catra's mournful voice, ascended into the dawn.

"Let me see you smiling…are you still with me?"

"Forever, beside me."

"Let me hear your laughter…are you still with me?"

"Forever, beside me."

"I shall never forget you, are you still with me?"

"Forever, beside me."

"I shall always remember … your love.."

"Forever, with me. The memory of you will sustain me."

"Until we are together again…"

Hello, Future

Chapter Notes

> Sorry, it took so long to update. I barely have time to write right now. So updates will be erratic for the time being. Thank you for your patience, enjoy.

"Fascinating!" Entrapta's high pitched cry of glee, rebounded from within the Crystal Pillar's for yet another time. Her exclaimions had been on constant repeat for the last few hours. Her enthusiasm for discovery was as explosive as ever. The scientist was eager to unlock yet another secret of the First Ones' ancient tech.

It was mid morning, the sun overhead, here on the grasslands beyond the desert was not as brutal. Warming the lush savannah in a gentle heat that is more muggy and less arid. That was much easier to handle. The air was spiced with the scent of dry grass and the sweet smell of magnolias. The white noise of insects whispering just beyond the pillars.

Glimmer wandered amid the formations, with her horde issue comm pad held high over her head. As Entrapta took readings. The Queen of Bright Moon, as always, was dutiful in helping her friends scientific endeavors. But not all that interested in it, releasing a huge yawn as she walked in figure eights amid the crystal pillars. She had not gotten a good night's sleep in days and it was starting to drag her down.

Bow was currently crouched at the base of one of the outermost crystal's pillar's. Magnifying glass arrow in hand, studying the complicated facets at the base. That was etched in First Ones glyphs, just like what was in the walls within the beacon's. The sunlight glinted like shattered glass over the thousands of various peaks and angles of the scarlet crystal's, glowing like ruby's amid the field of wild grass.

"These crystals…are not natural." He concluded.

“No, they are similar to a Rune Stone…First Ones tech!” Entrapta announced, as Glimmer drew near the Archer, her curiosity peaked.

“The crystalline matrix inlaid beneath the various pillars…is similar to Darla’s interdimensional drive system…These crystal formations are plugged into the planet itself, siphoning the magic necessary to power…a complex, multi-dimensional gate of unimaginable power…completely independent and contained within this formation…capable of inter planetary and off world transportation……” Entrapta kept postulating, her voice growing both with exhilaration and volume.

“So this Beast guy could be anywhere right now? Perfect.” Catra quipped, bitterly.

Bow paid her a tentative glance, at her disgruntled growl, finding the Magicat standing in the center of the formation, glaring at the ground with her arms crossed. Ears pinned down and tail lashing violently. Melog was prowling at the outskirts of the formation, their body a deep maroon. Their mane and tail sparking with fearsome amber flames, as they sniffed the ground. No doubt picking up the residual scent of the Eternian.

Entrapta paid Catra’s huffy attitude no mind, totally focused on the data scrolling on her screens back on Beast Island. “I could extrapolate the frequency used for the vortex and track it to where the portal’s exit point is?” Entrapta offered helpfully, with a shrug.

Bow was highly empathic and quickly caught on to the unspoken tension between Entrapta and Catra. He wondered what the heck happened?

“Yes…find out where he went and then, Shut it down…shut them all down!” Adora ordered, storming towards Glimmer. Her eyes glowing red, as she gripped the hilt of Despara’s sword tight. A threatening humm vibrating from the slender blade.

Entrapta’s image on the pads screen was alarmed by Adora’s sudden shift in desires but quickly nodded.

“As you wish…but just so you understand..once I shut them down…I can’t turn them back on…at least not until I fully understand how they work..” Entrapta admitted with a nervous chuckle, she would never arrogantly mess with portal's ever again.

Catra’s mouth fell open in surprise, at Adora's sudden reversal. Whatever she had learned within the Crystal Castle had her much more cautious in regards to Eternian’s now. She no longer harbored any intention of ever using a portal to go to her homeworld it seemed. A part of Catra was relieved, happy even. That Adora had chosen Etheria’s well being over her curiosity about Eternia. Yet another part of her was saddened, that Adora had to choose. Forced to delay perhaps indefinitely on knowing her family because it was just too dangerous.

“We need to regain control…here. These Eternian’s are dangerous, we don’t know what their agenda is. We can’t let them get the Kaydak Crystal and I do not want them with any means of a quick escape.”

“With Jitsu’s help, we have begun to uncover all of their hidden spies. King Micah and Lonnie are assembling recovery teams as we speak.” Bow offered, his voice cracking with nerves at the vengeful aura glowing behind Adora’s eyes. She had not known about the spies and this new piece of information was only making her more on edge.

“Good, I’ll interrogate each one of them personally.” Adora nodded with a snarl. The sword shimmering away into the silver bracer once more. As Catra silently moved in next to her. Gently slipping her hand into hers, clasping their fingers together. Needing to ground Adora and draw her turbulent emotions away from the rage and fear now governing her. The red ebbed away from her irises, as soon as they touched. Then Adora released a long, trembling breath.

“I can’t allow them to have their way with Etheria ever again.” Adora whispered, her voice low and rough with trepidation.

“Did you find your answers?” Catra asked softly, pulling Adora away from the other’s to cool down.

Glimmer watched them depart, brow furrowing with worry. Her thought’s spin as well, with catastrophic theories concerning these Eternian’s. Who had so far infiltrated their society, stolen their people and plundered not only their resources but sought the most dangerous relic Etheria had.

As soon as they got beyond the formation. Adora turned, reached out and held Catra’s other hand. Halting their progress and confronting the magicats, concerned eyes with a small, resigned smile. Then released one of her hands, leading her onwards towards the pile of field stones.

“Yes, Hordak gave me so much more information about She-Ra… who is the Champion of Etheria, the conduit of Protection. I have a sacred duty to maintain a connection with the four other primal worlds in the Tri-Solar System. To not only balance the magic of Etheria but also the primordial magic of the universe.“ Adora began, as Catra listened attentively. As she explained all about the other core planets and their champions. Explaining sadly since the magic that created Zie-Thy had been destroyed along with the Planet Krytis. Hordak believed there was no way to ever balance the universe again. That thanks to the First Ones tampering, what remained of the universe's magic is doomed to spiral out of control until its inevitable destruction. Adora cringed, trembling with the grim finality of what she had been told.

“There’s always hope, nothing is beyond saving Adora. Not even the Universe.” Catra released her hand and moved in front of her. Reaching up tenderly she cupped Adora’s cheeks, offering her a warm smile of assurance.

“You taught me that.” Catra pressed her forehead to Adora’s. “We don’t give up, one day we will go back out there into space to

return the magic to the universe and Krytis will be our first stop!" The feline declared, as a surge of joy and gratitude washed over her link with Melog.

(I will hold you to that promise, my friend.) Melog brushed up against Catra, as they walked past. Settling down on the ground near a large flat stone. An incredibly loud and pleased purr rumbling from deep in the large cat's throat.

Catra pulled away from Adora, gentle laughter bubbling softly from her chest as she stared fondly down at Melog. Leading Adora over that flat stone and sitting them both down. Before leaning over and stroking the giant cat tenderly and giving them a good scratch behind their ears. Humming contentedly as she felt the warm pulsing of Melog's mane against her skin. They had changed so much in appearance, but the core of their comforting aura was still the same.

Adora grinned softly down at Melog, marveling for a moment how much they had changed. Taking a couple breaths to center herself and organize her thoughts before continuing. She couldn't understand the exchange between Melog and Catra, but she could interpret by their similar purr's and the lazy swing of their tails, that it had been a loving exchange. Melog was good for Catra, a loyal and caring companion she could alway count on to be by her side. She would never be alone again and would always have someone to talk to and seek support when she needed it. Adora was so grateful that fate had bonded these two together.

"Melog looks so powerful now…" Adora mused, stroking the giant lion at her feet from head to tail.

"They no longer have any Wild Magic, just my Etherian Fire Magic." Catra shrugged, as an explanation for their change in appearance.

Adora scratched Melog under their chin, "A fresh start."

Melog's purr grew louder and more pleased, stretching their chin upward eagerly as Adora scratched harder. Their glowing blue eyes closing slightly in blissful abandon, basking in Adora's enthusiastic affection.

"Yeah, I guess. We are both discovering what our magic is capable of now." Catra chuckled, her cheek flushing as she felt Melog's pure enjoyment over their link. As the tender moment slowly faded back into silent reflection.

"I was able to relive Mara's life and I learned so much about the First Ones. They were scared and driven by fear, seeking to weaponize the magic of not only Etheria but on the other core planets as well. They didn't care about the damage they were doing to the planets or the people they were hurting, wanting only to save themselves from Prime. " Adora's blue eyes were distant, focused on the past.That had been so full of pain and heartbreak and very little hope.

Catra clasped their hands once more, giving her hand a squeeze urging her to continue. While Adora never looked up from the ground, her stare was distant. As she retold everything. It was a harrowing tale of hardship and misery that had ended in tragedy. But through it all, Mara had been brave and loyal to her own beliefs. She sacrificed everything including her life to make sure Etheria was safe, that it had a future.

Adora told her about Senator Keldor's attempt to weaken and enslave Despara using the Shard of Kaydak. How her fury had been corrupted by the Nameless One. Destroying the lab and devouring everyone within and turning Senator Keldor into a living corpse. How Light Hope had been corrupted by that rage virus, twisting her mind to set off the Heart of Etheria. Doing the Nameless Ones bidding, seeking to destroy all life and bring upon the infinite silence.

"The Nameless One was able to manifest here on Etheria… through the Shard of Kaydak." Adora shuttered, haunted by the image of a black, void deep shadow looming like death incarnate.

Followed by the stagnate stench of rot and decay. A single red, hateful eye in the center of its featureless shaped head. The pupil fractured as if it was shattered "We have to make sure these Eternain's never get their hands on that shard. " The sinister aura of that demon, still so powerful even in memory that it made her blood run cold with dread.

Catra swallowed hard, at Adora's statement, her own memories of the Nameless One overwhelming her. A terrifying presence, both dark and seductive consuming her. So similar to Pirmes's light, enslaving her body and soul. Yet with Prime she had been unwilling…with The Nameless One…she had allowed him to claim all of who she was and recreate her in his image. All for the sake of revenge…

"Senator Keldor…he… bowed down and called the Nameless One, lord…" Adora turned to Catra in alarm, jolting the magicat out of her dark reverie.

"Keldor…was like an Acolyte of Prime? The clones referred to Prime…as Lord Prime…treated him like he was some kind of God. " Catra muttered, focusing on putting the pieces together instead. Refusing to allow those tortured memories from the portal power over her again. Cringing as in pain, as several other traumatic memories from the Velvet Glove surfaced in her mind to torment her instead. Hissing and squeezing Adora's hand so tight her claws punctured the blonde's palm, drawing blood. Adora sucked in a sudden breath, gritting her teeth refusing to let on that Catra had unintentionally wounded her. Catra groaned, releasing Adora's hand and scrubbed her own hands down the back of her head. In an attempt to reassert self control and tamp down on the fear overwhelming her. Talking about the Nameless One, about Prime… Keldor…was setting off all of her fight or flight instincts. Her heart was slamming against her chest and she was panting struggling to keep the panic at bay. Melog growled and shook themselves violently, trying to shake off the ill feelings washing over them through their link.

" Entrapta downloaded the personal logs from Arxia on my com pad, I've been going through them for the last few days. Senator Keldor was up to something…The Heart of Etheria Project was something more than just a weapon to defeat Prime. I'm certain of it. But it was not just him, the Senator's on other core planets were part of it too, this Galactic Council…They were controlling all the planets at the time?" Catra mused, quietly. Reviewing the old Gar's logs in her mind. While Adora merely nodded, having lived those days through Mara.

"I agree, Mara didn't trust him…near the end, the core planets were all rebelling against this Galactic Council and banishing the Senator's off world. I don't know if Keldor made it off the planet in time before Mara moved Etheria into the shadow dimension." Adora offered, subtly healing her palm under the guise of clasping her hands together between her legs. Feigning the need to detach and gather herself as well. She felt sick and her skin was crawling with unsettled feelings.

Catra's eyes were darting around the ground, her mind racing as she gathered all the information they had so far, putting more of the pieces together.

"Keldor must have made a pact with the Nameless One…" Catra muttered.

"What do you mean?" Adora was scared, her stricken blue eyes turned to Catra. Desperate for her to explain.

The Nameless Ones voice once more echoing inside her memory. A dire and ominous warning.

(Those who thirst for power, the ones who crave to dominate and control. Will come to me for aid and I shall offer them what they seek. As it was in the beginning, as it will be again. I shall infect the willing souls. In so doing, I shall subjugate the living to my will. Until I am once again whole. Then I shall devour this universe,

bringing an everlasting peace with my ultimate silence. You can not stop what is eternal.)

"When I was…'destroyed' in the portal reality. That demon spoke to me, offered me power…so I also made a pact with the Nameless One…" Catra cringed, curling in on herself. As the weight of her confession sought to choke her voice. She was so consumed by grief and rage over Adora's betrayal yet again. That even in that unstable reality of her own creation. Adora wouldn't stay, didn't choose her, didn't want to be with her. Adora's disregard of her subtle acts of devotion yet again. Broke her and she had given up then, let go of the cliff and welcomed death. To be rid of the pain of knowing that she didn't matter to the one person she loved the most.

It was then the Demon had spoken to her, offered her everything she ever wanted in exchange for her soul. She was reborn as a servant of the Nameless One, so she would have the power to make Adora pay! Hurt her as she had been hurt, again and again.

"He…He seduces you…when you're at your weakest… prey upon your worst nature and then consumes you…" Catra shuddered, squeezing her eyes tightly shut as she cowered into herself. Shoulders hunched, muscles clenched trying to defend herself from the malicious echo of violation from those memories, so similar to the trauma of Primes assault.

"The Nameless One…he was in there with me." Adora's ground out, in a hushed growl of revulsion. Unable to comfort Catra just yet, so focused on her own trauma. She had been so scared, as the darkness began to consume her. The ominous preparatory feeling of being hunted, as she shared Beatrix's memories. Until she was drawn away into that twisted, corrupted version of the Fright Zone. Where she had been tormented by her sins, tortured by her endless failures… stabbing deeply into her very soul. Until she was crushed under the weight of her guilt. Her spirit lay broken within the void, curled up in a pathetic ball, wallowing in her misery.

The echo of all their voices…(**You Must Let Go**) haunting her. All the people she had failed were giving her the means to protect herself. Yet she had been unable to heed their words.

"He was…." Catra admitted. She had been protecting Adora's magic from that demon, until the blonde found her way out of the corrupted memory core and into the thread of Dream Scorpia had created.

"That demon was…devouring my magic…consuming my soul. " Adora breathed, slowly raising her eyes to confront Catra. Her whole body trembled, as she rubbed her arms and shuddered so very disturbed by what had happened to her. As she felt the phantom tendrils of corruption entombing her once again. The searing pain, like ice coursing through her veins. Gnawing and slowly devouring her as that demon sought to corrupt her soul. A deep, malicious laugh of triumph as it finally won vibrating throughout the void. Defeating the last of Adora's defenses, shattering her persona completely as she finally gave in to its darkness.

"I understand now…why you were so scared that he may still be corrupting you." Adora swallowed hard, the lump of fear and shame nearly choking her. Turning to regard Catra thoughtfully.

Catra bit her lip, to stop it from trembling, as a silent tear escaped the corner of her golden eye. Trailing down her cheek, only to be caught by Adora's hand. As she tenderly reached up and cupped her face. She rubbed it away with her thumb, the love and empathy for what she had gone through in the portal reality clear in her searching gaze. As they now shared one more trauma.

"I will never let his darkness touch you again." Adora's eyes hardened with conviction. Her proclamation was as earnest as ever.

Catra offered her a watery smile, closing her eyes and turning into her caress with a soft grateful sound. Reaching up and

clasping her hand over top of Adora's as a gentle purr rumbled from deep in her chest.

"I'll always protect you, too…dummy." Catra opened her eyes and laughed in relief. Thankful to have survived yet another encounter with that overwhelming evil.

"The Crystal Castle is purged now of corruption." Adora released a held breath of reassurance, turning away and casting her eyes upward to the warm, clear blue sky. It was over…for now…they had escaped that vile demon. They could use this time to prepare and the next time they met they would defeat him…or at least keep him trapped in that void for eternity.

"Good…" Catra nodded, leaning into Adora and resting her head against her shoulder. Adora wrapped her arms around her holding her close, as she pressed a soft kiss to the top of Catra's head. Catra turned enough to tuck her face into the crook of Adora's neck, taking a deep sniff, relaxing into Adora's comforting scent.

"I love you." Adora whispered, nuzzling her behind an ear.

Catra hummed in contentment, it had been an intense few days. This tender lull between them soothed the anxiety and heartache, at least for the moment.

Catra turned her head, pressing a soft kiss beneath Adora's chin returning her declaration with silent affection. Her tail curled around Adora's waist, as she basked in the sweet tenderness of their embrace.

"We are all going to get through this…Adora…together." Catra professed.

Adora glanced down, her worries were instantly put at ease, by the confidence that shone in Catra's eyes. Never had she seen or heard such a positive outlook from the magicat. Being around the princesses had really changed her for the better.

“I know we will…” The gentle warmth in Adora’s smile was a balm for Catra’s own worries. Bolstering her emotional stamina past this last tragedy.

Better days were on the horizon, she just had to breathe and keep fighting.

The retrofitted skiff was a sight to behold. The metal hull gleaming under the setting desert sun, just beyond the crystal formation. All sharp angles and sleek lines. It resembled an elegantly designed sailboat, one would see on the shores of Salineas. With a broader more robust bow and slowly sloping stern. A large cabin sat in the center of the main deck, With a slightly open forecastle jutting up from the tip of the oval shaped cabin. Embedded ladder’s led up from either side of the cabin to the smaller platform above. The command deck was framed in slightly sloping windows, with a rounded canopy for a roof open at the back. A mariner style steering wheel and consoles similar to what was on Darla’s were mounted in the front against the windows .The forward deck had a huge foil mainsail mounted on a thick mast, along with a smaller fore sail. There were now eight thrusters at the back instead of four and sloping fins jutting out on the aft and starboard sides of the boat. Under the fins were stabilizing rotor’s like what was on Runners back at the fortress. A short keel extended out of the bottom of the hull, as the larger skiff hovered on a cushion of air. The engine was off and the low hum of the blades was whispering amid the more erratic chirps and clicks of insects nearby.

“That is not even a skiff anymore!” Catra exclaimed as she grinned in wonder at the obviously far more comfortable ride ahead. Melog gave an excited chirp from beside her, padding over to the on ramp jutting out from the side of the bow.

“Nope.” Bow offered, hands on his hips. Beaming with pride at his handy work. He had worked for weeks with Brojee, Caz and Drissi on this new model of skiff. Using a bunch of metal scrap and

vehicle parts from the Fright Zone. Along with pieces of starships from thousands of other worlds that the Scrapper's had brought with them from their destroyed ship.

Realizing after his trip to Mystacor, transporting a larger group. That they needed a bigger, more versatile craft then the glorified hover dingy…those Hordes Skiffs were. This was just a prototype though, it would need to be put through its paces. Before he could submit the building plans to the Maker's community for approval.

"Come on, let's get on board." Bow waved, jogging up the ramp and heading down the main deck to a ladder that would take him up to the top steering platform at the head of the cabin.

Catra followed him dutifully, eager to learn how to drive this flying sailboat. She enjoyed piloting and she was good at it. Her highly tactical mind and reaction speed was faster than any of the other's in the Best Friend Squad. Which made her the obvious choice to fly Darla out of some very tight and intense situation's during their time getting back to Etheria.

Adora lounged below deck, the whole cargo hull had been converted into a living space. With two beds in tiny rooms tucked at the back of the bow behind wooden doors and one bedroom tucked into the cone at the stern. The middle of the compartment had a kitchenette with a dining table surrounded by booth seating on one side with a small bathroom on the other side. The cabin was lit warmly by pot lights overhead in the roof. It was quaint and comfy and Adora was instantly enamored by it. She had woken up in the bed at the cone of the cabin just last night, getting a trial by fire tour of the ship. As she was forced to navigate through the foreign compartment in the dark. Following the tense voices of Glimmer and Bow above deck. Barely reaching the forward deck in the dead of night, before Glimmer hopped down from the command plateform. Startling her as she landed on the deck beside her and blinking them away to Catra's side.

Adora was sitting at the table, comm pad in hand waiting for her call to go through. Needing to check in on Liam.

Glimmer was busy in the kitchen, the sharp sounds of food prep echoing in the roomy cabin. As the connecting tone of the pad accented the clinking of dishes.

“So this Liam fella?” Glimmer offered, pulling down a bowl from the overhead cupboards above the stove.

“He wants to be a Stone Mason and was traveling with me back to Mystacor.” Adora offered, her index fingers framing the pad tapping anxiously.

The light conversation paused, when the screen flashed as the call connected.

Liam’s face appeared, along with Spirit's long nose hovering over his shoulder. The horse had thrust his head through the flap of the tent, as soon as he heard Liam taking a call. Liam looked bleary eyes, jaw unshaven and thick dark hair uncombed. Adora had no idea about time zones and didn’t take into account that perhaps the young man had been sleeping.

“Liam!” Adora exclaimed, smiling in greeting. As a warm, relieved feeling washed over her from her bond with Spirit.

“You're ok!” Liam cried back, shaking the pad in his excitement.

Adora could make out the hide panels of the large Plumerian yurt they had hauled with them for shelter.

“Are you still in the ruins?” She asked, as Glimmer appeared at her elbow. Curious to see what this Liam fella looked like.

“Yeah” Liam breathed, turning and offering a small smile to Glimmer.

“Hello…Catra?” He offered curiously.

Glimmer laughed and shook her head, “Nope, Glimmer.”

“OH! Jeez, sorry your majesty!” Liam's eyes were suddenly fearful, his face gone pale at his perceived disrespect of royalty.

“It’s alright.” Glimmer forgave him easily, it was an honest mistake. Not everyone on Etheria knew what she looked like, even though the name of the Queen of Bright Moon was far more known. She quickly moved out of view to tend to her meal once more. Wanting to leave Adora to her conversation with the young man. Only to freeze midway out of her seat. When Liam explained why he was still hanging around Crystal Castle.

“The Sorceress of Crystal Castle is mentoring me in Stone Masonry.”

“Sorceress?” Adora glanced up, eyebrow arching skeptically, catching Glimmer’s eye. Glimmer immediately sat back down and shuffled back into view beside Adora in the booth.

“Yes, her name is Beatrix…and wow…she’s brilliant. It’s only been a couple days and I’ve already learned so much about Rune Stones.” Liam gushed.

“She appeared in the Memory Chamber when we were trying to figure out how to free you from the corruption.” Glimmer offered, “She looked like, Light Spinner…she was a big help…we wouldn’t have known how to use our magic to free you otherwise.”

Adora nodded, “I met her in the Memory core..the Crystal Castle absorbed her…final thoughts when she died. She helped me find Catra and…Shadow Weaver…saved me yet again.” The complexity of her emotions regarding her old guardian, was still a storm inside her. Yet it had calmed just a little, with the knowledge of the unjust struggle she had endured growing up as an outcast.

“I want to show you something!” Liam's eyes were bright with pride, as he quickly scrambled out of view. Leaving Adora with Spirit.

“I need you to keep tabs on Beatrix, if she starts acting more Weavery…I need you to warn me over our bond, so I can come to deal with her.” Adora was quick to send Spirit a mental image of Shadow Weaver.

The horse's brown eyes widened with sudden clarity as to whom this Beatrix truly was. Then nodded sharply, illustrating that they understood their mission.

Liam reappeared, brandishing the beginnings of a very ornate, more bulky, almost gaudy looking metal Chanfron. Adora gasped, barely concealing her shock at the sight of Spirit’s new head armor. The trim was lined with tiny empty sockets, that would hold gemstones and a hollow central mounting where the crystal horn would be.

“That looks…good.” Adora cleared her throat, watching Spirit roll his eyes from behind Liam’s shoulder. Adora quickly bites her lip to stop from snickering. Spirit thought the armor was ugly and he was loathing having to eventually wear it.

“Beatrix critiqued my previous barding and found it lacking. That I wasn’t developing it to its full potential.” Liam advised, setting the armor piece down.

“What’s wrong with Spirits old barding?” Adora asked. The leather had been lightweight. The simplicity of it’s design had been elegant and much less flashy, suiting her tastes.

Spirit whinnied and huffed, stomping his hooves. Agreeing with Adora’s fondness of the old style of Chanfron.

“Well…Spirit kinda transformed into Swift Wind for a moment… and shot off those massive magic beams from his horn. “ Liam explained, hands waving frantically as he told the harrowing tale.

Adora's heart drummed against her chest, gazing at Spirit in awe. Realizing that when she transformed into She-Ra, He transformed back into Swift Wind so there was hope of getting the Alicorn back!

Spirit’s warm brown eyes shone with pleasure.

“It melted his artificial horn when his real horn grew out of his head and scorched the leather of his chanfron…so I’m building a new chanfron… Hopefully…it will be stronger and able to withstand the magic…cause I'm going to reinforce the new crystal horn with harmonizing runestones…it will also detach if Spirit transforms again. That way he can use his magic either way. ” Liam prattled on, leaning to the right to produce a leather bound journal and began to show Adora his design sketches and research.

Adora smiled and nodded in the right places to acknowledge she was listening to his long, drawn out explanation. But she understood very little of it, just content to listen and happy that he was finally able to start to fulfill his own dreams.

So far Beatrix’s instruction seemed harmless, everyone deserves a second chance.Spirit would keep a close eye though. Liam went one to explain that Kronis is missing and the clones had returned with their brethren. Who had come at first to contain the situation at the Beacon, then had taken them into custody per Hordak’s orders. Adora was alright with that. Perhaps that was where they needed to be right now. She honestly did not have the time to educate them and hold their hands as they worked through becoming individuals. As she did for Wrong Hordak. In retrospect, Wrong Hordak may be the perfect candidate to guide his brethren forward then anyone else. He understood what they were going through and could answer all their questions, since he had already gone through it.

Bow was going through the final check of all the systems at the main control panel, the embedded screens glowing in the fading light of evening. The operation panel was set to the right of the wheel mount. Glancing up curiously from time to time, as he heard Catra sigh deeply yet again. She was standing along the very edge of the starboard side of the command deck, that was

just beyond the window's with only a tiny railing to stop you from falling to the main deck below. With her arms crossed, staring out into the savannah beyond the railing with the most melancholy expression of longing on her face.

Several approaches as to how to tactfully inquire about why she looked so sad, crossed his mind, along with several scenarios as to how prickly the feline might respond. He had learned early on, she hated when people pried into her business and got rather annoyed when put on the spot to respond. But he also cared about her and he hoped by now she understood. That a friend worried and always wanted to help.

"Cat…." Bow started, receiving a raised palm from the Magicat. Silently instructed him to stop, already knowing where his line of inquiry was going.

Bow huffed, returning his attention to the screen in front of him.

"This place…was my home…a thousand years ago. The Serenia Savannah and yeah, I'm a little sad so drop it, Arrow Boy. I'm dealing, ok." Catra grumbled, sliding her gaze down to the new, more bulky bracer's Bow was wearing on his wrists. They looked high tech, like something out of a Horde weapon's factory. She had noticed right away that he had also replaced his quiver and arrows with a utility belt around his waist.

"New gear?" She changed the topic, nodding curtly towards his wrists.

Bow smiled broadly, he had showed off his new energy bolts last night to Glimmer. But he was eager to show off again.

Bow crossed his arms, tapping a small protrusion on the underside edge of the gauntlets. With a short series of clicks, tiny, reinforced twin metal crossbow limbs sprang up from the top mounting of the bracer's. With a thin barrel down the middle, were the risers and flight groove might have been. That disappeared into the bulker part of the gauntlet near Bow's

elbows. The back of the bracer was glowing a piercing green, just like the blaster pack of the energy pistol's. Brojee had shown them back on Beast Island.

Catra's eyes widened, already impressed. Bow raised the gauntlets with a cocking sound and then aimed his arms, curling his fingers into tight fists. Lightly tapping the trigger button, with his middle fingers. That was embedded into the palm portion of the strap that wrapped around his hand. Then she felt a heat warm her face, heard and felt an audible crack followed by a whistling. A spark exploded from the depths of the bracer's barrel, smoke dissipating out the back to curl around Bow's powerful bare biceps. As a strange rush of air flowed over either side of her head. Her ears pinned back and she winced. As a series of soft thoop sounds issued from Bow's crossbows. The projectiles were glowing green balls that shot past her. Faster than her eyes could track, exploding into the pile of rocks sitting several yards behind the skiff. The rock's exploded, with more concussive force than ones shot from an energy pistol.

Catra turned abruptly and watched the rock pile's shattered stone debris fall for a moment. Tail lashing in agitation, that he had gall to shoot so close to her head!

About ready to turn back, claws extended and give him a good tongue lashing for being so arrogant and reckless. Her temper cooled into complete disbelief and awe. At just how accurate of a shot Bow was. Finding one of the largest stones on the very peak of the pile, now held three letters carved into it, 'BFS'

She shook her head and chuckled ruefully. "Good shooting, Arrows."

"Were you scared?" Bow taunted, with a smirk.

"Never." Catra finally turned with a smirk of her own, her sadness washed away by Bow's display of prowess and the fact he had defaced the landscape for her. Knowing she would find it amusing. That said without words, how close they were to each other and

that she already had a family. One she wanted to be a part of, more than ever.

"Guys!" Glimmer cried out in alarm, rushing out of the cabin behind Adora. As the blonde waved a comm pad over her head.

"What's going on?" Bow quickly deactivated his crossbows. As Adora and Glimmer mounted the last rung of the ladder onto the forward command deck.

They all crowded around the screen. As Mermista prowled back into view.

She was storming down a wide dock, cluttered with various kinds of cargo towards a massive wooden ship.

"I send Sea Hawk out to gather a pirate crew to ferry Scorpia's aid shipments to the islands in the most need and what does he do! He steals my father's flag ship instead!" She ranted, her face was flushed red and she was shaking in barely contained fury.

"What's worse…he gave the damn ship to Sweet Bee!" She continued, mounting the gang plank and storming on board. "I got no aid shipment, he won't tell me what he did with the money I gave him to pay for the pirate crew!" She pinched the bridge of her nose, releasing a long suffering groan. "But I did get something worthwhile out of it all. That you might be interested in!" She huffed, turned her pad's camera out to the expansive main deck of the Galleon.

There was a blonde kitten, sitting on a barrel. Knees drawn up to their chest, staring out over the sparkling ocean beyond the boat. As various breeds of hybrid and antineeds moved over the deck tending the ships riggings. "I got your kitten and would you believe it. Their name is Finn too." Mermista smiled smugly, an inquiring arch to her dark eyebrows about the kitten's name? As she turned the camera back towards herself.

"Odd little coincidence, don't you think?" Mermista cooed, sardonically.

Bow nodded and lunged for the wheel, pushing a lever on the side console beside him to rev up the main engine. As the once low humming of the skiff's rotors was drowned out by the back engines kicking into a deafening roar.

"We're heading to Salineas, give us your coordinates." Glimmer instructed, taking the pad away from Adora's now slack grip. As the blonde was now standing there, blinking and completely shell shocked by what she had just seen. The kitten had Catra's stripes, her dark ears and tail…the resemblance was uncanny?

Catra's mouth kept opening and closing, as she also saw similarities to Adora in the kitten's appearance. Their soft blue eyes and blonde hair was more than obvious. They paid each other a bewildering glance, unwilling to voice just yet what they were both thinking. As their cheeks warmed and they both meekly looked away from each other unwilling to voice the strange thoughts now steamrolling through their minds.

Solace

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comments and everyone who left kudos on the last chapter. Well, many of your questions will be answered in time. This a long fic, I really wanted to flush out the world and history that the writer's spoke of but never went into any detail. Everything I have written about so far was spoken of, or in the backgrounds of the show. The idea of the Wyrm's came from the vase Adora coveted in the Library that had a white dragon on it. The first Vision Adora has when touching the sword. She see's the oasis in Serenia that surrounds the broken Sunna Stone. As it will be in the future, after she releases the Heart of Etheria. But in time yes, all the mutant wyrm's secrets will be revealed. Along with He-Man and what happened to the other core worlds in the last thousand years. I have so much more lore to share. This one has a long sex scene in it, I have put stars in front and behind.
> Enjoy!

After supper, Catra had retreated to their bedroom at the front of the cabin. Needing to be alone and sort out the whirlwind of emotions she had shoved aside for the last few days. Now with the current threats over and done with, she needed some time to deal with them. Adora had let her go, feeling the same need to be alone with her thoughts. So she had gone above deck. To lay out on the bow beneath the stars and just think. So much had happened in such a short time.

As soon as she had entered the compartment, Catra had shed as many clothes as she could. Needing to be free of the constricting cloak and the weight of her leather jacket. Now her white shirt and torn black leggings had followed, adding to the pile in the

front corner. Leaving her in only her black breast wrap and matching panties.

The bedroom was small, a cozy little compartment just big enough for a bed and a couple floating shelves. Set on either side of the molded headboard, to be used as night stands. All embedded into the curved, front bulkhead. Smooth, bare walls and no windows surrounded her. Only one door that leads back into the living area of the cabin. The tiny room, softly illuminated by small orb shaped lamps protruding at the corners of the roof. The den-like atmosphere and the semi-darkness gave her a sense of security. It was the perfect hiding place for Catra to feel safe and be able to take her guard down. So she could finally relax.

Yet, here she was doing none of that!

Curled up in the farthest corner of the room. Tucked against the wall, clutching a pillow against her chest, hyperventilating instead. Shivering with delayed grief and overwhelming dread. She had nearly lost Adora….again! The horrific image of her lifeless body, laying limp in her arms, strangled in corruption haunted her. The Nameless One had been so close to devouring her…What would have remained of her then? Would she be a decaying husk? Like Shadow Weaver? A Void Being like she had been? Or just a lifeless corpse ...a stubborn ghost refusing to cross over just like Max? How many times would Adora's life be on the line before her luck ran out and she was killed. In a few months time, she could very easily be like Levi? Having lost her only true love and drowning in sorrow and rage? It was all just too much to handle…

Catra groaned, pressing her face into the pillow.

(*My friend…your emotions are howling inside of you…)* Melog's voice whispered through their link. Soft and entreating her to calm down.

"I can't stop…thinking about Adora dying…I just got her back!" Catra hissed, struggling to voice her fear. Her chest felt tight and her throat burned, as tears silently escaped her tightly shut eyes.

That was quickly absorbed into the plush cotton of the pillow pressed up against her face. Her fingers clenched, claws ripping at the fabric as she fought to tamp down on her rising panic.

(*Focus on what Perfuma has taught you…control your inner monologue. Do not allow your negative thinking to torture you?*) Melog offered, gently. Wrapping her up in a soothing aura. As they were currently somewhere above deck unable to physically reach her.

Catra groaned, clenching her teeth, biting down on her lower lip. Seeking to distract herself with pain.

It wasn't what Melog had wanted and the alien cat was swift to jolt her with a surge of disapproval for hurting herself.

(*Stop!)* The sudden bellow of reprimand through their link was enough to make her snap her eyes open with a sharp gasp.

Catra thumped the back of her head against the wall in frustration. Wiping the blood away with the back of her wrist, she healed fast so the punctures would close quickly.

With a heavy sigh, Catra reluctantly let go of the pillow and wiggled her butt. Relaxing her body into a meditative position just like Perfuma had taught her. Ruefully wishing for those magic stones that had helped her find peace before.

She slowly took a deep breath and held it for several seconds, repeating the process until her heart slowed and her breathing calmed down. When she felt calm once more she finally opened her eyes.

"Catra…" Glimmer voice floated from the other side of the closed door. Quiet and wavering slightly. Obviously nervous about disturbing the magicat and being verbally rejected. Or perhaps feeling foolish incase she wasn't even in there to begin with and she was talking to an empty room like an idiot. Either way, Glimmer was a ball of nerves.

“I’m in here, Sparkles.” Catra responded morosely, alleviating Glimmer’s uncertainty. Catra swiftly crawled over to the door, leaning her back against it. To prevent Glimmer from opening it. The cabin doors didn't have locks, which was already proving to be rather annoying. From experience back on Darla, living in such close quarters, privacy was hypothetical at best. Glimmer was known to just barge into rooms. It wasn’t that she didn’t understand the need for privacy or personal boundaries. She was just impatient and driven by either her excitement to share, or her single minded need to confront and solve any and all personal disagreements head on. Get it all out in the open and sorted so they could all move on and start to repair their relationship.

Catra was unwilling to be seen so vulnerable right now, with her eyes red and swollen from crying and snot dribbling from her nose. Having the Queen of Bright Moon see her in such a distressed state was humiliation she could thankfully avoid.

As if on cue the door moved forward only to be blocked instantly by Catra’s hunched back. As she had pulled up her bare legs to her chest, crossing her arms over her knees and tucking her tail tight around her ankles.

Glimmer grunted in confusion at first then meekly closed the door. Understanding that Catra didn’t want to talk face to face. This wasn’t the first time or the last, that Glimmer had been met with some kind of barrier blocking her from a face to face conversation with Catra. Back on Darla the Magicat would push the metal frame of her cot up against the door. So when the automatic door slid open, there was a solid metal frame sealing the opening. Forcing Glimmer to stay out in the hall, with no way to invade her space. So many heart to hearts had happened between them this way… ever since the Velvet Glove.

Catra’s ears twitched as she listened to Glimmer settle on the floor outside. Catra bowed her head, with a small, fond smile. Knowing Glimmer as always was respecting her need for separation. Silence reigned for a long time, as Catra focused on the soft

scratching of Glimmer's nails on the floor as she gathered her thoughts.

"I've never got the chance, but I'm sorry about Max." Came her condolences, as soft as a whisper.

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes, in annoyance. She hated hearing those rehearsed words of sympathy. So she didn't respond, biting the inside of her cheek to keep from reflexively saying something snarky.

Glimmer was quiet for a while after, sorting through her thoughts.

"Losing people you care about sucks." Glimmer finally kept going with a long suffering groan, she was rambling, unable to summon the courage to speak her mind.

"Ugh…get to the point." Catra snarled back as she could sense the reprimand coming. She had been on the receiving end of far too many of these disparaging talks over the years with Weaver. About her attitude, her lack of effort…her blah, blah, blah. She never was good at being an obedient little soldier like Adora. So it wasn't much of a surprise that she had eventually disappointed Glimmer.

"What I'm saying is…I care about you, Horde Scum. But you've kinda been a real jackass lately." Glimmer accused, her voice tight with irritation.

Catra sighed and nodded. Knowing exactly where this was going, because she had been a real ass to her Aunt. Casta had patiently endured her impatience, her irritation and then her complete disregard of her order's. By lying to Glimmer, about her whereabouts. When she was going back into Arxia. Putting herself and Cyrus's lives at risk, needing to find Keldor's office and get to the bottom of what his true plans were with Etheria's magic, In her mind it was worth that risk. Honestly. Cyrus was the best choice for the mission. He is more expendable than Glimmer, to

her at least. As callus as that thinking was, it was how the Horde raised her. Cyrus already knew all the secrets of Arxia, he was the best guide to continue to explore. She just couldn't afford to take the chance that Glimmer would not approve and try to stop her. So it was better to ask forgiveness than permission. What chance would she have to really look around deep inside that ancient outpost. If Glimmer just kept teleporting her back out every time she snuck in. Sometimes subterfuge was the only way to get things done. It was sneaky and underhanded, but it was the only way for her to get results.

Glimmer swallowed her anger at being left out yet again on a dangerous mission. Tucking away how bad it hurt to feel that Catra still, after everything they had been through together still did not trust her.

"I don't want to lose you…" Glimmer whimpered, getting to the heart of the matter.

Catra blinked several times in shock, never had she heard Glimmer sound so broken. Already she could hear the soft sniffling and gasping breaths as Glimmer began to sob. Overwhelmed by her fear of losing yet one more person she cared about. Spurning Catra into action, she flung the door open. Depositing Glimmer backwards through the threshold with a yelp. Onto her back into a shaft of light cascading in from the living compartment in front of them. Glimmer lay stunned, glassy eyed and staring up at Catra for all of a second.. As Catra froze. She wouldn't apologize for what she had done. It wasn't her intention to hurt Glimmer but protect her. She was insecure about making the first move. She wanted to be affectionate, comfort her, yearned to hug Glimmer and show her she actually cared. But she quickly just fell back into old habits, poking her claw into the Queen's forehead instead.

"Stop worrying about stuff you can't control." Catra stated, cringing internally because she was a damn hypocrite. But it was cathartic to hear those words coming out of her mouth.

"Ok…" Glimmer sighed, rolling away and moving to kneel in front of her. She sat inches away from the magicat struggling with her self control. As tears rolled down her cheeks and continued to sniffle softly.

Catra gave her a slow blink and Glimmer grinned. Receiving silent consent, she instantly reaches out and pulls the once aloof hybrid in. For a much needed hug. With a relieved sigh, Catra curled into Glimmer, not realizing until then that this was the solace she needed right now. A low, contented purr rumbled from deep inside her chest, as she tucked herself against Glimmer. The tip of her tail flicked happily against Glimmer's hip . As her own arms wrapped around the Queen and held on tight.

Adora stared up at the stars, tracing the pattern's she had discovered during the war. When she would retreat outside of the Rebel Camp deep in the Whispering Woods, to think, to dream and just sort herself out. The deck planks beneath her were hard, creaking everytime she moved even a little. Disturbing her rampaging train of thoughts. That kept getting derailed down one tangent or another. She had so much to sort out, thanks to the Crystal Castle. It would take her a long time to come to terms with it all. So she resigned herself to the chaos in her head, hands folded over her stomach. Letting her mind drift. Her thought's destination always landing back on the same fatal realization she had last night. After retelling Mara's life and eventual death to Catra.

Her time was limited…the day dreams she had back in Thaymor of growing old together, living a simple life with Catra would never come true. The succession of She-Ra was an endless parade of dead Hero's. Who had given everything to protect Etheria from whatever evil was threatening it at the time. The Nameless One was Eternal…that evil could never be defeated, it would never just fade away, it merely changed faces and it would always threaten the universe. She was the only thing standing against it, the only power strong enough to force it to retreat for a time. But

eventually she would be met with an evil that would be more powerful than she could defeat. It would take her life, or perhaps she may have to sacrifice herself…just like Mara to keep everyone safe. But then the universe would just summon another Champion to take her place and the eternal war would continue. Her life, her destiny…was fighting. It was hard for her to come to terms with that reality. If she wanted to survive…she had to get stronger, if she didn't then her life would be cut short. It was what she had to do…

"Hey, there buddy…" Bow's tender baritone invaded, Adora's latest deluge of troubled thoughts. She finally resurfaced enough to realize the skiff had stopped moving and it was currently moored in a dried out gully within the sandstone Canyon's of the Crimson Waste. She absently traced the lines of limestone and shale along the rim of the barren rock walls in the distance. That was still visible in the pale light of the moon's, the lower parts of the canyon lay too deep in darkness to see anything. With nothing for her eyes to focus on she returned her gaze back to the endless starlight above with an acknowledging grunt to Bow.

"I can't drive through another whole night without sleep so we gotta camp here for a few hours." Bow shrugged, then settled down on his back beside her on the open deck.
"You need to teach us all how to drive this thing, then we could take shifts." Adora moved her hands from her stomach and crossed them behind her head.

"Well, that will have to wait until I'm rested enough to think straight. Right now, I'm so tired, I think I can smell colors." Bow cracked an old joke.

Adora turned and offered him a small conciliatory smile. As Bow was now laying down beside her, joining her in stargazing.

"Yeah I get that. I'm tired, too. Bow." Adora finally admitted after a long silence.

"Well, then maybe we should get to sleep?" Bow offered his voice full of the same tenderness and care he always had towards his friends. Not truly understanding what she meant.

"No…Bow. Not that kind of tired." Adora snapped her blue eyes toward him for a second. Then shot her gaze right back up to the stars. Unwilling to confront Bow's worried gaze, it would shatter the tentative grip she had on her emotions as is. In the end it didn't matter anyway…
"Adora?" Bow said her name with such tender concern, that it immediately had her in tears. She heaved a broken breath then grimaced, clamping her jaw tight in an attempt to hold in her despair.

"Oh…Damn….What's going on!" Bow exclaimed, rising to a sitting position and hoisting Adora up after. Until they were both sitting cross legged in front of each other.

Bow regarded her softly, rubbing his hands up and down her arms seeking to console her. As Adora bowed her head and wept silently, picking at the cuticles of her fingers as she was once again crushed with guilt. Because she should be grateful…That she had been worthy of She-Ra's power and she had the ability to do so much good in her lifetime. But she wasn't, she was scared and sad and angry right now.

"I…need a break…" She admitted, in a broken whisper. "I am barely holding it together." she sighed, watery blue eyes shooting up to regard Bow for an instant. Knowing he would understand. He had seen her this overwhelmed before, during the first few weeks of Primes occupation. Her gaze falling back to watch herself picking at her finger's once more in shame.

"Adora…you're allowed to have that.." Bow advised, "I have no idea what it's like bearing the weight of the universe on your shoulders, but I am sure it can be incredibly exhausting at times."

“You have no idea.” Adora breathed, laughing ruefully.

“You are the strongest person I know, Adora. But you can’t do it all alone. You know that you can count on your friends to help pull some of that weight. I will do everything within my power to help, to take some of that responsibility off of you.” Bow promised, “You know I will…all of us will. Glimmer…Catra…the rest of the Alliance…all of your friends. You need to lean on us, before you become this overwhelmed. Ok.”

“Ok…” Adora nodded, knowing that there always was a finite amount she could depend on the other’s for. In the end, she was She-Ra, when it came to crunch time saving the Universe was on her and her alone. But she was always grateful for his support. She made a promise to herself. She was going to enjoy every moment she had left with them, with her true love. She would make the most of her life!

Bow pulled her in, holding her firm in his arms and letting her cry into his shoulder. Stalwart and strong, he was her rock to draw strength from as she purged all of the stress and grief of the last few days. Holding on tight and cherishing him. When she was all out of tears to shed, she began to shiver. No longer running hot from her anxiety, she was able to once more feel the cold.

“Yeah…it’s freezing out here.” Bow rose to his feet and pulled her up after them. They both rushed below deck, to find warmth. Heading towards their bedroom’s and eager to crawl under the sheets and snuggle up to their girlfriends.

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Catra was curled up under the covers, dozing lightly when Glimmer’s shrill shriek pierced the night, followed by an irate shout. “Bow!”

She had no time to prepare, as she heard Adora rustling out of her clothes. Then she felt Adora's weight invading the bed. Her frigid naked body pressed up against her back was like laying against a living ice cube.
"What the Hell!" Catra hissed, as a shivering Adora plunged her frozen hands into the warmth of Catra's armpits, tucking her cold feet between her furry thighs.

"So cold...warm me up…" Adora whined, nuzzling her nose into the crook of Catra's neck, pressing sweet kisses to her pulse point.

Catra groaned, trying to sound disgruntled but the result of Adora's needy affection. It came out more like a lowly moan of supplication instead.

"You're such a baby…" Catra complained half heartedly, as she tolerated becoming Adora's source of heat.

Adora needed more…she had missed her so much. With all the heartache and death that had happened in the last few days. She needed to feel…loved, needed to show Catra how much she meant to her. She wanted ... .to love her. She was desperate to once again, feel the magicat's naked body flush against her own. Their last love making had been so pure and exhilarating but far too short. She wanted to reclaim that intimate connection again, take her time...

Adora moaned with yearning, as the tender press of her lips against Catra's neck became more urgent. As she kissed a path upward toward Catra's chin, licking and nipping the tender skin covered in velvet soft fur.

Catra gasped, as heat pulsed in her belly, a tingling sensation cascading throughout her body.

"Oh….ah…" Catra moaned, her body trembling. Before she could catch her breath and turn and greet Adora's mouth eagerly with her own.

The blonde pulled away, quickly leaning up and over her. Pushing Catra gently down onto her back. Claiming her lips with her own once more. Catra's hands instinctively flew up and curled into Adora's hair along the sides of her face. Pulling out that wretched elastic band, to free her hair to cascade over her shoulders.

Adora moaned softly against her lips, as Catra gripped the back of her head. The hybrid's other hand splayed over the small of Adora's back, holding the blonde on top of her own body. The kiss deepened as it always did, fueled by desire. As their tongues dueled. Obliterating all thoughts and trapping them both in the moment, as they sought to pleasure one another.

Catra was able to take a well needed gasp of air when they pulled apart briefly. Adora smirked down at her, heaving for air, pleased with how breathless and flushed Catra was.

Catra offered her a slow, sensuous smile, cupping Adora's cheek tenderly. Her eyes shimmering with pure unconditional love.

"I missed you…My love. " Adora breathed in a hushed whisper.

"I can tell…Princess. " Catra smirked, caressing her fingertips down Adora's flushed cheek.

"I want you…" Adora's tender gaze began to smolder with desire.

"Then you can have me." Catra breathed, having just enough room between them for her to pull off her chest wrap. Tossing it to the floor. Revealing her perfectly, round breasts in offering. As her tail curled lovingly around Adora's wrist.

Adora's stare became intense, as she bent down and crushed her lips against Catra's once more. As her right hand roamed over a soft, supple breast. As she began a tender, tactile study of her body. She kissed her as if their time apart had been far longer than it was. As if she had lived a lifetime, starved for her love, her affection, her body…she needed and she wanted and she was given….freely.

Catra released a faint whimper as Adora's tongue once again found her neck. Sucking and nipping a path downward to her collarbone. That small, wanton sound drove Adora's courage onward. Till she hovered her mouth over one of Catra's bare breasts.

The anticipation was killing Catra, she didn't want to rush her. But her insides were quivering with need. Her breasts were tingling and her nipples had tightened so hard. When she felt Adora's hot breath upon the hardened nub, it sent jolts of pleasure throughout her body. Her groin was aching and she was now unbearably damp between her legs. Her clit was throbbing and Adora hadn't even touched her down there yet! This may well be the most agonizing torture she had ever endured. She was close to sobbing in frustration if Adora didn't lean down and finish what she intended.

"Adora…please…" Catra's softly spoken plea whispered between them. Even though she had tried so hard not to beg…her voice had sounded so desperate. Adora's dreamy gaze, floated up from staring in wonder down at Catra's breast. Catra was instantly mesmerized by the glowing intensity pooling in her eyes, that looked the very same twilight shade as her runestones. When she had transformed last in the Crystal Castle, completely balanced and at peace with herself.

Catra inhaled sharply, holding her breath. When Adora slowly lowered her head.

Catra was quickly light headed and filled with a pleasurable euphoria. As she felt Adora's full lips brushing against her nipple, then her tongue swept over the nub.

Catra gasped and bowed upward, shocked by the force of her reaction. Then lazily, Adora's tongue traced circles around her nipple. As it puckered even more, becoming almost painful. In moment's Adora began suckling, humming in delight.

Catra groaned and closed her eyes, basking in the delicious sensations. As she arched into her. Wanting more, as her core began to throb with a desperate need.

Adora turned her attention to the other breast, kissing around the nipple before licking and sucking with lusty abandon. Adora wasn't talking, completely focused on pleasing her. Her efforts were eager and maddeningly patient, as she slowly made her way beneath the sheets. Kissing her way downward to Catras' taunt belly, the muscles now spasming under the blondes kiss swollen lips.

Catra was quickly hurtling towards that explosive release and Adora hadn't even touched her down there yet!

Then suddenly, just as she felt Adora's lips tracing the band of her panties. She stopped, frozen and hovering over her sex. Her hot breath puffing in bursts of, arousing heat against her underwear. Making her skin tingle in expectation every time she expelled air.

Catra had curled her hands near her ears, having twisted the pillow's fabric near her head. In an attempt to control herself, as Adora's sensually played with her body, driving her into a frenzy of maddening desire. Her claws were already shredding the fabric as she had struggled to contain her impatience.

Then Adora popped up, the sheet once over her head now cast aside to pooling down around her bare waist. Her blonde hair was frizzy and wild around her shoulders and she was staring down at her. Eyes glazed with lust and shy uncertainty.

"I don't know what I'm doing…" She admitted in a low, husky voice. Chewing on her lower lips nervously.

Catras mouth fell open in utter shock, her tail that was once swishing in a pleased manner up and down the side of the mattress became still. Her chest was heaving with pent up desire. She had been on the very edge of release and she had been

denied! She wanted Adora to just touch her, this was such a torturous tease!

Adora's eyes were locked on the seductive heat smoldering in Catra's eyes. The desperate yearning for her to finish what she started. She had been so close…Without further delay Adora swallowed her nerves and just rolled with her lust fuelled desires. Crawling backwards and pulling Catra's panties down to her ankles. Her hands trembling as she caressed backup Catra's legs to the hybrid's inner thighs. Both hands spread her legs and moved upward, towards the apex. As her fingertips brushed feather light against Catra's womanhood. It sent the most delicious shiver throughout Catra's whole body and the feline mewled plaintively.

Adora stroked the longer, curls of fur that covered her there. Her tactile exploration was as slow and devoted as it had been for her breasts.

"You're so beautiful…" Adora muttered in awe, as her other hand pressed flat onto Catra's stomach and caressed upward to the curve of her left breast. While stroking her index finger down the seam of the hybrid's sex at the same time. Then she petted downward with her other hand back towards Catra's hips, the slight pressure of her palm was so stimulating, Catra couldn't help the long, languid groan that issued from her lips, the sound ending in a low, blissful purr.

Then Catra inhaled sharply, as her core spasmed. As Adora placed a soft kiss to her inner thigh. Catra was so worked up now the slightest pressure between her legs would set her off. Then with a startled cry, she felt Adora's finger tip dip just inside the entrance, teasing and tracing the folds of her opening. The blondes finger's played for a moment, parting the folds. Investigating the warm, wet heat with a sensual dedication, wanting to memorize every dip and curve.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and bit down on her lower lip with both fangs to ground herself as she felt ready to fly off the bed!

She was shaking, as Adora finally pressed her face against her core. The blonde's tongue lightly touches her clit, licking it in short, swift swipes.

"Ahhh!" Catra cried out, back arching painfully. In both pleasure and shock. Completely overwhelmed by the pleasurable sensation of Adora's mouth. As the blondes tongue slid in tiny circles around her clit, in a passionately intoxicating stimulation. Then traveled down her slit to her opening. Teasing the entrance with long swipes, before returning to her clit. She sucked the taunt, pulsing nub, then began flicking the tip of her tongue lightly against it.

"Adora…" Catra gasped, as she was now trembling uncontrollably, her knees were shaking and her finger's had found their way from the pillow and into Adora's hair. Holding the blonde head down against her sex, curling and flexing her finger's as more powerful spasms began rolling through her core.

Adora was driving her to heights she had never achieved on her own, while trying to pleasure herself. The blonde was completely enraptured by what she was doing, sucking and licking Catra into an even more intense frenzy. As she had now slipped her hands underneath Catra's ass and was holding her more firmly against her mouth. One hand scratching with purposeful pressure against the bundle of nerves at the top of her tail. Which was now thumping against the mattress in a loud, staccato beat.

Catra was out of control, her head was spinning and she couldn't stop the gasps and loud, wanton cries from escaping. Rocking her hips desperately against Adora's mouth.

Then her whole body tightened, as Adora finally slid a finger inside. As she sucked hard on Catra's clit at the same time. The hybrid's body began to writhe eroticaly, as she was rocketed towards the most powerful orgasm she had ever experienced. As Adora was pumping hard and fast in and out of her, until Catra's walls clenched against her finger. Pulsing and throbbing, as pure, breathtaking ecstasy crashed through her. Like the mighty waves

of the ocean, slamming against the rocks of the shore. She was pulled under and completely overwhelmed by their power.

Catra couldn't catch her breath…as she finally resurfaced. Only slightly aware of Adora moving away. Curling against her and pressing a tender kiss to Catra's temple, before settling down between her legs. Adora laid her head on Catra's chest. Her finger's tracing feather light circles over Catra's collarbone and then her shoulder's stripes. As Catra slowly came down from the most exhilarating high of her life! Catra held her tightly, her true love's heat surrounding her, soothing her now hyper sensitive skin. Catra was trembling, as she was still tingling deep inside. That had been the most enjoyable experience of her life!

"Are you….ok?" Adora's husky voice whispered into the soft light of their cabin.

"That….that was amazing…" Catra responded, in a slurred, hushed breath. Still too blissed out to manage anything more complementary. But she would have…if she could coherently put words together properly. But that was all she could manage at the moment.

"Good…" Adora answered, cheeks burning, as she buried her face into Catra's neck once more. Brushing her lips against the velvet soft skin lovingly.

"How did you know how to do that…' Catra asked, absolutely thrilled and completely gobsmacked at the same time.

"Mara… well her cousin Dare actually. When he has a few pints of mead in him, you would not believe the bedroom tales he tells." Adora chuckled, snuggling farther into Catra's embrace. Feeling rather shy and vulnerable after being so intimate.

"So you….stopping and telling me you had no idea what you were doing? Was, what…you just being coy, trying to make me lose my damn mind!" Catra cried in amused indignation. Before pressing a

sweet kiss the crown of Adora's head, that tucked just under her chin.

"No!...I wasn't trying to tease you…I was just nervous..I've never done any of that before…" Adora defended, pulling away from Catra's neck to stare down at her with wide pleading eyes for her not to be mad. Her honest response and the slight quiver of her lower lip, beseeching Catra to believe her. That she had no intention of teasing her that she just had wanted to please her, show her how much she was cherished, how much she was desired…needed.

"Adora…calm down..calm down…I was joking. Ahhh…come here!" Catra thumbed away the tears falling down Adora's cheeks and pulled her back into a loving embrace, caressing her strong arms and rubbing her back. Regretting her teasing. Adora's emotional state was so raw and fragile right now. She needed tenderness, not smartass comments. When Adora stopped shaking and her tears dried. Catra broke the silence.

"I loved it…I love you…Princess…" Catra smirked down at the blonde crown of Adora's head. Before rolling the blonde over onto her back. Adora stared up at her in confusion at first. A slow, sensual smile of anticipation spreading over her face. As Catra leaned over her, whispering hotly against her ear.

"Well, I learned a few things from the bandits in the Crimson Waste…so let me show you…" Catra promised, sucking Adora's earlobe into her mouth before kissing a trail down her neck with pure intention to tease and draw all manner of exquisite sounds out of her before she found release.

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The next morning, Catra emerged from their cabin still basking in the afterglow, Every muscle was loose, not a shred of tension remained. Her mind was gloriously blank and she had never felt lighter. Wearing Adora's long sleeve compression shirt, that was several sizes too large for her more petite frame.

Sex therapy she decided was way better than meditation to calm her body and soul.

She found Glimmer sitting on a stool in front of the tiny island set before the small kitchen. Sipping from a sterile white mug, hiding her knowing grin. Catra paid her a curious look as she passed, heading for the fridge to find something to prepare for breakfast. Since the only thing available was a full carafate of that completely disgustingly bitter,black tar, Bow liked to call coffee.

"Sleep well?" Glimmer offered, her tone highly suggestive.

Catra turned from the open door, arching a curious eyebrow. Catching on to the subtle innuendo but refusing to answer right away. Keeping her expression bland, as she hid her embarrassment that perhaps they had been far louder last night then they thought. In the end she decided to just own it.

"Very." Catra finally answered, with a smug smirk as she hid her blush away in the door of the fridge. Searching for some kind of epiphany as to what to make, by the contents inside. Perhaps she would surprise Adora with breakfast in bed? She had left the exhausted blonde, snoring fitfully. Back in their now rather rumpled looking bed.

Glimmer merely nodded, "Definitely an enjoyable night, heh, Horde Scum."

Catra turned abruptly, crossing her arms ready to confront her.

"You are not getting any of the dirty details." she declared hotly.

"Don't need to." Glimmer giggled, eyes sparkling with mischief. Jerking her chin towards the dining booth set beside the kitchen.

Catra closed the fridge door, leaning around the counter to find Melog laying out over the cushions. His whole body was a vibrant pink, his halo mane and tail glowing a brillant indigo. He was sprawled on his back, huge paws in the air, tongue lolling out the corner of his mouth completely blissed out of his mind.

Catra's cheeks instantly flared a bright crimson as she muttered bitterly.

"You have got to be kidding me." She thumped her forehead against the fridge door in humiliation.

Glimmer merely laughed merrily as she took her leave, heading above deck with her coffee, to give Catra some privacy to cool down.

Lost Boys

Chapter Notes

Thank you again Pink Storm for your comment, thanks also to all those who left Kudo's. Enjoy the next installment.

His world was burning…standing atop the crowsnest on the main mast. Young Sea Hawk, barely twelve years old. Had watched the decks of the merchant vessel below set alight by flaming spears from a marauder's long ship. As the larger boat had laid in wait, under the cover of night, hidden further within the inlet just off the Red Shores. Until the small merchant schooner had sailed past them deeper into the narrow fjord. It had come upon them at greater moonrise, silent like a predator. Once they were trapped, with the looming cliffs on either side blocking their escape. Their massive long ship had come alongside them sending a volley of flaming spears over their decks. Then turned around and rammed the side of the bow. With the reinforced metal stempost of a looming, dragon head that dominated the front of their ship. That easily shattered the beak of the schooner and punched a huge hole into the wood of the merchant vessel's wider bow. Causing the jibbom to snap and fall into the sea. The weight of the heavy pole jutting out from the bow, breaking the foremast and sending the head sail fluttering to the deck. Instantly maiming the Merchant's vessel's ability to maneuver…in minutes they were dead in the water and at the Marauder's mercy. The older lookout manning the crowsnest with him, had no chance to see them in time and warn the crew. So like the coward he was he had jumped overboard when the boat was set alight. Leaving young Sea Hawk alone, to witness his home for the last six years going up in flames.

As the marauder's boarded in a streaming horde. Of burly fur and hide armored warriors. Setting upon the crew and began pillaging the ship, stealing its bounty and massacring any sailor bold enough to try and stop them. Swords and axes flashing, the blades dripping with the blood of the fallen, pounding their

weapon's against painted round shields, in a terrifyingly loud crescendo beat. As if they were war drums.

The sound and fury, cowering the younger, less experienced sailors trapped on the main deck before the hold. Forcing the older crew to rally around the frightened young men. Who were then cut down without mercy, leaving those unwilling to fight to be slaughtered. Culled like craven cattle, in a swath of screaming terror as the Marauders stormed towards the hold.

Hawk was mesmerized by the flames, frozen and unable to move as the ship was consumed one deck at a time, in a hellscape of fire and blood. His finger's gripped the sides of the old wooden barrel he stood in. Lost to a light headed daze of fear and shameful exhilaration. He swallowed repeatedly. His throat raw from the thick smoke curling around the masts and shrouds below him. It hurt every time he took a breath, his chest burned. His throat felt like he was swallowing acid, as he squinted to relieve his eyes of the tears blurring his vision.

It was the sight of Bull, a tall, dark skinned human boy, several year's Hawk's elder. His tight curly black hair was curled into dreads, pulled back with a leather cord into a long ponytail down his back. Bull was thick and broad shouldered, slightly rotund around the middle. Standing defiant over the body of their guardian on the quarterdeck before the stern. Dressed similar to him in a white cotton shirt with the sleeves rolled up and heavy cotton brown pants held up by leather suspenders. His feet were bare as were most of the cabin boy's here on ship. Meaty fists raised, prepared to defend himself amid the battle raging around the decks. The old cook that had taken him and several other street orphan's in and had given them a home. Lay at Bull's feet in a pool of crimson.

The sight of a grizzly marauder, wearing the skin of a wolf as a cape was closing in upon them. Was what finally shook Hawk free of the trance. With a scream of pure rage, Hawk lept from the crowsnest. Dagger clenched in his right hand. He stabbed the blade into the main sail to slow his fall, riding the blade down as it

tore through the heavy fabric. The ship was lost anyway, but if he was fast enough perhaps he wouldn't lose his best friend!

As he reached the bottom of the sail and his blade tore free, he clenched the dagger in his teeth as he was in freefall. Adjusting his weight confidently to land in the webbing of the ropes below the sail, known as the shrouds. Climbing and swinging hand over hand, until he was close enough to leap to the main deck. Hawk crouched low needing to move unnoticed amid the fighting and sprinted through the fire. Ducking and dodging the combatants, as he raced across the deck. Heading towards the stairs unerringly, on the side of the captain's cabin. Ascending towards the quarter deck above, fueled by the bravery and unwavering certainty of victory only a child could muster.

Hawk leaped upon the wolfman's back like a wild thing, plunging his dagger into the side of the bandit's throat. The marauder never saw Hawk coming, so certain of his advantage over the child before him. A huge, badly scarred hand lunged out blindly to grab at Hawk. as the man gurgled and collapsed to the deck. Hawk stood over him, eyes glazed, chest heaving for clean air.

"Hawk…" Bull gasped in disbelief, dark brown eyes wide. Then laughed thinly. Clasping the shorter, red haired boy on the shoulder with a proud smile.

Hawk bowed his head, sniffling softly knowing the old man was dead. He rubbed a finger under his running nose. Coming to terms with the loss of yet another adult in his life. The sea was a harsh mistress, that gave and she took just as easily as the tides. He was used to it, at least he thought he was. But the ache in his heart proved otherwise. He couldn't stop the tears now tracking through the ash and grit upon his young face.

"Look…we all loved the old fool, but there was nothing for it. We gotta survive. " Bull sighed, leaning down and pulling Hawk's dagger out of the bandit's throat, handing it back to him. Hawk took the weapon with a crisp nod, wiping the blood off the blade on his pants before resheathing it on his hip belt. As he watched

Bull starting to fleece the body of the old cook. Pulling the various gold jewel encrusted rings off the old man's wrinkled fingers and stuffing them in the coin purse that hung from his neck. Then he pulled the bright red bandana off the old man's nearly bald head, handing it to Hawk.

Hawk nodded and slipped the cloth over his head, wearing it like an ascot.

"Help!" A shrill, cracking voice exploded from below decks.

Hawk and Bull raced to the railing, looking overboard. Finding another cabin boy, lean and long in the limbs. In nothing but his underclothes of gray shorts and a thread bare beige tank top. With a thick mass of wheat blonde hair, that hung around his shoulders. Attempting to crawl out of a slender gun port along the hull. As fire and ash exploded out of the gun ports further up near the keel.

"Monkey….hold on. We're coming!" Bull shouted, quick to take charge. Leaping off the front of the quarter deck,, landing in a forward roll and then charging towards the grated hatch that led to the lower decks.
"Dammit!" Hawk floundered for all but one second, before gripping his dagger tight and following after Bull. Scrambling back down the steps two or three at a time and slipping into the now dark hole after Bull.

The lower decks were impossible to navigate quickly as they were so clogged with smoke. Forcing them both to crawl along the floor. The chaos of screams and fighting had been reduced to the whimpers and sobs of the dying. As the marauder's had taken all that they could and abandoned the now sinking ship.

Several agonizing minutes passed as they slowly made their way to the port side of the hull. Forced to feel the boards beneath their hands tremble under the strain of the ocean. Listen to the low, mournful creaking of the ship as the weight of the water began to cave in the forward compartments. The sudden

explosions of the powder kegs from the fore cannon's. Stopping them in their tracks, chest's aching with lack of clean air and hearts beating in their throats. It felt like they were staring death right in the face and laughing at it.

Finally they made it into the aft section of gun port compartments. Finding the heavy iron cannon had been pushed to the side. With Mouse hovering by the cannon's port hole, hanging onto Monkey's ankle. Mouse was a sea elf, tiny in every way. Except for her large, almond shaped eyes of a pure cerulean blue. With cyan blue scales and darker teal green fin's on her wrists and shin's. Her pointed ears hung low, beneath a gray skull cap. Wearing nothing but faded tan overalls with large pockets on the sides. A narrow, corkscrew shaped shell, accented with swirling deep ocean color's hung on a leather cord around her thin neck.

She had been teaching Hawk the names of all the different shells that could be found in the sea, but he still could not remember a single name. But what he did know was that the shell was as sharp and deadly as a dagger. She had used it before as a weapon to protect herself, stabbing it into the thigh of a fat merchant pursuing her for thievery back in their last port. She had been pinned in an alley just before docks. She managed to get away and scramble back on board the schooner, with a very shocked and humbled Hawk. Who had been with her and had figured he had to be the chivalrous one and defend her. Barely able to pull his dagger before the tiny Sea Elf handled the situation and ran off.

Mouse may be cute and small but she was also feisty and could take care of herself.

Bull gave the smokey room a cursory glance, finding a coil of rope near the barrel of gunpowder. He quickly set to work, as Mouse pulled Monkey back inside. The skinny boy stood obediantly, golden hazel eyes glazed with fear. As Bull tied them all together.

"So we don't get separated." he declared, before crawling back out of the room. Pulling the three of them behind him. The

journey back up was as nerve wracking and harrowing as before as the ship was starting to go under the waves. The ocean was rising towards them as they crawled, soaking their arms and legs and already seeking to drown poor Mouse. Who is far too obstante to let the undertow drag her away. Growling and swearing at the dark water, as they painstakingly made their way to the main deck by feeling alone.

Bull never told them the plan, he merely charged towards the nearest railing then leaped overboard. Throwing them all into the dark water's below, in a desperate act to save them. Pulling the rest screaming in terror down into the black, night waves buffeting the drowning ship. Then Bull dragged them all back to the surface, fueled by his devotion to keep them safe, keep them alive. Spurning him past all his reserves of strength and straining muscles. Far too stubborn to allow the weakness of his body to claim the lives of those he cared about. He would deal with the physical consequences later. As they reached the surface, gasping and sputtering. They all began scanning the cresting waves for anything they could use to buoy themselves up. But their eyesight was not as good as Hawk's, who pointed to an unmoored lifeboat floating a few yards away amid the debris. Bobbing through the surf like a murky shadow, barely visible in the dim light cast by the moon's through the severely overcast sky above. Monkey was the most agile and was first to climb aboard, helping the rest into relative safety. They all flopped exhausted over the tiny floor of the row boat, as it was pulled back out to sea. Leaving the schooner to sink beneath the waves behind them.

Sweet Bee left at dawn, stating she had business to attend too. That she would return within a week with the aid supplies from Sea Worthy. As payment for Sea Hawk's rescue and helping her claim this fine vessel for her crew. Which was the only family she had left. She had vowed to take care of them and they had been homeless for far too long.

After Finn had said their goodbyes upon the solitary dock, that dominated the sheltered reef of the Island of Broland. They had retreated further inland, without a word as to where they were going. It had taken Sea Hawk most of the morning to find them. At first asking around the coastal village that sprawled along the southern shore of the island. Checking all the kitten's usual haunts, from the open walled grass and bamboo thatch hale. That acted as a communal kitchen built upon the beach, on the outskirts of the village. Where Hawk had assumed they had gone for some breakfast so early in the morning. Finding only a handful of local fishermen having a small repaste of coffee, freshly harvested fruit and toast. None had seen the kitten upon the dock earlier or even noticed if they had passed by. Slowly making his way up the fine white sands of the beachhead to the tiny village. Made up a variety of bamboo and grass thatch huts and wooden cabana style cabin's. The villager's he found, already out and about tending to their daily tasks. Hadn't noticed Finn either, passing through the narrow streets. So Hawk was quick to widen his search further inland. Navigating through the small rainforest of large ferns, pine and sandalwood trees that dominate the upper, more rocky portion of the island.

"Hey, Kid." Double Trouble's mischievous grin dominated the screen of the com pad in Finn's hands.

Finn grinned back just as brightly.

"A little birdie here on Mystacor told me, Peekablue got rescued by Scorpiania soldier's. He is with Princess Scorpia and Perfuma right now." DT nodded, their smile widening at the relief and joy spreading over the kitten's face.

"That's great news, Auncle, thanks." Finn released a long breath, their anxiety calming significantly now.

"Where are you now?" DT was curious, at the strange leafy crown of the canopy behind them.

“Broland Island.” Finn answered.
Never heard of it.” DT mumbled, tapping their chin.

“Uncle Hawk and Auntie Mista are taking care of me right now and guess what!” Finn exclaimed, practically jumping with their excitement.

DT arched an eyebrow.

“My Mom’s are coming! I overheard Auntie Mista talking to them this morning, when Bee was leaving on her new boat.” Finn rushed out, eyes wide and gleaming eagerly with a beaming smile.

“Bee got a new boat?” DT inquired, vaguely interested.

“Yeah, we stole the Salinea’s King’s flagship.” Finn chuckled.

“Well, I am sure he is good and furious with you now.” DT cracked a proud smile.

Finn merely shrugged uncaring, their gaze being drawn to the sparkling morning sea just beyond the plateau.

“Peekablue didn’t want them to see me…as I am now…this will mess stuff up?” Finn asked, their voice soft and morose.

“Well, Peekablue can be a bit dull. Perhaps messing things up is what saves the future, kid?” DT declared, crossing their arms over their chest stubbornly.

“You think so?” Finn's expression was hopeful, warm blue eyes shining with happiness. They wanted to see their mothers as they really are, wanted to be their kitten again…for as long as they had left.

“Look, kid. I’ve already warmed them up to the idea of being, mom's. So you go right ahead and just be you! Kitten had already started figuring out I’m an imposter anyway. Girl’s always been far

too observant and clever for her own good. I never could fool her for long." DT smirked.

"Really…" Finn gasped.

"I'm going underground for a bit, so I'll see you when I see you." DT explained, their face was impassive, even though their yellow eyes were shiny with tears.

"Ok…' Finn's response was small. They had endured several long episodes, growing up alone with the other's heirs. When their guardian had to disappear for a long time.

"When we do meet again, kiddo. I expect all my questions answered…I know your hiding things…don't know why, don't really care right now. But know that you will have to come clean about everything eventually. So enjoy yourself for right now." DT advised before cutting the feed.

Finn heaved a huge breath, nodding. They had heard DT tapping their claw against the metal amulet just out of screen. The chameleon was unraveling their secrets, they would not be able to play obtuse for much longer. Their small hand unconsciously released the side of the pad and flew to the pouch latched around their thigh. Needing to feel the shard, safe and secure in their keeping. Taking a quick sniff of the air. There had been a strange scent lurking out of sight, ever since they left the Valley of the Lost. Having followed them across the southern coasts of Etheria to Sea Worthy. They had also caught the scent on the Galleon here to Broland. So they had been extra vigilant ever since.

"I'll keep my promise, guys…" Finn pledged.

Hawk eventually found Finn on watch at the very tip of the northern promontory of the island. Perched upon a pale slender branch. High in the warm green canopy of the solidary Banyan Tree that grew at the very tip of this outcropping. Overlooking the

sea towards the mainland. With his old spyglass pressed to his left eye, fluffy golden tail swinging high in anticipation.

Banyan's usually only grew in the lowland parts of islands so finding one thriving so high up was a testament to this tree's grit and resilience. To defy the natural order of things and grow where it wanted to, no matter how harsh. Hawk had always admired this tree. It reminded him of his found family and how they had survived and built a thriving community here on the island.

Broland was the furthest out of a set of tidal islands, just off the coast of the Red Shore. The sea around the closer islands on low tide would dry up and one could walk ashore. But Broland was too far out to ever be without the protection of the waves.

After the shipwreck, the lost cabin boys of that fated merchant vessel had been pulled out to this island. It was long abandoned. Sheltered by grand stone arches, formed by the wind and eroded by the sea. That guarded the northern and southern arms of the island. Protected by treacherous shoals just beyond the arches. The only way into the harbor was through one of those grand stone archways, so unless you were an expert sailor who knew how to thread the needle. Your ship would be dashed upon those rocks.

Which was why the island was long abandoned, it was just too treacherous for most sailor's to attempt landfall. Which made a perfect oasis for them to build a home as they grew up. This island belonged to Bull, Hawk, Monkey and Mouse and only those they wanted to join their little village. Were taught the secrets of how to enter the well protected harbor of Broland Island.

"How's it going, Lad?" Sea Hawk offered, moving with ease, his steps long memorized in his youth. As he strode beneath the dangling aerial roots, that would one day burrow into the hard packed soil at the base of the tree. To become even more roots for the tree to draw nutrients from the ground. Moving with ease beneath the crown of branches and leaning casually against the trunk. Arms crossed over his defined chest, one booted foot lifted

to balance himself as he leaned his full weight into the tree. Stroking the tip of his mustache as he stared out between the curtain of leather brown roots. To the endless expanse of frothing waves beyond the cliff.

“Their coming…” Finn muttered, licking their lower lip in anticipation.

“Who…” Hawk smiled, feigning ignorance. He knew Finn’s story, as outlandish and crazy as it was. The child had confided in him during their journey to Sea Worthy, when Hawk had asked pointedly about the very familiar bandana they wore. Having memorized that piece of clothing as fondly as a well worn scar. He knew it was his…it was older and far more worn and threadbare than the one in his possession. So he wanted to know how this kitten had gained possession of it.

“My Mom’s are silly!” Finn declared in exasperation. Eek crawled out of the hood of their tan cloak. To sun itself atop the fluffy blonde mane of Finn’s head. Flopping their scaly self spread eagle over the top of the child's head with a contented sigh. Fluttering its multicolored wings briefly before tucking them tight to the sides, this long slender tail coiling around Finn’s dark furred ear.

“I see…well. Do you see their boat yet?” Hawk offered, with a chuckle.

“Yeah, It’s just out beyond the rocks.” Finn responded. “It's been there a while though.” the kit’s voice faltered in confusion. “I don’t want to come down, I’m not going to leave until I watch them dock, ok.” Finn continued, absently.

“I guess. I’ll leave you to it then.” Hawk nodded, pushing off from the trunk. “I was heading out beyond the guardian stones to retrieve them, but if you want to stay here I can’t force you to come along.” Hawk shrugged, making it only two steps before the slight weight of a small magicat landed on his back. Slender arms wrapped around his neck and a sharply grinning, toothy smile flashed in the periphery of his vision.

The laughter that erupted from Sea Hawk was boisterous, coming deep inside of his chest. The wholesome sound was full of amusement and unbridled happiness at the kittens' obvious excitement to not be left behind. He quickly braced an arm beneath Finn’s bottom to hold them more securely like a fuzzy backpack as he sauntered away from the tree and back into the forest behind.

Bow had guided the skiff over the shoal’s with ease, since the boat hovered on a cushion of air and not the water. But the arches blocking their path into the harbor was a whole nother problem. So he had circled the island hoping to find a better route but the northside was just sheer cliffs and the south was blocked by the granite archways. There was no safe way to enter the island? They had taken down the airfoil sail and were now just sitting beyond the island. Debating how or if they could navigate the skiff safely through the largest of the arches.

“I can do this, Arrows!” Catra stood at the wheel of the skiff, eye’s narrowing in determined scrutiny at the sea-worn, stone archways ahead. Bow was standing to her left, staring nervously at the navigation display screen. That had a bold red warning strobing on the top. [Course not recommended]

“If we were in space, sure, I’d believe you. But we are not, if you miss your mark even by an inch. This boat will be dashed upon the rocks and then be sunk…” Bow grumbled, the margin for error was too high.

Adora was hanging off the bow, having transformed her shield into a glowing lasso.

“I could swim through the arch and I could pull you through when I get on shore?” She shouted over her shoulder. She had been training all morning to summon She-Ra. With the limited amount of magic Sheana and Despara could offer, she couldn’t transform yet. But she could call upon a bit of She-Ra’s strength and speed.

Making her a stronger and faster Adora…which was fine she could work with that. Thankfully her weapon's transformation magic still worked.

"Maybe my Rune magic could teleport the skiff into the harbor?" Glimmer offered, leaning against the rail at the edge of the command deck with her arms crossed.

Catra released a long suffering groan at that idea, instantly feeling sick to her stomach.

Bow chuckled and gave her a consoling pat on the shoulder.

While Glimmer sighed heavily, "We need to figure out why you get sick when I blink. Cause you were just fine, way back when. When we kidnapped you, Horde Scum."

"No, I wasn't! I just wasn't going to show weakness to my captures. I should have just puked on you the first time, but I was in free fall out of the damn sky at the time and far too terrified to do anything but scream!" Catra retorted.

Glimmer cringed in regret. "Sorry…" She mumbled.

Catra sighed, "It's in the past, Sorry I got heated..I'm frustrated and I don't like water…being surrounded by it makes me very anxious." She explained softly.

"Ahoy, there friends!" Hawk shouted.

Adora rushed to the starboard side of the front deck, unfurling a rope ladder attached to the side. As Glimmer disappeared, only to reappear in sparkling light beside her on the lower deck.

They found Hawk rowing up to the skiff in a small boat, with the blonde kitten standing at the ready on the bow to climb aboard as soon as they reached the ladder. As their hands curled upon the side of the ladder, they jerked their chin over their shoulder and

sniffed. Then scrambled up the ladder as fast as they could, as if a demon was on their tail.

Hawk was startled at first, watching the ladder bang against the hull in Finn's haste to get aboard. Then he merely shrugged, figuring the kitten was just eager to reunite with their mother's.

After he moored the boat to the lower hull of the skiff, he climbed on board.

Chuckling fondly, when he found Finn standing nervously before Adora and Glimmer. Hands crossed behind their back and shifting on the balls of their feet, staring intently upon the deck. While Adora's gaze was transfixed upon the wing pin in their red ascot, that held a deep orange, blue and red crystal fragments embedded into the center. She recognized those shards, as her's and Catra's Runestones…

Bow was quick to climb down to the main deck and greet Hawk with a joyous shout and firm hug and pat on the back. While Catra remained aloof on the command deck, eyes focused on Finn taking in every detail of the kitten once more.

Hawk gave Finn a moment to unfreeze and greet them…but his eagerness had dissolved into awkward silence.

"Well, let's get you into the harbor." Hawk clapped Finn on the back, pointed up the main mast. "Get up there and be my eye's, Lad. If we run into trouble let me know."

":Aye, Aye…Uncle!" Finn snapped back. Blue eyes flying wide, then they swallowed and scaled the mast with their claws up to the top to avoid further questions.

Glimmer and Bow were confused, while Adora took a sharp breath. Glancing over her shoulder to Catra. Who wore the same surprised expression. They had spent the morning in bed, discussing Finn. The fact that the Finn back in Mystacor had changed, after their first crisis. How this Finn could not just be a coincidence…that there was something strange going on.

When Bow returned to the command deck, Catra gave him the wheel without a word. Hoping over the railing to the main deck, striding with purpose over to Adora.

“I’m going to get to the bottom of this mystery, Kay.” She brushed her hand across Adora’s shoulder as she passed by.

Adora nodded, never taking her eyes off the kitten.Staring up a tiny metal perch that acted like a crowsnest at the very top of the mast. As they extended the spyglass pressing to their left eye.

When Catra climbed up to stand beside them, the kitten sniffed then stood stiff with their back straight. Adora chuckled, at the sight of the two magicats greeting each other. The kitten’s tail had puffed up, when they smelled Catra. While Catra’s long dark tail was flicking in long swipes. Finn was quick to wrap their offending tail around their waist to conceal their emotion. As Catra smirked and sat down beside them so they would be relatively the same height.

“Hey, Finn.” Catra greeted, softly. Kicking her bare feet over the edge of the platform, keeping her eyes ahead. As the skiff began to slowly float forward towards the largest archway with Hawk at the helm.

“Hi…” Finn breathed back, focusing ahead through the spyglass as the archway drew near.

“I have lots of questions, but I need just one answered for now.” Catra offered.

“Ok…” Finn agreed.

“Back in Old Grimbles barn, you sang a song for me?” Catra began. ”Can you sing it for me now?”

Finn swallowed then smirked, yep. Their mom had it all figured out, they didn’t need to hide anymore.

“Grumpy cat, Grumpy cat.”

“She is so very grumpy.”

“You gotta remember, she's got a temper.”

“Scowling and shouting, scaring and snapping, stomping her feet upon the ground.” Finn crooned, with a slowly growing smile. While Catra nodded and grinned up at them in relief.

“Causing trouble with everyone, all around.”

“Grumpy cat, Grumpy cat!” Finn finished with a flourish, tossing the spyglass and catching it. Just as the mast passed beneath the archway. As the shadow of the stone passed over them, Finn sat down beside her. Joyful tears streaming down their cheeks, as Catra wrapped them up in a tender embrace. Combing her claws down their short blonde mane tenderly, as Finn sobbed uncontrollably into the front of her white shirt.

“I missed you so much, Mother!” Finn wailed, wrapping their arms around her tight as their whole body shook with the force of their wails. Finally after years of grief and loneliness, they could claim their hearts desire. They were once more in the safety and comforting arms of their Mother. That they had lost, the one who had died to protect them.

Flotsam and Jetsam

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm and Odd Bodkin for your comments. I so appreciate reading them. Thank you also for the Kudo's! It's been a minute since I updated, but here you go. Enjoy.

The warmth of the sun cascaded over them once again, as the skiff hovered past the massive stone archway and into the sheltered harbor. Finn felt a feather light touch against their thigh and the slight pull of a tiny object being extracted carefully from the leather pouch strapped to their upper leg.

With a startled gasp, they shot out of Catra's embrace. The sheltering warmth and security of their mother's arms falling away. Sniffing the air, as a desperate panic set in. They had been so distracted by their breakdown they hadn't been paying attention. Allowing the unknown thief to get far to close! "Finn…what's wrong?" Catra's worried voice filtered through the fog of raw, unfocused panic currently pulsing through them.

Finn patted the pouch, finding it empty. Their heart rate exploded in their chest, as their keen eyes scanned the lower deck of the skiff. The thief couldn't get away! They had to find them! Stop them…they needed to fulfill their promise…nothing else mattered but that!

"Someone's been following me since The Crimson Waste…it took the shard!" They shouted. Leaping to their feet, legs primed to catapult themselves right off the main mast if needs be.

Catra was instantly in motion, leaping from the platform. Swinging down the metal pole, in a spirling arc by one clawed hand. The deafening screech of shredding iron, following her descent to the deck. Sending an alert to Melog below deck, that they had an intruder aboard.

“What is happening!” Sea Hawk exclaimed from the wheel. As Bow cocked his crossbows, by flexing his arms over his head in a powerful flourish. While Glimmer called her staff into her hand and teleported from the upper deck to the bow. Intent on blocking whatever prey had set Catra into motion. Adora had been at the stern, when Catra had swung down the mast. She had swiftly vaulted around the cabin, sword in hand, scanning the forward deck. Her blue eyes glowing with power as she summoned what she could of She-ra’s magic.

“Someone stole the shard!” Finn called down to them. As they watched their mother in awe, as she prowled the lower deck. Sniffing and skulking around the central cabin. Her movements were smooth and silent. The form and poise of a perfect predator on the hunt for their prey. As the huge maroon toned lion prowled up onto deck from below. Their mane and tail snapping a fiery red.

Finn scanned the deck, slowly searching for any sign of the thief. As Adora, Bow and Glimmer began to scour the boat as well. Sea Hawk maintained course across the calm, sparkling water of the harbor, unaware of their stowaway. Waving in greeting to the small sloops, with fisherman casting nets as they passed. Heading unerringly towards the large dock, jutting out of the beach before the small village.

Just as they docked and Hawk leaped over the railing to moor the skiff. Finn finally caught sight of a familiar cloud of sparkles on the very tip of the bow. It floated over the forward beak of the skiff and onto the dock as silent as a shadow.

“There ... .the thief’s getting away!” Finn declared leaping off the mast and landing in a forward roll upon the dock. Bounding away on all fours towards the beach at full speed, with Catra running on all fours behind them. Melog raced after the two magicats, glowing blue eyes determined to catch up. Adora leaped sideways over the side railing, by one powerful hand. Sprinting after Melog, chin tucked tight to her collar bone and eyes firm and determined to catch up.

“Should I just blink…to them in a few minutes?” Glimmer offered, watching the four of them churning up a cloud of sand as they raced up the beachfront.

Bow tapped his bracer’s, sheathing his crossbows with a slight shake of his head.

“Naw I think they got this.” He advised, catching sight of Mermista waving to them from the grassy embankment at the top of the beach just beyond the dock. She watched the four race off with a mildly confused expression then shrugged, shaking her head with an amused chuckle. As the magicats and Melog quickly left Adora behind. She ambled down the narrow dirt path down from the village towards the beach. Keeping a close eye on Adora until the single-minded soldier, intent on keeping up to her feline partner disappeared from view. Things never really changed, Adora was always chasing Catra in one way or another. Their lively antics warmed her heart, her worries and anger faded away. She had been struggling lately to stay positive. She really needed to see those two idiot’s acting so carefree. She felt lighter again, more focused on seeing her plans through to fruition. Having her friends here to support her, she felt she could accomplish anything!

Catra had caught sight of the same sparkles as Finn. A nagging memory of her past life itching in her mind. The three of them raced down the beach head, kicking sand up into the air as they tore away from the dock at top speed. Tails high and curled, as every muscle became electrified and their senses became heightened as the hunt began.

The change was instantaneous as predatory instincts, long dormant, began to take control.

Finn was a few feet ahead, at the edge of the beach. Sniffing the wall of clustered ferns, blue eyes dark as their pupils were fully

dilated. Catra moved in silently beside them, eyes alert and unblinking as she scanned the forest sprawling out before them.

Melog chirped excitedly from a few feet away, having moved into the heavy growth of ferns. Only their long maroon tail could be seen, like a periscope cutting above the foliage. Catra and Finn barely acknowledged each other, slinking silently after Melog. As the lion led them deeper into the forest. Catra's ear's flickered, as she heard the faintest whisper of movement just to the left of a tall coconut tree. Finn heard it too and crouched low to the ground, crawling cautiously, as they flanked the tree under the cover of the ferns' wide leaves. Moving in slowly, butt high and fluffy tail lashing with excitement.

Catra slunk to the right, sniffing and creeping forward to block their prey's escape. As Melog mirrored both Magicats from their position a few feet ahead of the slender tree.

Finn's lips vibrated against their fangs, as a short trill issued from their throat as they closed in on the base of the tree. Their invisible prey was just in front of them, cowering behind the tree. They could not see them, but they could smell them! The sharp, tangy scent of sweat and fear was thick in the air. The heavy puffs of breath from panic and over exertion, whispering into their sharp ear's. Pinpointing their prey's location perfectly.

Then the prey scampered lightning fast up the tree! Finn growled and lunged for the trunk, claws extended but missed, slashing the trunk instead. Just as Catra darted to the side, leaping higher and swatting the air a few feet up above Finn's head. Slashing the tree with her claws and batting their prey off the trunk.

There was a squeal of fright, then a thump as the invisible thief hit the ground. Followed by a puff of sparkles. As a small, stout pixie appeared sprawled and dazed upon the ground. She had soft sand colored fur, covering a sweet, round face. Cheeks flushed scarlett and face sweaty, from her wild dash across the beach. With a short, impish nose and two large, soft brown almond shaped eyes. That were staring up at them in confusion, blinking

rapidly to clear away the frightened tears. She had short pale pink hair, tied up in twin ponytails on either side of her head. Fluffy bangs hanging low over her thin eyebrows, brushing against her eyelids. Wearing mismatched pieces of old Horde military armor. A pair of ballistic goggles were perched high upon her forehead, with one cracked lens. Her large pointed ears were folded back and her matching pink striped tail was thumping on the ground in fury. The silver metal gauntlets were repurposed as shin guards. A black sleeveless leather jerkin covered her torso, her bare arms covered in thin white scars that criss crossed over her biceps like stripes. A dagger was sheathed upon her hip in a thin leather belt. Along with a wider belt strapped across her torso, that held a bulging sack upon her back. She made no attempt to arm herself. Laying flat on the ground, chest heaving for air as she struggled to come back to her senses after being smacked so hard to the ground.

Melog sniffed and whined, sitting down on their haunches attempting to look less threatening. Sending Catra an urgent call for calm, as curiosity washed over them. This creature was pure magic? It was the first of its kind, they had ever met on Etheria? So much like themselves…not a golem…not a tool? But free…their magic was their own…birthed from the True Heart of Etheria perhaps. An ancient conduit of magic…one of the first races?

"Who are you?' Catra braced her hands on her hips, glowering down at the pixie.

"Kei-Lee…" The pixie muttered, never looking up but casting her eyes to the side in shame.

"Give it back!" Finn stalked towards her, hand out.

Kei-Lee growled, eyes darting up warily and staring awestruck at the three cats now caging her between them. Her eyes widened in shock, the shadow of disbelief quickly brightened by hope. As they fell on Catra. So focused on her mission, she had never taken into account how improbable it was for Magicats to be on Etheria? Now she was confronted by a legend…made flesh… Swallowing

her pride, she slowly pulled out a leather pouch hidden beneath her jerkin.

“Kaira…Child lost to Time, Daughter of Aoi, Rune Bearer of Fire…” She muttered, as if whispering a prayer. Deftly digging her fingers into the leather pouch now dangling from her neck. With a resigned sigh she pulled out the shard handing it towards Catra. Catra nodded, crouching down and reached to take the shard. As Finn crossed their arms with an affronted huff. Catra had no time to ponder why or how this pixie knew about her other name. As it was then, Adora exploded, through the wall of fern’s sword in hand. Heaving for air, cheeks flushed and sweat beaded down her face.

“By the stars above you three are so fast!” She gasped, quicking taking her position to complete the circle around the pixie blocking Kei-Lee’s escape completely.

Finn cast Adora a knowing smile over their shoulder. “You always say that, Momma.”

Adora sucked in a startled breath, sending Catra a surprised look. They had spoken for a long time this morning about Finn and all their crazy theories they both had. But to hear the kitten call her mom so fondly…it was still a shock to hear.

But getting to the bottom of it all was for later.

“Why did you steal the shard?” Catra demanded, tucking the crystal away in the pocket of her leather coat. She would find a more secure place for it later, giving it back to Finn was not an option. It is far too dangerous for a child to be responsible for.

Finn nibbled on their lower lip, releasing another puff of frustrated air through tight lips. As the shard disappeared into Catra’s pocket.

“My people vowed a thousand years ago to guard the Shard of Kaydak. We hid it away and kept its location secret for generations. But it was stolen several decades ago from its hiding

place. I and several others were charged with the duty to find it and bring it back." Kei-Lee sighed, shoulder's pitched forward and eyes downcast. She had spent so many years away from her people. Scouring every inch of Etheria for the shard. Only to have it in her grasp for mere moments before it was taken again. She felt like such a failure…
"Light Spinner." Adora recalled her sword and crossed her arms over her chest. As the magic reformed into her silver bracer.

Catra turned, silently inquiring for Adora to explain with a stern look.

"The Crystal Castle…absorbed Shadow Weaver's memories during her final moments. It showed me her life and her obsession with the Spell of Obtainment, she needed the Shard of Kaydak to invoke the spell."

"The magic dust in her vials…it was crushed up crystal from the shard." Catra nodded, "It allowed her to use the deep magic…"

"The power of the Nameless One devours any who seek to call upon its magic. " Finn added. Both women turned in horror to the kitten. Finding the blonde Magicat, staring back at them, their soft blue eyes shadowed by grim memories.

"How do you know so much about the Nameless One?" Catra demanded, griping Finn's shoulder's tight.

"I grew up under the threat of their resurrection. The Queen's of Etheria…gave their lives to protect the universe…" Finn began their voice rough with grief, as a single tear escaped to trickle down their cheek.

Catra was taken off guard by Finn's blunt answer of her friend's future sacrifice. Her blood ran cold at the prospect of losing them all. Losing Adora!

"When she teleported to Bright Moon…she was dying?" Adora turned to Finn, filing away the kitten's words to deal with later.
"So when she teleported herself and Catra into the Beacon…with

that demon's magic…she was already dying. So she had nothing to lose anymore, when she led me to the Heart…" she muttered, slowly working it out.

"Shadow Weaver had to use the Black Garnet's magic to keep herself alive after casting the Spell of Obtainment, when I destroyed her channeling shard in her mask. She had begun to decay again…I don't know…part of me thinks she was already a living corpse after that spell.." Catra brushed her hands through her hair, needing to calm herself. Talking about the Nameless One always sent her anxiety sky high. Finn had retreated out of her grasp and was leaning against a nearby palm tree. Arms crossed over their stomach, comforting themselves. Lost to their thoughts, as they stared outward towards the sunlit beach and the rolling waves. Beginning to devise plans to steal the shard back from their mother.

"One step away from a Husk." Adora braced her hands on her hips and cast her gaze skyward. Closing her eyes briefly to absorb the warmth of the sun overhead, needing to soothe herself.

"The shard is cursed, it only brings death and destruction to any who seek to possess it. " Kei-Lee cautiously rose up onto her large, furry feet. Dusting herself off, indignantly. "Which is why the shard needs to stay hidden." She grumbled with finality.

"Or destroyed." Catra snapped back, standing up.

Finn glanced over their shoulder, briefly. Silently agreeing with her statement.

"Let's head back. I saw Mermista heading for the dock. " Adora chucked a thumb back towards the beach. Catra moved after Adora with Melog trotting behind.

The short pixie scowled up at Finn as she passed by the kitten. Finn paid her only an acknowledging nod, before they followed after their mother's. Kei-Lee huffed and kicked a few stones as she debated what to do. Her presence was known, but she

couldn’t return to her people empty handed. So she decided to stick with Kaira, at some point she would get another chance to steal the shard and next time she wouldn’t get caught.

The trek down the beach was silent and full of unresolved tension. As Finn marched ahead of them all. Stomping angrily across the sand, with their hands balled into fists at their sides. It was a given the kitten was mad, because Catra would not give them the crystal. Adora kept giving Catra small furtive glances at a loss as to how to ever start this conversation about Finn’s origin. Catra was idly petting Melog’s coat, staring avidly at Finn, lost in thought and never even glancing up at Adora.

Kei-Lee found the women’s reluctance to confront the child annoying. It all made little sense, how could these young adults have a child so old? The kitten looked to be about ten and they were barely twenty? She was eager to find the truth and they obviously needed to hear it as well.

Trotting ahead to catch up to Finn. Kei-Lee resorted to her most powerful weapon to gain the Kitten’s trust. Her natural pixie charm…that consisted of her shimmering invisible and tripping the kitten up. Who promptly face planted into the sand with a yelp, as she reappeared in a cloud of sparkles.

“What's your hurry?” Kei-Lee grinned brightly down at them.

Finn glowered up at her.

“Finn, are you alright!” Adora shouted, rushing to their side. Worried that they had hurt themselves. Her motherly instincts kicked in unconsciously. Not realizing it was Kei-Lee who made them stumble and not some random sharp stone or twig hidden in the sand.

“I’m fine, Momma.” Finn groaned, raising themselves up on their elbows.

“You know that makes no sense, right?” Kei-Lee hopped on their chest, like a furry gargoyle ready to strike.

“Ooof.” Finn grunted, eyes flying wide in alarm as they were once again flat on their back. Finding oddly that the pixie was not heavy at all?

“How can two women so young have a kid so old?” Kei-Lee’s eyes narrowed in scrutiny, as she braced her chin with her palms, her elbows resting on her raised knees.

“I’m not from here, exactly.” Finn answered breathlessly.

“Then where are you from?” Catra asked as she plucked Kei-Lee from their chest, by grabbing her by the collar of her leather jerkin at the back of her neck and dropping her to the sand. Kei-Lee landed on her butt, sticking her tongue out at Catra impishly.

“You're no fun, Kaira.” Kei-Lee pouted.

“My name is Catra.” The magicat shot back with a rueful smile. The familiarity of this playful exchange is so reminiscent of her parents' relationship with Loo-Kee. A fondness for Kei-Lee was quickly growing in her heart.

“Then where or when are you from?” Adora confronted them, gently as she grasped Finn’s hands and pulled them back up to their feet.

Finn chuckled and rubbed the back of their head nervously. “It’s a long…long story…and kinda hard to explain. But for now. Lets just say I am from a different dimension...in time and space..yeah, that sorta fits.” The kitten reasoned, nodding in agreement to themselves.

“When we get the time, I want to hear it all. Cause you are honestly freaking me out.” Catra retorted bluntly.

While Adora ruffled Finn’s hair, seeking to ease their anxiety. “We’ve gotten used to strange stuff happening, but yeah…this is a

whole new kinda ‘strange’ for us.”

Finn grinned and nodded, content that they were adapting to the concept.

“I promise.”

Glimmer and Bow were nowhere to be seen, perhaps below deck? Or in the village they had passed along the beach. But they found Mermista pacing at the end of the dock, hands on her hips and muttering furiously under her breath. Her brow was furrowed, thinking…strategizing…perhaps. The ocean was churning beneath her feet under the wooden planks, frothing around the thick poles that held the dock in place above the water. The violence of the water gave away that she was obviously brooding over something.

Sea Hawk was nearby, sitting on the frayed top of the worn corner post of the dock, arms crossed and keeping a close eye on the seething water princess. Waiting for his cue to intercede and calm her down. If his timing was off and she found his concern annoying the sea would no doubt retaliate and he would be treading water far out in the bay. Mermista could be as unpredictable and volatile as the sea itself, but he was an experienced sea captain. He could navigate the most treacherous of water’s so dealing with Mermista’s moods was child’s play.

At least that’s what he told himself…

Catra was wary and slowed her approach, having been on the receiving end of Mermista’s ire far too often. All earned, she admits bitterly. Adora on the other hand, picked up her pace. Practically jogging up too Mermista to inquire what was going on. Her big heart and tireless courage always pushed her to face any danger head on.

Finn noticed Catra's unease and easily slipped their hand into her's. Offering her a warm, reassuring smile when she turned to regard them. The corner of Catra's mouth pulled up in a soft lopsided smile. At the kid's tender instincts. So much like Adora…

"This is sooooo annoying…" Mermista grumbled, grinding her index fingers in small circles on her temples.

"What's going on?" Adora urged, her tone hard, as if barking a command.

"My father…" Mermista groaned his name like it was a curse. "I had gotten reports that he was rebuilding the Salineas fleet. He only had a handful of ships a few weeks back, basically whatever had survived the war. But now! Now he has a whole damn armada of ships…I have no idea….how he got them built so fast. " Mermista huffed, her story interrupted by the chime of Glimmer's blink. Followed by a massive wall of shimmering sparkles, as a huge amount of stacked crates and baskets of food appeared on the beach before the dock. Along with Bow, a very short and slight sea elf dressed in gray slacks and a billowing white shirt. A huge dark skinned man, with long dread locks. Dressed in dull green, short sleeve tunic and dark pants. Standing conspicuously to close, just behind Glimmer. They were dressed just as roguishly as Sea Hawk…looking more like pirates…then simple island villager's. Bow was already enamored by them. Staring moon eyed. Up at the large man and his massive bulk of muscle.

The smug smile gracing the Queen of Bright Moon's face was well earned. As she had just proven with her Rune Magic. That it was far more powerful than what the Moon Stone had offered her. By teleporting the entire warehouse of supplies and several people all in one go.

"Bull….Mouse." Hawk quickly stood up and moved down the dock to greet them.

Mouse gave him a curt nod, as they passed by. Pulling out a thin metal chain from around her neck, that now held not only the

sharp shell but several other small trinkets. She unhooked a hollowed out coin and unwound the leather cord that was wrapped around the metal sphere. Spinning the coin high over her head as they reached the end of the dock. The mid morning sun glinted over the metal like a pulsing star, signaling the sloops out in the harbor.

"That was amazing, your majesty." Bull gushed, moving in even closer to Glimmer's backside and giving her shoulders a light squeeze of affection. Before swaggering down the dock towards Hawk. Calling out to the man with a thundering roar and raising a fist over this head.

Glimmer instantly blushed under the large man's praise. As Bow's eyes narrowed in irritation. His adoration for the man cooled instantly, as he finally caught on to the man's ulterior motives to constantly praising Glimmer for every little thing she did for the last few hours. The man was obviously attracted to the Queen of Bright Moon and Glimmer so far was soaking up the man's attention like a thirsty sponge. Bow was accustomed to dealing with jealousy…but his blood was boiling.

Catra, always alert and observant to strangers, caught the less than platonic exchange between the large man and Glimmer as well. Passing Bow a surprised, ` what the hell' expression. The archer merely shrugged, grinding his teeth as he turned his back on them all. Unlatching his tracker pad and pretending to scroll through some information.

Two large sloop's docked on the other side of the dock and a handful of deck hands disembarked to load up the ships on gang planks.

"Those Galleon's and Garracks…they were not newly built." Sea Hawk chimed in, having information to share.

Mermista stopped mid stride and glared at him. It was then that he promptly fell silent.

“How do you know that?” Adora asked. While Catra and Finn moved past her, something had caught their attention in the water. They cautiously made their way to the edge of the dock. Crouching at the edge, keen feline eyes tracking a flickering shadow moving below the surface. Melog yeowled from the deck of their skiff, prowling towards the stern.

Kei-Lee had climbed up the main mast and was sitting on the upper crows nest platform. Kicking her feet and watching the water below with a knowing smirk. From her vantage point so high up, she could make out the sleek, crisp movements of tail fins.

Just as Catra and Finn leaned over the edge of the dock to get a better look. A giant splash of water cascaded over them. They hissed and scuttled backward, as sweet melodic giggles echoed from below the dock.

Mermista chuckled softly, her ire forgotten at the sound of mischievous laughter. Passing the two soggy magicats, now sprawled on the dock. She leaned over the edge, her deep blue eyes glinting with mirth and her grin beaming at who floated below.

“Lyra…Ella…you had your fun now get up here. ” Mermista called down to the water.

Adora had her sword drawn the second, Catra and Finn got splashed. Now she watched two teens bobbing in the waves away from the dock. Both had similar tan skin as Mermista, but that was all they had in common. Swimming for shore, their lower half shimmering with the scales and wide fins of mermaids. One tail was a pearly white the other deep aqua blue. Once they reached shore, their tail’s faded away as they walked out of the tide. One was slight and overly slender. With long, straight golden hair that had just a hint of curl on the ends. Her clothes were simple, a tight black breast wrap, with a shimmering silver shawl draped over her shoulder’ and pearl blue tights. With a shell pauldron similar to Mermista’s tuck under the shawl on her right shoulder,

with an elegant harp, carved from pale bleached bones strapped to her back. The other teen was more broad, with toned arms and thick well muscled thighs. Her hair was raven, black. Bouncing near her shoulders in tight ringlets. Wearing flowing sheer blue pants and a deep blue halter top, accented by silk draping over each shoulder in a hooded capelet style cape. With shell encrusted bracers on each wrist, a dagger belt hung heavy around her curving hips. The many blades gleaming in the mid-morning sun.

"Who are they?" Adora whispered to Sea Hawk.

"Mermista's younger sisters." Hawk explained with a small smile.

"How many does she have?" Catra whimpered from the dock in dread. As she was now on all four's shaking out her mane. Splattering water everywhere, as she shook out her tail as well. Finn quickly followed suit. Water droplets misting the air around them.

"Well…My dearest Mermista has eight sisters…and four brother's… that I know about." Sea Hawk shrugged, "King Triton was a rather virile merman in his youth and had many liaison's all across the Archipelago." he finished slyly, as Mermista walked briskly down the dock. Her scowl once more firmly in place as she approached her sister's.

Catra whined in defeat and flopped onto her back on the dock. Mermista already teased her mercilessly and now it looked like it ran in the family. How was she going to survive…with even more Salineas royalty out to make a fool of her…for their own amusement. Adora was alarmed by Catra's defeatist antic's and rushed to her side to console her.

They retreated to the open hale for the noontime meal. Sitting along simple wooden benches, made of cut pine trunks. Polished

and lacquered to withstand the salt water misting up from the shore. The long tables were scavenged planks from sea vessels, gray and weathered. Now covered in platters of freshly grilled fish and roasted vegetables from the village gardens. With baskets of fresh sweet rolls decorated on top with icing sweetened with honey and bowls of island fruits lining the center of the table. Adora instantly dug into the repaste, with the vigor of a starving woman. Finn sat between her and Catra, nibbling on a sticky bun lost in thought. As Catra's tail whipped back and forth merrily as she salivated over her large helping of fish. Glimmer and Bow sat on the other side of the table, with Bull and Mouse. Bow had placed himself beside Bull on purpose, ushering Glimmer beside him and as far away from the muscle bound pirate as he could. Keeping a close eye on the man, in case he tried to flirt with Glimmer again.

Local's were clustered all around them, speaking in low, conspiratorial whispers. Scrutinizing the group with casual looks, that turned into lingering glares of loathing towards Catra. Who was becoming smaller and more withdrawn as the meal continued. Ear's twitching and tail lashing became more and more aggressive, as Finn began to scratch a claw nervously into the table top. Keeping their eyes downcast, as their ears perked up and tail dropped low as the tension in the hale mounted.

Sea Hawk, Mermista and her sister's sat near the end of the table speaking in hushed tones at first. Before Mermista groaned and crossed her arms on top of the table and slammed her face down into her arms with a dramatic cry of absolute horror and despair.

Which got everyone's attention instantly. Kei-Lee reappeared in a cloud of sparkles, leaning against a pole with a bun stuffed with fish half eaten in her hand.

"Care to share with the rest of us?" Catra arched an eyebrow pointedly as she firmly regarded Mermista. Now avidly ignoring the veiled threats surrounding her, she would not retaliate if the villagers decided to attack. But she would defend herself…so her ear's remained perked upward listening.

Adora’s mouth was full so all she could do was grunt in agreement.

“We’re here to help.” Glimmer offered, “I could call in more princesses if you need?”

“Brojee and Drissi are scavenging abandoned Horde tech around the canyon’s in the Crimson Waste with Darla.” Bow shrugged,”I could have them here asap?”

“No…more people would only draw more attention to us.” Mermista sighed, bracing her chin in a palm as she sulked.

“We were doing recon, around the Royal Island. It seems our father’s new fleet of ships was funded by Meadowlands.” Lyr smiled sadly, brushing her golden hair back behind her ear as she daintily forked up a bite of fish from her plate.

“The Andreenids are xenophobes?” Glimmer stated in shock.

“Why would they care about helping Salineas?” Bow brow furrowed in contemplation.

“Sweet Bee, recognized the ships your father has positioned as a blockade at Sea Worthy.” Sea Hawk added, finally have a chance to explain.. “They are over a thousand years old…once stored in the Meadowlands archives.”

“So King Buzz is now allied with your father?” Glimmer tapped an index finger anxiously against the table.

“I guess…” Mermista shrugged.

“But why…” Adora grumbled, finally chewing enough to swallow her mouthful.

“He wants something…obviously! I just don’t know what…yet.” Mermista heaved herself up from the table. Casting her sister's pointed looks of silent command, who merely nodded and strode

away down the beach. Wading into the water and disappearing into the waves.

"Anyway. I've got more important things to focus on right now. The resistance has to guard these aid supplies. As we hop islands, for the next few days. We're headed to the southern arm of the Archipelago. So let's get going, my people can't rebuild without these supplies." Mermista declaired, heading back towards the dock and the now fully loaded sloops.

Bow and Glimmer all shared a concerned look. Before scrambling after Sea Hawk, Bull and Mouse who were following the dethroned Princess of Salineas back to the boats. Catra was hesitant to follow, sitting stiffly at the table watching the rest leaving. Her tail curled tightly around her stomach, as she stared forlorn down at her twiddling fingers in her lap. Adora had heard the harsh whispers from the local's eating nearby but couldn't really make out what they were saying. But Catra had… her ears never stopped twitching and she had barely ate. Whatever had been said, it had hurt and left her wallowing in her regrets once more.

Adora understood how hard this was going to be for her…to be here. Among people who hated her, had every right to despise her for what she had done. To want to seek retribution for the destruction of their homes, the deaths of their loved ones.

Adora was about to reach out and reassure her, when Finn climbed into Catra's lap. Straddling the older magicat and cupping her cheeks in both of their smaller hands. Forcing Catra to look up at them.

"Look at me, Mother. You can't change the past and it hurts. I know. " Finn cringed inwardly at how hypocritical that sounded. But quickly shrugged off their guilt, some pain and suffering was necessary to mold their mother into the honorable Queen she would one day become. "But you need to move on from it, learn from it. Your future's not set in stone, you have the power to change it. Just like you had the power to change yourself…right?"

They declared earnestly, giving her squished cheeks a shake. "This is your chance to make things right, I believe in you…it's time to start carving out your legacy. "

"Finn…" Catra mumbled, pulling their hands off her face gently. "Thank you…" She sighed, offering them a small smile of gratitude. Once again, this kitten, who seemed far wiser than they should be at their age. Put it all into perspective in only a few choice words. She needed to be brave…right now.

Finn nodded and hopped off her lap, dashing for the edge of the open hale and offered their mother a gloved hand.

"Are you coming?" Finn asked with a radiantly adorable grin.

Adora and Catra laughed and quickly left the table. They each took one of the kitten's hands and swung them playfully between them as they made their way down the beach.

Kei-Lee followed in their merry wake, chewing on her bottom lip as she began to question her duty to her people, to her great, great grandfather…who was hell bent on returning the shard to its prison. It hadn't been that safe before…the Sorcerer had found its hiding place in the ruins of the oasis within Serenia and stole it easily enough. Which had them in this mess to begin with? Perhaps the shard needed stronger warriors to guard it? Who better to keep it safe than She-Ra and the Rune Bearer's of Etheria? Or perhaps there was a way to destroy the shard? Then the Nameless One would have one less conduit to use. To whisper their lies into the ears of troubled souls. There had to be a better way to keep that demon contained in the Timeless Dimension.

Moirai

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to all who left comments and kudo's. I've been gone for a bit...the writer's block is real!!! But I finally have something to share so enjoy.
> I will be posting a companion piece shortly that I have started to work on. It will be a series of short stories and scenes from my Series, Tapestry of Time that didn't make into the main story. It will be called 'The Moments Between.'

The Moirai islands were a haunted place, touchstones to the primordial magic of Etheria much like the Whispering Woods. Each island in the tiny chain of three, as distinct as each Immortal sister they were named after. The first island, Nora, was modest. With low forest peaks upon a small mountain and long, sandy shorelines. That held the majority of its inhabitants in small villages scattered along the coast in numerous giant chitin shell structures that resembled massive sea shells of all shapes and sizes. Just like Salineas, which had twin stone statues on either side of the Sea Gate. Each island held a mighty effigy to the goddess whose magic governed the island. Nora’s monument was a wild haired, old crone hunched over a wooden staff made of twisting willow branches, with pale butterfly wings protruding from her back. Carved upon the high cliff’s that overlooked the massive bay that spanned the three islands.

While the central island, Dewma was lush and vibrant with nature, with a thin grassy coastline that receded into a low, sprawling valley. Protected by the forest that blanketed the hills to the south and a grand mountain that ascended upward on the far side of the valley. A massive waterfall crashed down the mountain, pooling into a clear lake that dominated the valley below. Large

towns had flourished around the sheltered body of water. The shell-like tower's and smaller dwellings similar to what lay on every other Salineas island. The mountain held the effigy of a young woman swathed in a robe of feathers, her head cowled in a predatory bird's head. The hooked beak protruded from her hood, covering her face in long shadow's. She also held a staff, crosswise over her chest. The top of the staff held a bird with wings outstretched. Just like her sister's statue, she was carved to face the bay.

While the last island, Morta dominated the outer edge of the island chain. Rugged and rocky, with barely any shoreline to speak off. Dark forest covered the upper reaches, the trees and villages that lay within its green embrace. Always enshrouded by a constant mist. Moving among the ancient tree's, as if driven by some unseen force to keep the inhabitants within, concealed from the outside world. At the tip of the island, was an angelic effigy. Carved out of the rugged coastline itself. A small child draped in thin garments that covered her entire body and face like a death shroud. Elegant wings outstretched upon her back, her tiny hands thrusting a staff outward. At the very top of the staff was an elegant lantern.

Volcanic spires rose out of the ocean like giant teeth around the outer edge of Morta and Nora, scattered among the reef beds that surrounded the islands. As natural monoliths to guide ships into a narrow channel. That would lead them into the shelter of the bay within.

A lone figure moved silently and unseen as any spirit, amid the rolling mist that blanketed the ground. Swathed in a deep indigo cloak, resembling the fog at dusk. He had a heavy gait, moving forward with long strides. A heavy hood was pulled up, shielding his face from view. Tall and broad of shoulders, he wore steel banded leather armor and a long tan hide tunic draped overtop. The simple leather wrapped hilt of a broad sword hung from his

hip. Along with a quiver of arrows over his left shoulder and a long curving maple wood bow.

Weaving through the ancient Koa trees that crowned the island of Morta. The hardy growth of thick trunks and twisting roots, creating natural corridors through the woods. The wide canopy of branches fanning out to an umbrella of leaves fragmenting the night sky like cracked glass.

The figure headed upward towards the island's rocky pinnacle, which sheltered its lush plateau's that jutted out from the southside. Cool wind blew up from the cliff's edge and billowed the deep indigo cloak. As he walked out of cover and onto the narrow foot trails upon the upper heath. The dying twilight finally succumbed as night fell. What meager light the Greater Moon's cast, as they hide behind the blanket of clouds was not enough to see by. But his steps were precise and long memorized in his youth. As he was creeping up the tall rise of dried grass, to the crest of the plateau. That overlooked the southern, rocky shores of the island. Scanning the barren shoreline of large boulder's and sharp standing stones, outward to the frothing ocean crashing below. Slamming upon the jagged rocks that jutted like teeth from the depths of the open ocean beyond the island. The final sliver of light from the setting sun, flashing upon the waves on the far off horizon. As darkness moved to cover the island. He rose to a stand, turning to look over his shoulder briefly.

As a very lanky, hound bounded up to him. It had a large, squared shaped head, was mostly white with gray spots along its back and matching floppy ears. Sitting obediently at his side, as he continued his reconnaissance of the ocean beyond. Panting and long tongue lolling, warm brown eyes staring with pure adoration up at the man who cared for them.

"She was due hours ago? " He mused, "I shall keep watch until dawn, Argus. Then if my sister and her convoy do not arrive, I shall set sail to find her." With a tired grunt, Orion sat upon the crest of the cliff. Amber eyes vigilant to the treacherous sea's below as night sets in.

Dusk was falling as the convoy of sloops traveled over the open sea. The three ships bobbed in the waves, ascending and descending out of view upon the massive waves. While the sleek lines of the glorified skiff led the way. Cutting over the waves on an air cushion, created by its back thrusters and stabilizing rotor blades, positioned on narrow fin's that jutted out along the sides of the wide hull. The convoy had set off for Moirai later than planned. Mermista had wanted to wait for Adora and the other's to arrive. Delayed most of the day outside Broland, nervous and uncertain as to how to enter safely through the guarding stones. By the time the Sloops had been loaded and the crew's exchanged for fresh sailor's. So they had set off late in the day, the convoy of ships had at sea for a couple days now, one more night in the open water and then they would reach the three Sister's by dawn.

"Every ship needs a name Bow." Sea Hawk beseeched, with a wide eyed pleading gaze.

Bow cast him a soft look of mild amusement, shaking his head. Trying to stay focused on maintaining their course. Holding tight to the wheel, while glancing down at the various monitor's set in front of him. It was cute how ardent Sea Hawk was about nautical traditions.

"I have no idea. It's built from several skiff's and various other pieces of Horde Tech and equipment. I scavenged from the scrap yard in Scorpania…with Brojee and his crew." Bow started, pondering the idea for a bit before turning to Sea Hawk. Brown eyes bright with a sudden epiphany.

"Skiffy!" Bow declared triumphantly.

To which Sea Hawk cringed and clapped him hard on the back.

"We'll work on the name…together." He declared with a belly laugh.

As Bow merely nodded, having now heard the name out loud and realizing how absolutely lame it was.

"Entrapta is so much better at naming ships than I am." Bow pouted, staring ahead over the lower deck to find Catra leaning against the railing on the bow, lost in thought. While Adora practiced with Despara's twin swords on the lower main deck.

Catra leaned against the forward railing, arms crossed, as she huddled inside her tan cloak with the hood up. Facing the deck to avoid getting splashed from the ocean below. The skiff may be traveling on a cushion of air, but the crashing waves still struck the hull from time to time. She could deal with that, incredibly thankful that she didn't have to endure the motion sickness of rocking on the waves. The Horde battleships she had once traveled on year's earlier, may have been massive but the deck's still swayed and creaked under the strain of the ocean. Making her queasy, leaving her hanging off the sides and retching for most of the trip. The last time she was here in Salineas commanding the naval battalion's, she had masked her discomfort behind a determined scowl. Refusing to look weak around her subordinates.

Her wandering thoughts grew dark as she began to brood. Catra was quick not to wallow, quickly refocusing herself on the present. The wind was cold, blowing wet spray upon the deck of the skiff. As evening set in. Finn had retreated below deck as soon as they set sail. While Adora had summoned Despara's twin swords and was currently training mid deck. Dressed in only her long sleeved white shirt, gray pants and leather knee length traveling boots. Her slender blades glinted in the half light, as she swung them in a criss crossing offensive kata, ending in a single

thrust while parrying with the other sword. Moving into an elaborate set of feints and parries, her foot work was precise and well memorized. From her time training with Light Hope.

Catra watched her for a time, enraptured by how graceful she was. Her movements were fluid like she was dancing, going through both offensive and defensive postures. Gone was the punching, kicking brute from their cadet years, relying on her strength to conquer. Now her entire body had become a weapon, one she knew how to wield expertly.

Bow was at the helm, along with Sea Hawk, planning their route between the Moirai. A set of islands known as the Three Sister's, that were at the southern tip of the Archipelago.

Mermista had quickly filled them all in before heading out to open water. With the Sea Gate destroyed and the First Ones tech now offline. The island's inhabitants were more vulnerable than ever. With most of the King's fleet centered on Sea Worthy. The defense of the islands from being raided by marauder's from the Red Coast or pirates had been left up to each island to deal with. Which was proving to be more than their local militia's to handle, at least on the smaller more isolated islands. Such as the Moiria.

Her gaze fell inward, as she lowered her chin to her chest. Contemplating the coming days as she stared down at the deck.

Salineas was in ruins, the largest, sentry island that once protected the rest of the Archipelago was no more and the populace that remained on the smaller islands were barely surviving. Catra cringed with guilt, the claws from her crossed arms digging into her biceps. The Salinean's suffering right now was all her fault. Her ruthless need for power and conquest created the ripples now affecting the Archipelago.

She quickly tamped down on her self loathing, refocusing her resolve towards figuring out ways to make amends instead. Mermista had gathered what aid she could from Plumeria, Dryl and Bright Moon. The bulk of the aid from Scorpiana was still

blocked by the king's fleet. So she had her work cut out for her to protect the Archipelago. Catra's highly tactical mind was already planning ways to get Scorpania's aid out of Sea Worthy with the King's fleet none the wiser. But those schemes would have to wait until Scorpia got back from the Dark Edge. Perhaps she could get Lonnie on the communicator? Work out some alternate supply routes, for the aid currently on standby at the border outpost at the edge of Scorpania, to be transported up to the old Horde Naval base near Scorpioan Hills? Traveling down the Serpentine Strait wasn't ideal, it was a longer more convoluted route out to the Growling Sea…it would take time but the supplies would eventually reach Broland island. From there they could divide it up onto sloops…those boats were small and fast. Which was why Mermista was using them to transport aid. But they were not armed…not like a Horde Battleship. She would need to take into account the pirates that would want to steal the supplies. Salineas had become as unlawful and treacherous as the Crimson Waste since the Sea Gate was destroyed…those sloops would need a tactical escort…how many warships were still functioning back at the Naval base?

Taking a deep breath, as her thought's derailed once more. She slowly raised her gaze from the deck boards. Off to her left, over the stern and to the south. Catra spotted the three other sloops, carrying supplies. The sleek boats were cutting through the waves. Beyond those ships, Catra could see the jagged silhouette of Salineas on the far off horizon. The image grew blurry, as her eyes filled with regretful tears. Salineas was the largest in a scattered set of thirteen oceanic islands that formed the Archipelago. The closest one to the mainland and the only one that had held any tactical significance during the War. Salineas and the Sea Gate was the lone sentry that had protected the rest of the Archipelago from invader's. It also held back the Horde against using the Growling Sea as a means to attack Bright Moon from the east. Which was why she had destroyed it, then her naval forces moved north and sacked Sea Worthy next. Moving through Plumeria, clear cutting and burning the forest so they

could drive their Bot's and main artillery straight through towards Bright Moon.

The peaceful Plumerian's had been driven out of their forests and scattered to the winds, just like the Salinean's. Those who tried to fight back were slaughtered. Which was why the Horde was so despised throughout Etheria. As the Commander of the Horde forces she was hated across the main continent and was now branded the 'Butcher of Salineas.' Since she had attacked, while the Mermista was not there to protect her people. Annihilating the defenseless populace huddled within the royal palace as her warships reduced the castle to rubble. It had barely been a year since she had led several Horde naval battalion's towards that Sea gate and destroyed it, sacking the castle and then proceeding to eradicate every village upon the northern and southern shores of that large island.

The rest of the Archipelago had no strategic importance, as they were so far out from the main island. So the Etherian Horde had ignored them, setting their sights on sailing further north to Sea Worthy. Then moving inland on two fronts towards Bright Moon. With Hordak leading their forces through Plumeria, while Catra led their second offensive from the Fright Zone pushing into the Whispering Woods from the west. It was months of meticulous planning and small incremental moves, to take villages and towns as they encroached inward on both sides. That had amounted to absolutely nothing but pain and suffering on both sides of the War. As in the end, thanks to Double Trouble's betrayal. The Horde forces were decimated in some unknown valley, near Bright Moon during the 'Hordes last stand.' Then Horde Prime invaded, making the division between the Etherian Horde and the rebel's rather moot.

Catra releases a long mournful sigh, closing her eyes as a couple tears escape to fall down her cheeks as she casts her face skyward. The weight of her guilt and crushing remorse washed over her. Causing her chest to tighten as her heart ached, taking one shaky breath after another as she struggled to calm down. How did she fix this? So much loss, pain and suffering was caused

by her hand…it was too much, how did she move forward and make things right?

When she opened her eyes. She focused on the clouds overhead. Which were thin, bleeding across the sky in glowing pastel hues of pinks and yellows as the sun set.

Glimmer began to hum softly from the crowsnest, her tender, melancholy tune drawing Catra's attention. She directed her gaze to the main mast, finding the pink haired queen. Sitting on the narrow metal platform, swathed in her tan cloak from the Waste. Her bare feet swung, lazily over the side, as she greeted her source of magic as the sky darkened. Elidor rose upon the east as Adarion set upon the west. Giving up the throne of the sky to its counterpart. The regal might of Etheria's largest moon was halved tonight. The soft light it cast was not as bright making the ocean murky and almost black.

Catra nodded and turned towards the dark ocean, to watch the final ray's melting upon the endless waves in the distance. Raising her own voice to say farewell, her wordless serenade full of sadness and faint whisper of hope, that she could find absolution for her sins in the days ahead. That somehow she would find a way to heal the wounds she had caused to all the people she had hurt.

"You and Glimmer sound like Siren's." Mermista's voice filters into her bleak reverie.

Catra shook her head lightly to clear her thoughts, quickly concealing her pain behind a sardonic half smile. Hiding her sadness behind the cocky veneer, as easily as putting on a mask.

"I don't know if that was a compliment or not." Catra chuckled, her voice husky from holding back her emotions. "Aren't Siren's ugly monster women who lure Sailor's to their death?" She added, in a self deprecating huff.

“But their voices were very beautiful.” Mermista grinned back, as she further explained. Not allowing the cat girl to associate herself with monster’s.

“Okay…thanks. I guess.” Catra rolled her eyes, not knowing how to take that strange compliment.

“Here.” Mermista thrust a round, spiral shaped shell at Catra. That was hung upon a long leather string.

“What is this for? Where did you get it?” Catra instinctively answered, her natural mistrust making her not reach out for the piece of jewelry at first.

Mermista groaned, shaking the necklace at her impatiently.

“It's a glamour, I sold my voice to a Sea Witch.” She spat sarcastically.

Catra merely arched an eyebrow, offering her a slight lopsided smile of reluctant acquiesce at her lame joke. Before finally reaching for the necklace.

“It’s to keep you safe…or whatever.” Mermista tossed back, with a flippant wave of her hand as she walked away. “You can’t just waltz around Salineas, right now. Cause like, everyone will try and kill you on sight.”

Catra groaned and nodded. “Butcher of Salineas, got it.” She mumbled sadly and with a heavy sigh hung the shell around her neck.

As the magic enshrouded her body, it tickled her fur like covering herself up in the lightest, most airy blanket ever. Catra shivered from head to toe, closing her eyes as she got used to the strange sensation now covering her like a second skin.

It was the clattering of Adora’s swords striking the deck that made her snap her eyes open. Finding Adora staring wide-eyed in wonder and confusion at her.

“Catra…” She breathed, taking slow tentative steps towards her.

“Mermista, gave me a Glamour to hide my appearance.” Catra shrugged.

Adora nodded, her blue eyes shone with empathy towards her girlfriend having to hide. But the grim set of her jaw illustrated she understood its necessity. She did not want the mass beating that had happened on Darla’s cargo hold to happen to Catra ever again. The tense encounter in Plumeria, when Catra’s life had first been threatened by that mob and its leader. Only solidified the fact that it was not safe for her to just walk around Etheria right now.

Knowing that if Catra was ever in a violent confrontation again, Adora would not hesitate to protect her. From every Etherian who wished to harm her. As the Champion of Etheria it was a terrible position she didn’t want to be put in. So she was ok with Catra hiding, for now…but it was just a band aid solution it didn’t solve the problem. But she honestly didn’t know how to fix it…yet.

“So how do I look?” Catra spun around, arms wide trying and failing to sound positive. As her voice was weak and trembled slightly.

“Come…” Was all Adora said, reaching out and taking her hand. Leading her below deck. Hearing the vulnerability in her voice and knowing she needed time alone to recover. Long instincts from growing up in the Horde, to hide when feeling emotional are still very strong in both of them.

Finn was sitting in the booth in the main cabin. A slightly waterlogged journal open on the table before them. The pages were wrinkled and the ink smudged, from drying slowly over the last few days. They guided their hand over a page calling upon their magic. The page shimmered as a ripple in time cascaded over it. Reshaping it to how it was before being submerged into

the bay at Sea Worthy. Finn grunted in satisfaction, then turned the page and repeated the process on the next one. They were nearly half way through repairing Peekablue's Journal. It was tedious and time consuming, a slow bleed on their magic reserves but necessary. They couldn't tap into their source, in this timeline as it was already linked to another Rune Bearer. But they needed to know as much as possible about what awaited them at the Sunna Stones, when the Hunter's moon turned red. They needed to be ready…

Finn glanced up at the closed door to their mothers cabin. Catra had hidden the shard somewhere in there, they were sure of it. On the first opportunity they would sneak in and look for it. But as for right now, they were under surveillance so couldn't raise suspicion.

"Your mother's aren't around, so spill." Kei-Lee appeared in a cloud of sparkles, crouching before the journal on the table. Eyeing the now perfectly repaired, elegant script on the page with interest.

Finn yelped and shot backward against the bench. Blonde tail rigid and fluffed out to twice its size. It wasn't like they hadn't smelled the pixie hiding nearby but her sudden appearance was still jarring.

"Stop doing that." They hissed, dark ears pinned flat against their blonde head.

Eek hissed from their perch atop the fridge, shooting out their black tongue indignantly. At the pixies, pushy attitude. She was loud and her high pitched voice was abrasive against his sensitive lizard ears.

Kei-Lee rolled her eyes, chucking a thumb at the winged lizard who obviously did not like her much.

"I like him…haven't seen a dragonling in over a thousand years." Kei- Lee laughed, as she crossed her legs upon the tabletop

getting comfortable.

“Eek’s just a magic lizard.” Finn shrugged as they corrected her.

“And I’m a magicat…stop lying.” Kei-Lee groused, crossing her arms over her chest.

Finn sighed, “Look…things are complicated and I don’t want to mess up this timeline's future..so stop harassing me.”

“Too late for that kid.” Kei-Lee smirked, “The damage has been done and you did it on purpose so you might as well go all in. I say.” Settling down on the table with both her legs and arms crossed at the same time, looking like a smug genie.

Finn ignored her, thinking it over. As they repaired another page and turned it.

The clipped sounds of toe claws and boots sounded down the stairs, stalling the uncomfortable interrogation.

Finn glanced up with a bright smile glowing on their face.

“Hi, Mom’s.” They greeted, their brilliant smile falling and blinking in amazement as Adora and a Fox Hybrid waved back, before crossing through the main compartment and disappearing into their cabin. Finn sniffed the air as they passed, smelling their feline mother’s scent beneath the glamour.

“What was that about?” Kei-Lee, muttered. Going invisible and jogging after the two women finding a more interesting mystery to investigate. Slipping through the slowing closing door to eavesdrop on their private conversation.

Catra stood stunned by the wall-length mirror on the far corner of this modest cabin. The image before her was striking to behold, she had the same face and body shape. But her fur had bronzed, her freckles now a rusty red while her dark ears were now a warm

chestnut brown. Her smoke gray tufts that were just starting to grow in had turned platinum silver. Her wavy, shoulder length hair is now a fiery red, with a fluffy tail to match.The tip has a matching tuft of silver. But the most striking were her mismatched eyes, staring back at her, one was a warm hazel green the other a soulful amber brown.

“You're a Fox Hybrid…” Adora breathed.

“I look like…Tama…” Catra gasped, brushing her claws through her short tufts nervously.

“You’re still you…right?” Adora was concerned, moving in front of her and cupping her cheeks tenderly.

“Yes…dummy. It’s just my outer appearance that’s changed. I’m still me.” Catra assured her with a raspy chuckle.

“Good.” Adora grinned softly, then leaned in, pressing her lips against Catra’s in a tender, loving kiss.

Catra smiled and began to purr. Her shorter, fluffier tail wagging merrily behind her, causing the hem of the tan cloak to raise up like an umbrella.

“Tama…purred too…” Adora sighed sadly, pulling away and wrapping her arms around Catra and holding her close.

Catra nuzzled her face into Adora’s chest, holding her tight. As her own chest tightened at the remembrance of huddling together with the little fox hybrid on Adora’s bunk that first cold season. Listening to her soft rumble, that mixed so well with her own soothing purr as the three of them fell asleep.

“Damn…I miss her..” Catra sniffled.

Adora nodded, her chin resting atop Catra’s head as she squeezed her even tighter. Never wanting to let go.

“Momma…” Finn called softly, pushing the door open softly to peek inside.

Finding Adora and the Fox woman sitting upon the bed, their quiet conversation falling silent as they entered. Adora was now dressed in her underclothes of a gray tank top and black shorts. While the Fox Hybrid has discarded her tan cloak, leaving it in a pile on the floor. Dressed in a white shirt and nearly worn out black legging, with far too many rips along the thighs and blown out knees. From the outfit alone, Finn knew it was Catra.

“It’s me Finn.” Catra reached out a hand, her own voice echoing from her new form.

“I know..” Finn smiled and tapped a finger to their nose.

Catra nodded and laughed softly.

“Can I see it?” Finn asked, their voice soft almost meek.

Catra nodded, pulling out the shell.

“You had one of these, didn’t you. To disguise you as a Thaymorian deer hybrid?” She stated, bluntly.

“Yeah…you guys were never supposed to know it was me.” Finn heaved a shaky breath.

“You came back in time for the Kaydak Crystal.” Adora added, reaching for their hand. As the kitten was starting to tremble in fear, unsure about revealing more of their secrets.

Adora was empathic enough to notice the kitten’s sudden trepidation and fell silent. Allowing them space to share it they wanted to. She wasn’t going to push them, at least not yet.

“What happened to your glamour?” Catra took Finn’s other hand, tenderly between hers.

“Jitsu destroyed it, at least the glamour part of it. Peekablue gave my amulet to Double Trouble…who I guess pretended to be the Thaymorian boy to keep an eye on you two.” Finn shrugged.

“Why?” Adora was confused, glancing at Catra briefly.

“I don’t know…the Seer of Fate never was very forthcoming with his reason’s. I just learned to follow his instructions and not question as I grew up. ” Finn smiled weakly. King Peekablue’s aid, within the Court of the Crystal Kingdom, had been brief but monumental. He would appear like a sudden flame, holding private audiences with his mother’s and then disappearing as if he had never visited at all. A lone wanderer, moving through the kingdom’s like a ghost. Appearing only when needed. His mother’s would always heed Peekablue’s words, taking the necessary precautions when warned about future threats. But in the end, all their efforts to protect them, to protect Etheria…the universe was in vain.

The resurrection of the Nameless One was inevitable…but not this time!

Finn had made a promise and they would keep it!

“What happened in your time?” Adora’s question was gentle, her blue eyes watching carefully as her child’s face crumpled in sorrow for but only for a moment. Then the sadness vanished as they plastered a bright smile on their face instead. But the shadow of grief was still haunting their watery blue eyes.

“I can’t tell you…at least not yet. I feel, I have pulled too many threads from the pattern already.” Finn responded cryptically, turning to Catra and tapping the shell.

Their soft blue eyes, so much like Adora’s holding her gaze firmly as they sought to change the trajectory of the conversation.

“Keep this hidden and keep it safe, if it should be shattered your cover will be blown, just like mine was.” Finn advised with a weak smile.

Catra’s nose flared, with the shell held so close to her face as she showed Finn. A strong iron scent of blood coated her nose from the shell. Her eyes flared in horror as she dropped the shell. “What’s wrong?’ Adora was alarmed.

“Some magic does not come without a price.” Finn advised, with a remorseful glance down at the shell. Pulling their hands away from their mother’s and retreating from the room.

“Nothing…” Catra responded briskly to Adora’s concern, pulling the shell necklace off and standing up. Setting the item on the shelf beside their bed that served as a night stand. As soon as the amulet was taken off the glamour faded, her true feline form shimmering into existence. Catra was shaken by the sudden understanding of the form she had been given. Came at the cost of another life.

What kind of vile magic was this…

“Raise the color’s, so the Sister’s know that aid is here.” Mermista screamed from the bow at daybreak.

As Sea Hawk and Adora, pulled on the rigging now strung up the main mast of the skiff. A seafoam green flag unfurled with Mermista’s silver trident in the center. The sloops behind them raised the same flags. As the convoy of ships sailed expertly into the field of rocky spires before the islands and into the vast harbor that linked the three islands together. Mermista may no longer be the ruler of Salineas, but she refused to just be pushed aside like she didn’t matter. In the weeks away from Mystcor, she had formed her own resistance of loyal subjects. Under her own banner, from now on she would fly her color’s proudly and let her presence be known throughout the Archipelago. That she was still here and she would always take care of her people!

Glimmer once more stood in her tan cloak at the bow of the skiff. Gazing with awe and wonder at the tropical beauty now surrounding her. She had never been this deep into the archipelago. Leaning over the railing of the bow, admiring the clear water. That was so vibrant, the hues of green and deep blue sparkling beneath the foaming waves below the skiff as if it was made of crystal.

"Beautiful…" Glimmer gasped.

Mermista smirked, "I know, right." Then she turned to Catra who was standing on the other side of her. All warmth and good humor melted from her expression.

"You better get that glamour on before we reach those boats." She commanded, pointing forward to the crowded bay ahead.

Catra nodded, she had been gripping the railing with one hand, white knuckled with anxiety. Now she unfurled the thin leather rope with the shell from the palm of her other fist and deftly looped the magic amulet over her neck. Tucking it away beneath the tan desert cloak. As the fox hybrid shimmered into existence.

Glimmer's brow furrowed in confusion at first, then her expression softened into pity. She quickly averted her gaze not wanting Catra to see how conflicted she was about her hiding her true identity. She understood why Mermista had given her the glamour, to avoid unwanted confrontation and violence. But she was unsure if this was the best way to go about endearing Catra to the Salinean people. If they found out she was in disguise, it might backfire and make them distrust her even more.

Finn stood at the top of the crows nest, spyglass pressed to his left eye. Scanning over the three very different landmasses stretching over the bay. The open water before them was scattered with various types of fishing canoes with local's sitting quietly with long poles in their hands. While three larger catamaran's sped towards them at top speed. The various brightly colored sail's pulled taunt in the wind, as the sea hybrids and

elves hung off the long pontoons as they sailed past their convoy. Waving and crying out in excitement. Each catamaran turned behind them, then sailed up alongside each of the supply sloops and guided each one away towards the three islands. Each Catamaran sail had a different emblem, one was a pale blue with white butterfly wings. Leading a supply sloop towards the left most island, Nora. One was a brilliant orange with a silhouette of a bird's head with a sharp beak. Leading it's own sloop towards the central island, Dewma. The Catamaran ahead of the skiff, leading them and the last sloop towards the leftmost island, Morta. Had a sail of deep indigo, with a gracefully sculpted lantern in relief.

Sea Hawk guided their skiff towards the more rocky island at the furthermost edge of the bay. While Bow stood off to the side of the command deck, completely enraptured by the beauty of the Three Sisters.

As they drew deeper into the bay they noticed that the islands were about a mile apart, with a wide divide of ocean between them. Simple wooden ferries were passing back and forth between. The islands seemed to have a symbiotic relationship with each other. Each separate but also, surviving as one being.

Adora moved silently up beside Catra, softly clasping her hand on her own. As they both took in the wondrous sights of the islands now looming around them.

Adora blinked rapidly in amazement, as she was once again confronted by the effigies of the three sisters. Now weathered by the passage of time. She had been to these islands a thousand years ago as Mara. When the Heart of Etheria Project was in its infancy. Sent to petition the Salineas Rune Bearer to allow a Rune Stone to be erected upon the largest island within the Archipelago. In exchange for First Ones technologies. Building the Sea Gate and linking the Archipelago's magic to the Heart of

Etheria, through the various statutes that adorned their landscapes.

The statues' finer details were now worn smooth by the crashing waves, fine cracks running along their surface. Further tarnished by being covered in both moss and barnacles near their bases. Even though time had not been kind to them, they were still astounding to behold. Jutting from the landscape like stone titan's, overlooking the harbor.

The power stones once embedded into the tops of their staff were empty? The hollowed out portion of stone, spiking Adora's anxiety. She knew so much more about the First Ones civilization and their underlying schemes to weaponize magic power throughout the Tri-solar system. The sudden jolt of fear that perhaps…some other opportunist faction in the universe had infiltrated Etheria and stole them. Or even Skeletor or Crita? Everyone seemed to have something to reclaim here on Etheria…

Mermista's eyes darkened as her eyebrow knotted together in confusion as she noticed the stone's absence as well. Her eye flew upward from the statue to the peak of the plateau above. As a lone figure in a dusk colored cloak stood watch over the edge.

"Orion!" Mermista screamed, waving her arms over her head in greeting.

As Glimmer gasped, taking a shaky breath as her eyes widened in sudden recognition of the lantern adorning the staff on the statue of Morta.

"That's the lantern…from my quest…during my coronation." She blurted out, her voice high pitched with astonishment to find it here of all places?

Eyes in the Dark

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all who have left Kudo's and Lenoravampire2142 for your comment. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time the boats moored themselves at the small dockyard in Morta's sheltered harbor. Orion had trekked back to tall coconut trees that edged Morta's coastline. Lingering in the shade, upon the treeline, not wanting to get underfoot. As the quaint little set of floating docks, mostly used by local fishermen. Became unusually cramped and busy as both the Sloop and a very large Skiff hovered into port. A few fishermen that had entered port earlier that morning. Rushed down the docks away from their small Troller's. Leaving their full net's of fish dangling half out of their holds. The hum of excitement and gratitude buzzed in the air as the Sea Hybrids and human villager's eagerly converged up the two new boats.

The Broland sailor's tied off the Sloop and began to unload the cargo. All the while, Bull bellowed order's from the bow. The fishermen were set straight to work, hauling the crates down the docks to the beachhead.

Hawk was quick to tie off the skiff to a mooring upon another dock, a few yards away from the sloop, on the U shaped dock. Keeping a good distance from the comings and goings of the mob of overly helpful villagers. While Bow powered down the engines from the command deck. The skiff slowly settled upon the choppy water as the air cushion dissipated. Rocking in the waves just like a regular boat.

Orion never set foot upon the sand until he caught sight of Mermista disembarking down the gangplank of the skiff for the dock. The princess had barely made landfall at the end of the

wooden planks, before her brother had wrapped her up in a tight hug. Swinging her around merrily while laughing loudly. His joyful sounds, echoing down the beach and bouncing off the trees.

Mermista couldn't help but be sucked into his happiness. Grinning broadly and clapping him about the shoulder's. Her warm brown eyes glinted with amusement at how excited he was to see her. It had been years! The last time she had seen him, he had still been a lanky teen. Voice cracking, awkward and nervous to the changes of his body, as he began to transition from a child towards an adult.

She gasped in amazement at how much he had matured. When his hood fell away, as they twirled. Revealing a young man of roguish beauty. Full, sandy blonde hair hung in a wild mass around his head and down to his broad shoulders. His jawline was scruffy with the hint of a beard, not yet old enough to grow in full. His skin is as bronze as Mermista's. With warm, blue-green eyes like the sea. That danced with unbridled excitement at having his older sister in his arms once more. Orion was younger but now twice her size. Built like a tank and obviously just as deadly. By the hunter's leather armor he wore and the weapon's upon his back and at his waist.

"Orion…put me down!" She finally screamed, collecting herself.

Orion merely grunted and set her down.

Mermista had barely gotten her feet back on the sand before her brother's hound had galloped up to her and promptly tackled her to her ground.

"Ugh…seriously! Argus!" Mermista cried, fending off the dog and his eagerly slobbery tongue. That licked up each of her cheeks, before finally sitting down. Tail wagging hard and hunches still wiggling, as if rethinking if his greeting was not yet finished.

By the time Mermista had managed to regain her feet, she found her friends now standing at the edge of the deck. Staring at her

with fond looks, Glimmer and Bow were snickering, enjoying the sweet moment between them. They both came from loving families and could appreciate the fond welcome Mermista received. While Adora looked absolutely smitten by the reunion, a distant yearning for her own lost brother, shimmering in her gaze. While Catra, concealed in her fox glamor remained aloof. Covering her amused smile with a hand but the blush on her freckled cheeks was very bold.

“Alright...show's over. Get over here and meet my little brother!” Mermista commanded, with an indignant huff. Crossing her arms over the chest, feigning indifference.

Everyone moved forward to greet Orion, except Catra. Who lingered at the dock, picking at the hem of her cloak’s hood nervously. Her anxiety about being rejected froze her in place. The guilt of her past sin’s to these people, always stabbing her self confidence. She knew she didn’t deserve a warm welcome and so she didn’t expect one.

Finn noticed her reluctance, from their perch upon the crow's nest of the skiff.

“Eek…I think mom needs a little encouragement. She hasn’t met you yet, now may be a good time to introduce yourself?” They smirked conspiringly with the flying lizard, sitting on their shoulder.

Eek nodded, as they took flight. Then landed lightly upon Catra’s shoulder.

Catra felt the sudden pressure and turned, just as the lizard snapped out its tongue to tickle her upon the tip of her nose. Offering her a cheerful hiss.

Catra screamed and leaped ten feet in the air, sending the lizard off her shoulder with a back hand. Eek flew out of range, as the

fox hybrid landed in the sand and darted towards Adora on instinct.

Adora turned, eye's flying wide as she noticed the flying lizard she had accidentally created several years prior. Flying off back towards the crows nest, where Finn was rolling around cackling with glee.

She was quick to realize the magical lizard was no doubt, friends with her 'future', dimension, hopping kid.

"That was quite an entrance?" Mermista commented dryly, as Catra slowly calmed down. Painting and clearing her throat as she slowly came down from the fright. Casting Finn a stern look, as she gathered herself. Releasing her claws from the white fabric of Adora's shoulder and moving to stand beside the blonde. Smoothing down her extra fluffy rusty red tail and tucking it timidly around her waist.

"And who is this excitable Fox?" Orion, cocked an eyebrow with a laughing smile.

"Ah…" Catra cut her eyes nervously to Adora, who stood frozen at her side. Mouth opened and my brain stalled. Finding no help from her girlfriend, which was typical. Adora was terrible at lying. Thankful for her own quick mind, lying for her had become a very easy, survival tactic growing up.

"Kaira…" Catra stammered, the only other name she could honestly say was her own. Even if it was from another life.

"Very pretty." Orion nodded, leaving it at that as the other's introduced themselves.

It was mid-morning by the time they had finished setting up camp upon the shore. Bright Moon tents were now scattered in a

crescent near the tree line and the group was inside the larger command tent. Seated upon an assortment of fluffy pillows around a low table, where a map of Morta was unfurled and stayed flat by strategically placed stones on each corner.

Adora sat at the head of the table, having discarded her long sleeve shirt for an athletic style, red tank top. So very thankful Bow had gone to their room's back a Mystacor and grabbed their travel packs. Stowing them on the skiff before heading to the Waste to pick them up. Mermista and Sea Hawk sat on the other end. While the others crowded around on either side. Catra was sweating but still wore her tan cloak, she was feeling skittish. Being surrounded by so many stranger's, she needed the extra layer of protection to hide in. Glimmer had tossed her cloak immediately, it lay somewhere in the tent. Now she was in her lavender leggings and off white top that tied behind her neck.

The smell of roasting fish and vegetables was heavy in the air as the cook from the sloop had begun a massive pot of stew over the central fire. It would take most of the day to simmer and be ready at supper. Its savory aroma, as the broth came into its full flavor, would taunt Adora all day.

Adora's stomach growled as if on cue. Kaira smirked from beside her on the corner of the table. Everyone chuckled knowingly, as Adora blushed and rolled her eyes. Her stomach always had something to say whenever she smelled food. It was humiliating.

"Ok…so we got seven villages all in the forest that makes up most of the island." Adora leaned up on her knees, hovering over the map and pointing out each village. Taking command of the meeting as always.

"Morta has had an influx of refugees from Salineas, along with most of the other islands. We've had a year, mostly. To get them settled, Horde Prime didn't have much interest in the islands. The clones pretty much left us alone. If we would have fought back, formed some kind of resistance like the Mainland. That would have got their attention and know doubt Prime would have wiped

us all out. But we didn’t, we kept to ourselves, we had our own problems to deal with trying to recover from the damage the Etherian Horde caused.“ Orion offered, his tone was neither apologetic or ashamed, but just simple facts.

Kaira shrank into herself just a little more. Pulling up her hood and folding her knees against her chest. No one seemed to notice, but Adora. Who lightly rubbed her back for a moment, offering support and reassurance that she was there and they would fix things…together.

“During Primes occupation, all we had to contend with was the Horde setting up communication spire’s in the sea along the mainland coast and spying on us with surveillance drones. The clones never set foot on the islands, so, we have been lucky at least that much.” Orion explained. “But the resources on the smaller islands, like ours, are limited. Such as shelter and food. We just don’t seem to have enough to go around. With the shields down, we are gonna need a more secure place for the people to go when the storms hit.”

With that said, Kaira straightened with purpose. Unfurling from her hiding posture to lean over the map. Adora was amazed by how focused and on task Kaira became. Kaira was never like this during their time in the Horde. She had pulled out her com pad and was now busy typing up notes. Her slender finger’s a blur on the keys at the bottom of the screen. Glancing up at Orion from time to time, to show she was still engaged as to what he was saying. As he went into detail about each village and what they needed to survive the coming storm season. All the while her large ears were twitching and fluffy tail, now swishing back and forth behind her pillow seat. Creating a shallow half circle divot into the sand.

Several minutes later, Kaira was meticulously surveying the topography of the map. Morta was mostly forest, ascending up one massive slope to a series of flat plateaus. There really weren't any valley’s or even a mountain to shelter in during those storms.

“Scorpia was sending mostly building materials and construction equipment. So the villages could re- enforce their storm walls.” Mermista folded her arms over her chest, her tone bitter.

“I’ll get that aid out of Sea Worthy, I promise.” Kaira tapped her chin, formulating plans to use the natural resources of the island to protect the villages here on Morta. The island had lots of trees…but no real mountains, so no cave system to hide in.

“What are your storm walls made from right now?” Adora inquired.

“Wood mostly, harvested from the forest. It’s very old and very sturdy, long since petrified and turned to stone from the salty sea air. But the villages had to grow beyond those storm walls to accommodate the influx of people. We've been working on extending the walls, but the wood isn’t as strong and we’ve run out of time. “ Orion shrugged.

“You got a Horde Spire to the south, just off the coast of Dryl.” Kaira tapped the crudely drawn sigil of the tower.

“No ones going to want to go inside .... anything Horde is cursed.” Mermista huffed. Rubbing the back of her neck anxiously.

“That wasn’t my intention…but we can strip the outer hull. The panel’s are a lightweight alloy, able to withstand the vacuum of space so they should be sturdy enough to endure gale force winds. You could attach them to the new stormwalls, reinforce them.” Kaira was quick to pull out her communication pad and start a series of equations.

Orion laughed, “I am sure I could get plenty of volunteers to destroy a Horde spire.”

Kaira looked up with a pleased smile.

“How do you know what a Horde Spire is made of?” Bow was intrigued.

Kaira grimaced and rubbed the back of her neck, not answering.

Bow was observant enough to realize.

"Oh…" he muttered, casting his gaze down in shame. He knew how Primes Horde chips worked, that Catra endured a forced download of all the knowledge a clone would possess. It seemed she would always have that information stored in her brain.

"Don't worry about it, Arrows. Glad I got the knowledge, it will be cathartic to rip apart one of Primes Spires. Trust me, I'm good." Kaira offered Bow a small, reassuring smile. Giving his hand on the table a small pat and a squeeze. Seeking to wipe the shame and regret now shadowing his face as he looked at her.

"Ok, then we'll take a boat out to the spire." Adora offered. "Entrapta can give me the new entry codes. Bow and I can go inside and start dismantling anything useful for the villages to use."

"Works for me." Bow slapped his knee.

"I'll go with you." Kaira offered, wanting to be actively helping instead of just planning and also off this island. Her nerves were shot and she had only been here for half a day. But the constant stress of having to be alert to threats was taxing, as she felt she was in enemy territory. Her true self was hidden and so far everyone had accepted Kaira at face value. She was safe…kinda.

"Adora, I'd rather you stay here…we could use She-Ra's speed and strength to get those supplies in order." Mermista refocused on the blonde. Watching Adora train on the deck of the skiff on the way here. She knew she couldn't transform into She-Ra fully. But she could call upon the champion's super human speed or strength.

Adora was reluctant to accept, swallowing and staring down at the map trying to figure a way she could do both. She was on edge, would be the entire time they were in Salineas. She couldn't help it, after what happened to Catra in Darla's hold. This place felt like

being behind enemy lines, with unknown threats everywhere. She didn't want Catra out of eyesight!

"We got this, Princess." Kaira gave Adora's crossed knee a light slap and a small smile.

Adora reluctantly nodded.

"We gotta get the supplies inland…but the forest is rather dense so we need a plan." Mermista was quick to get them all back on track.

"I'll just blink all the supplies to the villages." Glimmer shrugged. "Going to need a little help though." She turned to Orion with a smile.

"How does your teleportation work?" Orion inquired, absently scratching his dog behind its floppy ears.

"I had once needed to see or at least have been to whatever destination I wanted to blink to. But now I can blink to a person anywhere on the planet as long as I know them." Glimmer explained.
"So if I go to each village you could blink the supplies to me?" Orion nodded.

"Exactly, we could be done in a day!" Glimmer explained triumphantly.

"What happened to the power stones, Orion?' Mermista was quick to change the topic now that the supply issue was solved.

"I have no idea, about a month or so back they stopped working." Orion shrugged. "Then one day they were just gone."

"That was when the Rune Stones stopped working?" Glimmer offered, steepling her finger's in the very same manner as her late mother. "When all the first ones tech, went offline."

“Well, that’s going to suck with the Storm Season just beginning.” Mermista groused.

“Storm Season?” Kaira offered, she honestly did not know much about the Archipelago besides military targets. She wanted to know exactly what they were dealing with.

“Well, on the Mainland you guys have the cold season. Here on the Archipelago we have months of torrential rain and the occasional hurricane to deal with.” Sea Hawk explained. “On top of Pirates and Raiders…that is.”

“The power stone on each statue would cast a shield over the island during huge storms to protect the people.” Orion sighed.

“It was all part of an intricate web of energy shields connected to the Pearl…the Salinean Rune Stone. It was all a part of the deal Senator Keldor had with the Salenian Sea elves over a thousand years ago. Their Rune Bearer had hoped to use those shields to protect the islands if Horde Prime ever invaded.” Adora spoke up.

Mermista arched an eyebrow, blinking in surprise.
“Long story.” Glimmer leaned forward and patted Mermista on the shoulder. Silently telling her that they would clue her in as to what happened to Adora soon.

“So if the power stones are broken why would anyone want to steal them?” Bow was confused.

“They are still First Ones tech.” Adora interjected with a frown.

“Which is a bad thing.” Glimmer offered.

“In the wrong hands…” Kaira clarified.

“So we need to find out whose hands have the Power Stones and if the rest of the stones are missing on the other islands!” Mermista slapped her hands on her thighs and stood up.

“We have a mystery to solve people!” She proceeded out of the tent, her eyes hard and determined. She would never allow any more harm to come to her people.

“But let's get these supplies delivered first.” She beckoned from beyond the tent.

Everyone rose to their feet and followed her outside.

It was just after midday by the time the Skiff closed in on the spire. Catra stood on the command deck beside Bow. The both of them were watching through the semi-circle of glass that shielded the control panels as they closed in. As the slender, gleaming metal tower came into view over the waves. Catra had seen those spires all over Etheria, as she fought with the rebels. Lone sentries scattered across the landscape, reminding them all that Prime could see all, knew all and that he could crush them whenever he deemed necessary. Now with Prime gone, the spire's threat was gone too. Now they were just silent monoliths to a dead tyrant.

Catra could appreciate the sharp elegance of their architecture. They resembled a mighty spear, thrusting out of the waves and upward into the heaven’s. Now these tower’s that once stood watch over the enslaved masses of Etheria would protect them. A slow, satisfied smile crawled up Catra’s face. She loved how righteously karmic it all was.

As Bow guided the hovercraft in, between two curving buttresses on the base, that floated on the water. The Spire’s out at sea were a little different in design to the ones on the mainland. A central column down the length of the structure, spearing deep into the sea bed miles below. The Spire stayed upright by floating on curving buttresses, protruding from that central column. The sharp angles of the Spire high above was very similar to a Spear, with a wider central command in the middle and three short protrusions like a three sided pommel. Each platform was massive

for docking spacecraft, leading into the central column to a docking bay. The top of the Spire was a huge protruding point, resembling some intergalactic Spear head. The structure was powered down, where once there were green lights threading up its length to show it was active. The outer hull was now a dull slate gray.

"So, why are you not wearing your glamor?" Bow asked, powering down the skiff.

"I doubt anyone from Salineas is going to see me out here…also… it makes me itchy." Catra shrugged, as she finally pulled off her tan cloak. It was far too hot and humid out here in the middle of the ocean. Draping the garment over the railing, before leaping over the side. To land in a crouch on the forward deck, now only in her white short sleeve training shirt and torn black leggings.

With practiced movements she quickly moored the skiff, by tying it off onto a half extended docking clamp at the base of the spire.

Then leaped onto the angled hull and began to climb up towards the platform that held the bay door's high above.

"Are you going to be able to get up here, Arrows?" She called down smugly, as she clung to the metal on the vertical column. Her claws had punctured the metal as she climbed, as if it was a tree.

Bow was standing on the bow, his left crossbow gauntlet already cocked and ready to fire. With a smug smile of his own, he curled his fingers into a fist and fired. A grappling hook exploded from the cannon mount on his arm with a bang. The power and speed of his new trick bolts was amazing. The grapple easily soared upward for miles, puncturing the edge of the docking platform, effortlessly. Then he merely just reeled himself upward, tossing Catra who was hanging off a chunk of spire a cocky, flippant salute. As he flew upward, past her perch.

Catra cackled with good humor, climbing the rest of the way. Once they had made it up to the wide docking platform outside the massive bay doors. Catra glanced over the edge, finding Melog sitting on the bow staring placidly up at them.

"You coming?" She called.

(I shall remain here, keep watch.) They responded through their link.

Catra merely nodded, heading over to Bow. Who was already talking to Entrapta over his tracker pad, in front of the entry panel.

Catra glanced over his shoulder, finding the lavender haired scientist was surrounded by an array of massive roots. The soft shadows of trees, falling around her.

"Where are you?" Bow asked, while tapping on a small task window at the top of his screen to check on Entrapta's download for the entry passwords for all of Salineas spires.

"Plumeria." Entrapta responded, moving off camera for a moment to direct the clones she had with her. "We are about to begin our expedition into the extensive system of subterranean tunnels beneath the Heart Blossom. There is so much Wyrm DNA here…" she mumbled.

"Is it enough to track Omega Prime?" Catra leaned into view for a second.

Entrapta instantly stiffened, cleared her throat and promptly turned away from the screen. Avoiding Catra in every way.

Catra's ears drooped and she cast her eyes downward, instantly feeling rejected and self conscious. She had apologized to Entrapta back at Arxia, why couldn't she just get over it and forgive her like she did before? She had done much worse to her in the past…namely stunning her and shipping her off to die on Beast Island. She seemed to have bounced back from that. She

had been her completely normal, hyperactive, Tech obsessed, weird self around Catra for months after her rescue from the Velvet Glove. Why was her latest blow up at her, such a big deal, now! What changed…why was she ignoring her. Not knowing how to fix things between them and so very angry with herself. Catra's thoughts were spinning, guilt and regret eating away at her. As she growled and flexed her claws at her sides, struggling for control. She felt like crying, screaming and violence all at the same time. The desire to slash and claw at everything, anything just to release the emotional poison burning her guts from the inside out. So very scared that she had lost Entrapta's friendship, forever.

"Yes…but I want to follow the trail…there's so much more data I could collect. " Entrapta meekly stated, as if worried Bow or Catra might get mad.

"Be careful, Trapta…we worry." Bow offered, he would no longer stand in her way. Only remind her to be on guard. "If you run into any trouble down there, send us an alert. Glimmer can blink us to you."

"Kay…" Entrapta responded from off camera, already distracted and deeply engrossed in her research. The signal cut out a second later.

Leaving Catra and Bow standing outside the bay doors, staring at each other with concern.

"You two got into a fight?" Bow commented, bluntly. As he keyed in the code on the door pad.

"Entrapta doesn't fight, she just stands there and takes it." Catra sniped. "Like some bug eyed punching bag."

"Mind telling me what happened?" Bow pushed, ignoring Catra's less than nice description of Entrapta, as the door's slide open.

"Frosta got hurt real bad, I got scared and lashed out. Yelled at Entrapta, blamed her for what happened. My typical bullshit…I

apologized right away when I got myself back under control. But she is not forgiving me this time…so…" Catra sniffed softly, rubbing a finger under her nose. As the dam of her emotions was about to burst, she could feel the unbearable pressure in her chest building and was struggling to keep her tears contained.

Bow instantly turned just as they entered the shade inside the massive cargo hold. Wrapping her up in a warm, soothing hug. Catra stiffened instantly, ear's folding back and tail rigid. But quickly softened, curling her arms up and holding Bow. Accepting his comfort, finally allowing the tears to fall.

"Just give her time, she'll come around. You gotta show her you've changed, that you're trying to be a better friend." he offered, his advice and obvious concern was so genuine. He cared so much…about her…about everyone.

Catra moaned and tucked her face into Bow's neck, seeking just a little more reassurance that she could make things right.

It was late afternoon by the time Catra and Bow emerged from the bowels of the spire. Melog had been dozing on the crows nest platform, high above the deck, when they smelled their master once more. Instantly they were awake and fully alert, ear's flicking and tail wagging as they sat up.

Raising their regal lion's head upwards, confronted by their master's dower expression. From the platform high above them, standing just outside the heavy doors. Engrossed in listening in on the heated conversation her dark skinned companion was having on his tracker pad.

"We are going to need a small army of clones and some really high tech tools to get this thing torn apart." Bow vented at the screen.

"I can't spare a small army right now. Hordak's got most of the clones held up in the Sky Tree." Entrapta responded, her eye's

falling distant. Hordak had been secretive again, holding back his own research. She didn't know why, but after what happened last time. She was done with being polite and respecting his secrets. This time she was determined to find out what he was up to. It was on her work order chart. Prioritized along with so many other tasks she had undertaken as of late. She could manage…she was a pro at multitasking!

"But I will send Wrong Hordak and a couple clones out there to train the Salinean's on how to take a spire apart without blowing themselves up."

Bow could hear the indignant squawk of said clone, echoing in the background.

"That was a risk!" Bow shouted, voice high pitched and cracking. He had been opening panels and tinkering with the spires innards all day! The idea that he could have just blown himself and Catra sky high was sobering to say the least.

Entrapta frowned at the clone off screen, before returning her focus back to Bow. Immediately going into a long, highly detailed explanation as to how easy it was to blow up a spire while poking around in its technological guts. She had already 'accidentally' done it on multiple occasions.

Catra's ears pinned back and with a grunt of displeasure she left Bow on the platform and began climbing down. Melog hopped back down to the deck, as she climbed back over the railing of the bow.

"Hey, buddy." She scratched behind their ears briefly as she walked past. Heading below deck to get out of the sun and cool off. Maybe grab a quick shower, she had been sweating terribly in the musty confines of that Spire.

Melog was lounging on Catra's bed in her cabin, when the magicat reappeared from the main compartment, dressed in nothing but a

towel wrapped around her.

Her thin layer of tawny fur was glistening with moisture, her darker mane wet and brushed back. Catra picked up her own communication pad from the side table, keying the code for Lonnie.

“Hey, girl…where are you now?” Lonnie picked up, she was no longer in the command tent. But now by the look of the smooth pale green walls, she was in a Force Captain’s quarters in the Forge complex.

“Salineas.” Catra answered, keeping the camera turned off as she propped the pad up on her side table. Moving to her pack in the corner to dig out some fresh clothes. While Lonnie began to explain in full detail what had been happening back in Scorpania, her voice droned softly in the background. Catra’s ear’s swiveled to keep listening. As she rummaged in her pack. Smirking as she found her baby blanket folded and tucked away at the bottom of the bag. Bow had packed them all travel bags, from their room back at Mystacor, before heading out to the Crimson Waste. He was such an attentive and thoughtful friend. He had listened to her talk about her parents and her baby blanket over their time at Mystacor, no doubt packing it cause he knew it meant so much to her. She could really take some pointers from Arrow’s as to how to be a good friend.

With a tired sigh, she plucked out her maroon and leather tunic, with the cut outs. It was not clean or fresh…by the smell of it. With a groan she quickly donned the tunic and pulled on her black leggings. She had been wearing, for days. She really needed a new set of clothes.

When Catra glanced up, after pulling on pants. She found Huntara now hovering over Lonnie's shoulders.

“Hey, there. Kitty. “ Huntara greeted, with the smug half smile that grated on Catra’s nerves.

“I thought you were hunting Tri-clops?” Catra spat back, tapping the screen propped up in her side table, to turn on her camera. “Did you get lost?” She laughed teasingly.

“Naw, that bastard got his ass handed to him, thanks to your magic friend there.” Huntara nodded towards Melog on the bed, as Catra picked up her pad and flopped backward onto the bed.

“Looks like they got a magic makeover.” Huntara added, with an admiring whistle.

“Long story…” Catra mused then, stared at the screen in alarm…”How did you know about that fight?”

“I was tracking Tri-clops through the Scorpion Hills. By the time I showed up. I saw the aftermath all over that heath, it was pretty apparent who Tri-clops was tangling with. I spotted that Eternian with my binoculars limping off on a hover sled over the Serpentine Straight. Then I caught sight of you guys down below, figured Melog was in good hands. There really was no way to catch up to him. So I headed back here to see if I could borrow a skiff.. So I could go after him.” Huntara shrugged, her story was completely plausible so Catra never questioned it. Melog on the hand, folding their ear’s back and narrowed their eyes at Huntara. Sending Catra a sharp feeling of confusion, they didn’t remember clearly if Huntara had been a part of their fight or showed up afterwards. They had nearly died and the whole thing was rather traumatic and hazy.

Catra’s gaze shifted to them for a moment, as their strange feelings crossed over the link.

“We moved ourselves into the Forge complex, it’s getting real cold up here on the Mainland.” Lonnie resumed their conversation as Huntara moved out of view.

“Bow tells me, you guys are on a joint mission to capture all of Skeletor’s Spies with Bright Moon?” Catra prodded, she could hear the squeak and groan of Huntara rocking on a metal chair's back

legs. The woman was right at home in Lonnie's room it seemed. "Yeah, got Jitsu looking through surveillance tapes pointing out his buddies." Lonnie leaned back and crossed her arms behind her head. Laughing at something Huntara had said in the background. Whatever it was, Catra's keen hearing only caught a few choice words and it was rather derogatory towards the ex-Skeletor soldier.

"Did Kyle and the rest make it back?" Catra added as she lounged on top of the comforter on her bed. She wasn't too fond of Jitsu either, so felt no need to defend him from Hunatra's disrespect.

"Yeah, a few days back. Levi's patched up and is as ornery and pig-headed as ever." Lonnie growled.

"Sounds about right." Catra chuckled.

"How did you end up back on the Islands. I figured that would be the last place you would ever go. Since the Salinean's want to put your head on pike." Lonnie quipped.

"Got a call from Mermista, looks like she fished that Kitten we were looking for out of the ocean. So good news, we got the shard back…just have no idea what to do with it." Catra shrugged, she was exhausted and about to fall asleep.

When the sudden clatter of a body hitting the floor resounded from Lonnie's side of the call then the explosive sound of pounding boots slowly fading away.

"What the hell…" Lonnie mumbled, staring off to the side of her camera as Huntara made a hasty exit.

"What was that all about?" Catra's eyes were open now and her heart was thundering in fear in her chest.

"I have no idea, but what do you need?" Lonnie returned her attention to Catra.

"I need you to send me the final status reports from the Hordes Naval Base , which is north of Scorpion Hills. I want to see if anything is left there that could be used to transport aid out to Salineas. I want to ship those supplies we rerouted to the outposts on the border of the Wastes back up to the Naval base." Catra asked, her body relaxing again as a nap became more intoxicating.

"Sure thing, I'll send all the equipment and supply logs to your pad. Later, Cat." Lonnie cut the call, just as Catra's eyes fell closed. She was out cold in a matter of moments. Finally feeling relaxed and safe enough to sleep.

The rest of the day was spent with Adora, Mermista, Sea Hawk and the rest of the crew of the sloop. Hauling crates and equipment into seven separate piles. As Orion travels from one village to the next, sending word over Mermista's communicator when he has reached each village. So Glimmer could teleport the supplies. It was dusk by the time the supplies had all been delivered and Orion had made it back to camp.

The evening mist blanketed the ground, creeping through the forest and slowly ascended as it did every night upwards towards the plateaus of the island. As Orion hit the beach once more, a mournful dirge echoed from near the shore. He paused to reflect upon the twin voices serenading in the distance.

One was only humming, slow and mournful. While the other sang, a sad, heartfelt melody. Of pain and regret towards the setting sun. The acoustic harmony between the two voices was absolutely stunning. Ascending and descending into the coming night, drawing him towards camp, entranced by the heavy emotions weaved within the lyrics.

"As the light is fading, my heart is breaking."

“I’m tearing apart, I’m tearing apart.”

“As my sin’s surround me, a storm is raging. ”

“I’m trying again, I’m trying again. ”

“Eyes on the burning horizon, I seek out guidance.”

“To deny my violence…to deny my violence.”

“Here in the islands, Here in the islands. ”

“I’ll find my forgiveness…

“Here in the islands.”

“I’ll become a better version of me.”

“Here in the islands, Here in the islands.”

A stiff breeze had picked up as Orion entered the beach, Argus howled from his side. Drawing his attention further along the twilight shore past the cluster of tents. To a lone figure walking upon the sand, huddled in a tan cloak. At their side was a large animal, he could not make out what kind at first. The two figures are still concealed by the gloom of rolling mists from the tides. But the shine in their eyes was unmistakable. One was a large animal by their four legged gait, the other walking on two feet and holding themselves tightly.

By the time the soft light of the tent’s outer, hanging lamps finally illuminated the figures, only one was visible. The Fox Hybrid… Kaira…her companion had disappeared.

But Argus was still on high alert, tail wagging and nose to the sand sniffing.

Orion narrowed his eyes in scrutiny, debating if questioning Kaira about her companion was warranted. Did it pose a threat to the villages? Was it trying to stay hidden or merely off hunting as nocturnal predators tend to? In the end he decided to give Kaira the benefit of the doubt, he trusted his sister's intuition for people. She did not surround herself with anyone that could not be trusted.

"Stay!" Orion commanded, slapping his thigh to get Argus attention. There was no need for the hound to go tracking. He would allow the creature to have its privacy for now. If it posed a danger to the island or any of its inhabitants, though, he would not hesitate to kill it.

By the time Orion made it back into camp, he was greeted by the dulcet tones of a strumming lute. Finding his sister nestled in the arms of her pirate lover before a roaring fire in the center of camp. Along with her new friends and a few of the Broland crew and some local fishermen. Who were living on their boats nearby, their livelihood keeping them away from their families further inland. Needing to be out upon the bay at first light to catch their haul of fish.

All of them were lounging around the fire, absently listening to the dark skinned Archer play on his instrument and speaking softly amongst themselves.

Orion strangely felt like he might be intruding upon some intimate gathering, as he settled down on a rock nearby with Argus at his feet.

Mermista was laughing rather boisterously at something, Sea Hawk had just muttered into her ear. When she noticed him.

"Stop lurking in the shadow's like a ghoul and join us, Orion!" She called teasingly. Waving him into the firelight.

Orion smiled and nodded, as the blonde woman with the ponytail shifted over closer to the Fox Hybrid making room for him near Mermista.

He sat upon the sand, leaning forward to gain Kaira's attention. Who was snuggled up against the blonde woman with a magicat kitten dosing in her arms. They looked like such a beautiful family. Orion was enamored by the scene instantly.

"You have a very powerful voice." Orion commented, glancing over to Glimmer as well. "You are both…amazing."

Glimmer blushed and ducked her head, nudging Bow at her side with a shoulder.

Bow leaned over and kissed her forehead tenderly. His lips lingering on Glimmer's skin far longer than normal. Making a point to Bull, who was sitting across the fire. Deep in conversation with member's of his crew. Oblivious to Bow's public display of affection. When Bow finally pulled away he was quietly disappointed the burly Casanova had missed his subtle act of claim upon the Queen of Bright Moon.

"Well, my voice is pretty awesome too, ya know." Sea Hawk boasted, jumping to his feet and springing into song. Never one to not become the center of attention.
"Oh, What shall we do with a drunken sailor!"

"What shall we do with a drunken sailor!" Sea Hawk bellowed, striking a heroic pose with one boot on a nearby rock and thrusting his fist into the air.

Just as the rest of the Broland sailor's began to encourage him more by joining in. Bull shouted in a roaring deep voice, meaty fists pumping into the air.

"What shall we do with a drunken Sailor…so early in the morning!"

Mermista groaned, rolled her eyes and swiftly stood up. Striding purposefully over to her boyfriend and fisting his red ascot pulling him in roughly.

Sea Hawk yelped at being manhandled, his eyes flying wide in surprise with a hint of arousal. As Mermista crashed her lips against his, silencing him instantly with a seductive moan.

The Broland crew roared and whooped their approval.
"Shut up…" Mermista whispered against his lips, ending the kiss with a sassy half smile. As she uncurled her fingers from his shirt and sat back down.

Sea Hawk giggled like a giddy schoolgirl, as a huge grin of pleasure spread over his flushed face.
"Anything for you, Dearest." He breathed. As his outrageous personality was brought to heel by Mermista's public show of affection.

Everyone burst into laughter as the shanty died into companionable silence.

Glimmer broke the silence several minutes later with a very pointed question.

"Who is the statue at the head of your island?"

Orion turned to acknowledge her, his expression was warm. As he leaned towards the stew pot resting on a flat stone near the fire. Spooning himself up some stew into a coconut bowl.

"That is the Sovereign Deity of Morta, Skuld. One of three immortal sisters, who are said to tend the tree of Fate at the center of the cosmos. Skuld's duty is to cut the threads of mortal coil from the Tapestry of Time. " Orion began.

His tale held an ancient power and it left everyone around the campfire speechless for a time.

“The lantern she holds…it looks very familiar?” Glimmer pushed gently.

“Ah, that is her Starlight Lantern. She uses it to guide lost soul’s to the Eternal Realm.” Orion explained, spooning up a bit of stew with a hum of satisfaction.

Glimmer frowned, even more confused. While Adora and Kaira shared a knowing look. The secret of Angella’s fate, a heavy burden they both bore. When the time was right, they both would sit Glimmer down and tell her the truth. But that time wasn’t now…hopefully soon.

“If you want to know more, we can hike up the Shrine of Eternity at the top of the plateau tomorrow.” Orion offered.

“I would like that very much.” Glimmer nodded, then stretched, settling down against Bow to enjoy the rest of the evening by the fire.

Several hours later, hidden away in her tent that she shared with Adora and Finn. Catra sat hunched over her cot, glaring down at her communicator pad. Reviewing her cargo routes and equipment logs for the Horde Naval Base.

Her mind was occupied with task lists, crew files and basically obsessing over every step in her strategy. To locate the aid currently held up in the border outposts along the Crimson Waste. Get it shipped to the Naval Base, stowed on the two remaining Horde Frigates still operable at the base. Assign a skeleton crew to man said frigates along with a small protection detail. On a handful of smaller, but more versatile assault craft, that she would get transported over from the Fortress. She knew of a few still in storage in militia warehouses that had never been requisitioned by the Naval Base. Since their fleet of patrol boats had been enough to secure the waterways, during the war. It would be faster if she could ship the supplies to one location here in the Archipelago.

Set Up a supply depot, like she had tried to set up in Sea Worthy. Then transfer it all onto unmarked ships to complete the journey to the other islands. Like they had to the Moirai islands. Mermista never sailed her color's until they were safe in harbor. No doubt to avoid being attacked by pirates. But they would still need more protection, the tiny armored rafts would not be enough? The sea was massive. They needed more...perhaps a Scorpion cruiser in the air for aerial surveillance?

Catra took a calming breath, glancing over to the shell hanging from the metal post of her cot. Being in disguise all day had been taxing, her skin felt itchy now. The glamor felt like a thin, skin tight glove always rubbing against the velvet fur on her arms and legs.

It would definitely take some getting used to.

She had stayed by the fire for as long as she could stand it, but she didn't feel safe around so many other people. Who's intentions and feelings towards her true self were no doubt hostile. So she had retreated to the security of her tent, secluded and hidden from the other's. She could finally relax. Beside Sea Hawks friends, Bull, Mouse and Monkey who were commanding the other sloops. No one else from Broland was with their expedition, so it was just them she had to worry about. Who had seen her true identity. Bull did not seem to be concerned that the ex-Horde commander had gone missing since boarding their skiff back at Broland. Bull was probably indifferent or grateful she was gone.

She jerked her attention to the closed flap of the tent, at a burst of laughter from the fire. Her ears perked upright and her tail thumped against the mattress, the last thing she wanted was to have a sudden visitor and have her cover blown on the very first night!

"Mother…" A quiet entreaty whispered just beyond the flap.

“Finn…hang on, I’ll let you in.” She called, growing more and more comfortable with the maternal title. Ironically, thanks to Double Trouble. Standing up and heading for the front of the tent. Her nose twitched as she smelled her kitten’s scent. An endearing mixture of herself and Adora’s scent. Which invoked such a fierce maternal instinct within her. To protect this kitten, care for them and make sure they always knew how much they were loved. To give them everything she had been denied. Her fingers worked deftly at the leather ties to release the flaps.

Finn scampered into the tent, with a tiny lizard held gently in their hands.

“That little monster belongs to you?” Catra yowled, back pedaling back to her cot. Shivering with revulsion at the sight of the slimy lizard that had scared her so thoroughly that morning.

“Yeah, Eek tends to make an entrance.” Finn chuckled, as the lizard stuck out its black tongue in a very obstinate manner.

“That’s a bit of an understatement.” Catra grumbled, sitting back down on the cot and resuming her perusal from the Naval Base’s. Reviewing the final inventory reports before the Horde pulled out a year ago. Finn busied themselves by rolling out their camping mat and gathering their pillow and blanket from their pack.

Catra glanced up, wondering if they were going to be warm enough? How cold did it get out on the islands?

“Finny…” She called sweetly, not even thinking. Then her brow furrowed in confusion. Trepidation gnawed at the back of her mind, at how natural that endearment had rolled off her lips. She had always felt a connection to this kitten. Ever since she had first heard about them from Huntara back at Mystacor.

Finn gasped and froze, mid pillow fluff.

“I…don’t know why I just called you that?” Catra chuckled, nervously.

“You always called me that.” Finn answered with a sniffle.

“Is it ok?” Catra began again. “Cause I’m not really your mom…” For the last couple days she had been reserved about showing Finn her true extent of her affection, for that reason alone.

Finn spun around, shaking their head. “Yes, you are.” They declared, conviction firm in their tone. “No matter what version of you…you will always be my mom and…I will always love….” Finn swallowed, seeking to restrain themselves and find the best words to express how they felt. They didn’t want to scare her, with a declaration or give away too much as to what happened to her.

“Finny….” They finally breathed, leaving so much unsaid, but their blue eyes were wet with gratitude, but most of all. Shimmering with such a deep unconditional affection for her. Showing her without words that she meant everything to them…

Catra’s awkward smile widened into an authentic grin of pure happiness. Instantly she was comfortable with how she felt towards Finn. No longer, holding back the intensity of her feelings. Worried that she wasn’t allowed or would not be accepted by….her kitten.

“I have something for you.” Catra leaned forward and quickly pulled her pack from under the cot. Unlatching the top flap and rummaging inside. Pulling out her own baby blanket from a thousand years ago.

“My blanket…” Finn sucked in a sharp breath, hands reaching instantly for it. Finger’s curling in and clasping like an eager little kid for their most favorite thing.

Catra was quick to offer the blanket to them, seeing the yearning and joy shimmering in their eyes at the sight of it.

She barely had it handed down to them, before they had clutched it tightly to their chest and pushed the soft woolen side of the blanket up to their nose. Their finger’s bunching in the blue dyed hide as they pressed it against their face.

Catra saw all the tension leaving their body as they smelled both Adora and Catra on the fabric. Finding solace in the same way she had as a baby…before being sealed away in that stasis pod for a thousand years.

The long drawn out sigh that escaped Finn's mouth was heavy with cherished reverence for the blanket. This item was the most precious source of comfort Finn had ever owned.

Catra knelt before them. Her hand reaching up and petting their head gently, as they basked in the smell and feel of the blanket. "Thank you….mother…thank you." They wept softly, pressing the blanket up tight to their face and hiding in its folds.

Catra said nothing, just pulled Finn into her arms and held them close. Rocking and whispering small words of comfort. Finding her own face was wet, as silent tears fell. This kitten was hurting so much, she just wanted to take care of them.

Adora's laughter slowly died, as she watched Finn march away from the fire and head to the far end of the camp where their tent was set up. Disappearing inside.

She stayed for a few more minutes to be polite, until Sea Hawk finished the heroic tale of his rescue of Sweet Bee and her crew in Sea Worthy. Then quietly took her leave, heading towards her tent. As she made her way down the narrow alleys of the encampment, head craned back. As always pulled towards the mysterious night sky and the eternity of star's above.

Somewhere out there, was Eternia…her own parents perhaps? Her brother…maybe was lost amid those stars…hopefully not dead? In time she may one day meet them, be a part of a family. Her thoughts wandered for a bit, before settling back down on Etheria. Staring at the tent ahead of her, her wistful expression

turned somber. She already had a family here…one she was grateful to be a part of. She had Catra, who was everything to her. A kitten…she was eager to get to know. Cherished friends…all of them had become her family. Honestly she was ok, if she never got off planet to meet her biological family. She had everything she ever wanted right here. With a nod, a slow, contented smile spread over her face as she slipped through the open flaps of the tent.

Mermista watched Adora go, disengaging from the quiet conversation she was having with Orion. who was sitting beside her on the other side of the fire. Her eyes shifted to the side as both Bow and Glimmer eventually followed after the blonde.

The Best Friend Squad always seemed to gravitate together eventually.

She oddly did not feel excluded, like the Best Friend Squad was some elite club she wasn't a part of. The fact that their friendship was so closely knit, filled her with a tender warmth. One she knew very well, reaching out a hand towards Sea Hawk, who grinned happily and swiftly took a seat beside her. Holding her hand and guiding her weight into his side. As he settled his butt against the sand, holding her close as she continued her conversation with her little brother.

The relaxing qualities of being held by Sea Hawk were quickly washed away. As she suddenly felt eyes upon her again.

It was just like earlier that day, when she was walking the beachline, searching for clues as to who may have come ashore to steal the power stones. She could feel those very same eye's upon her. The eerie feeling of being watched was unsettling. Mermista pulled away from Sea Hawk, jumping to her feet and unlatching her trident from her belt. Staring at the black water of the bay, lapping gently against the beach.

“Dearest?” Sea Hawk called, his voice concerned.

“It’s nothing…I think…” Mermista narrowed her eyes in scrutiny, swearing she saw the water ripple just beyond the cloister of boulder’s butting against the shoreline further to the east. But the moon’s overhead were slightly hidden behind heavy clouds, making it hard to see. So it could have been nothing?

Just the water lapping against the rocks…but the anxious feeling never lifted and Mermista was quick to retreat away from the water to the security of her own tent.

Chapter End Notes

From now on when Catra is in her glamor, I will be calling her Kaira.

Whispers in the mist

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comments, I really do not want to give anything away as to what going to happen next. But Omega Prime was the mutant wyrm, on Beast island. That the scientist made with Horde D.N.A and Vasuki's scale. The Guardian of Life, the white wyrm with the blue eye that Mara met in the Highlands of Bright Moon. Also thank you to all who left Kudo's. PointlesslyPoetic, I love reading your stuff too.

“Why is everyone bunking in our tent? When they have a perfectly acceptable cabin in the skiff” Catra observed dryly. As Bow and Glimmer set up their own cot across the tent.

“We haven’t had a Best Friend’s Squad Sleepover since Space.” Bow responded, pulling off his crop top and tossing it on top of his back. That was leaning against the side of their cot. Proceeding to pull off his boots and pants next. Until he was in nothing but his red boxer’s with little white hearts. The months spent in space together in such close quarters, struggling to survive the unknown threats of the vacuum and avoiding Horde Primes scouts, Had gotten the four of them very comfortable with each other.

“That sleepover was not by choice.” Catra quipped, folding her arms over her chest and scowling at Bow good naturedly.

“Technically, you're right. Darla was malfunctioning at the time and the bunk room was the only section with life support.” Bow nodded.

“We were stuck together for days, while Entrapta did repairs.” Catra snapped back, rolling her eyes.

“Those were the best…we really got to know each other then.” Adora pointed out.

“Forced bonding…my favorite kind.” Catra chuckled sarcastically.

Bow stuck out his tongue. “Do you always have to be such a brat?” He commented with fake indignation.

“Always.” Catra grinned.

“I, for one, enjoyed that time together. We hadn’t seen Adora at bedtime for weeks, she was always having a sleepover in your room.” Glimmer accused lightly, before slipping behind the rice paper partition with her sleepwear draped over an arm.

Both Adora and Catra blushed, remembering those first few weeks after their escape from Prime. It had been a rather sweet yet awkward time rekindling their friendship. Adora cleared her throat and chuckled, before crouching down before her pack. Tossing Catra one of her overly large white t-shirts and then promptly disrobing down to her underclothes just like Bow.

“Am I part of the Squad?” Finn asked softly, sitting on their camping matt at the back of the tent. Ready for bed, in their black chest wrap and black shorts. Sea Hawk old red ascot is still tied around their neck, as they never took it off.

“Of course, you're basically…Best Friend Squad 2.0, kiddo.” Glimmer winked playfully at them. As she walked out from behind the rice paper dressing partition in her lacey lavender and pastel blue nightgown.

Finn grinned happily, blushing and ducking their head. Their blue eyes falling distant, because her words were dead on. They were a part of the Best Friend Squad 2.0…which consisted of Archer, Flora, Shoal and them. The rest of the heirs were very good friends but they were older and just didn’t click the same way. Horus was the oldest and so much like his mother, driven to discover the secrets of the universe. He never had much time to spend with making friends. While Ciri…she sorta became their

leader…kinda became their mother, when they all went into hiding after the whole disappearance of their parents.

“Well, if this is going to be a Best Friend’s Squad Sleepover, then we gotta play truth or dare!” Adora declared, now wearing just her gray tank top and loose boxer shorts.

Finn licked their bottom lip nervously, sensing their momma had ulterior motives with the choice of game.

“I hate that game.” Catra groaned, leaving the divider right behind Glimmer. In one of Adora’s larger white training tank tops that hung just over her hips. Her black panties peeked out from beneath the hem, from time to time as she prowled up to Adora. Shoving the blonde in the back playfully as she made her way over to their cot and sat down cross legged, throwing her pillow in her lap for a bit of modesty.

“Yeah, it's a lot more fun to play when you have some alcohol to take the edge off your embarrassment.” Glimmer sided with Catra, settling down on her cot and pulling up the fluffy comforter onto her lap to keep her legs warm.

“Well if we want to include Finn, then we can’t drink.” Bow nodded towards the kitten.
“Yes, you can.” Finn picked at their baby blanket nervously, debating if they should admit the truth.

“You’re…like seven!” Adora stated in alarm, suddenly wondering how poor of a parent she must have been to allow her kid to drink at such a young age.

“This is just a form I've taken…uhm..I’m actually much older.” Finn answered softly. “My magic is Time and Space.” As if, that was an explanation enough as to why they looked like a child but weren’t.

Catra and Adora instantly looked at each other in surprise.

Then Catra grabbed her pillow and chucked it hard at Finn. The kitten had no time to react, as the soft cushion rebounded off their face.

“Well that explains why you spout off about things you should not understand at your age.” She ranted, feeling somewhat vindicated. It had been very humiliating to be told off by a kid, who had an uncanny skill to point out all her worst faults. Then offer such mature, sound advice to fix her fuck ups.

Finn merely chuckled ruefully, tucking the pillow in their lap.

“How old are you!” Bow was suddenly very alarmed.

“I guess around your age.” Finn shrugged.

“Then why would you disguise yourself as a kid?” Glimmer jumped in.

Finn grimaced, their reason was purely selfish in nature. They wanted to relive their childhood with their mother’s at least for a little while. “It’s not a glamor, exactly. I just reversed my age when I went through the portal and passed through the crossroads between worlds.” They explained. “It's still me…just a younger version…of me. ” They answered, hedging around answering with overly detailed explanations as to how they did it, not why.

“I understood none of that.” Adora sighed, flopped back on her cot in defeat. Undercovering Finn’s secrets was going to be far more complicated…but that was what she had assumed anyway.

“Whelp, let's get this game going then!” Bow just rolled with it, pulling out a Salinean Wine bottle from his pack. The bottle was slender, tinted a rose color with an elegantly shaped neck.

“Where did you get that!” Catra shrieked, she had drank Salinean brandy back in the Waste during their victory party and got drunk off her ass far to quickly. It had been a wild and rather tumultuous night for her. After nearly kissing Scorpia and then that horrible

talk with Adora. Where she finally had to accept that Shadow Weaver never gave a shit about her! She was feeling very self destructive. Which led to her drinking far too much then a crash course with discovering intimacy. So not all bad, but not great either. She learned she never wanted to lose control of herself like that ever again! She could only guess that that stuff was going to knock her out cold in two swigs.

"Sea Hawk…I'm supported to use it to christen the skiff after I come up with a name for it. But I really have no idea what to call it and if we drink this dry. Then maybe he will back off about it for a bit while he has to go find and purchase another bottle." Bow smirked, popping the cork.

"You're kinda devious, aren't you. Arrows." Catra chuckled, at the appalled look on Bow's face.

"Naw, Bow's just avoids dealing with stuff sometimes." Glimmer laughed, sliding a pointed look towards Bow. She had to admit, the passion in their relationship had cooled somewhat since his absence back at Mystacor and both of them were avoiding that conversation.

Bow was looking embarrassed but also confused with just a touch of guilt mixed in. Which meant, he knew exactly what Glimmer was leaving unsaid.

Catra was instantly intrigued. "Tell me more!"

"Bow wouldn't tell his two fathers that he was a rebellion fighter, instead he lied and told them he was at boarding school. According to his letter's home, Glimmer and I were his classmates. Because he was worried that they would be disappointed in him or whatever. " Adora clued her in with a playful grin, instead. Oblivious to the tension simmering between Bow and Glimmer.

Bow groaned and slammed his face into his pillow.
"See…point made. " Glimmer roared with laughter, as Bow avoided looking at everyone in the room. She was fine with the

deflection. No one needed to know that their relationship was struggling right now.

Glimmer leaned over the side of the cot and picked up the bottle that Bow had set down.

“Here…take a drink it will take the edge off.” She offered him the bottle, sympathetically.

Bow released the end of the pillow, but still hid behind it as he took the bottle, taking a long swig.

Which only made everyone laugh even harder at him.

“Ok, fine let's get this game over with, so I can get to sleep.” Catra settled down on the ground, tucking her legs to the side. As she leaned against the cot, between Adora’s bare legs. Adora was quick to pull out a brush from her pack and start working it through Catra's now shoulder length tangle of brunette hair. Catra’s ear’s instantly moved downward out of the way, to give Adora room to work. Silently showing everyone in the room that this was a well practiced before bed routine for them.

Catra hummed in pleasure instantly, closing her eyes and leaning forward a bit to give Adora more room to brush downward. All while Finn admired them both from their sleeping matt. Warm memories of their childhood washing over them. As their Momma had spent a great deal of time brushing their hair before bed each night, too.

“Alright then, Horde Scum since you're so eager. Truth or Dare.” Glimmer demanded.

Catra grunted and snapped her eyes open, staring Glimmer down.

“Dare, Sparkles.” She shot back.

Glimmer was stunned for a moment, then a slow mischievous smile curled her lips, as if she was prepared for the magicat

natural tendency to be combative.

“Bold start.” Adora patted Catra on the shoulder sympathetically. Knowing from experience how reckless that move was with Glimmer.

“Close your eyes and open your mouth.” Glimmer dared, her lilac eyes holding Catra’s gaze firmly. Figuring she got her, since Catra had very little trust in anyone that wasn’t Adora.

Catra complacently squared her shoulders, closed her eyes and opened her mouth.

“Now what?” Adora mouthed in shock at Glimmer.

Glimmer was stunned for only a second before she crawled off her cot. Moving swiftly to rummage in her pack, pulling out an aerosol whip cream can. She shook it hard for a minute and then crawled over to Catra, squeezing a large dollop of it into her mouth.

Catra tensed at first when she heard the hiss of the spout, then as soon as she tasted the cream. The most sensual, almost erotic moan issued from deep in her throat. Adora couldn’t help but blush and wiggle her hips, that sound was so familiar since their more recent lovemaking that it had instantly made her aroused.

Glimmer giggled and attempted to back up, only to have Catra snap her eyes open and snatch the bottle out of her hands. Thanks to her lightning fast reflexes, stealing the bottle had been extremely easy.

“Mine!” Catra declared, shaking it up and squirting more into her mouth and swallowing it. Finishing with a satisfied lick of her lips, her eyes focused on Glimmer again, pupils dilating with trepidation. As Glimmer was still inches away and slowly hovered her hand above Catra’s head, waiting for permission. Catra slowly blinked at her.

A goofy, lopsided grin spread over Glimmer’s face as she ruffled Catra’s mane, affectionately. Humming happily as she retreated

back to her cot.

Finn used the distraction to lean forward and stole the whip cream away from their mother, squeezing some into their own mouth before tossing it to Glimmer. Who took a shot of whip cream before passing it on to Bow.

Catra grinned triumphantly at Glimmer, having passed her subtle trust test.

Glimmer was pleased, her cheeks rosy and eyes glistening with joy. Catra trusted her not to hurt her, she was finally willing to be vulnerable with her. It was a momentous moment for the Queen of Bright Moon, who had been working for months to regain the magicats trust. Since their falling out in the lowland marshes of Thaymor. Only to find out now that Catra's trust in her was far greater than it was before.

"Ok, my turn." Adora glanced over to Finn. Who instantly squirmed nervously.

"Truth or Dare."

Finn thought for a moment, then sighed in resignation. "Truth."

Adora grinned, tapping her chin for a moment to drag out the moment. "I can guess easily enough that the ascot you wear is Sea Hawks."

Finn nodded, "The wing pin is yours, Momma." they added, knowing where this was going. They had caught Adora staring at the pin many times in the last couple days. Knew she was curious about it, but was holding her tongue waiting for the right time to bring it up. Adora had been more than patient, but she needed answers and this was an opportunity for her to get them. This wasn't how the game worked, but they were not going to argue either. They understood her need for answers.

"But what is up with the stone fragments?' Adora finished, her eyes soft, conflicted if she truly wanted to know now that she had

asked.

Finn groaned, crawled forward and stole the bottle of wine from Bow. Taking a long drink. Everyone watched with a mixture of wonder and horror as they saw a kitten pound back a bottle of wine like a seasoned pro.

Running out of air, Finn slammed the bottle down a quarter gone and took a deep breath. Needing that time to work out their words. "They are fragments of my mother's soul stones." They left it at that, not willing to admit that their mother's are dead and this is all that they had left of them.

But they didn't have to, it was enough. Catra ghosted her fingertips over her forehead where her tiara and the runestone that manifested when she called on her magic. Her other hand reaching up and taking Adora's hand, breathing heavy. Adora wore a grim frown, accepting what was left unsaid. Holding Catra's hand and rubbing her thumb over her knuckles soothingly. While Glimmer stared wide eyed, taking it in. Bow had his gaze locked on the bottle, understanding the finality in Finn's explanation but refusing to allow it any power over him… just yet. The future was not set in stone, there was time to fix it, change it…keep his friends safe.
"You drank half the bottle in one go! " Bow exaggerated in a loud shout, snatching the bottle back.

Finn offered their uncle a small, apologetic smile. But they felt much lighter, confessing that their mother's were gone. The familiar grief was easier to handle while under the influence of the wine. They had been worried they might break down and cry inconsolably all over again as they had as a child. They had been a blubbering mess upon seeing Double Trouble in this timeline, but their death had just happened. The heartache was still fresh. But the years living without their mother's, gave their heart time to heal, to scar. Where unbearable sorrow had once resided in their heart, they now felt hollow and numb. It wasn't a pleasant feeling, but it was less painful to bear.

“Alright Adora, Truth or Dare.” Bow tossed, the blonde, the whip cream can. Getting the light hearted nature of the game back on track. Giving Finn time to calm themselves, as they looked ready to cry.

Catra was lost in thought, as well. Her mind is in overdrive with theories as to what may have happened in Finn’s time and why the kitten was so obsessed with the shard. It was bad news for everyone, so what kind of apocalypse did they just escape from?

“Truth.” Adora grunted, as she sprayed a huge amount of cream in her mouth before passing it down to Catra. It had been tough to hear that she was gone in Finn’s timeline but not surprising. She was She-Ra, it was only a matter of time before she joined that line of dead champion’s. She had come to terms with that back at the Crystal Castle, so she was quick to compartmentalize her own mortality. Push it aside, live in the moment and not allow it to have much power over her.

“Have you ever farted and blamed someone else?” Bow asked, with a straight face.

“Easy!” Adora chuckled.
“Kyle!” Adora and Catra responded in unison, before exploding into a fit of giggles. Bow’s silly question is able to pull the Magicat out her brooding.
“Story?” Finn grinned, hopping on their butt eagerly. Tales of Kyle were always the most hilarious.

“We were in what…fifth or sixth year of training?” Adora leaned down to Catra, squeezing her shoulders for confirmation.

“Does it matter?” Catra glanced up, reaching over and retrieving the brush from the thin mattress and handing up to Adora. Who took the silent demand with a warm smile and began to brush her hair again. Catra squeezed some cream into her mouth then tossed the can to Finn. She was living in the moment more as well, enjoying the good times as they came and not allowing herself to become sullen about things she couldn’t change.

“Well…the mess hall was trying out a new ration bar…it was worse than even the brown kind. It was green and it gave you the worst gas ever. Anyway, I had skipped both breakfast and lunch that day so I was extremely hungry…so I ate like three of them!”

The game continued for a long time, they barely drank the wine and Bow ended up dumping it out. Finn was the first to crash, falling asleep early. Followed by Glimmer and Bow.

As always, Adora retrieved her boot knife and tucked it under her pillow before settling down in the cot with Catra. Pulling her flush up against her front and holding her close as she tucked the blanket over both of therm. Snuggling into the feline’s neck and kissing her tenderly, enjoying the magicats sweet moans of pleasure.
“Good night…my love.” She whispered softly against Catra’s ear.

Cata gasped, this was the first time since their lovemaking back on the skiff. That she had heard Adora’s endearment for her. It was the most wonderful sound, so full of deep affection and tenderness it took her breath away. She wiggled herself more tightly against the taller blonde, who had curled around her back. Pulling Adora’s hand up from her waist, threading their fingers together and pressing them up against her heart. That was now beating swiftly beneath her breast. Showing her how much that word had affected her.

“Sweet dreams…princess.” Catra breathed, as a soft purr issued from her chest. Nestled in Adora’s arms, all her worries faded away. She felt safe, knowing she was surrounded by people who loved and accepted her. It does not take more than a second for Finn’s own purr to echo with Catra's throughout the tent.

Glimmer sighed, as she rested her head against Bow’s bare chest. While Bow held her close, smiling softly in his sleep. Even if things had cooled off between them, they still loved each other deeply. She knew without a doubt that would never change.

With the low rumble of the magicats purr, the cool, fresh sea air wafting through the dark confines of the tent. A peaceful aura surrounded them all. As Adora felt absolutely content, falling into a deep, dreamless sleep.

Finn was not so lucky…

It was long past midday, the Sun was just starting to sink into the golden hills of the sprawling Savannah. The clear blue sky was darkening on the horizon with heavy clouds. Warning of an evening downpour. It wasn't uncommon for the weather to change suddenly this time of year. As the warm season transitioned to the hotter days. Finn was walking the long, narrow ramparts of clear crystal. The inner facets that were now set on fire by the setting sun. Walking the length of an open colonnade, towards the archer's perch, on the outer watchtower of the Crystal Castle. The watchtower lay beyond the covered bridge that linked the two parts of the massive castle. Built upon the two broken halves of the Sunna Stone. It was part of the upper bastions of the outer fortifications. That curtained the main castle around the foot of the twin stones. The Watchtower, was the Crystal Castles first line of defense. The upper turret was the highest point of the outer fortifications. In which the Sentinel Guards could observe the most distant parts of the open Savannah. The uppermost housing of the turret was the distress beacon.

While the majestic main keep lay behind them on the larger fragment of the Stone. Tall arching windows, refracting the light in a prism glow down towards the beautiful city of Solaris. Washing the cityscape in a shattered rainbow of glorious colors. Smooth, elegant balconies, wrapped around the upper tiers of the Keep in a naturally flowing spiral. The higher reaches, accented by many delicate spires, ascending up towards the clouds.

Finn was in their royal finery, of black dress pants and white jacket with a gold trimmed collar and silver flame embellishments,

curving down each long sleeve. With a frilly pearl white shirt, the wide collar popped up. Their long blonde hair was tied back in a low ponytail with a powder blue orchid corsage around their wrist. They were not much older than twelve, lanky and just starting to build muscle in their arms and legs. From long hours training with their mother's to one day becoming a Knight of the Crystal Kingdom. Their face at the cusp of losing the childlike softness in favor of a more adolescent elegance.

An air of excitement sparked in the atmosphere of the Castle. Everyone was moving with haste to finish the preparations for the Royal celebrations happening this evening. So Finn had retreated out of the barely controlled chaos within the Main Keep to the Watch Tower. As the princess ball was about to begin. It was their mother's first year to host.

It had taken a supreme amount of courage for Finn to ask Flora to be their plus one. But they had managed to finally blurt it out, last hot season when the royal family was visiting Bright Moon, along with the rest of the Royal court. For the Lunar festival. An ancient Lunari holiday, Queen Glimmer had resurrected to honor the Half Moon magicats heritage, who had reappeared and were now under her rule.

Finn was watching the wide thoroughfare, out past the western gates. Which was full of merchant wagons and royal carriages. All converging upon the city of Solaris. The city sprawled out below the castle and around the Sunna Stones. In a very similar manner as Mystacor. With numerous quarter's divided by sentry walls, that curled and spiraled themselves through the city. It was a round city, almost dome shaped in its architecture. With the taller structures crowded closer to the Stones then receding to shorter, less elaborate buildings closer to the outer walls. Many smaller villages were scattered beyond the battlements within the embrace of the grasses of the Savannah. Finn could see the light's of their quaint street's glowing in Savannah as dusk fell. None of the villages were too far away that the protection of the Kingdom's Knights could not provide timely aid.

The sudden burst of excitement exploded in their chest, as they hopped up upon the rampart, seeing Flora's carriage amid the traffic. It was so softly colorful, the painted panels of the carriage were like a meadow of flowers. Mimicking the pastel hues seen upon the traveling wagon's of the forest people. Speaking highly of the Royal Family's ties to Plumeria. With wide blocky windows on all sides, they could see Flora's mother's crimson carapace and claw resting out of one of the open side windows. Queen Scorpia of the Kingdom of Scorpania, was a huge woman. Her countenance was both regal and powerful. Not only in personality but also in frame. Just seeing her claw made Finn's heart leap. Not in fear, but further excitement. Their fondness for their Aunt Scorpia was at least as much as their own mother. Who never went a day it seemed without calling the Scorpion hybrid. Seeking counsel as much as just needing to hear her voice, to joke and laugh and just enjoy some time with her. Their Momma's shared a similar close relationship with the Queen of Bright Moon.

Scorpia was their mother's best friend and she was the most warm hearted and endearing person they had ever known. Flora's deep blue eyes and platinum blonde hair and also her long scorpion tail came from her Antreenid mother. Along with Flora's kind hearted spirit. Her human arms, reed thin frame and delicate beauty came from her Plumerian mom. Also her indomitable will to always see the best in every situation no matter how bad. Perfuma was a wise and caring soul, always quick to smile and offer a kind, affirming word to others.

The gold leaf decorating the cab was in various floral patterns depicting the many flowers that grew in Scorpiania's sister state, Plumeria. Flora's other mother, Perfuma governed Plumeria, from the royal seat of Scorpania. Plumeria was still considered its own Kingdom but it prospered now under Scorpania rule.

The two footmen stood at the back of the carriage, on the back footboard in full crimson and black, Scorpania Armor. With massive, ornate power staves in hand. The coachmen up front. Was dressed in more light weight, ornate armor similar to the footmen. He sat in the curved, open cockpit, driving the carriage.

The four lower thrusters banks, on each corner of the chassis, glowed beneath the carriage.

As the various royal carriages hovered amid the less modern wagon's, that still had wheels. Belonging to the merchants and commoners who were also vying for position before the gates. Wanting to quickly set up their wares, as the royal celebration turned the central market into one giant festival for the night.

Finn scanned the ever increasing crowds, finding similar hover carriages from the other Kingdom's all decorated and in the royal sigils and color's. They easily picked out the twilight colors of Bright Moon, the high tech carriage of Dryl. That looked more like a spaceship…than anything Etherian. The shimmering, seashell encrusted carriage of Salineas. The less ornate but just as elegant green and gray carriage from the Highlands of Brightmoon. Surprisingly, Finn found the reclusive Queen Frosta also in attendance. The white and pale blue carriage of The Kingdom of Snow's hung at the back of the mob. It had been a very long time since they had seen the Queen, perhaps not since their third year of life. When she and the rest of the kingdom's royalty had attended Finn's first communion with Adarion. The reclusive Queen rarely left her Castle, her relationship with the rest of the Queen's seemed strained. Since long before they were born.

A tickle of clarity, fluttered in the back of their mind. A whisper as cold and crisp as ice, pulsed through them. This was not a memory…this never happened? Etheria was long conquered by the time Finn had turned twelve? But it was so real…how could this be a dream?

(Child of Fate…) A low rumble, growled in their ear.

Finn lurched from their crouched position on the rampart. Leaping on all fours back to the shimmering crystal flag stones. The whisper was not an entreaty but a summons. Pulling the kitten back across the covered bridge and down into the very bowels of

the Castle. Deep into the ancient caves beneath the Sunna Stones.

They moved effortlessly down a wide, dark tunnel, glowing orbs of light floated in the air like dust motes. Finn followed the smooth, well worn path as they moved deeper. Listening for the voice, the whisper from beyond this sphere of existence that only they could hear.

They were relaxed, completely at ease here in the dark. Having navigated these twisting caves with their Mother, for years. This was a sacred place for the Sunna prides. That only the Rune Bearer of Fire could visit.

Strange orange crystals covered in lichen grew upon the walls as they moved deeper. The crystals glowed bright, as if the core was ignited by some mystical eternal flame. The lichen crawling along the stone smelled sweet like nectar. It grew thicker as the tunnel twisted into a cavern. Then they heard the sound of water trickling above that could only mean they were beneath the waterfall, that was on the oasis side of the monolith. Solaris eastern half on the larger half of the Sunna Stones. Was more lush and covered in a thick forest of Baobab Trees, as the Western side on the smaller side of the Sunna Stones was covered in rolling hills and golden Savannah grass.

A hot wind howled up from the depths, blasting Finn right in the face and making them squint and raise an arm to ward off the heat. Slowly, making their way down along a set of narrow, naturally carved steps. That wound around the edge of the vast cavern that dominated the center of the larger portion of the Sunna Stones. Finn kept a hand against the wall, maintaining their precarious balance as they made their way down. Glancing over the side of the steps to the very bottom. Where a glow so intense and blinding lay, it was as if a star was burning far below.

Soon they stood at the bottom of the steps, surrounded by an immense orange glow. Ahead of them in the center of the cavern,

was what looked like a giant fire. It's mass flickering and snapping merrily in the pitch black void of the cavern's depths.

(How long will you make me wait?) *The rumbled breath echoed in their mind. The power of eternity, refracting and rebounding all around them. Finn swallowed, they had never felt this way before. So nervous and honestly scared about confronting the ancient magic that resided in this chamber. They felt like a small child, ashamed that their very existence was disappointing a loving parent. It was a strange and very off-putting way to feel. One they were very much not accustomed to.*

As Finn drew near they felt the dry ground beneath their feet tremble as the living fire shifted in the center of the cavern. Their mouth opened in awe as they walked closer to the flame.

Finding the transparent spirit of an immense serpent coiled around an anatomically accurate crystal heart. The long flowing strands of fur, that resembled licking flames. The serpent was at least a hundred feet long, coiling and stretching around the grotesque crystal heart. As if protecting an egg. Millions of tiny coppery scales hid beneath the patches of glowing fur, gleaming as if freshly smelted from the forge. The sheer strength and power the serpent held in its rippling musculature left Finn breathless. The phantom spirit of Ouroboros was immense. Then Finn's slow approach was stalled. As they saw one massive eye, staring right at them. It glowed yellow like a lantern, the incredible amounts of magic it held onto was staggering. Finn's own heart was hammering in their chest in fear. Frozen and unable to think as the beast's eye held them in place.

Finn was transfixed upon the heart at the center of the coiling Serpent. Watching as the twin chamber's flexed, pumping as if alive. The arteries jutting out on top on either side. Amputated from its physical body centuries ago. The vein's glistening upon the outer crystal skin like ice, upon a clear lake.

“The Soul Ember…” Finn gasped, it had been so long since they had seen it intact. In their time the last remnant of Ouroboros had been shattered, just after the fall of the Solaris. Finn had been bound and dragged to the chamber and forced to watch. As Evil Lynn, in an act of absolute supremacy, over the Crystal Kingdom destroys their sacred relic. After his mother had been murdered, She-Ra and the Queens of Etheria were gone. No one was going to save them from Skeletor’s reign. Finn had to admit it had broken them, all fight and hope had left them then. Making it that much easier to be tossed into a cell and left to rot for years, as a slave to Whiplash.

Finn moved towards the crystal heart as if pulled by a string. Their bare feet shuffling forward, blue eyes glazed and distant. Entranced by the magic slowly engulfing them. As they neared, the vision before them shimmered, like ripples on the water.

Catra stood before the Soul Ember, as she was now. Perhaps a little older. But still a young dame, with a wild mane that now reached her shoulder blades. Her gray tufts were braided, with sun stone shards beaded into the knots. Fluttering in the eternal wind, howling from the depths of the relic. Black ash was painted over her mismatched eyes, in a thick band from temple to temple. An glowing orange rune was etched upon her forehead, a slideway's V.

Finn didn’t remember their rune’s very well, it had been a long time since their mother had taught them the Hybrid Runes. Catra’s pupils were blown wide, as if she was hunting. The ring of blue and yellow, so thin. It was as if the Sun was eclipsed in her eyes.

She was wearing a leather hide corset, dyed blood red. It barely covered her chest, leaving her stomach bare. A thin, pale white capelet was draped over her shoulders. Still baring the black sigil of Horde Prime. No doubt taken from a clone, desperate to cloth herself as much as possible. Their mother would never willingly wear any piece of that uniform ever again. Her wrists were sheathed in black leather arm guards. Tied together with thin,

crossing stripes of tan leather cords. Both of her arms were raised, hands pressed flat against the Soul Ember. Once again black ash marred the tops of her hands in a thick band with different Runes etched in white. A simple three branched tree symbol upon her right, a jagged S shape very much like a lightning bolt upon her left.

Upon her curving waist was a thick black leather, gold buckle belt. With a simple hunting knife sheathed at her hip. Her legs are protected by thin, black pants. With heavy boiled leather's greaves, buckled over her shins. Standing barefoot upon the dry earth, toe claws digging into the ground to maintain her stance against the wind. She resembles some kind of mythic pirate more than the Queen she would one day become.

Finn didn't know if this was the future of this timeline or perhaps an Alternate Universe. They navigated so many while moving through the crossroad of Worlds within the flux of energy that inhabited that portal.

This could be a residual vision, from their memories or a glimpse of what was yet to come. Either way, as they closed in on the Soul Ember their breath hitched and their heart lurched in their chest.

Within the facet of the Soul Ember, was Mara…her visage shimmered to be replaced by Adora. Who was shrouded in a thin white dress with gold accents around the elegant bodice. Only to shimmer again, transitioning back to Mara in her pale blue armor. It was confusing and ominous at the same time.

***(The future must be secured anew)** An elderly voice echoed, from everywhere all at once.*

***(Return what once was stolen.)** A second voice, younger but still mature.*

***(A bond broken and torn asunder)** A third voice, much younger, childlike.*

(Balance once woven…now knotted and frayed) *Ouroboros continued the chant.*

(Must be restored…the weave made whole once more.) *The final voice was their own. Leaving Finn, shuttering with the raw power of time and space coursing through their body. Their muscles felt electrified as the vision exploded into a timeless void of nothingness.*

Finn cried out, bolting upright on their mat. Their senses were primed for a fight, ear's twitching and tail thumping. Pupils blown wide as their eyes scanned the dark interior of the tent for threats that never came. Confronting only the silence of the early morning, as the sun had yet to rise. The world locked in a tranquil twilight between night and day as the duality of magic intertwined on the horizon.

"Well, that's an awful way to wake up." Kei-Lee advised, coming into view in a cloud of sparkles right beside their bed. Kneeling inches away from their mat, staring at them with keen interest.

"Stop doing that!" Finn groused, pushing the pixie's shoulder hard to force her to stop hovering so close.

"Your magic aura was glowing all around you." Kei-Lee observed, "You get visions…like the Seer of Fate?"

"No…" Finn grunted, bowing their head and clutching their forehead in a raised palm. Bracing their elbows on their bent knees. They suddenly felt very nauseous.

"First one…" They reluctantly admitted.

Kei-Lee nodded, "My great, great, great, great granddad…he got vision's after going through the crossroads of World's after Mara's Portal. Nearly went insane, he did. "

Finn snapped their head sideways in shock.

“Loo-Kee…he was onboard Mara’s ship when she transported Etheria into Despondos. He was carrying the Kaydak Crystal back to the Oasis to lock it away forever…” Kei-Lee, grimaced. “ Unstable Portal’s mess with your mind…some magic has a price. Ya, know. ”

Finn just stared at her, dumbfounded by her statement. Taking several deep breaths as they sought to calm down and not throw up the wine now bubbling in the back of their throat. It didn’t work and in a flurry of movement, they rushed out of the tent. Disappearing into the tree’s behind the tents, retching and coughing miserably.

Gateway to Eternity

Chapter Notes

> As always, thank you Pink Storm for your comment. I can never answer your question's with out giving spoilers. But all will be explained. I have started typing up my fic notes, maybe I will post them sometime. Also thanks to all who have left Kudo's so far.

The Greater Moon's hung heavy, with their smaller court of satellites scattered over the night sky. As the last of the day's warmth ebbed away. It was well past midnight, far into the early hours before dawn. The sky was still a dark tapestry of sparkling starlight, as the clouds hung low upon the sea.

Kei-Lee rubbed small circles on Finn's shoulder blades, as the kitten retched into the bushes out beyond the rebellion tents. Their suffering hidden, within the heavy fog and thick ferns that crowded within the palm trees guarding the beach. The wet splash of the contents of their stomach hitting the foliage, disrupting the nocturnal song of the wildlife. Which stuttered at their intrusion only to start up again a moment later, more agitated, calling in warning to their kin.

"Wow…you had a lot in there." The pixie observed dryly, glancing over the kitten's shoulder. Her awe, quickly twisting into a grimace of disgust. As Finn's dark ears pinned back against their head. As their shoulders lurched forward yet again. Dry heaving miserably. Their whole body trembling with the recoil of their stomach muscles. Light headed and woozy from the temporal backlash of their vision. Clammy and still disorientated. Finn was struggling to regain their composure. After a couple more fruitless attempts to ease the nausea, Finn finally slumped back on their butt. Flipping their now sweaty, blonde bangs over their ear, fruitlessly. Only to have the long strand fall forward once more, over their teary blue eyes. With a sigh, They began to wipe away the spittle from the corner of their mouth with the back of their hand. Only to groan

in disgust, as they unwrapped the now soiled bandage from around that wrist. Revealing the fresh pink scar, of a bad burn now disfiguring the velvet fur.

“Well, that’s ugly?’ Kei-lee observed with mild interest.

“A memento from Tri-clops, while escaping Etheria in my timeline.” Finn groused, Sweet Bee had done a great job rebandaging it. But no amount of ointment and care was going to stop that ugly scar from forming.

Kei-Lee stared at the scar for a moment, before pulling down her goggles. Her left index fingers, clicking the gears on either side of the lens to increase the magnification. As her warm brown eyes grew comically large behind the glass.

“The dermal damage…was deep…you were hit with at least 150 Kilowatts or more?...by the angle I’d say it was an aerial assault, while in retreat?”

“Yeah, Death Seeker Drone. You're a tech master?” Finn cocked their head to the side with a cordial smile.

Kei-lee sat back on her hunches. “I tinker with whatever tech I can get my hands on, really. I am not part of the guild or anything…it’s just a hobby…when one lives for thousands of years…it helps to have interests. ” She shrugged.

Finn grinned.”Can you fix my power staff?”

Kei-lee’s eyes lit up with excitement. “Alternate dimensional tech! I’d love to take a look at that!”

Finn didn’t know if this was her strange way to distract them from their nightmare or honest interest? But her eagerness to investigate and the hope that she may be able to fix their damaged weapon was enough to lighten the anxiety they felt after experiencing such a powerful vision.

“Lets head back to the skiff, it's in my bag, in the main cabin.” Finn rose to their feet, grabbing Kei-lee’s hand and dragging the pixie after them. As they sprinted back towards the tents.

“Finn…are you alright?” Adora’s frantic voice called to them just as they left the tree line. The blonde was jogging towards them, dressed in her night clothes. Shoulder length blonde flying hair loose and fluttering behind her. As she ran across the open area of dried grass behind the tents. Brandishing her pillow dagger in her right hand, the sleek blade glinting in the half light of the moons. With the Magic of She-Ra weakened as it was. She wasn’t going to summon the limited amount she had access to for minor issues, such as investigating why her kid ran off in the middle of the night. When her dagger was more than enough protection.

Kaira was right behind her, dashing past the taller woman, to quickly kneel down before Finn. Her hazel and amber brown eyes keen, as she slowly scanned over the kitten’s body searching for wounds. Her avid gaze instantly paused on the burn.

Finn groaned in dismay and quickly clasped their hands behind their back hiding it.

“We heard you leave suddenly…and I can smell vomit?” Kaira sniffed, accepting that her kitten did not want her to fuse over them about that burn. It was fresh, but healed so it wasn’t serious. The story behind it could wait for now.

“I’m fine, mom’s.” Finn rolled their eyes in mock irritation as a giddy smile played upon their lips. Loving every minute of their two mother’s overbearing concern.

Kaira, smirked, teasingly. “Too much wine?”

“Yeah, something like that.” Finn smiled weakly back up at her. Refusing to offer more of an explanation. Haunted by the strange mixture of their remembered past, rippling with this timeline's new future. Now twisting inside their memory.

“Sounded more like a bad dream to me?” Adora flipped the dagger in her palm, catching it by the hilt. Trying to look calm and carefree, but her posture was too straight, her back to rigid. She desperately needed them to open up about what had happened to them and why they were here. Her anxious nature spinning far too many disaster scenarios inside her head. She needed knowledge, so she could plan, so she could control the outcomes.

Finn, chuckled and nodded knowingly. She had heard them moaning in the tent before disappearing. Both of their mom’s were extremely light sleeper’s thanks to growing up in the Horde.

“That too…” Finn’s smile wilted into a tired sigh. As Adora’s warmth quickly cooled at their hedging. Cringing under their momma’s stern, reproachful look. That quickly evaporated into a shamed, downcast frown. As Adora quickly concealed her discomfort. By clearing her throat and tucking her dagger into the waistband of her shorts. Not wanting to be threatening in any way towards her kid.

“Want to talk about it?” Kaira offered, softly. Cupping their cheek briefly to draw their face up to meet her sympathetic gaze. Quickly, snapping her hand away when the affectionate touch sent tremor’s of disgust down her spine. The underlying manipulation hidden within the guiding hand was not lost on her.

Finn’s eyes widened in surprise, heart hammering in their chest. As they watched in dismay as each of their mother’s recoiled from them. Suddenly acting nervous and fearful. It was confusing…but they merely shrugged off their strange behavior. Being the kind hearted, compassionate person they were, they sought to soothe them.

“It was weird and it made no sense…but sure, why not.” Finn offered, after that dream…they might as well go all in with the truth. As Kei-Lee had pointed out earlier. At least an abridged version to appease their mother’s, until they could figure out what that vision really meant. They were not going to just sit them

down and vomit their whole tragic life story in one go. But little crumbs, here and there would be alright. Just enough to keep their mission on course. They were pretty certain now that the future was in flux…just like Peekablue had said back at Mystacor. Finn took both of their hands and led them away to the skiff. Both Kaira and Adora's fragile maternal confidence returned at the sweet gesture. They smiled down at their kitten, as they walked down the beach towards the docks, with Kei-Lee chuckling in their wake. Finn was fully grown, but had sought to relive their childhood, craved their mother's touch and attention as innocently as any child. Kei-lee's laughter strangled to a sad sigh… the innocent yearning for love and security. Spoke volumes as to the trauma and heartbreak Finn had lived through in their own timeline. They hadn't said it directly earlier that night, but Kei-Lee wasn't stupid, she could infer quite well. That Finn had lost both their mother's at a very young age, in a very swift and brutal way.

Mermista had not been able to sleep, as she felt those mysterious eyes upon her. The constant pressure of their scrutiny was too much to bear, so she slipped away from Sea Hawk's embrace in their cot. Leaving their tent, to wander the shoreline until dawn. She had so much on her mind, concerning her people's plight to rebuild after the War. Her father's skewed priorities were infuriating. What an insufferable hypocrite! He had disowned her because he felt she had failed as a ruler. That her absence from Salineas, during the Etherian Hordes attack was unforgivable. The fact that she had been in Bright Moon at the time. Was proof of her immaturity, that she was more interested in partying with her friends than buckling down and being responsible. He blamed her for everything. The destruction of the Sea Gate…that allowed the Hordes warships to enter the harbor and breach the main island's shores. Holding the death toll that surmounted during the Hordes relentless attacks upon the villages along the southern and northern coasts. He had called her selfish, irresponsible, lacking

the wisdom and strength of character to rule. Yet, here he was being selfish and completely blinded by revenge. All he cared about was wiping every trace of the Horde off the planet! He had somehow gotten a hold of a whole fleet of ships, ready to sack Sea Worthy any day now. Completely disregarding the fact that Sea Worthy was affiliated to the Kingdom of Bright Moon. One of their allies! Because Horde ships were docked there…he didn't care that the ship's sigils no longer bore the red wings of Hordak, but the Stinger of Scorpania. That they were not Horde anymore… or that they were trying to make amends.

She, on the other hand, had always put her people first. Always striving to protect the islands and had been working tirelessly since the fall of Prime to get the Archipelago back on track. She had sent Sea Hawk to enlist the aid of an old frenemy…of sorts back in the Valley of the Lost. A wealthy merchant. Captain Falcon, who was powerful enough and influential enough to have accumulated a small fleet of ships. He sent two of his men to discuss terms, who had shown up with Finn. She didn't know yet if Captain Falcon had accepted her terms for his help. Or if Scorpania's aid supplies were out of Sea Worthy.

But she needed to make progress in her plans. Far too many lives were at stake. Both here in the islands and for Scorpia's men stationed at Sea Worthy.

Scorpia was sending transport's over the mainland to collect her troops. But the evaluation would take time. Then her father could sink all the empty Warships to his heart's content. Her father would have no reason to keep harassing Sea Worthy after that.

Hopefully, when they were done here on the three Sisters. Captain Falcon would have his Flagship with his merchant fleet, docked beyond Broland Island. They could start sending out the supplies to the rest of the Archipelago before the first storm hit. At least to the islands that didn't hate her, several already had turned their backs on her. Her siblings, who ruled those islands not wanting anything to do with her or her aid.

Mermista sighed and rolled her shoulder, snapping a bitter glare towards the dark ocean lapping at her feet. “I can feel you staring! Just show yourself!” She shouted furiously. Unsurprised as she was greeted by the silent water’s of the bay and the lonely starlight above. A stray tear rolled down her cheek, as she kicked a stone angrily into the water. Her burning gaze cooling into confusion, as her eyes fell on a shiny piece of scale or Chitin bobbing in the surf.

“What in the Two Seas?” she mumbled, crouching down and picking it up. It was nothing like she had ever seen here on the archipelago. Turning it in her palm, as she scrutinized its thin, smooth surface. It wasn’t a piece of shell, or crustacean? Lacking the bumps and spotted staining from withstanding the salt and pressure of the depths. Perhaps a fragment of an insect… carapace?

Which only deepened the mystery. She turned to scan the rough, jagged cliffs rising above her, finding that she had wandered all the way around the coast. To the head of the shoreline. Stopping just underneath the ghostly, shrouded statue of Skuld...the stone slot where the Deity’s power stone once sat within the Starlight lantern, glaringly empty in the moonlight.

The somber fog that never left the forest, did not dissipate until the first rays of the Sun graced the watery horizon. As the star’s faded and the Moon’s set. The sky quickly washed in brilliant, fiery hues of the coming dawn.

Glimmer and Catra sat far from camp, within a small cluster of rocks that formed a break water that guarded the southern side of the harbor. Having teleported as far away from the beach as she could get. As much for privacy during their communion with their sources, as it was to keep Catra's true appearance hidden from the islander’s. Sitting back to back on a tall boulder jutting out of the surf near the tip of the shoreline. Their harmonies this time

had changed, as Catra's voice ascended joyfully now with the Sun. While Glimmer’s descended into low tones of farewell. The emotions weaved within the magic, synchronizing briefly as their aura’s glowed in unison. The Queen’s body shimmering with a pale silver halo, while Catra’s flared a brilliant orange. As a heartfelt melody of hope and yearning for closure for far too many regrets echoed in the dawning light.

Melog sat upon the sandy shore, their thick maroon coat, shimmering with vibrant firelight, as their mane shone like a mirror, reflecting the coming sunrise. Absorbing their master’s magic, as she communed with her source…Adarion.

It was midmorning by the time the crew had torn down the tents and begun to stow them back aboard the Sloop. Mermista was pacing the beachfront, her gaze riveted upon the tide rolling in. Scanning the sparkling water and frothing waves along the bay. In long, endless sweeps…searching for those mystery eyes that had plagued her all night. Even hidden within the confines of her tent, she could still feel them. A steady pressure of scrutiny that never left even in her sleep. It had been disconcerting and unwelcome, she wanted to find who it was spying on her and give them a piece of her mind. She was tired and grumpy and needed to get to the bottom of why she was under surveillance.

She had a crazy thought that maybe it was one of Tri-clops cloaked drones watching her? But that made zero sense…with Entrapa’s modified Horde drones those Eternian aerial spies had become rather scarce. She hadn’t gotten a single report from the islands loyal to her, of a sighting in weeks.

But those eyes, she could feel even now…somewhere out there in the water. Watching her…taking her measure…seeking to determine if she was worthy…the strange feelings of being silently tested was irritating to say the least. It put her on edge…she hated feeling like everything she said, everything she did,

everything she felt was being cataloged and dissected by some unseen entity.

"Dearest?" Sea Hawk's concerned call shattered her unnerving reverie and she jumped suddenly as he touched her shoulder.

"What are you searching for?" He asked softly, clasping their hands together. He had woken up alone this morning, which had been rather disconcerting. Their relationship had become serious, since he had professed his love. His princess had taken down her walls, becoming more vulnerable and honest with her own feelings in their private moments. Their devotion and emotional connection was strong and growing more powerful everyday.

Being cast aside by her father, shunned by several of her siblings as they sided with him. Then losing her magic had finally crushed her once confident and fearless spirit. She had been left homeless and adrift. She had lost everything that truly mattered. Her sense of self was shattered, leaving her floundering as to how to move forward.

Since returning to the islands. She had come to depend upon him, to help guide her in these turbulent seas. Of finding her own independence without the support of her royal title. She was a commoner now, with no power and no money. Sea Hawk had stepped up to the challenge, to show her that he was capable of taking care of her in all the ways she needed. As she slowly rebuilt herself, reclaiming her confidence and purpose once more. He had become her compass, showing her all that truly mattered in this life. Showing her love, showing her understanding and patience. As she struggled with her anger, her bitterness and her resentments. Showing her that she was worth more than her crown. He was her rock to draw strength from and he would not let her down!

"I don't know…I feel something watching me…but I can't see it." Mermista growled in frustration.

Sea Hawk stared upward for a moment, ascertaining the warm, clear sky and then slowly drawing his gaze out upon the open bay. He methodically scanned the sparkling water for a time, his eyesight was far superior to Mermista's. Which was why he had been named Hawk back on that merchant frigate so long ago and made a lookout. Capable of thinking fast and tactically about what he saw out on the ocean. He could ascertain the hazards quickly, determined by the weather, the height and girth of the waves. The silhouette of land masses on the horizon, the types of ships in the far off distance, by their number masts, the shapes of their bow's and the marks upon their sails. Able to direct the helmsman on a safe course through the rocks on choppy seas and make out even the most dim flash through the maelstrom of the storm. Where the light houses beaconed them into safe harbor.

His deep blue eyes pierced the distance, bouncing from the larger fishing trawlers and smaller vessels currently out upon the bay. Following the waves crashing against the large rocks that jutted from the surf at the head of the islands. As he strategically searched for anything abnormal within the vast harbor.

"Do you see anything?' Mermista questioned softly a few minutes later.

"Yes, but nothing to be concerned about." Sea Hawk responded absently, still concentrating on his search.

"Tell me what you see." Mermista pushed, incensed that he would be so vague. Her patience was thin and she felt strung far too tight, ready to snap if even the slightest more tension was applied.

"Lots of boats out there this morning, it's fine weather to be sailing. Dewma's commercial dockyards are busy, I would say rather overcrowded, with frigates being loaded up. The sails are high on those ships, so they are ready to disembark soon. We got a dolphin pod, following a trawler to the east of the bay, off Morta. Because the trawler's nets have a hole in it and some of the fish are escaping." Sea Hawk pointed to an old, rundown

looking boat far out on the bay with an amused chuckle. “The seagull’s are circling close to shore near Nora…I’m guessing it is because there is chop in the water, from the fishery. “ Sea Hawk paused, as he felt his ear’s pop. Glancing over to Mermista, finding she was also unsettled. Rubbing her ears at the sudden odd echo that sounded in the distance.

As the sea pulled back…

an omen of impending doom that all islanders understood.

Sea Hawk was on high alert, scanning the horizon frantically now. Finding the boats once out in the middle of the bay had disappeared. No doubt pulled away with the sea. Then a resounding roar exploded overhead, the sand beneath their feet trembled. Sea Hawk and Mermista ducked on instinct. As it sounded far too close to Horde cannon fire.
“Poseidon's beard…Dearest? …That does not sound good.” Sea Hawk blinked rapidly, to clear his suddenly dry eyes. As if all the moisture of the ocean had been sucked out of the air. Quickly gathering himself and standing back up.

“There’s several Cutter’s and Sloops from Nora, heading towards Morta’s warf…there.” Sea Hawk pointed to the northeast.

Mermista followed his finger, finding several sailboats coming in at top speed towards the beach head. Their trim, pale blue sail’s. The bore the emblem of white butterfly wings. Were taunt, the sharp lines of their bows cutting through the waves. All of them are propelled at great speed and out of control, by some unseen force back on Nora.

“What the hell?” Mermista muttered.

Then a massive wave towered behind the Cutter’s and Sloops, pulling the rest of the Trawlers from within the bay towards Morta’s coastline. Tossing them all like toy’s, out of control on a collision course with the beach head.

The ominous shadow of the massive wave quickly loomed over them, a tsunami ready to wash them all away. As the deafening roar of several tons of sea water threatened the shoreline with certain destruction. The height and girth of the coming wave was capable of washing everyone and everything away in an instant.

Sea Hawk's body unconscious braced, boots digging into the sand. His eyes riveted not upon the raging water speeding towards land. But upon Mermista, who stood her ground before him. He was absolutely confident in her abilities to protect them all. Her brown eyes were hard with resolve. Slowly, raising her hands to command the magic. As she began to move with the current of the crashing wave, directing the weight of the water in fluid movements of her arms. Towards the mouth of the bay and out beyond the jetty of standing stones. Taming the wild riptide and bringing the fleet of haphazard boats gently towards the shore. As the wave evened out its powerful tides washed back out to sea, crashing against the field of guarding stones. That lay beyond the beachhead, with such force that several of the pillars lost their integrity. The weight of the water tearing them in two. The peaks toppled into the water, as what was left sank under the sea, creating a wider waterway into the sheltered harbor.

The Cutter's and Sloops from Nora, exploded into the far northern side of the dockyard. As no one was at the helm to guide them safely into port. Sending debris and water into the air, that cut like shrapnel along the beach.

Mermista was not deterred at all, as the splintered wood fell like rain around her. She was charging down the shoreline at full speed. Catching sight of Orion, racing out of camp towards the water, towards the fleet of fishing boats. Now bobbing in the shallows near shore. The crew's were scrambling to drop anchor, so their damaged vessels would not be pulled back out to sea and sink, or become beached upon the shoals.

Mermista was quick to see that Orion was not wearing an alarmed expression like her. But one of known, tired frustration, as if this sudden catastrophe was commonplace around the Three Sister's.

Which only made Mermista more determined to beat her little brother to the docks Growling low in her throat, she ducked her head and lunged forward at greater speed. Rounding the head of the vast dockyard, just in time to hip check her little brother into the sand.

"What in the name of Neptune was that!" She shouted, in exasperation as she ran past him.

Orion yelped in fright, but barely lost his footing. His forward stride stuttered a bit as he regained his balance. Changing course to race after his older sister.

"What the hell, Mista!" He shouted, as Mermista jumped up on the planks of the dock. Charging past the wildly, rocking Skiff, still mercifully docked against its moorings. Charging to the far end of the warf to survey the damage to the boats from Nora. That had crashed headlong into the dockyard. Their sterns were burnt and blackened with soot?…the foredecks on the Cutter's had taken heavy damage. The upper railings were splintered and blown apart. Both the Cutter's and the Sloops sails were tattered, hanging limp from the splintered main masts. It was as if the ships had been propelled off course by a huge blast?

"What is going on?" She hissed up at Orion as he finally stood before her. His own gaze taking in the highly damaged vessels. He sighed heavily, regarding Mermista with a knowing grimace.

"Delphi…no doubt messing around with potions she shouldn't." Orion groaned. As if that was answer enough.

Mermista arched an impatient eyebrow. There was more going on around here? Either Orion knew what it was and was keeping it from her, silence was just another version of deceit. Or he truly was oblivious. She didn't have enough information yet to accuse him of anything, so she held her tongue.

Adora and Glimmer crowded around them, seeking answers. While Kaira surveyed the whole sordid confrontation from her

perch on the crows nest of the skiff. Her claws were dug in deep, on the metal rim of the circular platform. As she maintained her currently rather precarious seat. As the skiff was still frantically rocking upon the crashing waves, slamming into the dock. Her fluffy chestnut ears, once pinned to her head, after the far off explosion. Slowly flicked forward as she listened.

Bow had been standing on the command deck, prepping running checks on the engines. Making sure his boat was in top condition to sail at a moment's notice. He was quick to see the commotion and pause his engine check. Heading out of the cockpit and disembarking off the bow. Jogging towards the amassing crowd of crewmen starting to converge upon the beachfront.

Everyone was watching the tense exchange between Mermista and her brother.

Who merely just walked away, leaving Mermista fuming on the edge of the dock.

Sea Hawk was quick to take charge, paying Mermista a worried glance before moving past her and approaching Bull. Who was standing with his hands on his hips, glowering at the wretched state of their Sloop. That had been washed away from the dock and beached upon the shore. Thankfully, it had not been damaged by the small fleet of random boats that had crashed into the dockyard further north.

“Can you get her afloat?” Sea Hawk asked.

“Yeah, I got the man power to pull her back out.” Bull grunted.

“Ok, then head over to Nora...find out what’s going on over there and send me back a report.” Sea Hawk, nodded towards the bay. Tapping the data pad he had locked into a leather satchel on the side of his Rapier belt.

“Wouldn’t it be faster if Queenie just teleported me over there?” Bull chucked a thumb over his shoulder at Glimmer, with a hopeful smile.

“That’s not how her magic works!” Bow interjected heatedly, heading over towards Sea Hawk and Bull. Not appreciated the big louts, disrespectful new nickname for Glimmer.

“Ah, well. Worth a shot.” Bull shrugged, chuckling to himself. “Love to have a bit of alone time with her highness.” He muttered under his breath, a slow wistful smile pulled upon his lips.

Bow ground his teeth, having to glower up at the taller, bulk of the huge man. As Bull once again seemed socially oblivious, or arrogantly bold. By planning to blatantly flirt with Glimmer…in front of her boyfriend! Yet again!

Sea Hawk thankfully caught on, to the simmering rage Bow was valiantly trying to keep contained. As he flexed and unflexed his fists near his thighs.

“No worries, My boy. I’ll speak to him.” Sea Hawk clamped his hands on Bow’s shoulder and steered him away from Bull. Before the Archer decided to violently stake his claim to the Queen of Bright Moon.

“Don’t mind him…Bull sees himself as a bit of a Casanova, but honestly he is rather harmless…or should I say…Luckless with the ladies. You have nothing to fret about.” Sea Hawk, jabbed Bow in the side with an elbow. Offering the irritated young man a reassuring smile and suave twirl of his mustache. Before returning to Mermista’s side.

“If you say so, Sea Hawk.” Bow grumbled, keeping his eyes on Glimmer. As she watched Mermista storm off after the brother. Before heading back to the skiff, intent on following Bull and his crew over to Nora.

Mermista trailed after her little brother, back into the nearly packed up camp. Scowling at his back, as she began to review her interactions with him yesterday. He hadn’t outright refused to take her to the forest villages, when she had asked. But had

expressed that it wasn't needed, that he was perfectly fine handling the distribution of the supplies on his own. She didn't want to step on his toes, he was in charge here on Morta not her. So she had been fine with it, she was not always greeted warmly anymore by the islander's. Maybe he wanted to keep her involvement in providing food and supplies on the down low for now, which she understood. Anyway, she had her own mystery to solve and wanted to explore the coastline. After finding that piece of insect chitin she was growing suspicious. The mystery of the stolen power stones may be more of a secret? One he was keeping from her?

Kaira leapt down from the crows nest, passing Adora and Glimmer a inquisitive look before all three headed after Mermista and Orion. There was a hell of a lot more going on in the Three Sisters and it wasn't good.

"Spill!" Mermista spat, crossing her arms and tapping her foot impatiently.

As Adora, Kaira, Glimmer and Sea Hawk surrounded the young man blocking any avenue for him to escape.

"Calm down, you know Delphi…" He shrugged. "She's always blowing stuff up."

"Delphi?" Glimmer asked.

"Our little sister, she governs over Nora…she likes to dabble in Alchemy." Mermista both shrugged, groaned and rolled her eyes, all simultaneously.

"She's the Sea Witch." She leaned in close to Kaira, whispering with a smirk.

Kaira nodded and offered her a small smile in return.

“So…I guess you govern Morta, then Orion.” Adora chucked a thumb absently towards the forest.

“Each of my siblings are the caretaker’s of one of the islands in the Archipelago.” Mermista answered. “Except me…” She finished with a bitter snarl, crossing her arms over her chest.

“No reason to worry, sister.” Orion offered with a heavy, resigned sigh. “But if you want to check up on her, then let's head up to the Eternity Shrine. I was planning on taking Glimmer up there today anyway. We can turn the telescope in the observatory towards the island and do a little spying?”

“What aren’t you telling me, Orion! I found insect chitin on the beach last night. What the hell is happening around here! ” Mermista ranted, her anxiety spiking. Waving violently towards the still churning waves far out upon the bay.

Orion scrubbed a hand down his face, “Come with me, then.” He beckoned them all into the forest. “There is a lot to explain about what has happened to the Archipelago in your absence, sister.” His tone was hard now, no longer warm or gentile as it once was.

Mermista ground her teeth and followed with her friends in tow.

Sea Hawk, Adora, Kaira and Glimmer hung back more than a few paces, trying to linger on the periphery of the shouting match currently going on ahead of them. Between Orion and Mermista.

“Antreenids!...How could father sell us out to Meadowlands like that!” Mermista exploded.

“He didn’t sell us out! He signed a treaty…last year. Allowing them to set up observation posts on our islands to keep an eye on Prime’s spires. In exchange for food and supplies, that's it!” Orion growled back. “They just never left after Prime was defeated.” Orion finished bitterly under his breath.

“Why didn’t you tell me what was really going on?” Mermista snapped, poking Orion in his shoulder blades pointedly, as she was walking behind him.

“Why would you care! You haven’t been around for years!” Orion exclaimed over his shoulder, stomping in the lead.

Merimista's mouth hung open for a moment, as she stared in shock. Her expression quickly cooled to mute acceptance.

“Ok…Granted…I have been on the mainland a lot more in the last few years.” Mermista nodded. “But I was fighting the Horde! Making sure our people were safe.” Mermista cast her gaze downward in shame, rubbing the back of her neck. Refusing to voice the real reason she had not returned to the islands.

Kaira noticed the trauma response, swallowing hard. What Prime had done to her, to Scorpia, Mermista and Spinnerella. Chipping them, enslaving them…that brutal destruction of their free will would haunt them all for a very long time…perhaps forever.

“You were partying with the pirncesses. Like you always did… living it up, flaunting your crown all around the archipelago. While the rest of us dealt with the overcrowding of our islands when your people abandoned Salineas. ” Orion spat.

“Father gave me a crumbling kingdom…I was handling it.” She defended. “I wasn't going to the Dolphin social or all those insipid parties just to have fun. I was trying to connect with a tech master’s to help rebuild Salineas. To fix the Sea Gate.”

Orion nodded. “I’ll give you that. You did manage to fix the Sea Gate and lured all your people back to Salineas. Believing that they would be safe…only to have the Horde show up a couple years later and annihilate the coastline unchallenged…cause their protector was gone!” He finished in a heated shout.

Mermista sucked in a sharp breath, suddenly blindsided by Orion’s statement. As he parroted their father’s harsh words, right back at her. Incensed but also shamed, she growled and cast her head

aside, struggling to control the hurt of betrayal that was now washing over her face. As her eyes burned with tears, valiantly focusing on some unseen point amid the trees. Struggling to remain stone faced after enduring such unexpected cruelty from her own sibling. A brother who once idolized her in his youth, that now blamed her for the sordid state of the Archipelago.

Kaira's ears pinned back in shame, as Orion's rage echoed throughout the forest. Adora glanced over to her, concerned that she may bolt. Instead, Kaira heaved a shaky breath, keeping her watery eyes downcast upon the dried underbrush crunching under the bare feet. She had wrapped her fluffy tail around her waist and was absently petting it down to the tip. A nervous action, Adora knew from their childhood. When they were forced to line up after drill's with the rest of Red Squad and get yelled at for screwing up. Adora had the urge to reach out and pull her into her arms, but she resisted. It would only draw attention to her and then she would feel like her pain was on display. She would definitely run then. It was breaking Adora to see her so upset. Kaira looked on the verge of crying. The fox was biting her bottom lip to keep it from trembling, blinking rapidly to dry the moisture welling in the corner of her eyes.

Mermista on the other hand was handling Orion's harsh words differently. She was trembling with rage, hands balled into fists at her sides. Her face was so flushed, it looked beat red. Her brown eyes had turned stoney, now glaring up at him in heated challenge. Before she could rally to her own defense.

"That is totally unfair!" Sea Hawk charged forward, defending her. " The Horde was advancing on Bright Moon…we had a spy in our midst, feeding very important battle plans to the enemy. Your sister's keen deductive skills and cunning mind. We were able to devise a trap and caught that spy! If not, Bright Moon would have fallen to the Horde and then the rest of Etheria would have followed anyway. We all helped evacuate the survivor's off Salenias. So I figure your grudge is rather pointless… Your sister was caught between a rock and hard place…she didn't know about the attack…otherwise she would have been there. She

made the best call she could under the circumstances. She was a part of the Princess Alliance. She had a responsibility to protect more than just the Archipelago!" Sea Hawk took a deep breath, opening his mouth to continue to ramble. When Mermista snapped her fingers in his face, startling him and cutting off his ranting. Offering him a small, tolerant smile silently beseeching him to stay quiet. Her eyes were scorching with humiliation, burning into him. His help was unneeded and unwanted. She could fight her own battles.

Sea Hawk moaned and then begrudgingly nodded.

Then the conversation cooled down for a while and they all walked in silence. Moving south along a well worn path, through the forest.

"You never really took the throne too seriously, sister." Orion scoffed, rolling his eyes. "Which is why, father cast you out and gave the crown to Aquarius."

"That pompous blowhard!" Mermista snarled under her breath..

"Who's Aquarius?" Adora whispered over her shoulder to Sea Hawk. Who had fallen back and was walking behind her.

"Mermista's eldest brother…and yes. He is a cock twaddle. An arrogant, egotistical royal ass, with a razor sharp tongue to match." Sea Hawk answered, scratching the bridge of his nose nervously. Trying not to draw Mermista's attention as he spoke his rather unflattering opinion about her brother. As she was absolutely infuriated, not just at him but at everyone in general now.

Kaira couldn't help but snicker at Sea Hawk's crass assessment of this man. Sea Hawk was a straight shooter and told it as it was, which was why she respected him. That and he liked to blow stuff up and set things on fire…so they had a-lot in common. Glimmer

groaned and palmed her face, while Adora stared at him with a small bemused smile.

The group had trekked deep into the woods, as the siblings fought. Orion was not guiding them upward towards the villages but further south along the rolling foothills of the higher plateau's near the head of the island. Koa tree's hovered in tightly rooted cluster's as far as the eye could see. Their canopy fanned out above them.

The simple homesteads they come across were built nestled within the small open glades among the groves of trees. The squat homes were built from the sturdy wood of the forest, with simple thatch and moss roofs. Each with a tiny garden and sea stone wells. Subsisting on the land and asking no more than what the forest and the sea could provide.

The impressively thick trunks of the ancient Koa trees, guarding their small plots of land, helped to hide them and protect them from more moderate storms. While their majestic umbrella of twisting branches and full deep green leaves. Shattering the sunlight and having it dance upon the thick underbrush of lush ferns and freshly harvested garden's. All the berries were picked, leaving the bushes empty. The garden plot's barren, only the yellow, dried up stocks of corn and shriveled remains of other vines remained. Wooden pens for livestock ringed around modest sized barns out back of the homesteads. Which lay empty. The squat windows and doors of the farmhouses were barred by thick shutter's, tied and bolted for the storm season. Not a soul could be seen, as they traveled through the farmyards.

"Farmer's?" Kaira asked softly.

"Yes, the outlying farm's here are the surviving families of a shoreline village of fishermen. That used to reside on a small beach further south, near the mouth of the bay. The village was sacked by Red Coast Marauder's over a decade ago. The survivor's

moved into the forest after that and became farmers.” Orion explained.

“Where are the farmer’s now?” Adora asked.

“They would have packed up for the storm season and moved to one of the inner villages higher up on the plateau. “ Orion nodded northward.

“Where are we headed?” Glimmer inquired, as they finished crossing another glade and were instantly enshrouded in shade once more. As the green embrace of the thick forests crowded around them.

“Up to the observatory on the highest plateau, it's within the sacred grounds of the Eternity Shrine. “ Orion smiled warmly back at Glimmer. “I promised to show you, didn’t I”

Glimmer smiled back. They walked for a long time, each one lost to their own thoughts. In time they moved into a crowded glade, with rows of simple stone columns set upon a flat, podium like dais. With tiny ceramic vases that held only one flower and incense stands, some of the sticks were still smoking.

As they silently passed down a narrow row of gravestones. The quiet conversation quickly faded into a respectful silence. It was obvious that this was a sacred place….a cemetery.

Kaira paused in front of a gravestone, eyes scanning the names etched in the pillar. It reminded her of the monument they had erected for their fallen friends back upon the Scorpion Hills when they were kids.

“Kaira…” Adora's voice was barely a whisper, as her hand gently entwined with her’s.

“Lonnie…” Kaira choked out, never taking her gaze off the stone.

Adora passed her a strange look, then turned to the gravestone as slow understanding passed over her face. Their squad mate never

remembered where she came from, only that the Horde had found her. The soldier's had gathered the dead and thrown a tarp over them. Then brought her to the base, when she was just a small child. But she had remembered monuments like these and what they had stood for. Told them stories about how her people respected the dead and paid homage to them by telling stories and erecting a marker, like these. Spurning the Alpha strike team of Red Squad to go on a journey to create a monument for all the friends they had lost.

After the death of Louis, they had all been pretty shaken up for a long time. The unity of the squadron had been broken and at the time seemed unsalvageable. That trip together had brought them closer again at least for a time, with a single purpose: To find a beautiful place to grieve and pay their respects to the kids that had died. While the Beta strike team held down the fort and covered for them with their superior's. It had been the best and worst week of their lives.

"Perhaps…this is where she came from?" Adora nodded towards the column of names.

Kaira was quick to unlatch her communication pad from her belt and begin to record the scenery to show Lonnie later. Everyone deserves to know where they came from, to have a chance to reconnect with a lost family.

A lone willow tree stood guard at the center of the rows of stone markers, its pale spindle thin branches dusted with gorgeous white flowers. Adora stopped, enthralled by the sight. It was so different from the other willow's she had seen so far on the Mainland.

"Adora?" Kaira paused in front of her, glancing curiously up at the willow.

Adora closed her eyes, slowly raising a hand and like Razz had taught her. Sought to feel the magic in the air. A low throb like a

heartbeat pulsed against her finger tips. The magic was somber, quiet…a reverence in its weave.

Kaira's ears perked up, as she suddenly heard voices and faint laughter upon the wind. It was startling, but not unnerving. Her mismatched eyes narrowed in scrutiny as she saw Melog moving silently amid the forest just beyond the cemetery. They had been following them, keeping a close eye on her. Their fur had darkened and their mane was glowing softly in a soulful blue hue. Tapping into the veil, separating the realm of the living from that of the Eternal. As it was so very thin within the stones. Kaira could feel the now very familiar spirits of the dead surrounding them.

"You guys are coming!" Mermista shouted, startling them both back to full awareness no longer enthralled by the magic.

They paid each other a knowing look, each taking a deep breath to settle themselves back into this reality. Then Adora nodded, grabbing Kaira's hand and leading her through the gravestones more rapidly. Headed towards a set of steps, carved into the forested hillside that slowly crawled upward to the lush, jutting plateau high above.

The gate to the Shrine of Eternity was an ancient limestone archway. Guarding the peak of the plateau at the very end of the naturally winding stairwell.

Simple stone slabs balanced perfectly upon each other. Kaira's eyes widened in surprise as she passed beneath the stones. There were runic carvings etched upon the underside of the standing stones, badly worn down by weather and the passage of time. She reached out and pressed her palm against the archway. The runes were smooth and nearly unreadable. Squinting and cocking her head to the side as she fought valiantly to read them.

Adora paused underneath, her thoughts falling back to another arch she had once seen. A simple sandstone archway from her

dreams, during her captivity in the Crystal Castles Memory archive. Shadow Weaver had been guarding a sand stone archway identical to this one. Protecting the magic of She-Ra….protecting her and Catra…protecting them all from the Nameless Ones armies. Sacrificing herself yet again so that they could survive…to save the universe.

Kaira brushed her hand down the runes. Moving in close till her nose nearly touched the stone, as she valiantly tried to read the runes.

The gateway was like a doorway, tall and rectangular like the stone effigies back at Mystacor, that circled the outdoor magic collection chamber for the Great Conjunction…the celestial event in which the Lunari are said to return to Etheria.

So many meanings…so many similarities..to other monuments she had seen.

Connections…intertwining…threads…all over Etheria.

Kaira sighed then looked away from the unreadable etchings, finding Adora still frozen beneath the archway as well. Her blue eyes were distant as she was lost to her thoughts. As her mind started to put more pieces into place. The Willow Trees…that Razz used to teach to weave the magic, her ability to reach out and touch the magic that surrounded her. These archways…perhaps… had a deeper meaning as well?

"Adora…" Kaira nudged her gently, bringing her back to the present.

"Orion…what is this?" Adora called, pointing to the arch above her.

"It is the gateway to Eternity…the legend is that when the Hunter's Moon turns red the veil between life and death becomes thin. If one was to cross through the gate it may open into the Eternal Realm…but if you do cross over…you can never return."

Orion’s voice answered from several steps upward. It was low and creepy, as if spinning a ghost story.

Kaira’s ears pinned back and her tail began to whip anxiously, as she took a wary step backward from beneath the archway. Suddenly she could feel the distant hum of magic…the tingle of the Soul Pyre spell against her fur. Just like back in the cemetery. It may just be a story, but this place was linked to the Eternal Realm…she was certain of it now.

“It’s just a fable…” Orion laughed, merrily. “But the Islander’s of Morta celebrate the day of the dead up here at the Shrine, when the Hunter’s Moon turns red at the end of every cool season. It is a wonderfully, joyous festival. Where we all dress up in costumes, feast and tell stories about those we have lost around a huge bonfire.”

“Lonnie…told us about that tradition.” Adora regarded her with a reassuring smile, as she reached for Kaira's hand. Kaira clasped her offered hand, trusting Adora implicitly. When suddenly, Adora pulled the reluctant fox through the archway to the other side.

Kaira yelped and stumbled forward, when Adora abruptly yanked her through.

Once through the gate, she punched Adora hard, in the arm and then scampered up the last few steps to the cobblestones above.

Adora rubbed her bruised shoulder lightly, staring up at Kaira with a rueful grin. Who was now perched on the top stair, sticking her tongue out teasingly at Adora. With a bright laugh, Adora chased after Kaira, up the last remaining steps. A merry peel of playful laughter followed. As the two women disappeared from view as they grappled and chased after each other.

Leaving Glimmer giggling upon the steps behind the archway, smitten by their playful antics. Sea Hawk’s eyes were dancing with amusement, his spirit lifted by their light hearted behavior. While Mermista huffed and crossed her arms as if annoyed. Even though

her eyes were warm with veiled fondness for the two women. They followed Orion as he guided them up to the shrine above.

Finding Adora and Kaira standing off to the side of the cobblestone path. In a small natural alcove, carved into the hillside, where a small pond had been formed. Ringed by flat stones, the man-made pool was filled with pristine water. Unmarred by even a leaf or stray stick, from the forest floor. The trees were thick around them, now that they were back on flat ground. The shrubs crowded around the clear pool of water, their leaves more vibrant than the woods that grew below the plateau. The soft sounds of birds, called from the branches. While the cemetery below had been hallowed ground, encased by an unnatural hush. The shrine above was lively and vibrant with life.

Orion knelt before the pool and cupped some water into his hands. Bowing his head for a moment as he ritually washed his hands and anointed his brow and then his eyelids with wet fingertips.

“What is going on?” Glimmer asked Mermista.

“Since this shrine is dedicated to Morta's deity. He is purifying himself before entering the Shrine of Eternity.” Mermista sighed, “It's an island superstition, if one's soul is not cleansed and they are judged by the Keeper of the Gates of Eternity, their soul’s could be damned to the void.

“Skuld.” Glimmer nodded.

“In this way, we wash away the darkness, cleansing our thoughts, our vision and our spirit. To prepare ourselves to enter the light of the Starlight Lantern at the end of our days. To let go of our mortal coil and embrace the Eternal Realm when it calls to us. ” Orion explained, in a far more respectful manner.

Kaira swallowed, the Sunna had a belief similar. To allow your shadow’s to fall behind you and always walk towards the Sun.

Toward Adarion, the source of Fire Magic here on Etheria.

Prime also had made himself a deity, twisting the belief of the light into a doctrine to control all the worlds he subjugated. Kaira shook her head briefly, freeing herself from the clone knowledge she had been forced to absorb while chipped. That always seemed to seep into her thoughts, like a poison.

In many ways Adarion was her deity, she sang to them every sunrise and every sunset. Absorbing fire magic, as Adarion in turn got to know her authentic self through her lyrics. It was a form of communion between Source and Rune Bearer, very similar to how Glimmer communed with her source…the largest Moon…Elidor. As she was the Rune Bearer of Light, yet she had yet to put words into her harmonies. Her voice blended with whatever song Catra chose to sing. Their magic and emotion's weave with each other, as if dancing…

Kaira turned her gaze skyward, shielding her eyes with a hand as she stared up at the clear blue sky, gazing with new insight upon the fiery Orb. That now dominated the sky during the daytime, an ancient source of magic that Etheria had not seen in over a thousand years. She wondered if Adarion's magic had a persona, similar to Sheana and Despara. If perhaps one day she would meet them.

Suddenly the forest once again became unusually quiet. The animals that once rustled amid the underbrush just behind the gate were now silent. The coo's and twitters of the birds seemed muted, until two black birds landed on the top of the limestone archway. Their loud startled caw's echo out over the shrine grounds. As Argus exploded out of the limestone archway behind them. Large paws pounding down the cobblestones, long pink tongue hanging out the side of their pointed muzzle. Dripping with saliva and flapping like a war banner in a high wind. An unrestrained joy and exuberance to their entrance. As the hound scampered up to Orion. The young man took a quick turn from the pond and crouched low to receive the excited dog. As Argus

skidded before Orion, with his front paws dancing, tail wagging and barking happily.

Orion smiled warmly and affectionately patted the hound's head. Argus immediately calmed down. The hound brushed her nose under Orion's palm, as if directing him. Before she stood, pointing her nose upward towards the north ridge of the plateau above them.

"Your…friend has been shadowing us up to the Temple." Orion turned to regard Kaira, with a sharp look. "Argus and I have never seen a being like them, do they pose any harm to us or my people?"

"No…" Kaira raised her hands, assuring Orion. "Their name is Melog and they…have trust issues. They wanted to scout around to make sure nothing was going to harm me or my friends."

"Your friend is prowling up on the northern ridge, there." Orion pointed up along the edge of the tree line near a flat barren cliff face of jagged limestone. "If they keep heading in that direction they are going to run into the Meadowland Airship docks. The Antrineed soldiers are not going to be very welcoming if they see them.

Mermista merely snarled, folding her arms more tightly around her chest.

Orion turned back to Mermista. He didn't like it either, was reluctant to defend them as they had become rather meddlesome to the day to day running of the Three Sisters. But they had been helping for a lot longer than Mermista.

"After the fall of Salineas, we had thousands of displaced people flooding all of the Archipelago….again. We were not prepared! It was the end of the cool season, we had only days until the storms hit. They escaped the Horde with nothing. We didn't have enough food or clothes, or even shelter for them…then Prime showed up! You were gone…we were scrambling to find a way to take care of

everyone. Then King Buzz's military showed up, offered us aid in return for setting up observation posts.

Kaira bowed her head, holding herself. Remorse for what she had done. Stabbed at her conscience like a dagger to the heart.

"He has been protecting us, giving us engineer's to help build homes and storm walls last year. " Orion defended, half heartedly.

"Storm walls that were built wrong and barely shielded the villages." Mermista spat back, "Otherwise you would not be asking for Scorpania's aid, this year?"

Orion sighed and nodded. "They do not understand how to build the type of walls we need. Meadowlands has mostly stone and mortar retaining walls lining their shores…built hundreds of years before these engineer's were born."

"How many were lost last year?" Mermista spoke quietly, placing a comforting hand on Orion's shoulder. Quelling her accusing tone, for one of genuine care and concern.

"Several hundred in the lower villages…last year. So those villages have been evacuated and crowd the higher settlements that are better protected." Orion groaned. "I'm trying sister…but I have too many to care for…"

Kaira's ear's wilted, as her tail lowered to dust the ground. As raw, unfiltered guilt flooded through her. Rubbing the ache in her chest with her fingertips. Knowing that she had caused all this continued suffering. The deaths that had continued to mount were her fault. These were the ripples from her actions that Perfuma had told her about. But she refused to hide behind the rage and hate that once protected her from feeling. She endured the burn of regret that throbbed in her chest, swallowing the bile forming in her throat. As she confronted the vileness of her past self, moving past the self loathing to a place of calm clarity.

That she would never allow that darkness to consume her ever again.

Kaira closed her eyes, reaching through her link to the Melog to check up on them.

(I am fine…but yes, It is true. I can see two Meadowland airships docked up here on the peak. Insect Hybrid Soldiers in full leather armor, are patrolling the perimeter. I promise not to get too close.) Melog reported back.

Kaira nodded, taking Adora's hand and following after Orion. Who led them up the path. The forest encroached on either side of the path, soft shadow's of their branches falling over the stones. Waving in the gentle breeze, passing over the temple grounds.

Kaira kept glancing upward to the peak of the plateau above, Adora noticed and gave her hand a squeeze.

"We know so very little about Meadowlands…they're xenophobic? Why would they help Salineas?" Kaira muttered.

Adora had been watching Mermista, who was scowling at Orion's back. She was fuming about everything that had happened in her absence. Sea Hawk was wary, keeping a close eye on his Princess as the tension mounted between her and her little brother.

Glimmer was slowing her pace, falling back in front of them. Overhearing Kaira's question.

"They retreated underground a thousand years ago, isolated themselves from the rest of Etheria…to finally be interested in what's happening beyond their walls…it's kinda…" Glimmer started to explain.

"Odd." Adora finished.

"Sweet Bee's a hybrid from Meadowlands, she hates the King…her uncle. Since he had banished her and her crew after her failed attempt to seize back the throne." Kaira sighed.

Glimmer nodded, she knew that story. “She’s loyal to no one but herself, I don’t know what she’s up to after Sea Hawk saved her at Sea Worthy…but she’s a wild card and that’s never good.”

“Agreed.” Adora nodded, “Let's figure out what’s really going on here, then we can triage a plan to help Mermista’s people.”

Both Kaira and Glimmer nod in agreement, unwilling to jump to conclusions that the Antrineeds were up to no good right away.

They came across a set of four dog statues, lining the path. They looked exactly like Argus, gentle hounds with floppy ears and kind eyes. The statues on the right held the Starlight lantern in their mouths. Heads raised high, as if seeking to cast the lantern light upon the world. The statues on the left, had their heads bowed. A set of three diamond shaped crystals adorned their brows.

Glimmer paused, in awe before those statues. Her fingertips fluttered up to the diamond shaped crystal embedded into her chest between her breasts. Her mother had three crystal’s just like that in her chest…the mark of an Immortal. Angella had so many links to this deity…Skuld. All of them were lining up, that Glimmer was descended from this goddess, that Skuld could very well be her Mother…

“My mother had those crystal’s in her chest…” Glimmer whispered, tears welling in her eyes. “She was an Immortal…”

Adora placed a hand on her shoulder. “I met her during Mara’s time. She was just a child then, C’yra…the Rune Bearer of Light was raising her in the Temple of the Sky…what would one day become the Castle of Bright Moon.”

Glimmer was surprised but not shocked, she knew her mother had been alive for over a thousand years.

“There is so much she never told me.” Glimmer responded, reaching up and giving Adora’s hand a squeeze before turning and walking away.

“Is now the time?” Kaira leaned in and whispered close to Adora’s ear. The burden of their secret was really starting to weigh upon her conscience.

“I think so…but let’s deal with the Antrineed situation first. We can sit her down tonight…it’s going to be a hard conversation.” Adora sighed, heavily.

Kaira nodded and brushed her red hair back with both hands, trying to calm down her nerves. Then followed Adora up to a covered gateway that sat dead center of a tall, elegant wooden fence that surrounded a vast courtyard within.

As she approached Glimmer was already taking pictures on her data pad of several runes, carved into the wooden framework of the fence. Intrigued, Kaira jogged up to her. Slowly taking in the intricate knotwork with runic symbols hidden within.

“What do you see?’ Glimmer asked, the data pad held close to her chest, flipping through her pictures slowly on the screen.

“Well….” Kaira pointed to the highest knot, “These knots are way different then what’s up on Mystacor.”

“I could have told you that.” Glimmer huffed, casting her a wry smirk.” But I can’t read them…you can.”

“Right…” Kaira quickly got on track. Clearing her throat.

“Well, I’ve come to understand that different kinds of knots form different meanings…basically the shapes matter as much as the embedded rune itself. The Elemental runes back in Mystacor are cyclical...circles of magic that weave together…like the magic glyphs you create…these runes…are more like a compass…a map…or a constellation…” Kaira slowly began to brush her fingertips down the tail of the etchings, stopping at each runic symbol.

“Death…Insight…or true vision..uhm…travel…uhm…Celestial judgment…Starlight, peace and protection…a shield that wards off

Evil.” Kaira finished in a soft mumble.

“So…Runes are really nothing like the First Ones language, they don’t make sentences? ” Adora observed.

“Kinda, yeah. The Runes can mean several things all at once, it depends on how they are written…the pattern they are in...how many are weaved together?” Kaira explained, with a shrug.

“I’ll teach you First Ones, if you teach me the Hybrid Runes.” Adora offered with a hopeful smile.

“I want to learn both of them too!” Glimmer raised her hand and jumped up on her toes like an over zealous student.

Adora laughed softly, nodding in agreement.

While Kaira gave Glimmer’s pink hair a teasing ruffle.

“Whatever, you dork.” She chuckled lightly. As Glimmer bumped her hip against her’s with a fond smile. Her indigo eyes shining with joy at being included in their banter.

“Are you guys coming!” Mermista called in exasperation.

“Coming!” Adora jogged away with the Kaira and Glimmer behind.

Crossing under the covered wooden archway into a huge open courtyard.

They stopped just inside, gazes drawn to the massive open walled pavilion set at the back of the courtyard. Simple paper lanterns hung from the timber pillars, upon iron hooks. Along the wide veranda that wrapped around the two sides of the temple. The building was sitting upon a grand stone dais with a wide wooden stair ascending to a massive entrance hall that cut the pavilion in

half. The heavy wooden doors to the main building are sealed by a thin silver woven rope.

Behind the entrance hall, the main building stood tall, with sloping roofs inlaid with clay tile. Simple, elegant looking gables adorned the roof, which curved upward like crescent moons. Behind was a huge tower with wrap-around balconies. Ascending upwards into the clear blue sky high above. The top of the tower was a dome that was open, what looked like a giant cannon made of crystal jutted out of the opening towards the sky.

Orion led them up the stone steps and into the front entrance, unfurling the rope and opening one of the door's just enough to usher them in. The heavy oak door groaned eerily under its own weight.

It was an unassuming structure on the outside, but within. Its vaulted ceilings were awe inspiring. With thick, wooden beams running overhead, trimmed with silver garland that sparkled like starlight.

"Wow…" Glimmer breathed, spinning in slow circles in the center of the massive, open room of the main temple. Taking in the dozens of white pillow's tossed upon the sides of the room as there was nothing else. This wasn't a place of worship, but of self-discovery. Where one could sit in the tranquility of the main room and contemplate their life and find solace in the death to come. At least that's what Glimmer believed. She would ask Orion about the reason for the barren room and pillow's, later.

The wooden floor creaked with age as they moved deeper. Sunlight filtered in through small circular windows set at the top of the walls. Casting rays of light upon the shadowy inside, that looked like shooting stars.

Kaira sniffed the air, tail swishing anxiously, low behind her. The air was stale as the Temple had been sealed for many months. Yet slightly fragrant with a very soft scent, which reminded her of fresh rain.

They moved through the main room and into the back hall, towards a narrow staircase. That wound around the inner pillar of the tower, through several open rooms with outer balconies and then further upward to the open observatory at the top of the tower.

The observatory inside was rather high tech, the rounded walls lined with metal and cables. It was completely out of place in such a simple, pillar and beam constructed building.

“This place is very much like the observatory on Mystacor.” Glimmer remarked.

“First Ones writing.” Adora squinted, as she crossed the open floor towards the wall. Brushing her hands down the glowing etching upon the wall.

“A reclaimed piece of machinery from the Forgotten Age?” Kaira mused, surveying the room more closely. The Etherians of that age, used whatever First Ones tech that still worked after the move to Despondos. To aid them in rebuilding their world after the Heart Weapon had nearly destroyed the planet.

Orion and Mermista mounted the iron steps up to the tall metal tower that held a giant crystal telescope. Mounted on a metal slab at the very peak of the tower.

Orion slipped into a leather pilot seat in a tiny cockpit beneath the telescope, typing on a flat screen on a command deck in front of him. There was a loud whirring sound as the heavy telescope swung downward and to the east.

“What are you doing Orion.” Mermista demanded, hands on her hips. Scowling down at him with distaste.

“I’ve been really busy preparing my villages for the storm season and I have not had time to visit our little sister’s on Dewma or

Nora for at least two months. So I spy on them instead." He explained, in a distracted voice.

"Great use of the Celestial Eye in the Eternity Shrine." Mermista commented dryly.

Orion ignored her, he knew very well he had been dishonoring the deity of Morta with his selfish use of her sacred relic. But he also didn't care, time had not been on his side for many years.

The screen snapped to life as the telescope zeroed in on the long beach front of Nora. The tall shell shaped tower's that once silhouetted the shoreline were decimated. As the entire stretch of sand had become an out of control inferno! Engulfing the various dockyards and the villages scattered along the coastline.

"Holy…Hades! " Orion leaped from the seat, nearly catapulting himself down the tower steps.

"What's going on! " Mermista screamed, charging down the steps, right behind him.

Soul of the Deep

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm and Lunatheblackwolf, for your comments and all who left kudos.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Finn sat upon the circular platform of the crows nest, high above the skiff. The leather bound spy glass, pressed tight to their right eye. The finger's of their free hand curled firmly around the metal band in the center, that held the collapsible tube ridged. Their claws, gripping the rim of the platform were fully extended and embedded deep into the metal. As a gust of hot wind buffeted the skiff. Sending their long blonde hair fluttering behind them. Swallowing several times to try and moisten their dry throat, before pulling the glass away and shouting down at their uncle.

"There is nowhere to dock!...the whole pier is on fire!"

Bow nodded, from his position behind the wheel. Half hidden in the shadow of the skiff's partially open cockpit. So the kitten could not see the full extent of their uncle's fear.

"What are we going to do!" Finn screamed, leaping from the platform and swinging themselves down the pole by one clawed hand to the lower deck.

"We do what we always do. Kid. Improvise." Bow answered, when the kitten finally scrambled up into the cockpit. Bow's once warm brown eyes were steeled with grim resolve. As he pressed a button on the touch screen panel, set just to the right of the wheel. In the front command housing of the controls. Releasing the anchor, to moor the skiff a few miles out from the ruins of Nora's massive dockyard. A whole fleet of ships were sinking or already falling beneath the rolling waves several miles ahead of their position. A graveyard of ship debris cluttered the water, along with masts jutting out of the frothing surf.

[I am going to sail further south, see how far the destruction goes. Hopefully we can moor ourselves closer to land.] Bull's rumbling baritone, issued from the skiff's com channel. Bow glanced up and to the stern, watching as Sloop, Bull commanded veered off towards the long coast of Nora.

[Alright…] Bow started to respond, pressing a button mounted in a forward com panel above the wheel. Moments before another communication broke through.

[This is the merchant vessel, Althea…we have been dashed upon the rock's just beyond the Three Sister's and are taking on water… the crew have been evacuated onto life boats and are currently headed towards safe harbor within the bay. This is a general warning to all ships headed towards the Three Sister's. A rogue wave originating from Morta is headed south, south west towards Salineas. All vessels bound to the Three Sisters need to change course, or you will meet the same fate as the Althea.]

"That's not good." Finn moaned, ears pinning back against their head. As their fluffy blonde tail lashed nervously behind them.

[Static…fading in and out crackled from the com's, then several short status communications between other ships either in distress within or beyond the islands, or currently struggling to find a pier to dock upon. All echoed over the deck from the com speaker's]

Bow's expression was unmoving, at hearing all the crews in distress. His heart went out to them and it hurt, that he couldn't help. But he had his mission! So he was focused on his task of buckling a gray leather utility belt around his waist. The pouches were all full, with his new arsenal of trick bolts he had crafted for his new weapons. Then quickly adjusting his crossbow gauntlets, to make sure they were tight. Finger's tapping swiftly over each power pack, mounted at the base to run a quick diagnostic. To make sure his weapons were fully charged and operational.

[Bull! This is Monkey, I’m headed your way. The damage to Dewma’s docks is minimal. I am guessing Hawk's Princess had something to do with that! I haven’t heard from Mouse since the morning check in. I tried to get her on the com’s but Mouse is not responding…I got a location…but it’s right in the middle of that fire storm!]
Finn swallowed hard, glancing to the right as Kei-Lee climbed up the last rung of the ladder to the control deck. Her sandy colored fingertips were stained with grease. Tossing Finn their now fully intact power staff.

“Wow…that was fast.” Finn breathed, catching the staff that was only minorly modified with a crudely wielded patch over the break.

“Will it still transform?” They asked, while futilely pressing the button on the pole.

“No..the gears are broken and I don’t have the tools or replacement parts to repair it completely. “ She huffed, wiping her greasy fingers on her worn, leather pants. Then raised a small hand to silence them before they could voice another question. “The sunstone shards on the tips will not ignite either. The upper one is cracked so the magic stored in that stone is gone, so the one on the bottom has burnt itself out, due the sudden discard of the upper shard. So I will have to replace those.”

Finn nodded, disappointed but they had learned to roll with sudden misfortunes.

”Right now, It’s a glorified stick…but it is still useful.” Kei-Lee blew a frustrated puff of air up into her low curtain of pale pink bangs, crossing her arms over her leather jerkin. Her stern expression, seeking to stall any of Finn’s complaints with her work.

“But you can fix it…right?’ Finn pleaded, suddenly worried that they had gotten their hopes up for no reason.

“Yes, If I can get it back to my workshop.” Kei-Lee, smacked the kitten on the shoulder with a reassuring smile.

Finn nodded, spinning the staff happily with both hands. It was better than nothing and they were grateful.

[Monkey! Going into that firestorm is a death wish! I’ll find a safe place to moor the Sloops, head towards my location.] Bull’s gruff demand suddenly exploded from the com speaker’s making them all jump.

“Are we going to follow Bull?” Finn asked, quietly.

As the tell-tale chime of Glimmer’s teleport vibrated from the deck below.

Finn and Bow darted to the command deck’s front glass. Finding the rest of the Best Friend squad, Sea Hawk, Mermista and Orion all standing near the bow.

“Naw, looks like we got a better way to transport inland.” Bow smirked, leaping down over the side railing, to the lower deck.

Finn merely nodded, following their uncle's lead and leaping towards the main deck. While Kei-lee vanished in a cloud of sparkles.

“How are we going to do this?” Kaira pondered, staring awestruck at the wall of fire. Currently consuming the entirety of the beach head before them.

“I could blink us all inland?” Glimmer offered with a shrug.

Adora released a tight breath, that was not a good plan. Blinking blind into that inferno was not safe.

Kaira crossed her arms, frowning at Glimmer.

Who wilted somewhat under her reproachful glare.

“That would be like the hole escape fiasco all over again.” Bow shuttered with the painful memories of the Crimson Waste. Of all the times both Glimmer and Adora landed on him. Whenever she missed her mark on the rim of that cursed hole trap. Giving Glimmer’s shoulder’s a reassuring squeeze. “We’ll figure out another way.”

Glimmer nodded, clasping his hands with her own, that were resting on her shoulders.

“I’ll swim over and when I find a safe place for you guys to port into, I’ll let you know over the com’s.” Mermista never waited for any objections. Dashing across the deck and diving over the stern.

Orion growled, tossing his bow and quiver to the deck as he ran after his sister. Unlatched his deep indigo cloak, just before diving after her. It fluttered in the air for a moment before pooling at the very edge of the railing.

The water was treacherous and the beach was an inferno! Adora was jolted into action, if they got hurt trying to find a safe place to teleport? She needed to be with them to protect them and heal them if they got seriously hurt. She was not going to lose another friend. The guilt of not being there for Max in time, burned her heart spurning to rash action.

“I’m going with you!” Adora shouted, leaping over the railing after Mermista.

Finn watched their Momma leap off the side of the skiff without any warning. Instantly their ears pinned back, as their heart leaped into their throat with dread.

“Wait! Adora! “ Kaira shouted after her, but she was too slow to stop her.

Watching in dismay as the impulsive blonde plunged feet first into the frothing ocean and disappeared beneath the waves.

"Soooo…I guess we just wait here then…" Glimmer sighed, tapping a finger against her thigh to quell the anxious energy she was feeling. Not surprised by Adora's impulsiveness, but not happy about it either.

While Kaira snarled and punched the railing in frustration.

"You better not die, you idiot."

Adora

A murky blue-green world surrounded her, as the water was churning with debris and clouded by sediment churned up from the sea bed. The broad and absolute destruction of the ships in Nora's harbor, cluttered the bay with wreckage. The current slowly polluting the whole of the bay with it.

The faint light from above filtering down from the surface, slowly becoming darker and less opaque the deeper she swam. Her human eyes, floundering to make sense of the alien world beneath the water. Fragile, coral ledges rose around her, made of brittle limestone deposits. A bulk of the reef was badly damaged, cluttered with the corpses of many sunken ships. Chunks of reef, floated amid the wrecks, dead and dying coals, sponges, jellies, anemone and other aquatic invertebrates of all colors clouded the water. Making it even harder to see. Most of the fish and other larger sea life had swam deeper into the bay seeking to escape the destruction of their home. Leaving only the corpses of the unfortunate, to lay crushed upon the sea bed or float lifeless upon the surface high above amid the clutter of lost cargo and ship fragments.

Adora’s gaze darted anxiously, through the murky depths finding no trace of the glinting scales of mermaid fins. She had figured it would be easy to keep up to Mermista and her brother. She was a strong swimmer, thanks to the many years she spent upon the water of Half Moon lake. Swimming laps up and down the bridge from the island to the shoreline of the Whispering Woods. Building up her stamina so she could maintain her transformation into She-Ra for longer.

She had always struggled with waiting, needing to be in action, to be useful when a crisis arose. Suddenly regretting her reckless choice to follow them. As all she saw in her field of view was tall, slithering masses of seaweed and endless shelves of shattered reef beds.

Her lungs were quickly burning with the need to breathe. Disappointed and humbled, she swam for the surface intending to swim back to the skiff.

Cresting the surface, she sucked in huge gulps of air. Wading in a circle to find no trace of the skiff. She scanned the horizon futility as the violent waves rocked her up and down. All she saw was an empty ocean, increasing her frustration at herself. As she realized that the current had caused her to drift far from the skiff. With no hope of finding it. She was quickly ascertaining her options, she would need to swim ashore on her own. It would take time, but she could do it. She had full confidence in her ability to swim for great distances. She could rest on her back from time to time to regain her strength, when she needed to. Turning in the direction of Nora, she was startled to find no trace of the destroyed pier or even the wall of fire that was consuming the coast. With no landmarks and no way to ascertain her bearings…her eyes flared wide with alarm. As the cold reality of the predicament she found herself in, hit her hard.

She was in the middle of the bay? Treading in a circle again, she was desperate to find safe harbor. But there were no other boats? The water was absent of debris for her to cling to. Panic began to creep upon her, as her eyes darted around the barren waves.

“This was a bad idea…” Adora muttered, in fear.

Mermista

Trident in hand, Mermista shot towards the beach just beneath the cresting waves. Her powerful tail, snapping in the water as she kept a close eye on her surroundings. Worried about getting hit or trapped by debris that was now clogging the water. Making fast, pinpoint maneuvers through the flotsam of broken pieces of wooden ships and lost cargo. As she swam at top speed towards the sand.

Orion was swimming within her wake, his darker, indigo fin snapping and swaying as he adjusted his course to match hers. Rolling to the left to avoid a thick yard arm, cutting down through the water. Only to kick sharply to change course as the riggings still attached to the pole sought to wrap around him and drag him down into the depths.

They could feel the heat, penetrating into the water before they even neared the damaged port. The water was so full of wooden fragments and larger pieces of the decks and hulls, from the field of slowly sinking ships. That they had to surface, gather their bearings and then prepare to dive again. Every time they surfaced the heat hit them like a brutal slap across their wet faces. The intensity of the inferno, growing larger and more terrifying the closer to the land they got. Causing them to squint into the glare, before diving back under to seek a reprieve from the painful throbbing of their eyes, caused by the caustic smoke. Rolling over the frothing water like a choking black cloud.

They were deep inside the graveyard of ships, with so many masts jutting out of the water. It looked like a jagged forest, growing up from the depths of the bay.

“Sister..” Orion swallowed hard, glancing around the horrific damage to Nora’s merchant fleet in utter terror. Wondering bleakly how many bodies lay, trapped and drown within the hulls of all those ships. Now, slowly fading away beneath the waves.

“Can we save them?” Orion questioned, staring bleakly down at the fading silhouettes of the ships below the surface.

Mermista heaved a heavy sigh, “Those we might have saved are silent by now, little brother. We lingered too long, getting up to the Shrine of Eternity.” Her voice was soft and grim. “But those trapped on the island still need us.” She finished with a brisk nod towards the fire storm that lay ahead.

Orion brushed his wet hair back off his face in frustration. Grinding his teeth and nodding in slow, understanding. He would have time enough to beat himself up for his choices when this was all over.

“Lets just stay focused, Orion. Follow me, I’ll lead you through this mess.” Mermista answered, navigating with an urgent, yet cautious approach through the debris field. Her expression was hard and unflinching amid the death that now surrounded them.

Orion was taken aback by how cool and collected she was in the face of such tragedy. How she naturally just took the lead, instructing him as she would a soldier under her command. Her once cocky, over confident persona was now tempered into a sharp, unflinching warrior when in the face of looming death. Cloaked in an armor of unrelenting determination, to meet those challenges head on and conquer them. No longer, embittered by responsibility for the crown of a crumbling kingdom. She was driven now by a purpose greater than just her own whims and wants. She had grown into a compassionate and stalwart leader. Who would do everything within her power to always take care of her people, to safeguard the entirety of the planet with her magic.

She had become someone that was truly awe inspiring. What she had gone through during the war, had steeled her in ways he could not comprehend. Far wiser and more mature than had been before. Orion's respect for her only increased, but he also felt so much sorrow for the hardships she must have gone through. That had hardened her and sharpened her into this fierce, tireless warrior she had become. She had gone through so much as a member of the princess Alliance, endured so much while fighting against the Horde…fighting Prime. The war had changed his sister in more ways than he knew. He realized that he did not know her anymore. But he wanted to know her, understand what she had gone through, what she had witnessed and how those experiences in the war beyond Salinas had reshaped her.

Into a Queen…

Adora

Picking a direction at random and hoping she was headed towards land had felt like a futile waste of energy. So she had merely allowed the current to carry her, trusting that it would pull her towards land. Using all her strength to stay above choppy water. As she bobbed up and down with the rolling surf. Keeping an eye out for anything that she could use to help her float. She was getting tired, treading water out here in the ocean was far more exhausting than back on Half Moon lake. Where the water was more tranquil, flowing gently away into the woods.

Adora was struggling to keep her head above the water, her clothes were water logged and the added weight was starting to pull her down. Kicking her feet and moving her arms was becoming sluggish. She had summoned a reserve of energy from

Sheana, her eyes now glowing a brilliant blue. But the magic was waning, Sheana had not absorbed enough magic to keep her strength up for much longer. With a yelp a wave crashed over her head, dragging her down beneath the water. Suddenly submerged in the murky green grasp of the raging sea. She found herself floundering desperately for the surface. Adora was once again stricken by intense panic. Then there was a roar, a rush of bubbles surrounded her, blinding her as she suddenly plummeted towards the sea bed. Her eyes burned from the salt and her ribs began to compress as the pressure mounted. An incredible pull, yanked on her ankles. Dragging her ever deeper into the fathomless shadows to the depths below. As an echoing drum beat of the waves above pounded in her ears.

Clamping down hard on her jaw, holding in her screams of terror as she was pulled downward into the darkness.

(*Don't breathe!)* She flailed, relentlessly, against the incredible strength of the current. Seeking to break free of its iron grasp. She had never felt so weak, or frightened. Clamping the lips tight, fighting upward for the last flicker of light that was the surface. Her chest burned for air, as she struggled to swim even an inch upward. As that pinpoint of light was slowly snuffed out, by the murky depths of the ocean.

Mermista

She glanced behind briefly, as she cut sharply to the right and then dove. Avoiding colliding with a plummeting mast that had suddenly appeared out of the gloom of the murky water. Cutting towards them like a spear, the split and broken shaft shedding splinter's of wood as it disappeared into the depths below. Thankful, Orion was alert and adept at swimming, able to keep up and maneuver with her. Mermista shot her eye's upward, lips thinning into firm resolve as the hull of a huge merchant vessel

appeared above them. Its looming shadow quickly engulfed them.

They had no way to escape being sucked into the hull, so she would have to navigate through the lower decks and up through the hold. Quick to sheath her trident upon her back and tuck her tail up into a diving pose. Adjust her arms over her head into a knife position. Mermista prepared herself to evade the impending collision.

Orion swam alongside her, his tail glinting in the half light. As he moved into position with her, so that they would be pulled into the wreck headfirst. As the suction grabbed them. Mermista took the lead, tumbling forward with the current, then kicking her fin in two powerful thrusts to weave into the broken side of the wooden hull. Twisting into a left roll, arms tucked tight to her sides to cut through the narrow opening of a doorway. That led into the ship's small galley. The room was cluttered with floating casks of ale, dishes, cutlery and sharp knives. Glinting in the dim half light like glittering shrapnel, ready to slice and impale them. Mermista pulled her trident from her back and deftly swept the clutter to either side of them. Creating a makeshift passage for them to pass. Resheathing the weapon just in time to dive through a dark, narrow passage at the end of the galley.

Orion kept a close eye on his sister’s tail, repeating her movements a second behind. As they used the twisting current inside the ship to their advantage, to traverse the short outer hallway beyond the kitchen and then plunge deeper into the open, empty hold and up through the main deck hatch. Spinning in the water like a corkscrew to cut out of the current and swim for the surface.

Kaira

From the deck of the skiff, Kaira watched the mammoth inferno that engulfed the coast with rising trepidation. Calling out to her magic over fire, willing it to rise from the depths of her soul and into something tangible. Slowly her fingertips ignited, a warm glow just below the surface of her skin. Thanks to Cyrus and his teaching her the tenets of magic. She was able to call upon her power with far more confidence than before. She understood how to manifest it, how to manipulate it beyond herself. To manifest it as a weapon…as a tool…or merely command it…as she was the Rune Bearer of Fire!

(Fire Magic is combative in nature, offensive in its intention)

Catra allowed herself to fall upon the righteous fury she felt at the out of control destruction of the shoreline. Focusing herself upon the action she wished to take.

She wanted to control that fire, tame it…quell it…extinguish it…

(Focus is control, Power is emotion)

The wild hunger of the flames screamed back at her. A shrill, feral howl within the searing heat vibrated against her ears. Kaira sucked in a startled breath, as her hand was suddenly clutched.

A frightened scream ripping from her throat as the solid deck was yanked out from beneath her, replaced by the dizzy, tumbling sensations of being sucked from one place to another. Soon replaced by a searing, unrelenting heat slamming against her whole body, that stole her breath. The white hot glare forced her to close her eyes to protect her sight. As it sought to burn her eyes to ash. The feeling of Glimmer's hand on her shoulder faded. As her stomach churned, as she was whisked away from the rest of them to somewhere unknown. Her heartbeat was a rapid fire against her chest. As the sensation of falling out of control and totally blind washed over her.

“GLIMMER!!!!” She heard herself cry out in sudden and overwhelming terror, as she was left tumbling away from the rest of them. Passing from that glittering, incorporeal space that Glimmer teleported through and into a molten light.

Adora

Suddenly with a great swell, as if a wave beneath the ocean had cast her out. She was flung from the water and into a pitch black world of nothingness. She was spinning wildly, struggling for purchase finding nothing but air. Then once more she was falling, crashing into the cold sea. Slipping beneath and frantic to find anything to hold onto less she be pulled under once again. Finding nothing but water, slipping through her hands. It was a sickening sensation, as she was once again hurled through the air. Tumbling along some underground rapid’s, bouncing off boulder’s and rolling out of control in the rushing waves. Until she was slammed against a solid surface.

Against her will, Adora gasped, inhaling the caustic seawater rushing all around her. She was sucked under, before her lungs could burst as another hard surface pressed against her stomach and raised her out of the water.

Gagging and choking, spitting and scrambling to clutch desperately onto anything that would keep her firmly in place upon this sudden, smooth and slick ledge.

(*Calm, down…Rune Bearer…my you is a slippery thing* .)
A deep, elegant voice whispered in her mind.

Adora lay flat, on her stomach, panting and heaving for air. Sprawled over shimmering scales, as dark and deep blue as the

ocean's depths. Her hair was free and now plastered to her head and shoulders. Quickly wiping the salt water out of her eyes. Enthralled with how those scales seemed to glow, softly lighting the under sea cavern she found herself in. In a gentle, calming starlight hue. Above her there was jagged rock, barely an inch away from the top of her head. Below the scales she could see the rushing waves, crashing against her half submerged boots. As she hung limp and lifeless over the Serpent's blunt snout. She vaguely noted that she was bleeding from her left temple, where she had impacted the rocks earlier.

Her hands were scraped up and every muscle in her body was burning with lack of oxygen.

"Thank you…for saving me…" She breathed, holding onto the scaly snout with as much strength as she had left. Noting how the noise of the ocean had diminished since being sucked down that tunnel and into this cavern. Its deafening roar now dulled into a low echo that vibrated through the rock walls.

(You were caught in the undertow and the current pulled you here. I just barely caught up to you in time. Rest easy, I shall carry you until we reach dry land.) The voice in her head reassured her.

"Who are you?" Adora mumbled, she was half coherent. Water logged and nearly drowned she could barely form a sentence. She could barely open her eyes, left squinting. As she valiantly tried to make sense of the blurry visage of the Sea Serpent now carrying her on its blunt, upturned snout.

(Ryujin, Elemental Guardian of Water…Vessel of She-Ra… we have met before.) The voice chuckled, electric blue eyes shone in the darkness of the cave with amusement. ***(Your confusion concerns me that perhaps you may have brain damage?)***

Adora giggled and shook her head ruefully, she had met them… but that was in another life. "You're not the only one who thinks

that, I’m starting to think so too.” With a huff, Adora flopped her forehead down upon the serpent’s scales needing to take a moment to recover. She knew Ryujin, and had met them long ago as Mara. When she had traveled around Etheria. To garner the support of the Rune Bearer’s for the Heart Project. They would have time for proper reintroduction once she was free of this cavern and back on dry land.

Finn

Their hackles rose in warning, as their bare feet once more gained purchase on solid ground. Sensing the danger their ears pinned flat and tail fluffed out to twice its size. They were quick to raise their hand to shield their eyes from the glare of the flames that surrounded them. The wind gusted, hot over the scorched sand. That had melted the turned to glass. The crackling roar of the inferno was howling, the massive pillars of flame rising towards the sky, licking at the billowing clouds of black smoke now blanketing the whole island. The shattered, burnt out husks of ancient shell structures lurked like a jagged silhouette amid the flames. That was barely a yard away from where the group had appeared.

Bow gasped at the overwhelming devastation, his eyes filling with tears that were not just from the smoke stinging them. But from the brutal understanding that so many lives had just been snuffed out in an instant when that explosion had rocked the island and thousand’s more may lay mangled and dying with the wreckage.

Glimmer whimpered, biting her lower lip to stop it from trembling. As she made a futile survey of the inferno, to find a way to enter the wall of flames that surrounded them.

“Poseidon have mercy…” Mermista breathed, overwhelmed by the shear size and ferocity of the fire. The realization of the death toll that now confronted them, shattered her. A small cry of misery escaped her tight lips as she instinctively turned and hid her face against Sea Hawk’s chest. Clutching onto him for support as she wept.

Sea Hawk held her tight, petting a hand down her dark hair seeking to soothe her. Leaning down and whispering into her ear.

“You can do this Mermista…You are the strongest, smartest, bravest and the most resilient and resourceful woman. I have ever known. It may seem hopeless right now, but I believe in you. We are going to figure out a way to save as many as we can.”

Orion stood staring in stark horror, swallowing and blinking in bewilderment.

There was no way Delphi had survived this…let alone her people… it all seemed so hopeless.

“Where ... .where is mother?” Finn’s voice was small, plaintive and so very, very frightened.

Glimmer whirled around in sudden fright, her indigo eyes darting around in vain to the shocked and horrified faces of her friends. Finding no trace of Catra!

She had never lost someone in mid transport before….it was worse because it was Catra…who hated blinking from place to place. She had promised Catra back at Mystacor that she would be more considerate. About how uncomfortable and stressful she found teleporting. But she had been in such a rush to get here, she never even gave the magicat a warning before teleporting her. She had just rudely grabbed her and snatched her away like a piece of luggage!

“Fucking….hell…” Glimmer growled, her inner voice screaming in reprimand at her own self for being so reckless.

Finn whimpered, as they were once again confronted by the horrifying prospect of losing both their mother's in an instant. Suddenly, their breath became labored short and rapid. The flames of this reality fading down a dark tunnel, as they felt adrift once more in the drowning pain and misery of their youth.

The air was thick, black and suffocating. The echoes of the cruel timeline they had come from. Was a maddened cry of the damned. Pulsing like a slowing heartbeat inside their mind. Finn began to choke, gagging on their own blood. As they crumpled to the shimmering, smooth ground. Heaving for air that would not come. Their timeline hummed with a destructive static, too loud, too full of discordant calls for mercy…for peace…for silence. As the nameless one swallowed the galaxy, infinite in its hunger, an absolute and never ending darkness…and they knew without a single doubt…within the infinite silence.

They were gone….they were all gone….

…They had run out of time…

Chapter End Notes

I had to cut the chapter in two, cause it was getting long. Figured if I was going to leave it as a cliff hanger I should make it good! LOL. I will not leave you hanging for long.

Heart of Fire

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm and LunaTheBlackWolf for your comments and all who have left Kudos. I am sorta all over the place right now, but I am following my muse. So here is another chapter.

They had set out for Moirai late that afternoon. Setting a course northwest from the tip of Broland Island. Out towards the vast open water, heading towards the western most islets of the Archipelago. The hours had passed slowly, with Sea Hawk investigating every part of the ship. With the eager excitement of a young boy with a new toy. Bow had loved every minute of showing off his new high tech skiff. Catra, Finn and Adora had stayed out their way. Climbing up to the crows nest. Grinning and chuckling amongst themselves as they enjoyed the show. While Glimmer and Mermista hung out in the control deck. Glimmer was at the helm, guiding the skiff so Bow could show Sea Hawk around. Mermista would groan and roll her eyes, feigning annoyance. Every time, Sea Hawk squealed in absolute delight. As Bow walked him around the main deck below, pointing out any and all nautical advancements he had made. To the twin sails, the riggings, the overall more streamline design of the hull. Which would make his skiff one of the fastest ships on the sea.

Showing off his boat like a proud father.

Dusk was now falling around their small fleet of ships, the gently rolling sea reflecting the evening color's like glass. Catra had just finished her evening farewell to the Sun. Standing on the bow, contemplating the coming tribulations that lay ahead for her. As she was willingly sailing deeper into enemy territory. Already getting a small taste of the fear and loathing from the sailor's back in Broland. She had no delusions that the people of the Moirai hated her just as much, if not more. Her ears folded back in distress, she had so much to atone for. Her tail curled around her

waist and she began to soothe herself, by softly fanning her fingers through the fluffed out end. Brushing her fur back down, with meticulous percission. Long practiced in her youth, to maintain at least the illusion of being in control of her emotions. A disgruntled huff of air escaped her lips. As he desperately sought out that calm center. She was struggling to think clearly and not spiral into pointless negativity. Silently watching the last rays of light sinking below the water on the far off horizon. Where the skycolor's met the ocean.The brilliant reds and oranges burning the peaks of the waves. Flowing out into the dark water, glistening off the surface like a molten sheen.

While Glimmer stood at the stern, gazing up at the largest of the Greater Moons ascending into the sky. Welcoming her source with a warm, reverent smile. As if the stellar object was some ancient king, greatly respected. But also a dear friend, sorely missed and deeply cherished.

The darker tones of night were dominating over the back of the skiff, the stars shimmering into life high above. The duality of the light was in play in those brief moments. As the sun gave up its reign over the sky, Elidor and his court of moons arose. The transition of power was always slow and cordial as both the Sun and the Moons ruled over the sky. Each taking their turn, to cast their light and then when their reign was over. They would depart, without much more fanfare than the gloriously colored horizon between them.

Mermista and SeaHawk had disappeared below deck before dusk to prepare them an evening meal, fit for the High Seas. At least that was what Sea Hawk had crowed, fisting the air in triumph before going below. Professing loudly to Finn, who was standing nearby. What an amazing cook he was and immediately going into some far-fetched story about how his food had saved the lives of his crewmates years ago on some far off island of cannibals who had wanted to eat them. While Mermista on the other hand rolled her eyes dismissively. Chuckling softly at Sea Hawk's inevitable exuberance at the mundane task. Following him with a curt wave at them over her shoulder.

Glimmer passed Adora, who was half sitting on a wooden keg braced against the main mast. She had a bent leg tucked under her butt, her knee resting up on the rim of the lid. Her other leg extended straight out to keep her balance. As she used her boot knife to carve up a piece of driftwood she had found back on the beach on Broland. Finn was perched on the barrel behind her. Kneeling and leaning their full weight against her back, as they had hooked their chin over her shoulder. Lightlying gripping her biceps with small hands, as they watched her work.

"Do I ever get good at this?" Adora muttered, absently towards Finn. As she stuck her tongue out the side of her mouth in concentration. She was trying to carve Melog again, hoping the driftwood would be softer to widdle.

Finn had been rather clingy to both of their mother's all day. Always touching them in some small, unobtrusive way. Neither seemed to mind. So Finn nuzzled into the side of Adora's neck with a giggle, dark ear folding back so they could tuck their face into the crook beneath her chin. Taking a deep comforting sniff of her scent. That they had missed so very much…

"Yeah…you made most of my toys when I was little." Finn muttered, as Adora giggled. Their little button nose tickling the soft skin under her chin.

Glimmer had been swiftly introduced to the young kitten back at lunch on the beach. She had long ago learned to roll with the weird that came with being magical. So as far fetched as having your bestfriends kid from the future,slash, .Alternate dimension… whatever just shows up and starts calling them both mom. Was alarming and really, really…freaky…their ability to time travel was far more terrifying to contemplate. Since she was thrust into yet another crazy scenario of trying to navigate their never ending complicated future. Glimmer had pretty much made her own words of advice, her mantra. She would solve what she could and let her friends help her deal with the rest. Trying to control the future that scared the living hell out of her had never worked out

so well. So she just kept taking deep breaths and reminding herself to trust in others…

Glimmer cast a ball of light into the air as she passed Adora. Adora glanced up and gave her a wide smile in thanks. As the shadowed deck around her was suddenly illuminated into a warm brilliance.

Glimmer made her way over to the bow, finding Catra up on the front railing. Squating on the top rail, toes curled over the metal and claws fully released. Knees drawn up to her chest and tail tucked tight around her ankles. The tips flicking anxiously. She had her bare arms folded over her knees and her chin resting in the crock of her arms, lost in deep contemplation. Having left her leather jacket back in their cabin, as the afternoon heat dragged on. Leaving her in only her red tunic and black leggins. Her eyes were transfixed upon the sea ahead, watching the dark water below being parted along the sharp nose of the ship.

"Your emotions are all kind of mixed up again tonight… I am here to listen? " Glimmer offered, leaning her back against the railing beside her. Keeping her gaze averted to watch the darkening horizon behind them. After their heart to heart a few days back while traveling across the Crimson Waste. She did not want to spook the cat girl, by looking at her. Which would be seen as confronting her about being emotional. Knowing that was a sure way to piss Catra off and have her clam up instantly about what was bothering her.

Catra chuckled ruefully, "It's so weird when we sing together, I get echoes of your messed up emotions too, Sparkles. I'm just not nosey enough to point it out."

"Brat…!" Glimmer spat, scowling down at her hands now gripping the railing as she had turned around. "Being genuinely interested in how one of your best friends is dealing with… " Glimmer waved her hand over her head, whimsically before finishing with a belated pause. "Everything…is perfectly normal in a healthy friendship."

"I'm dealing…ok." Catra huffed, hating that she had to point out her deflecting behavior…when it came to opening up about her feelings. She was already embarrassed about her breakdown over nearly losing Adora. Her mind has spun out onto other more pressing anxieties since then. Working through the various wretched scenarios, one after another. Needing to parse out every terrible outcome that could come to pass in the next few weeks, months, years…in regards to this overwhelming amount of magic. That they all had access to now.

She damn well knew she wasn't problem solving, but catastrophizing. But she just couldn't help it! Thanks to Perfuma and Melog's emotional insights. She understood that it was a trauma response from growing up in the Horde. A survival tactic to try and protect herself from future harm.

Catra cut her eyes sideways, finding Melog. Who was always close by when she was trapped in her head. A soothing comfort, washing over her through their link. As the huge cat was lounging on the stern, offering her a wide toothy yawn. Stretching their front legs out and kneading the deck briefly with their large claws. Completely at ease, here on the sea. Before settling down and curling up to continue their nap. Their body was a dark sandy brown, the lava like cracks in their flank glowing a pale yellow. Their mane and tail, flickering like a sputtering bonfire. Bluntly broadcasting to anyone who is paying attention to the alien cat. Catra's emotional state was anxious and unsettled, with just a hint of irritation mixed in for good measure.

"Still evading…Horde Scum." Glimmer smirked, turning back around to leave Catra to her brooding. When Mermista appeared above deck with a tray of slightly burnt biscuits. Sea Hawk trailing behind her with a crate dry rations from the hold.

"Not what I expected after all that boasting?" Glimmer spoke pointedly towards Sea Hawk. While Sea Hawk looked dejected and guilty at the same time.

"The 'mighty chef' set the kitchen on fire…these biscuits are the only edible item to survive the culinary carnage." Mermista shot, Sea Hawk with a pointed look.

"Who would have thought, Fish Flambe could get so out of hand!" Sea Hawk pouted.

Bow squawked in horror from the command deck, then bolted down the ladder and into the main compartment of the ship to see the extent of the damage. This boat was his baby, he had worked so hard on building it with Brojee and the other's over the last month or so. With the Horde wreckage they had taken from the Scorpania scrapyard…he was terrified at what he may find below deck.

Glimmer found Catra once again above deck at the bow, perched upon the railing in the gray hours before dawn. They would both wake just before dawn as their ritual to bid farewell and welcome to their sources. But usually not so early. Glimmer was having a hard time falling asleep last night. It could have been the overly salted fish, making her stomach upset. Or her own festering bitterness of being cast aside by Bow for so long. While he had been lost to his inventions back at Mystacor. That made his nightly embrace in their bed as they settled into sleep. Feel rather aloof and ungenuine. Glimmer knew they needed to talk, but neither of them was willing to broach the silent truce they were locked in. Refusing to admit they were having problems and just living in the comfortable, yet lukewarm affections passing between them.

It was strange to find Catra awake this early, she usually appeared just as dawn was cresting to sing her morning vesper's.

"We meet again." Glimmer commented lightly as she moved in to stand beside her.

Catra merely grunted with acknowledgement.

"It's not like you to be up so early." Glimmer offered again.

“It's easier to leave the bed, when you don’t actually sleep in it.” Catra huffed, dryly.

Glimmer arched an inquiring eyebrow.

“For such a small kitten, Finn can take up an absurd amount of room.” Catra spread her arms wide to illustrate. How when she had finally gone to bed last night, long after midnight. She had found Adora fast asleep on her side of the bed, with Finn starfished on Catra's side. Out cold and snoring as loudly as their Momma.

“Couldn’t sleep?” Glimmer nodded, knowing it was just an excuse. Catra could have easily snuggled down next to Adora and Glimmer knew it. Those two were capable of folding and intertwining with each other in the most absurd ways. She had seen it more than once during their time bunking together both on Darla on the way home and during the rebellion in their hideout, after they got back to Etheria.

“Something like that.” Catra released a long, tired sigh.

Glimmer turned to scan the deck for Melog. She needed some kind of clue as to how Catra was feeling since she was being so closed off. Finding the alien cat curled up nearby. Their mane was burning low along their thick neck, the fire was a soft blue mixed with lavender. The lava cracks along their well muscled body were glowing a soft blue while their body had turned to a pale coal tone.

Catra was not exactly sad, but overwhelmed…lost in her melancholy.

With that little bit of guidance, Glimmer was certain she could navigate this awkward, obviously reluctant conversation about feelings. To get the tight lipped magicat to open up about what was bothering her without getting defensive again.

“We got time…” Glimmer shrugged, taking a calm, rather aloof approach to her prodding.

Catra laughed dryly, chucking a thumb over her shoulder back at the hold.

"That's up for debate." She spat smartly, already they could both hear someone down in the kitchen puttering about.

Glimmer merely shrugged again, casting her gaze upward to the glittering sky full of stars. The lesser moons were now high above, while the larger Greater Moon's were descending towards the slowly warming horizon. As soon as the sun rose those smaller moon's would fade into the radiance of another clear blue sky.

"The Horde makes you fear magic." Catra glanced sideways towards Glimmer. Her glistening eyes, already welling with overwhelmed tears. Quickly darted back towards the horizon, as if scared of maintaining eye contact with her concerned friend. Lest Glimmer's soft, caring eyes. Completely rip down her walls too early. Leaving her a blubbering mess like so many times before.

"Ok, makes sense since they wanted you to see Princesses as a major threat to the planet." Glimmer nodded. "So you're scared of magic, not a surprise?" She offered, softly. Which made a hell of a lot of sense, as to how stubbornly Catra had fought against learning about magic back at Mystacor in the beginning.

"I'm scared of my magic." Catra clarified. Needing to respond that she wasn't scared of the princess's magic ... .a vain attempt to maintain her reputation of fearless badassery in regards to fighting Princesses.

Glimmer nodded, folding her arms over her chest and giving her reproachful glare. Refusing to take the bait and snap back with a sharp comment of her own. Knowing Catra was deflecting but also opening up in that same infuriating backhanded way of hers. In which her truthful words were always sharpened with an insult.

"I already know what to expect from the other princesses lame ass,magic, it's not a real threat." Catra snarked back, with a

lopsided smirk that showed off a fang. Showing Glimmer that her snarky comment was just a joke. Needing to lighten the weight of this conversation.

"Enlighten me, why you're scared of "your magic. " Glimmer huffed.

"It's complicated." Catra groaned, scrubbing a hand down her face in frustration.

"Is that why you were so stubborn about learning how to wield your magic back at Mystacor?" Glimmer prodded more directly.

"My magic is different, I'll admit I feel so much more powerful now than ever before. Cyrus helped…I understand how to summon it…how to control it…sorta…but… " Catra rambled, reaching for the right way to explain it.

Glimmer finally turned back around, pressing the side of her shoulder against Catra's to offer solidarity towards this hard conversation.

"When I had to share the Moonstone with my Mom. My magic was diluted…it was limited." Glimmer began, "Now with the magic released and my Runestone destroyed. It's like tapping into a live electrical current, it jolts me. Everytime I draw from it…A limitless fountain of power…so deep and so fathomless it is kinda thrilling for me. "

"Do you worry what might happen if you lost yourself to that power?" Catra mutters.

"What's your magic like?" Glimmer asked, now curious about what Fire felt like compared to Light.

"I try not to draw too much. I don't trust that I can control it. It's ….it's like trying to hold onto the leash of this huge, unruly, wild

animal. That only wants to be free and do as it pleases." Catra grumbled, staring with trepidation down at her hands.

"So basically it's you." Glimmer remarked with a sly grin. As Catra cut her a sharp affronted glare out of the side of her golden eye.

"Horde Scum…you need to relax. If what you say is true, your magic doesn't trust you..because you don't trust it." Glimmer knocked her shoulder with her's. The shove was a bit stronger than she had intended.Catra nearly toppled over the front of the skiff. With a yelp, the feline adjusted her stance and swiveled on the railing, on the balls of her feet then leapt down onto the deck before she lost her footing completely.

"Ooops, sorry." Glimmer cringed, sliding down the railing to sit on the deck. She lounged against the bow, one leg raised and her elbow resting on her knee.

Catra groaned, as she slipped down onto the deck herself. She had been singing to Adarion for months now, offering her source as much as she was willing to share about herself. Yet she had never received any kind of real response back from that magic. The odd time she felt some kind of emotional response while singing. It wasn't clear enough to be coming from the Sun. Anymore then just her imagination trying to give her false confidence that she was actually bonding with it. The notion of magic to her was just so ambiguous and vague.

"Seriously…what is magic then?" Catra growled, settling down beside Glimmer. "Is it an elemental force?...Is it sentient…like Adora's or is it a Frickin Moon or Sun…What the hell is it!" She fumed, thumping the back of her head against the metal railing. As her tail thumped against the deck in an irritated crescendo.

Glimmer just shrugged again. "It's all those things…I guess. Magic is magic, it just is."

Catra blew a puff of hot air up into her long bangs in frustrated defeat, closing her eyes. "How can I trust something I don't know

anything about?”

“You think the hybrid runes we’ve collected will tell you?’ Glimmer offered.

“I had hoped I could learn more about my magic, yeah. “ Catra groused, disappointed by the lack of insight she had gained, compared to the hours of work they had put in so far.

They were quiet for a long time.

Glimmer watched her, with subtle glances. Noticing how Catra’s hands had begun to tremble as she gripped her knees tight. The tight hunch of her shoulder’s as she folded herself over into a tight ball.

“You trust Melog and their magic…their ‘your’ magic.” Glimmer wrapped an arm around Catra and pulled her close. Sensing she was on the verge of a breakdown and wanted to comfort her. Hold her close and reassure her that everything was going to be alright.

“So far what I’ve seen of magic…is it’s fickle, easily corrupted and very, very dangerous if not deadly. To not only others but to the wielder as well.” Catra leaned her head against Glimmer’s shoulder. Allowing this soft moment to pass between them. So very grateful to have the Queen’s friendship. Over the last year, they had gone from that fragile, antagonistic friendenemy relationship. They began on Primes ship just after being captured. To be comrades in arms seeking to find freedom, as the months of captivity dragged on. Then close friends who were struggling to survive the crushing void of space and make it home. To best friends, working together with the rest of the princess alliance to rid the Galaxy of Primes tyranny. To this… family…she never wanted to lose this.

“My mom was magic…She was the wisest, bravest, kindest and strongest person I have ever known. If magic can make someone as amazing as her…it can’t be bad.” Glimmer offered, ducking her

head down to offer Catra a soft smile of reassurance. Before pressing a tender kiss to the feline's forehead.

Glimmer's eyes flew wide, as she was stunned by her boldness. Suddenly very nervous that she had overstepped. Catra merely closed her eyes and hummed contentedly at the affection. So Glimmer instantly relaxed.

"Glimmer…after what happens to Adora…when she transforms… what has happened back at the Crystal Castle." Catra swallowed hard, unable to finish. As the residual fear and grief of those tragic moments when Adora seemed on the verge of death. Clamped down hard on her heart and made her throat tight.

"Adora's magic was being corrupted by that rage virus." Glimmer answered, her tone firm and absolute.

"Because, Keldor tried to control Despara with the Kaydak Crystal. In that horrible Portable Rune stone, the Disc of Destruction." Catra growled, gripping her hair in frustration.

Glimmer groaned, "Which is a conduit for the Nameless One." She had heard the whole story from Adora, over a week ago. Back at the crystal pillars on the edge of the Serenia Savannah, after they had rescued Levi.

"Who is magic." Catra pulled away, her watery mismatched eyes meeting Glimmer's worried ones. "The worst kind of dark magic."

Glimmer groaned, " I know…Light Spinner tainted my father's magic with that vile darkness….I get it! I do!" She clarified, in a high pitched squeal. Her own fear is displayed very obviously in the panic of her tone.

Catra knew nothing about Micah, or his past. But Light Spinner had to have preyed upon some kind of personal weakness to twist Micah into learning dark magic. It was predatory in nature and he would have had to sacrifice his own life force to wield it. She had been no better, she allowed the Nameless One to devour her whole in a moment of weakness, while trapped in the portal

reality. When she had lost everything she ever cared about yet again. Her perfect life was destroyed, being rejected by Adora as she betrayed their promise. All she wanted was revenge, to make Adora hurt in all the same ways she had hurt her.

"Glimmer…how can you trust that your magic won't consume you." Catra breathed, drawing her knees up to her chest and hiding her face in her crossed arms again. Her tail tip flicked anxiously on the deck.

Glimmer shrugged again, staring up at the softly warming sky contemplating her words.

"I've made friends with my magic a long time ago…It's way stronger than it ever was and yeah…I do find the power I'm drawing from is way scarier…but I also trust that it will always protect me and my friends."

"I am terrible at making friends." Catra admitted, bitterly.

Glimmer laughed, thinking it was a joke.

"If my magic ever overpowers me…if I'm ever out of control…I need you to kill me…before I can hurt anyone else." Catra gripped Glimmer's chin and drew her gaze downward. Confronting Glimmer's now tense, worried expression with a stern, determined scowl of her own.

"Promise me! " Catra urged, her voice pitching high with desperation.
"I…can't promise to kill you." Glimmer stammered, abruptly pulling away from Catra's firm grip and standing up. Hands balled up into fists at her sides and frowning down at her with disgust.

Why did she always have to be so fatalistic when things got heavy? It was like she was incapable of ever being hopeful that thing could work out in her favor?

"You had no problems killing me before!" Catra scoffed, rising up onto her feet before Glimmer. Finger's splayed threateningly at her

sides and claws unsheathed, as if she was holding herself back from slashing at her.

"That was different….I hated you then." Glimmer admitted through clenched teeth. Glancing, cautious down at Catra's claws. Keeping an eye on them in case the cat girl lashed out.

"You'll hate me again soon enough, if I go on a rampage and start killing people!" Catra shouted, waving a hand out towards the sea. Knowing damn well she would always be capable of killing others. Her rage was under control now, caged and sedated by knowing kindness and true friendship. But those instincts to hunt, to kill, to win at all costs. Had been sharpened and weaponized by the Horde. If pushed too far, if she drew too much. She could easily be overwhelmed by her own, rather feral magic. It was far too wild and unpredictable and they were definitely not friends! The prospect of losing her free will and becoming a puppet for some other power greater than her. Chilled to the very core.

"It's never going to happen!" Glimmer exclaimed, her voice rising in panic.

"But what If it does…" Catra, doubled down.

Glimmer hiccuped, licking her lips and scowling down at her in defiance.

"You are too strong and far too obstinate to ever allow anyone or anything to ever control you…" She growled in a low hiss.

"Promise me…Glimmer. You will do what needs to be done to protect everyone." Catra reached out and softly clutched the queen's hands. Urging her to comply, with a desperate, shimmer in her eyes. As she was on the verge of tears herself.

Glimmer sniffled and with tears streaming down her face she held Catra's beseeching gaze. That was now steeled with a firm resolve.

“I promise…” Glimmer whispered in a breathless sob. Bowing her head in defeat.

Catra

It felt just like the forge, back in the Fright Zone. Stiflingly hot and far too bright, forcing her to squint. Just to try and see past the glare, as if she was inside one of the industrial furnaces. She had spent countless hours, willingly or not. Within the cavernous recesses of that smelting plant. It had been so liberating to destroy it, during her final battle with Hordak. She felt like she had finally avenged Tama and cleansed all the horrible memories of what Shadow Weaver had put her through in that hellish place.

She could feel the immense heat surrounding her, but there was no flame? Growing hotter and hotter as she fell into that molten light.

The seashell around her neck was the first casualty of the incredible heat, the fragile totem cracked then shattered like fine porcelain. The shards instantly turned to ash. Dissolving into nothing, as the dust cloud was absorbed into the light. The fox glamor shimmered away. Leaving Catra as she truly was, to confront the fire in her true form.

Her short dark hair became dried out and frizzy like brittle straw. Framing the crown of her head, in a wild untamed mass. Her clothes were next to surrender to the ever increasing heat. Her leather jacket dried out, cracked and became brittle. Falling away from her frame like an autumn leaf crushed to dust. The cloth of her sleeveless maroon tunic and black leggings, warmed then promptly combusted. Leaving her falling totally nude into a howling, vortex of flame. Her tiara of threaded silver appeared, with the sunstone shard, hanging within an elegant knot upon her

forehead. The manifestation of her magic, glowed defiantly before the intensity of the heat.

Yet, still she wasn't scared per say, but she was cautious… knowing it was a temperamental element. As she slowly sank into the primordial firestorm. Her thoughts mulling over her complicated feelings she carried towards her magic, her past relationship with flame.

It was strange, how she had just leaped without fear into the column of flame after Adora. When she had set off that trap back in the secret tunnels of Mystacor during their flight to find the Fail Safe. Being reckless or impulsive wasn't like her at all, she had always been very meticulous about her actions. Every move she made, every word she spoke was always planned inside her head in advance. A survival tactic, honed in the barracks to manipulate or intimidate her bunkmates, or to evade Shadow Weaver's wrath. She never knew what to expect from one day to the next, so she was always strategizing, always hyper vigilant to any deviation to her surroundings, to the emotional shifts of those around her. Knowing when to use her claws, or her words as weapons to cut down other's, in order to maintain the fear and higher status she held over her bunkmates. Or when to use flattery, or act culled and shamed before Shadow Weaver. Who was her commander, who held all the power, to either praise or punish. Or when knowing none of her cunning tactics would work and she would have to cut and run, or hide out for days until things cooled off.

It had always been a chess match….her childhood…

But she had known, even then, instinctively…that the fire never posed any real threat to her, that it was a kindred spirit…an element she had a soul, deep connection with. In that regard, she came to understand how similar this magic was to her true self and that was when she began to fear it.

With the added warmth, came the pain and also comfort. Her skin beneath her fur cracked and absorbed the heat. The fire inside of

her now flowed over her muscles like lava. Seering her bones and joints as they were forged anew.

Her whole being was overwhelmed by the raw intensity of fire magic. As her true identity was laid bare before the flames. The manifestation of her personal power became fragile. As the sunstone upon her forehead cracked then shattered. No longer having any cohesion of self, to maintain its form. The tiara, then faded away. Revealing a sideways V. A mystical, hybrid rune now etched upon her forehead, that glowed with a flickering light like a living flame.

A brand…that she was the Rune Bearer, chosen by Etheria, to become the embodiment of Fire itself.

She was at the core of her magic now...no longer able to keep anything hidden or reveal only what she felt safe sharing with Adarion. All the dark recesses of her soul were laid bare before them. Unfiltered and every aspect of herself on full display before Adarion's judgment. She could no longer hide and she felt so very vulnerable.

The light that surrounded her, pulsed with a myriad of colors. An incandescent world of blue, purple and white hues. All flashing in harmony with yellow, red and orange bursts. A universe of flames curled and danced in greeting as her descent finally slowed and she began to float within what she intrinsically knew was the Heart of Fire.

Glimmer

"Adora's not here either?" Bow observed, quietly to Glimmer. As he was rechecking the power status of his gauntlets.

“Where is she, then!” Mermista whirled around, as if Adora would suddenly appear if she spun around fast enough.

“She dove into the sea after you and Orion, Dearest.” Sea Hawk explained calmly, as he grasped Mermista’s shoulder to stop her frantic movements.

“Well that’s just great!” Mermista growled, rolling her eyes in annoyance.

“I’ll go get her…” Glimmer nodded, closing her eyes and focusing on Adora. So very thankful of her new ability to track her friends and teleport directly to them. She had already searched for Catra and had found no trace of her. As scary as that was, she tried to focus on what she could do. She would get Adora and then they could figure out how to find Catra, together.

Catra

She was at the core of the inferno now. She floated naked before the very soul of Adarion. Her mismatched eyes stared unblinking at the furiously, pulsing lights that surrounded her. Enraptured ... .Enthralled…Spell bound…by the purity of its untamed aura.

Her eyes were stinging from the intensity of the flames.

She closed her eyes.

From behind her eyelids, she began to listen.

A song…as timeless and eternal as the universe.

A firesong…that roared and crackled to life within her own vocal cords. She began singing a melody, more glorious and inspiring than any she had ever sung before. The sound drew her soul

memories of all the Rune Bearer’s who had ever wielded the magic of fire. Their lives cascading through her mind’s eye, painful in their sweetness. So many lives lived and extinguished in a blink of an eye, as Adarion guarded and guided each one throughout their brief existence.

Then her own life flashed, tranquil nights sitting by the field stone hearth with her mother. In their small farmhouse out beyond the village, nestled within the warm embrace of the golden savannah grass. As Aoi brushed through her thick, long mane. Waiting for Saladin, her father to return…from his resistance missions against the Eternian’s.

Festival bonfires and celebrations in the village square, as the Sunna celebrated the harvest during the cool Season, the solstice in the cold season, the Great Hunt, come the warm season and the Equinox during the hot season.

Her memories picked up speed.

As the song changed, it became low and mournful. It spoke of war, persecution and genocide. The inevitable destruction of her homeland and her family's desperate flight to escape. Fear and anxiety ate at her heart, as she endured the horror and unyielding sorrow of slowly losing everything…

Abandoned in a tiny cage, in the darkness, lost and forgotten…for a thousand years.

The song changed again, becoming sweet and innocent.

Then a brilliance illuminated her heart, as her new life began in the far future.

The radiant glow of hope…of love…encapsulated her, strengthened her in ways she only came to understand as she matured. As a new song drew her further into the flames, an invitation to accept herself as she truly was.

As she reached for it…rage hot and unrestrained burned her soul. The sharp thrusts of spite and bitterness cut deep into her. As resentment and heartbreak shattered her completely. She recoiled from the flames and was left gasping and choking for air. The song built up into a terrible crescendo, beating against her chest, as unrelenting and unmerciful as those lonely, rage fueled years had been.

Unworthy, unwanted, useless…broken…so tired of fighting… why….why…why was I never good enough…why…am I always alone?

As the tumultuous memories of a troubled childhood within the Horde bombarded her. Adora's betrayal as she abandoned her again and again over all those years. Until she finally gave up on her, cut the ties of their now, rotted and frayed bond. Sought to claim power for herself at all cost and in doing so spiraled out of control, until she struck rock bottom. All that she was, all that she fought for, all that she thought she wanted was meaningless. As she was now completely and utterly alone. With her heart rotting from despair and drowning to her hopelessness. She had destroyed it all!

She wept for all that she had lost and craved death…just to end her suffering…

Catra curled up tight, drawing her knees up to her chest. Tail curling around her legs as she tucked herself up into a tight, impenetrable ball, seeking to protect herself from the never ending agony that had been her life after Adora.

The once violent melody turned somber and echoed with a sense of hope.

A comforting warmth ignited, coursing through her and around her. She gasped and took a deep breath as her body began to relax, slowly uncurling. As the memories of her rescue, her redemption and her first real kiss washed over her.

Trust…true friendship…forgiveness…

Adora’s hand cupping her cheek, her soft, loving smile…the gentle caresses…that followed.

Her soothing purr, contentment, happiness….rumbled within the song of flames.

A slow harmony, full of sorrow. Discordant and mournful like a dirge for lost souls. Echoed beneath the once happy tune. As she was now plagued by the constant worry and uncertainty as the world changed beyond her ability to cope. The hidden threats now surfacing and the fears of the unknown as magic surged across the planet. The bombardment of hidden threats had followed the defeat of Prime…like a vanguard of doom. So many ugly wounds, deeply scared and never fully healed were like shadows amid the flames.

A low, ominous melody reverberated in her soul…a vibration of warning…

Catra sucked in a breath, curling a fist over her breast where her heart burned. Trembling in fear, blinking rapidly to clear the tears, now cascading down her cheeks as she was now confronted by a treacherous power that lay before her…a destiny uncharted, a legacy unmade…by a laughing skull and then a searing assault upon her soul. A sudden massive burst of flames lunged towards her. A hunter, lying in wait within the pulsing firelight for its prey. The inferno was so swift and deadly, she had no time to react, not even scream. She was instantly consumed by it.

Unable to accept, unable to forgive…unable to let go…All that she was, turned to ash…and faded away into those wild, untamed flames…

Within the Nora inferno..

The first to feel the change was Glimmer, the pressure in the humid air seemed to pop like an explosion, without sound. She was just about to teleport, but instantly refocused upon the sheet of flame burning a few yards before them.

It was the sharp smell of brimstone that alerted Bow, moments before a column of molten flame shot towards Finn. The kitten was kneeling on all fours, their blue eyes staring down at the glass beach beneath them. Frozen in some fugue like state, trapped inside their own mind.

"Finn!" Bow was quick to react. Flipping a pocket open on his utility belt and pulling out a metal clip. Slamming into the underside of his left gauntlet, then cocking his weapon over his head to load it. His crossbow sprang forth from the top of his wrist, as he pointed and then fired at Finn. A ball of light exploded from the barrel, expanding and curving around the kitten. Encasing Finn in a force field, that quickly absorbed the blast. The flames flattened out over the shimmering surface, dissipating as they flowed over the curve of the shield.

Glimmer's battle honed instincts kicked in. As she summoned her staff and then carved a round, magic shield into the air. The lunar glyphs glowing a brillant indigo as she charged and re-enforced the shield. Indigo eyes glaring, towards the inferno where the attack had originated. Searching for the still hidden threat from within the rolling wall of flames.

"What the hell!" Mermista cried, pulling her trident from her back as she moved into a defensive stance.

As Sea Hawk unsheathed his rapier and Orion his long sword.

Catra emerged from the flames, chin held up at an arrogant angle. Striding towards them with an air of smug superiority she hadn't carried since her time as Commander of the Horde. A burning rune shone from the center of her forehead. She wore no

clothes but the coiling flames that enshrouded her body to maintain her modesty. Her short mane crowned her head, alight and burning like a wildfire. Her face was serene, her soft, copper fur glowing from within. Her blue and golden eyes were far more striking than before. Blazing with a furious light so predatory, so threatening it made them all hesitate.

"Catra…" Mermista breathed, in a hushed whisper of pure terror.

Catra cocked her head to the side, as if unable to understand the word Mermista had spoken. Her pointed ear's were upright and quivered with interest, long, serpentine tail lashing and glowing, molten claws fully unsheathed. The sharp tips, alight as if her claws were torches. She resembled a vengeful goddess more than just a mere magicat. Intent on stalking and hunting down her prey and exacting a divine retribution on all who opposed her.

A cold sweat covered Sea Hawk's body as he took in Catra's fearsome, god like appearance. She had become something truly glorious…in her fiery appearance. The immortal flames that had infused with her body was enthralling and yet also so very terrifying at the same time. Sea Hawk swallowed and took a tentative step back. Unsure if he could resist being enraptured by her untamed beauty.

Orion narrowed his eyes, recognizing this woman as the Butcher of Salineas. She must have laid waste to Nora! All this bloodshed and destruction was her fault! His blood boiled and his need for exact retribution screamed inside of him. He raised his sword and charged.

"Butcher!" He howled, promising that he would have her head or die trying. His people would be avenged!

Untethered

Chapter Notes

Sorry, I disappeared for a few weeks. I had to work through several chapter's to get it all together before posting again.
Thanks Pink Storm and LunaTheBlackWolf for your comments.
OH SHIT!!! is very apropos. Thanks to all who left Kudo's, tuck in and enjoy, it's going to be a bumpy ride.

Adora

"I need to go to Nora…my friends…they could be in trouble." Adora kept repeating, in a mumbled, barely conscious haze. As she lay prone on her back, across the Elemental's Guardian's snout. Her body ached, muscles sore and burning. From hours of struggling against the unyielding sea. The tips of her fingers and toes tingle. So stiff she could barely twitch them. Her thoughts were sluggish after nearly drawing. As the adrenaline faded from nearly drowning. Fatigue was soon weighing her down, as her arms and legs dangling over the sides of the serpents slightly upturned nose.

No longer clinging to them but now trusting that they would ferry her safely. The toes of her leather boots dipped in and out of the water, when the beast's snout bobbed up and down. As the massive sea serpent, slithered down the underground river. Navigating with ease around the large clusters of stones that churned the fast moving water. Their sight far superior to hers and capable of seeing clearly in the semi-darkness.

Adora had long since given up seeing any of their features. Due to the murky darkness of the underground tunnel The shimmering glow of their scales and their piercing blue eyes are the only parts Adora could see. She had no idea where they were going, her

consciousness slipping in and out as they traveled. When she came too, feeling waterlogged and groggy. Mumbling anxious, incoherent words yet again. She would crack her eyes open, valiantly trying to track where they were. Finding that they had traveled out of the near darkness of and into a faint half light. Her eyes focused on the mesmerizing reflection of still water above her upon the rough roof of a cave. The crags and ledges overhead, illuminated by glowing blue moss. That had grown like a natural blanket over the curving, water worn walls. She could make out the jagged formations of both stalagmite and stalactite, jutting along the edge of the river they were swimming down. The worn down crags of smooth lava sediment that formed the walls. Roughened by the pillar of stalagmites with fluorescent moss growing upon their crowns and the stalactites dripping water from the roof. A steady crescendo of moisture that made her feel claustrophobic and anxious. She wondered if they were deep beneath the bottom of the vast bay? Or navigating down a subterranean river closer to the surface. Worry gnawed at her, that at any second this narrow corridor would be submerged. A slow, insidious sort of panic that had her chest aching. As she saw the twisting black vines, curled along the walls. Slick and rotting from the sea air. An ancient marker she could now easily find all over Etheria, from when Omega Prime had threatened the planet. Mara had to then contain them on Beast Island. A reminder that the First Ones parasitic weapon was still lurking somewhere and still needed to be dealt with.

She thumped the back of her head against the Serpent's snout, unwilling to allow her mind to derail onto even more anxieties. Forcing herself to remain on mission.

"Where are we?" Adora whispered, her voice low and croaking with trepidation.

(I am currently navigating through a Subterria tunnel, along the coastline.) Ryujin whispers softly.

Adora merely nodded, not really understanding what he was talking about but rolling with it for now. Since her mind was still

too sluggish to comprehend much of anything right now. But the word…Subterria nagged at her. She vaguely recognized that word.

Focusing her gaze upon the long, flickering glow of constellation patterns. Scrawled along the narrow walls of the tunnel. Which was obviously First Ones writing. Subterria…had been built by the First Ones…

"Where are you taking me?" Adora asked, in a slurred mumble. The air was stale and slightly acidic with the taste of salt, coating her tongue. Adora's throat was so dry, it felt like she had swallowed sand. Her lips chapped and cracked from being in the sea for so long. She knew her voice was hoarse and it was painful to talk.

(Nora is…too dangerous right now…the only safe route inland is through these tunnels beneath the sea bed.) Ryujin explained, their clipped, elegant voice bouncing off the long, narrow, earthen walls. In a sharp rebounding echo.

That made Adora cringe and clutch her ears, which were suddenly popping from the air pressure as the Serpent began to ascend upward as the river drew them towards the surface.

Finn

A static hum filled the air, the world around them was vibrating with an incredible amount of magic. Reality was pulsing with the vivid prism glow of temporal portal energies. It was just like when they had first traveled back through the crossroads of worlds to the nexus point within the Whispering Woods. The visual echoes of what once was, what is happening now and the endless possibilities of what may become. Shimmered within the rippling incandescent fabric of the reality surrounding them. Along with the sharp, piercing explosions of other timelines being born. All

branching off from each nexus point of what was and what will be. A collision of temporal chaos, bombarding them from all sides. As if trapped in some cosmic kaleidoscope, one in which they could no longer perceive as they once could. Their magic had become untethered to their home dimension now that it was no more.

Finn clutched their heart, as it was now shattered with grief. The magnitude of their sorrow flowed from their eyes in a torrent of hot tears. Hiccupping and gasping, in shock as the first of sob tore from their throat.. As the raw anguish of loss began crushing them.

Their friends…their family…once speeding away from the ever grown void. Giving them time to change their fate…had been devoured by the Nameless One…they had failed…them.

They where gone…but Finn…Finn remained…

Why…they were supposed to fade too?

Hot tears flowed from their eyes, as misery and shame gripped them. Staring forlorn at a fathomless black hole that spun in place of that reality. Churning beneath them, but not swallowing them. A mercy that both exhilarated and tortured them endlessly. Bruising the fabric of time with an ominous, menacing splotch, a void of nothingness. The low, demonic howl writhing from the event horizon was haunting. As if the voices of the damned, in their final terrified moments as their life force were all devoured. Was permanent etched upon the cosmic singularity, destined to call out their lament for all eternity.

It was both horrific and enthrallng in its dark, all consuming glory. Solid and grim like a grave, yet awe inspiring like a grand cosmic mausoleum. It could draw the eye and hold you prisoner. If you let it, slowly siphoning your soul away as it lulled you, its swirling darkness hypnotizes you.

A predator older than time itself.

Finn could not face it, so they bowed their head in defeat. Turning away and clenching their teeth. They no longer had the strength to endure the sight of it. Blame and loathing burned deep inside of their chest, as bile rose in their throat. Coating their tongue like acid. They felt sick, consumed by a suffocating hopelessness. Frozen and cowering before the unstable chaos that surrounded them. They were no longer sheathed in their child-like body. This world between, striping away their guise and forcing them to exist in their true form. Now fully grown, into a tall, athletically sleek frame. Still wearing their white tank top and black wrap underneath. With the same black shorts and red bandana around their neck. Their long and lanky body hunched over on all fours, retching and trembling. Overwhelmed and nauseous they were on the verge of throwing up. Fluffy blonde tail tucked low between thick, muscular thighs. Dark ears pinned back against their head, with their wild blonde hair plastered down over their cheek with sweat. The shaved side of their head was glistening. Sweat rolled down their spine, staining their tank top like a river, soaking the base of their tail. That hung low between their legs, limp and quivering as they suffered.

Their arms were long and toned, finger's curled into nothing, claws fully extended. Shoulder's quivering as they were heaving for breath. Their head was aching, a sharp pain piercing through the center of their forehead. As if someone had just thrust an ice pick into their brain. They couldn't form a single clear thought, everything was spinning, as if they were trapped in a whirlpool. Dizzy, their sense of balance swaying back and forth. Unable to gather their bearings, in the utter and complete chaos now whirling around them.

A firm, reprimanding tutting whispered in their ear's. Finn slowly raised their face, their skin was sallow and pale. The dusting of pale cornflower blonde fur upon their face was slick with sweat. Their expression was gaunt, staring up at the old woman with weary, hollow blue eyes. Moist with remorse and wide with overwhelming fear. As they were now enduring the torturous repercussion of their actions. Seeking to find mercy towards their plight. Only to confront the stern, yet kind, elderly visage of Razz.

The old woman was crouching down before them. Their pink dress, worn and ratty from eon's of being draped over the boney body. The elderly crone clutched her shawl tightly against her neck, with thin, ancient looking fingers. As if warding off some kind of chill. Her piercing stare was magnified by the thick glasses she wore. Taking in the curled, pathetic ball of magicat before them. Finn looked so frail, so weak…over tired and worn down by time itself.

Razz released a slow, knowing sigh. She had warned them, when she confronted them back on Mystacor. That they were messing with forces beyond their ability to control. Now they must reap what they had sown. It was heartbreaking to see them so scared and confused.

What was, was it and what will be, was a cruel and unyielding magic. She couldn't help but feel pity for the impulsive child. So full of good intentions and such a brave heart…

"Gran, Gran…" Finn croaked out weakly. Their voice had a very familiar rasp, much like their mother's. But lower, more melodic, reminding Razz very much of their biological grandmother…Aoi.

"You kids have been reckless with your magic. So now, you have become untethered, child." Razz cupped the young magicats face tenderly.

Finn merely grunted and hung their head, seeking to block out the chaos around them.

"It will take some getting used to." Razz groaned heavily. As she sat herself down before them. Her old bones complained about the movement. Her voice was soft, full of an uncanny wisdom. Born from countless eon's of being untethered herself. She existed now and forever in every moment that had come and would be in the future. She had gotten used to it…the confusion mixed with moments of sudden clear clarity of who and where she was. She no longer feared the chaos, but embraced it. So too, must this wayward young soul. Lest they become lost forever, their mind

twisted and destroyed by the endlessly complex weave of the Tapestry of Time.

“I’m lost…” Finn huffed, squeezing their eyes shut.

The layered meaning of those words was not lost on the old woman. Who merely nodded her head with a thin, knowing smile of understanding.

“For a time, you surely will be.” Razz offered, raising her arm and calling her broom from the ether and into her hand. The willow branch broom shimmered into existence in her grasp. She laid the oak handle across her lap and began to pluck thirteen willow straws from the head. Her fingers moved deftly as she began to weave.

As the Immortal Weaver, she was already reacting upon the magic that surrounded her. The flow of time was constant and it caressed every facet of her being.

“Will I go mad…like Kei-Lee said?” Finn whimpered anxiously.

“Insanity is not so bad…shifting between the timelines…” Razz shrugged, chuckling ruefully. She came off as slightly unhinged to most, but she felt it was just part of her kooky charm. “Takes some getting used to.” She amended,with a harumph “ But it can also be rather freeing…like being on one grand adventure.” She added, with a kind smile. Her eyes lit up excitedly.

Finn merely blinked nervously up at her, unable to focus for long as the chaos howled around them.

“You must let go…child.” Razz offered, in her simple cryptic phrase. The concept was as much an instruction toward enlightenment.

A salvation Finn was loathed to accept. As it was an epitaph for all that they craved…to leave behind the comfort and security they had just found with their mother’s. It was too hard…they couldn’t do it…they weren’t ready…so they chose to be oblivious instead.

“I don’t understand.” Finn grunted, glaring at their hands now balled up into tight fists. As they struggled to endure the sharp, piercing stabs that seemed to pierce unendingly into their brain.

‘You will.” Razz huffed, her finger’s nimble as she plaited the wicker.

“I failed…” Finn sobbed, their voice a faint broken whisper of complete defeat.

“What was your kids’ plan, then?” Razz asked, patiently. Her finger’s moving swiftly without her looking at them. Weaving the branches in a well practiced, long memorized circular, coiling pattern.

“We knew our universe was going to be destroyed, that after we left Etheria on Darla we were on borrowed time. The Kaydak Crystal had been reformed. The Nameless One was now fully summoned into our dimension and was devouring the unverse. So Horus built a Portal, using his magnetism magic and old first ones tech, harvested from Subterria. It was powered by the magic of Light, Earth/Dream, Water/Fire, Wind/Binding….all that was left of Etheria. I was to enter the portal and use my own magic of Space/Time to cross the dimensions to this timeline and steal the Kaydak shard. I was supposed to disappear…when they did…when my home dimension was sucked into the void. The Kaydak shard in my possession would be destroyed ...when I was devoured by the darkness in my home dimension. The Nameless One would never be able to manifest in this timeline or ever again…because it would have devoured itself in every timeline by destroying a fragment of its summoning stone. “ Finn explained softly.

Razz sighed sadly, what a strange and convoluted plan.

“It’s seems Horus’s theories were wrong. You never faded, when your timeline ceased to exist. But became untethered instead.”

“I didn’t have the shard in my possession.” Finn whimpered. “ Mother took it and…I never found it.”

“She no longer has it.” Razz sighed with bleak resignation.

“Where…” Finn stuttered.

“She has hidden it once again, but it is not sealed. So it is only a matter of time before it is uncovered again by those who can hear its insidious whispers.” Razz grunted, as she knotted the ends of the branches.

“When the Hunter’s moon glows red…I must have it…I have to take it to the oasis.” Finn mused, giving voice to Peekablue's last words to them. As the strange, ominous vision they had in their nightmare began to unwind inside their mind. With access to the Tapestry of Time, that now surrounded them. The magic of time offered them far more clarity than ever before.

(The future must be secured anew) Their meddling had damaged the weave…of this dimension. **(Return what once was stolen.)** Senator Keldor had invoked a fragment of the Nameless One in the shard. Attempting to tame Despara, but C’yra was able to cleanse the darkness. Severing the Nameless Ones influence upon this dimension. Loo-Kee had hitched a ride on Mara’s ship, during the Champion’s last flight heading towards Serenia. He had guarded and ferried the shard to its final resting place, deep underground. The Kaydak shard was then stolen a thousand years later from the Vault ... .hidden within the Subterria Labyrinth beneath what was once the Pixie’s oasis…in the past. Stolen by Light Spinner… **(A bond broken and torn asunder)** When the Kaydak Crystal had been shattered, five thousand years ago. The Nameless One had been banished to the timeless dimension without any way to influence the universe again. In her arrogance and ambition by using the ground up dust of the shard for her summoning. During the Spell of obtainment, Light Spinner once again tainted the crystal dust thus, threading the Nameless Ones influence to this dimension. **(Balance once woven…now knotted and frayed)** Where their cursed whispers had once again begun to taint and corrupt hearts. The shadows of their influence creeping like a cancer over the universe **. (Must be restored…the weave made whole**

once more.) They could see the damage to the threads within the Tapestry…how fragments of them had blackened and rotted. All caused by the Nameless One's slow, insidious corruption. As they seeded discord throughout the universe. The strength of the threads was being slowly frayed, losing their integrity…it was only a matter of time before they snapped…

Finn felt frozen in fear at the very thought of the tapestry unwinding…the absolute destruction of all that was and all that would be was daunting to comprehend.

Razz merely nodded. "You can still fix this, but you must go back to the beginning." she patted them tenderly upon the head.

Finn whimpered in despair under the old woman's sympathetic affection.

"I'm not ready…" They responded in a weak, thready breath. That was full of sorrow and pain.

With an understanding hum, she slipped a wicker woven collar around Finn's neck. Hooking the straw thin knots together to secure the talisman.

As soon as the woven necklace hung around their neck, the nausea ceased. The wicker is warm and pulsing with magic power. Instantly soothing Finn's fear and washing away the pain. The chaos ebbed away, like a tide being pulled back into the ocean. As sanity and order was returned to them.

Finn gasped and rocked back on their hunches, staring in awe at the woven necklace hanging from their neck. It was simply woven into a twisting collar, the threads glowing with a multi-colored hue.
"You….tethered me to Etheria again…" They breathed in wonder.

Razz merely nodded. "The Whispering Willows will keep you safe for as long as you need them."

Finn sniffled, "Thank you, Gran, Gran."

“I guess your time with them is not over, if you choose it. But when it is, when you are ready to finish what you have started, destroy this.” She tapped the wicker collar with a slender, wrinkled finger. “Then, You must let go, lest your mind be ripped apart. When the tides of time take a hold of you once more. You must return to the beginning. You can still save them…you see.” She cupped their chin, tenderly. Then raised a hand up to the pulsing air, wiping her palm across the air as if wiping away a film of dirt from a window.

Finn could finally see clearly again, the strange, pulsing kaleidoscope of time and space had once more become a clear map that they could navigate again.

As a battle scarred landscape shimmered to life within the fragment of reality before them. Finn focused on the shattered, glass fragment of time. Razz was showing them. Long, jagged, scorch marks marred the ground, great ravines of melted glass gouged into the beach. A hellish canvas of war and bloodshed.

As a wall of fire roared along the periphery of the battleground and a fire demon, hovering in the air before three exhausted and worn down warriors. Glimmer stood at the forefront, arms raised. Her clothes were tattered and burned, face smeared with ash. A massive magic shield cast in front of them all. Bow was standing in front of their prone child body, badly burned across his now bare chest. Gauntlets raised, the barrels smoking as his arsenal was running low and so was his battery packs. Mermista was kneeling at the back, encased in a water globe holding onto the blackened, charred corpse of Sea Hawk. There was no sign of Orion, it was as if the man had ceased to exist.

Finn gagged on the bile rising up with his gorge from their stomach. At the brutality, visceral carnage this fire demon had inflicted upon his uncles and aunts. Far too shocked to form words, they merely opened and closed their mouth like a gasping fish. Their body shivered in dread as they recognized the demon.

“Your Mother was unable to allow her shadows to fall behind her and walk towards the sun. She shunned and recoiled from Adarion’s full power. She wasn’t ready….and the magic consumed her.” Razz grimaced sadly.

Adora

When she came again to consciousness, she found herself laying upon dry ground. A large tidal cave surrounded her, the dull roar of the waves whispered from beyond the damp walls of the cavern. Perhaps a grotto would be a better term for where she was. With rough arching walls, cut into the cliff’s the rose outside and above. She could see the sea, out beyond a narrowing crack at the front of the cave. The low tide lapping upon the small stone ledge she found herself laid out upon. The sky was dark, covered in a black cloud of ash. The heat from the inferno burning above, sending a sweltering fog to swirl inside the cave.

Adora groaned and slowly rolled onto her side, raising herself up on sluggish limbs. To stand and languidly take in her surroundings. The rough, water worn walls were slick with salt water. The bottom edges, covered in green slimy moss and seaweed. The water at the mouth of the cave was reflecting, hypnotically against the walls. She could barely make out the faintly glowing etching. Of First Ones script upon the stone. As it crawled up and around the domed roof of the cave. Disappearing into a looming crevasse at the back of the cave, that no doubt led underground beneath the island.

“Where am I?” She breathed, taking note of the narrow hole barely visible at the back of the grotto. The tunnel entrance, hidden amid the jagged stalagmites rising up along the edge of the cave.

(I have brought you inland, to the southern tip of Nora.) Ryujin calmly informed her. (You kept muttering that your friends were there.)

Adora spun around at the sudden sound of the Elemental's booming voice. As the Serpent reared itself out of the water. Now, finding herself standing before the daunting presence of an immense Sea Serpent. Adora shivered in awe as she sensed the immense magical power that rose and fell like the tides across the deep blue scales of its body. The massive length of Ryujin's coils curled around the edge of the grotto, disappearing into the water at the mouth of the sea cave. The entrance now partially hidden behind their vast bulk, would lead back out into the ocean. In the flickering half light, filtering in through cracks in the worn down stone of the cavern roof. The pale light from the overcast sky was scattering over his scales. Adora could finally make more finer details. His scales were very tiny, sparkling with a silver blue hue creating a glittering effect. That was rather mesmerizing. Causing Adora to quickly become mesmerized by how mystical they looked. Quickly shaking her head to clear the spellbinding effects. She sought to take in the rest of the ancient creature. All manner of dull, gray and brown barnacles were attached along his broader, hunched back. The underside of his coils was a lighter blue, covered in wide, flat chitin plates. His dorsal fin is near the end of this tail, sharp and wide like a sharks, the edges marred by barnacles. With four sets of flippers, two longer and larger on top near his ventral plates beneath his sharp chin and two shorter and more slender beneath, where his coils narrowed towards his whip-thin tail. Even the sharp, powerful flutes at the end of his tail were covered in the tiny crustaceans. Illustrating that the Serpent had been wandering the sea's for eon's. His powerful coils were scared from head to tail from many battles. His head was rather small compared to the rippling mass of muscle in the never ending coils of its body. With an elegant and rather delicate looking frill that grew from the sides of his jaw, up and down it's back like a leathery mohawk. The thick dark blue spines trembled, the paper thin, translucent blue membranes vibrating with interest. Long whisker's of silky black quivered from just below his jaw. Long

sharp teeth jutted out from the lower lip of his protruding chin. While deep seated, electric blue eyes shone down upon her with a keen calculating stare. Taking her measure and judging her, all while holding her eyes captive in his rapt, unblinking gaze.

"Ryujin…" Adora breathed, shame coloring her cheeks.

(Aye.) He nodded solemnly.

"Thank you for saving me." Adora bowed her head respectfully.

(Foolish, child. Throwing yourself so carelessly into the waves. Did you honestly believe you were stronger than the ocean?) Ryujin reprimanded with a chuckle, thrusting his chin forward proudly as he laughed.

Causing Adora's face to redden even more.

"Where have you taken me, though." Adora asked, looking around the dimly lit grotto, oblivious to where she was. Watching the reflection of the water dance upon the rough walls. Seeking to read the First Ones writing and perhaps gleaning some understanding. Trepidation, chilling her as she scanned the back of the cave. The ledge she had been deposited upon was just the lip of the cave floor. The layered plates of lava stone receded away into the darkness of the crevasse behind her.

Ryujin cocked his head to the side, confused. (I have taken you to the entrance of the Subterria cluster beneath Nora Island.) He finally answered in a slow, tentative tone. As if she was simple minded.

"Ah, yes…I see.." Adora nodded, rubbing the back of her head. Her acknowledgement sounded rather thin, rather lame.

(I find it hard to believe that you have no memory of this.) Ryujin muttered. (You are the She-Ra…I doubt. I have become feeble minded enough in my advanced years of life to confuse the Magic of I-Lo.)

"Well…I've only been Etheria's She-Ra for a short time…don't really know how to access the memories of the previous vessels… without help. I vaguely remember…Mara came to Salineas…" Adora began, her predecessor's memories floating like puzzle pieces yet to be assembled in the right order.

Subterria… It was part of another project…a plan B of sorts to hide the First Ones from Prime. Who was exterminating them from the Universe. A web of tunnels that spanned the entirety of the planet. Powered by the Heart…full of "Clusters"...habitats in which the descendants of the First Ones could thrive, live and expand beneath the crust. Creating a subterranean civilization….hiding under Prime's nose. Who would believe he had exterminated them, once the top side of the planet was cleansed of all life. The First Ones were not naive, they were resilient and always had contingencies in place to protect themselves above all others.

Ryunjin scoffed and growled, their accusative whispers vibrating menacingly.

(Mara the Betrayer! She seduced my Rune Bearer with a promise of power and solidarity, at a time of great division. When the fear of Prime had the Archipelago tearing itself apart.)

"The pearl…" Adora sighed heavily in shame. "Senator Keldor lied to her…she didn't know what the Heart Project was…she thought she was doing the right thing at the time." she sought to explain, as if Mara's ignorance was repentance enough to exonerate her predecessor.

(Go, enter Subterria, it will lead you to your friends eventually..) Ryujin thrust their snort towards the shadowed cave at the back of the grotto. They were benevolent enough to save her life. But unable to forgive the atrocities Mara had blindly participated in during her time as She-Ra. Adora understood and with a heavy heart she bowed her head.

Ryujin offered her a curt, disgruntled sound. Before briskly departing, turning back towards the mouth of the grotto. Their coils, uncurling from the walls as they heaved their great length back into the open sea. Leaving Adora standing on the moist stones, with no way to follow them. With a resigned huff she turned towards the back of the cavern, where the entrance to the tunnel lay. She had only one way forward and with a nod of acceptance she summoned Despara's sword into her hand and marched into the waiting darkness ahead. The soft amber glow of her sword, illuminating the passage ahead in a brilliant crimson.

Glimmer

They couldn't breath, couldn't see. The thick caustic smoke from the inferno, the demon now controlled. Billowed and rolled over Glimmer's magic shield, a black fog concealing the immense wall of flame. That had encroached upon them on all sides. Roaring just behind the glow of her magic, a predator in wait. Prepared to leap and consume them, the second Glimmer's magic weakened.

As they were now sealed within a death cage of their own creation. Cowering in fear beneath the dome of magic, to slowly suffocate in the searing heat. Glimmer's chest hurt, it was hard to draw breath. She could hear the faint wheezing of Bow struggling to take in air. As he stood stoic beside her, keen brown eyes staring with an archer precision through the smoke beyond the barrier. Gauntlets raised and searching blindly for the demon.

Bow had called to Catra, pleaded to her to stop, to wake up…

As she called down a pillar of fire from the sky and shot it towards Orion. As the man charged towards her, vowing to kill her for what she had done. He barely made two strides. Before he was engulfed in flame. His death screams were quickly snuffed out as his body turned to ash.

Bow was still refusing to accept that it was Catra.

Their friend…their comrade…their best friend…when she set Sea Hawk aflame. As they all sought to escape a barrage of fire balls, hitting the beach all around them like meteor's. Frantic to get beneath Glimmer's shield after yet another failed attempt to subdue her.

It was easier to believe she had been killed already and what remained was just an animated corpse, a puppet driven by some wild, unquenched hunger to destroy…to consume and devour everyone and everything that surrounded her.

Bow was desperate to find a way to save them, grasping upon a now very thin hope that they could get out of this alive.

Mermista made a small noise, a mixture of a choking sob and clearing her throat to quell the tremor in it.

"What the hell are we going to do?" She moaned, head bowed, holding Sea Hawks burned and blistered body against her chest one last time. He had succumbed to his burns a few minutes ago, taking his last rattling breath. He couldn't speak, the blast of fire he had endured had melted his vocal cords. The intensity of the flame burning his whole body to a blackened char as the inferno rolled over him.

Unable to speak, to tell her how much he had loved her, how she had made his days worth living. He had just stared up at her, where his head had been resting on her lap. His final moments, spent staring adoringly up at her with his one remaining eye as the light slowly ebbed away.

Mermista sniffled, as she set Sea Hawk's limp head upon the ground. Refusing to give into her grief just yet, knowing that when she allowed the misery to take hold. It would crush her…

The Demon had killed her brother minutes before, incinerating him before he could reach her. Leaving only burning ash to spark and ignite the air as it drifted to the ground.

From that moment on, the battle had been pretty one sided. If it wasn't for Glimmer's shield they would all be dead.

"Can you send a wall of water at her?" Bow offered, chucking a thumb over his shoulder at the sea behind them. The beach had become enshrouded in fog, as the heat evaporated the water along the coast. Mermista had been drawing water from the vapor for her attacks. But she was loath to ever draw from the sea itself.

She would fling sea life to their deaths as well as the water. It wasn't an option…ever.

She merely scowled and shook her head, biting her lip to keep it from quivering. She felt hopeless, defeated. Coughing and stumbling up to her feet, she moved closer to Glimmer.

"What the hell happened to her?" She rasped out.

The high pitched, menacing cackle echoed threateningly from within the smoke. Followed by the concussive blast of several beached trawler's exploding. The shrapnel of metal and wood rocketed down upon the shield, like thousands of rocket propelled missiles.

Glimmer clenched her teeth and grunted in pain, as she felt every impact. Muted and dulled by the protection of her magic but her shield was still connected to her body. So she still felt every attack in some way.

The hatred and spite vibrating in that familiar laugh was tangible. It was as if the old Catra had been reborn. Now hell bent on vengeance. Spurned by the unbridled fury that defined her at that time. Her gleeful laughter as she destroyed the world around her, a merciless, harbinger of doom.

"I don't know…but…" Glimmer swallowed hard, staring at the smoky haze encasing the bubble. Deep down, a foreboding guilt was eating away at her insides. Whatever had happened to Catra…it was her fault. Dread and a grim conviction began to

surge inside her chest. Their conversation on the skiff on their way here, pounding in her head like an epitaph.

"You guys don't stand a chance against her and…I am not losing anymore friends." Glimmer's indigo eyes had darkened, a storm was brewing inside the queen. Resolute in her coming actions, fortified by her unyielding determination, to always protect others from evil.

It tore her heart to shreds, to ever associate evil with Catra again…

She had both hands up to reinforce the shield. The last time she conjured a shield of this size during their final battle with Primes forces. She had her aunt Casta there to help her.

She needed to get everyone out, desperation and selflessness spurned her magic. Without thinking, she pulled her left hand away from the shield. Fueled by the intention to keep them safe and the purity of her love. Four tether's of light shot out from her glowing fingertips.

"Wait…!" Bow cried in alarm. As the tether coiled around his waist.

Mermista sucked in a startled breath as another tether wrapped around her golden plated wrist.

"What are…" Mermista stuttered out, breathless and shocked.

The two remaining tether's wrapped around Sea Hawks corpse and Finn's prone form. Then in a flash of light they were all teleported away.

Leaving Glimmer alone and steadfast upon her course to fulfill her promise.

She brought down her shield in a crisp downward wave of her hands. It flickered and faded, allowing the burning black fog to swirl before her eyes. She didn't have much time, the intensity of

the heat bombarding her now was like walking through a wall of flame. The smoke was searing her eyes and breathing was a futile effort. The air was far too acidic and with no oxygen to take in. Her chest trembled and her sight was growing dimmer. But she stumbled forward, determined to find Catra and end this!

Lament

Chapter Notes

> Thank you PinkStorm, LunaTheBlackWolf and Pointlessly Poetic for your comments.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer

All around her, as she moved deeper into the raging inferno. Was the flaming wreckage of ships. As the waterfront had turned to vapor. Leaving a blackened and charred field of boats beached on their sides. The bulky fishing trawlers, marooned in strange haphazard ways upon the crumbling ledges of blackened coral reefs. Their dredging nets are fully released, still attached to tall winches upon their stern's. Draped like massive spider webs across the barren seabed behind the vessels. She noted briefly, to her dismay. The charred remains of fishermen scattered over the back decks. Blackened skeleton's hanging off the back railings, or tossed overboard to lay sprawled amid their nets. They had no doubt been knocked unconscious by the concussive force of the blast, before being drowned or burned alive by the inferno that washed over the harbor next. Grimacing in sorrow at the gruesome sight, Glimmer heaved a steadying breath. Refocusing upon her winding route through the labyrinth of boats. Preparing herself for the brutality of seeing even more carnage deeper into the harbor.

Leaving the trawler behind her, as slightly larger, more streamlined merchant schooner's and grand tall ships rose around her. Sat half buried into the shoreline, masts ascending into the black sky like matchsticks. Their wooden mast's shattered and broken, spearing the dried up ocean floor. The thick wooden poles set a flame,

huge sails shredded and fluttering like torn butterfly wings quickly burning away to ash.

Moving further inland, through the narrow corridors of smashed heaps of gravely damaged vessels. Glimmer realized grimly where they had teleported…what they had thought was the beach. Was just the dried up sea bed of Nora's harbor. As the remains of the massive piers now loomed around her, the firelight casting frantically dancing shadow's across the dried up sea bed. That flickered and leaped over the shimmering glass surface of the scalded ground. Making the surroundings even more eerie and apocalyptic, as she walked beneath the pier.

The dried out wooden planks above her head. Crackled and sparked overhead. While the thick waterlogged posts below, that had once been submerged, hissed as she weaved amongst them. The sudden and intense heat of the inferno boiling the water trapped within. Glimmer offered the sputtering steam, oozing out of the newly forming cracks in the post she just passed. A tentative glance. Suddenly worried that the supports beneath the deck was going to explode, due the pressure building deep inside. This whole place was just a ticking bomb, capable of raining down sharp, wooden shrapnel upon her head.

Glimmer swallowed hard as she surveyed the complete devastation that surrounded her. The hulls of the ships near the beach were all caved in. Dashed against the jagged rocks that lined the shoreline. Due to the catastrophically powerful explosion that had rocked the bay. Their slumping decks trapped within the rocks were partially touched by the fire. Fetid spark's floated like glowing coals in the air, cast upon the hot wind. She kept a close eye on those floating coals, as she navigated through the rocks, up onto the beach. Having already seen how dangerous they are. When the glowing embers touched down on fresh wood they would rip back into flames, consuming the rest of the ships that surrounded her, in a roaring bonfire that quickly turned it all to ash. Which could easily be her, if a spark touched her. So she kept vigilant as she deftly weaved herself through the rocks, unwilling

to touch them as they were all glowing a pulsing red. No doubt super heated.

All the while, Catra's teasing cackle and mischievous giggles serenaded her. Like a ghoulish specter from within the inferno. Always out of reach, hidden within the hellscape of the burning harbor. Sending every one of her survival instincts into overdrive.

"Spaaaaarkles…" Catra called teasingly from some unknown perch within the flames. "Death sits upon a throne here…" The feline mused, absently. Her voice rising and falling in an odd unhinged, sing song.

Glimmer had known that Catra was not in her right mind anymore. Ever since she reappeared, with her incredibly enhanced magic. Which only made her more deadly, more unpredictable.

Since leaving the security of her shield. Glimmer knew she was being hunted. Could feel the demon's eye's on her back, sense her presence lurking just beyond the wall of flames. Every time Catra called out, Glimmer would jolt and turn in a circle, searching for her. Her body coiled and ready to fight. Holding her staff against her chest in a death grip so tight her finger's ached.

"A strange city…of Sea Shells…scattered like broken bones." Catra whispered forlorn, then cackled madly. Catra's voice was off, a strange echo of something or someone else hovering within her tones.

The sudden laughter was unnerving and had Glimmer's heart pounding in her chest. As she made slow, tentative steps through the wreckage of several beached sloops. Trying to stay hidden, by weaving herself between the fluttering sails. The heavy canvases were slightly dragging near the melted sand from bent and twisted metal masts.

Glimmer could sense it, an ancient power vibrating within Catra's voice. She was definitely being possessed. Which only fortified

Glimmer's determination to save her!

"The worst and the best…have all gone to their eternal rest." Catra whined, as if saddened by the prospect of so many lives lost. The flicker of empathy in her tone was unmistakable.

Glimmer swallowed, slowly formulating a plan. Wondering if perhaps there was a chance to get through to her, save her from whatever or whomever had possessed her. She had done it before, cast out the dark magic from her father. She could do it again…

It was now her turn…to Save the Cat!

Every now and then, Catra's voice would taunt her. Sometimes hissing very close as if she was hovering just over her shoulder, making her jump and run for cover.

"Elidor! It seems I have slept for far too many hours…This world resembles nothing that was ours?" Catra added with a long drawn out, anguished moan. That carried upon the wind like a whisper. "All is gone…all is lost…" Catra lamented in a low, keening wail.

Then silence, heavy and foreboding…silence…

That seemed to drag on for eternity, leaving Glimmer disoriented amid the walls of flames, without a voice to follow. She had wanted to end this quickly, but it seemed Catra was just playing with her. The smoke was choking her, making her cough roughly as it burned her lungs. Her eyes were watering, not just from irritation. But from a slow, building frustration. She was scared and unwilling to confront the grim reality of the situation. That she could be very far out of her depth here… the doubts and deadly consequences of this confrontation. Always rearing its poisonous head in the back of her thoughts. Striking her heart like a viper, making her chest ache with the mounting grief of the inevitable. No matter how hard she tried to stay positive. She hated how helpless she felt, trapped in a no win scenario in which there was a possibility that she may have to kill her best friend…or

die trying. She hadn't felt this terrified and desperate since the Heart was set off for the first time. When it was draining not only her magic, but her life as well. Killing every last one of the Princesses, in the most slow and insidiously painful manner possible.

Sometimes, Glimmer could hear Catra singing, humming some otherworldly, jaunty tune from far away. As if she was merely whistling a merry song, while walking through somewhere beautiful and not this tragic hellscape. Proving to Glimmer as she scanned the burning ruins around her, that her friend may well be long gone. Her mind now twisted by the magic that had consumed her. She wasn't corrupted…Glimmer was well versed in sensing that kind of dark magic. It had clung to Shadow Weaver like the rancid stink of decay, her father too had the musty smell of the grave upon him. When he had been controlled by Prime, forced to once more tap into that darkness. Scaring more of him the process, leaving marks not only upon his arms but his face as well. They were faded now, but still the faint discoloration of decay remained upon his skin.

Then there were those long stretches of silence, where it was as if the feline had dissipated into the fiery ether. A stillness in the air, that sent Glimmer's nerves right over the edge. Making her feet move more quickly, jumping at every crackle and snap of the burning wood, desperately searching for cover of any kind.

Fear running cold through her veins.

The trauma of watching Catra rein hellfire down upon them all. Incinerating Orion in an instant when he charged at her. Then burning Sea Hawk alive….as he had been so spell bound by her godlike appearance. He never moved fast enough to get under Glimmer's shield in time. The brutal ferocity of her attacks and the sheer magnitude of her power. Was beyond comprehension. It left Glimmer trembling with a sense of foreboding that her life was very much forfeit.

“Resigned to my fate…to be cast aside and forgotten…by my mate…” Catra’s voice was low, miserable. Sounding as if her heart was breaking.

Glimmer could not make head or tails of what she was saying… but her chest started to hurt…a burning ache in her heart responding to Catra’s sadness.

Glimmer rubbed her chest over her heart with her fingertips, attempting to soothe the pain. Glimmer cleared her throat, refusing to be distracted by the sudden clenching in her chest.

As Catra was stalking her with the patience of an ancient predator. She was no doubt laying in wait somewhere nearby for her to get close enough to pounce.

“Come and play…Sparkles.” Catra’s voice cooed, tauntingly, over the crackling roar of the inferno.

Glimmer snapped her head to the side.

Catra’s voice had come from just to the left of her location.

With a startled yelp, Glimmer instantly changed course to avoid where she thought she was hiding.

Darting away down a side corridor of flaming ruin. As another more intense wave of doubt crashed over her. She had entered the wall of fire to confront Catra, having delusions of some grand final battle of wills. In which she was able to finally reach out and get through to her. Wake her up, pull her from whatever power was controlling her, forcing her to kill her friends…save her… When in reality she was just running blind and at a definite disadvantage. Against a hybrid, who now laid claim to the magic power of a god, whose senses were all far superior than hers.

Glimmer shivered…her courage wilting, knowing she was merely prey…

“Boo!” Catra’s fierce toothy grin exploded from the smoke just above her. Leering down inches away from her face. As the feline was crouched upon the very tip of the jib’s boom, at the bow of a beached Merchant Schooner.

Glimmer screamed, raising her staff above her head in a warding gesture as she frantically leaped backwards then jogged away to the right. Spurned by fright, fearing for her life. With her pulse slamming against her neck and every muscle burning with adrenaline. She ran past an iron bulkhead of a cargo freighter. That was overheated and burning red. The metal hull of the ship was smoldering, the rivets squealing as they readied themself to pop from their housing. Shooting out like a rain of bullets towards her as she ran past. Squealing again she spun her staff to defend herself, backing up without looking behind. As the bolts clanged harshly off the long handle of her staff. Dinging the metal and scratching it up, as they ricocheted back towards the smoke. Without realizing it, she was retreating backwards into a narrow passage of burning tall ships. The black smoke clogged the haphazardly made corridor making it impossible to see.

It was far too late before Glimmer realized that Catra had been herding her into a dead end. Darting her eyes around frantically, she found herself boxed in.

Tamping down her panic, Glimmer took a couple deep breaths. Squaring her shoulder’s for the inevitable fight to come, hoping against all odds that she could figure out a way to save Catra. She needed to purge Catra of that magic, just like she did for her father during the rebellion’s last battle.

Catra needed her!

Last minute saves…

The Best Friend Squad was known for them.

She could do this!

The little pep talk gave her reassurance that she would prevail.

With new found confidence, the Queen Bright Moon's eyes steeled once more with firm resolve.

"I know you're still in there…" Glimmer called back, her head on a constant swivel. Heart hammering in her chest, knowing how sly and cunning Catra can be when she is hunting someone. Having narrowly survived far too many one on one battles against her in the past.

"I'm not giving up on you, Catra…! " Glimmer shouted defiantly into the silent smoke. Charging the moonstone starseed, embedded into the star shaped emblem set at the bottom of the circular crown at the top of the staff. The smaller fragments of moonstone, encrusted upon the staff, began to glow as well. As she prepares to defend herself.

She was trapped, with her back against the wide burnt out stern of a massive Galleon. It rose behind her like an intricately carved tower of hardwood. The stained glass of the windows of the Captain's cabin was cracked and partially shattered. The wooden shutters, hanging loose and clapping against the window frames as the hot wind howled up from further inland. Where the core of the inferno raged.

The pine masts had all been broken, as the weight of the ship crashed into the sand. Falling over the back of the ship like logs perched up at odd angles for a bonfire. The rigging's groaned and clanged amid the tangled shroud's hanging limply over the stern. Webbing above her head within the masts speared into the sand. The enormous hinged rudder was half buried, jutting out like a ramp below the smaller windows of the crew quarters. As the rest of the ship's decks receded out of view, behind the looming stern.

Glimmer was caged into a small open area between the wrecks of several other tall ships. Smaller in comparison to the Galleon, but no less elegant even in their ruined state. Their many broken masts have fallen like kindling around her. She was hidden within a maze of a ship graveyard. With only seconds to decide what course she was going to take.

Attack or defend?

As she had nowhere to go, no means of escape.

The soft crunch of claws scraping against the fine pebbles of sand, announcing Catra's slow march towards her. Had her heart ramping up and her magic vibrating against her skin. Surging from the depths of her soul to protect her.

"You gave up on me a long time ago…you left me…Elidor!." Catra snarled, lunging from hiding behind a shattered pole of a mizzen mast from a nearby Schooner. Appearing like a bolt of lightning out of the wall of flames consuming the wooden masts scattered around the periphery of the battle ground. Glowing eyes burning with madness and fury. Flaming claws outstretched to sink into her flesh, sharp canines barred and ready to rip out Glimmer's throat. Catra's agility was unmatched, tightly packed muscles in her legs propelled her out of the smoke towards the Queen of Bright Moon like a fast drawn knife.

Unable to move fast enough to raise a magic shield against Catra's sudden, explosive assault. Glimmer could only recoil and scream in terror. As the fiery Demon grappled her to the ground, pinning her down. Her vicious smile gleaming inches away from her face as she snapped her sharp teeth inches away from her nose. The heat of the flames that enshrouded Catra's body, were quick to engulf what remained of Glimmer's clothes. She was set ablaze in an instant.

On impulse Glimmer teleported, her body shimmering out of Catra's iron grip.

"I never left you…" Glimmer professed, her voice soft, confused.

As Catra snarled in frustration as her prey disappeared.

"You disappeared for over a thousand years….only to reappear and act as if nothing had happened?" Catra hissed, pausing her rant. Only to sniff the air and then grin excitedly. Her fang's glistening in the firelight of the burning wreckage that surrounded

them. Turning to sneer over her shoulder, finding Glimmer had reappeared several yards away. Nude and now tangled overhead in the thick ropes of the schooner's shrouds. That webbed across the expanse between the Main and Foremast of the ship. Writhing and bucking in absolute terror, as she was knotted and helpless.

"Aww ... .how sweet to wrap yourself up like a present for me." Catra cackled, as she ran on all fours towards her. Climbing the taller, main mast. With a predatory gleam in her eyes. "I am going to take my time, unwrapping you." She mused triumphantly.

Glimmer fought desperately against the knots of the thick ropes, grunting and rolling attempting to free herself. As Catra closed in, sinking her claws into the wood. The malicious crack and snap of the wood as she closed in, fueling Glimmer's panic.

She was going to die!

At least that was what the Queen wanted Catra to think.

As Catra leered over her, having crawled up onto the shrouds herself. Glimmer's hands began to glow with light, she cut the ropes securing the shroud to the two masts. As gravity took hold and they fell. Catra yelped in alarm at the sudden turn about.

As the predator becomes prey!

Glimmer rolled forward, wrapping the netting on top of Catra as they fell. The heavy iron pulleys, still partially attached to the yardarm, wrapping around Catra's torso and pinning her arms to her sides. As they slammed hard into the packed sand below.

"You think I was actually going to make this easy for you?" Glimmer taunted, with a triumphant grin, as the cloud of soot settled around them. Straddling Catra's hips and holding her down as she struggled.

Hissing and snarling like a feral beast, her long tail lashing like a fiery whip beneath her.

Catra was bound tight, she was trapped.

She was at the Queen's mercy…

Reluctantly going limp under Glimmer when she realized that it wasn't just the nets holding her in place but a magic barrier as well.

She was scared!

She was locked and bound…inside a cage. The absolute terror that ripped through Catra was beyond measure.

Countless hours of 'correction', so many years of pain…tortured by the cruel, unmerciful hands of another…magic user…who had power over her…darkness…fear…weakness…spite and rage…all building and rebounding inside of Catra like powder keg ready to explode!

Catra's flared a brilliant white. Her defiant glare flashing menacingly up at Glimmer through the spaces between the ropes. Promising her pain, promising her a slow and agonizing death. With her sharp teeth gnashing, she hissed and spit up at Glimmer, refusing to submit!

"Your mine now…Catra." Glimmer huffed, out of breath and amazed her impulsive ruse had worked.

Then a desperate, agonizing howl erupted from the very air, all around them. The vibrations, tremoring the loose sand beneath them. Glimmer had no time to react, her eyes widened in horror as she opened her mouth in a silent cry of alarm. As a colossal burst of flame, flared up from inside Catra's body. So radiant and all consuming, as if the Sun itself had been born from inside the feline's chest. The white hot heat engulfed them both, turning them both instantly into ash. The solar flare, fed upon the ruins of the coast. Growing larger and more out of control, as it moved

further inland. Incinerating everything in its path, its hunger never quenched as it devoured the entirety of Nora. Then it vaporized the water and all life within the bay including all those who believed they might be spared upon their boats, so far out from the island. As the mighty inferno born from fear, from loneliness and grief and rage. Jumped to the rest of the three sisters. Turning each island into a blackened waste land. It's hubris spurning it to try to dominate the vast ocean beyond. But unable to sustain itself as the depth quickly engulfed its flames and swallowed them beneath the churning waves.

As a grim serenity returned to the archipelago.

Adora

She had been walking for a long time, moving both deeper into the island and also further below the surface. The tunnel seemed endless, stretching onward and onward without branching out. The walls were damp, moist roots twisted along the walls. Spearing themselves into the narrow corridor, from beyond the metal walls. Merging the First Ones habitat to the earth itself. The simple architecture of the hallway was familiar. Entrapta had led them all down into a Subterria tunnel very similar back on Beast Island. When they were trying to find a way to the server room without being detected by Crita and her mutant militia. Only to find Omega Primes living tomb instead.

She followed the dimly lit glyphs, her sword's amber light cast before her. The wet air slowly grew stale and dry, as she figured she left the sea behind and moved further inland. Her wet clothes had long since dried and her loose blonde hair had become wild and frizzy from the dry air.

Time passed, with the steady echo of her boots upon the metal floor and the empty corridor stretching ahead. The endless

hallway slowly sank her once alert awareness into an agonizing lethargy, as there was no end to this tunnel. It was as if she was traveling down to the very center of Etheria!

Her mind began to wander, traveling down bleak avenues of thought. Wondering how the others were fairing above? Worrying and berating herself about being separated from them. When obviously they needed her! Her silent reprimands, eased into a sad melancholy. As she began to talk to herself, seeking to ease the eeriness of the silence.

"Once again, I got myself into a mess…" Adora groaned, rolling her eyes in annoyance at herself, as she kept walking. "When will I learn…I am such an idiot! " she moaned. "Why didn't you stop me, Catra!" She chuckled, thinking of her true love. Knowing that when she got back to her side, the feline would have some sharp words with her. She would deserve every one that awaited her. She was even looking forward to pleading her case, just to infuriate Catra more. As she was just so cute when she was furious. Then Adora promised she would spend numerous days making it up to her. Fantasizing about all the sweet, tender ways she would make love to her. Eager to start gathering gifts and small trinkets from all the ports they would visit next. Until she would finally be forgiven for her recklessness….

"What was I thinking…why did I go out there…now I'm wandering down some dark tunnel to nowhere. " Adora groused, stomping her boots as she brooded.

As the faint light of the glyphs faded and then winked out completely. Leaving her with the pale red glow from her sword to navigate through the darkness.

She reached out to Despara, to Sheana, through her magic. Desperate and hopeful that they might respond, aid her more than just offering her small fragments of She-Ra's magic. But as always since the Crimson Waste, she found only their comforting presence and nothing more. It was as if they were sleeping…still healing…still gathering strength.

“Great…just great…” Adora growled, she made it two more steps before she sensed a sudden surge of incredible amounts of magic. Exploding above her, miles away. It was so raw and out of control she cried out in pain, falling to her knees. It left her whole body vibrating with the intensity of it. The magic coursing over her limb’s like an abrasive static charge. She remained out of breath and panting for a long time, as she felt the magic rampaging above her.

“What the hell is happening…” She moaned, struggling to her feet and jogging forward at a brisk pace. Ignoring how much her skin was stinging.

She needed to get out of here!

The journey seemed endless and Adora was getting very angry. At this tunnel! At herself…at the perpetual delay she had to endure to get to the battle she knew was raging above her!

The descent finally ended, as she entered a junction of three corridors. She spun in a quick circle, choosing the corridor that looked like it was ascending upward.

So focused on finding a way up, she stopped looking around. Ignoring obvious doorways and junctions to other halls. As she sprinted, choosing only the passageways that rose upward, intent on getting to the surface as quickly as possible. Eventually it became clear that she was traveling closer to the surface. The glyphs became more alive. No longer glowing a brilliant sea green, powered by the magic here within the sea. But a vivid, orange, pulsing and flickering like a fire.

Then another wave of burning magic washed over her, the concussive force slamming into her like tank fire. Adora screamed, falling to the floor and curling up in pain. Her whole body felt as if it had been set ablaze! The searing energy washes over her like a tidal wave of pure agony. After taking several deep breaths, she managed to get her heart to slow down and ease the panic. Uncurling slowly, as her body now ached as if she had just been

She-Ra for a long time. It was unnerving and scary. But she quickly compartmentalized the fear. She was so much more attuned to the magic that surrounded her now.

She had to deal…she had no choice…she did not have She-Ra anymore to help mitigate the intensity of the magic. So she had to figure out how to endure the pain the magic caused when her body was absorbing it. Perhaps use this ability to channel the magic of Etheria…through her human body…like Mara did?

"I need to get out of here!" Adora screamed, scrambling to her feet and running up the corridor. The tunnel became horrendously hot, the walls burning a bright red. The metal looked as if it was melting? The glyphs oozed and warped as the metal heated up. Adora could barely keep her feet, moving as swiftly as she could to keep the soles of her leather boots from scalding the bottom of her feet.
"Fuck..fuck…fuck!!!" She shouted in a clipped staccato, raising her sword higher and drawing more of her magic to illuminate the corridor further.

Finally the corridor even out again and widened into a horizontal cavern. The ceiling was higher, ascending out of view into darkness. As there was still barely any light. Triangular doorways were set into the walls, one in front and two on either side. The one on the left that would lead her back down into Subterria, the one to the right she had know idea where it went and the front one. That looked to continue upward. She never hesitated, racing across the small junction and up the corridor.

In time the metal once more disappeared as she entered into an earthen tunnel.

Stalactites thrust downward from the roof, hanging ominous inches above her head. While stalagmites jutted from the floor, like the teeth in the lower jaw of some long dead beast. She dismissed her sword, knowing it was only going to get in the way. Then proceeded to navigate into the natural maze. The pillars of rock greatly slowed her down, as she now had to squeeze herself

between them. Shuffling and cursing her way forward at a snail's pace. She would snag her elbows and knees along the rocky outcropping, scraping up her arms and legs. As she stubbornly pushed herself through very narrow gaps between them. "This sucks, this sucks, this sucks…" She hissed, feeling blood soaking into her white shirt and gray pants from numerous wounds. Grunting and cursing, she squeezed past yet one more tightly pressed formation. Heaving a breath of relief once she slipped to the other side. There was natural light, flooding down just ahead and to the right. She adjusted her course and continued the torturous journey. Just when she thought she had reached the entrance, she was met with the largest road block ever.

A massive stalactite, growing at an odd angle across the tunnel.

"You have got to be kidding me!" She screamed to the heavens. Furious and not paying heed to the precarious position the natural barrier had created by fusing itself to both the roof and ceiling of the tunnel.

Fueled by a white hot rage and utter desperation, a blood curdling battle cry erupted from her throat as she recalled Despara's sword into her hand and swung. Smashing the stalactite to bits, as the blade cut clean through. Setting off a dire chain of events, the tunnel began to rumble as she destroyed the pillar that was keeping it intact.

"Idiot!" Adora bellowed, running through the now crumbling tunnel. Pumping her arms and legs as she desperately stayed ahead of the collapse. Ducking and weaving through the more sparse earthen pillars in this never ending passageway. As the tunnel into Subterria, fell into itself behind her with a thunderous roar.

It took only moments for the rumbling of fallen earth to fade away and to find herself once more in another cavern. Smaller, less clustered with rock formations, the roof above held in place by roots now. But still faintly lit from narrow cracks in the earth high

above. Her hope that she had found her way out was quickly dashed, when she realized she was still several hundred feet below the surface.

Trapped inside a large burrow, dug out by an animal or several animals perhaps? To house them all during the Storm Season's no doubt. Empty and abandoned now but the earth was still freshly moved?

With a tired, resigned groan she hung her head and trudged forward. Heading towards the narrow tunnel that the animals would use to enter the burrow. She dispersed Despara's sword as it reappeared upon her wrist as a Silver Gauntlet. Then crouched down and crawled through the small opening and disappeared into the earth.

As the hours passed, the magic above faded until only silence remained. A hauntingly eerie calm hanging above her was unsettling. She moved unerringly upward, through the natural passages. Pushing through narrow fissures in the rock. Crawling through a tunnel barely large enough for her now. Her clothes were soon caked in dirt and soot, as ash clung in the air.

Navigating only by the sparse beams of light, that filtered in through the cracks in the earth around her. With single minded determination, Adora continued to push herself upward. through the ever narrowing channel.

Her mind receded, falling deeper and deeper into herself. Focus drawn to a pinpoint, as she tunneled upward, scraping and digging at the earth when the channel pressed too tight against her. Pulling and ripping away roots to make her passage large enough to accommodate her body. It was slow, tedious work but she finally made it to the surface. The thin layer of clay she had been digging at fell away. Wiggling and squirming out of a barren, lifeless hillside, as if the island itself had just given birth to her.

Adora tumbled out of the hole and out into the open air, in shock. The wind howled around her, hot and fetid with smoke. Her eyes stung and nose ached as she retched and struggled to draw in fresh air. The light was muted, as a heavy black cloud bank had rolled in blanketing the sky. Adora felt faint, after struggling for so long. She forced herself to her feet and staggered a couple steps and then pitched forward onto her face. Her body was so overworked, the muscles were spasming with exhaustion and unable to carry her weight.

The coarse, dry dirt scoured her face, like a scrubbing pad but she was too tired to care. Needing to take a moment to gather herself she sluggishly rolled herself over onto her back and leaned up on an elbow to take stock as to where she had emerged.

Her breath caught in her throat, her chest tightened and trembling. As she slowly, agonizingly slowly. Took in the absolute devastation of the island. There was nothing…nothing left.

Just scorched earth that stretched out to the horizon. The sight of the blackened and barren wasteland, devoid of all life. Was hard to comprehend, so horrific and all consuming was the destruction. It left her slack jawed, numb, her face blank in shock, at least for a moment. Then the sheer magnitude of the life alerting event struck her like lightning. Silent tears flowed down her dirty, scraped up cheeks, as she was slowly crushed by her sorrow and shame.

This was all her fault…they were dead…everyone and everything had been incinerated by the inferno…there was nothing left… nothing…

Her world shattered before her…as crushing despair and self loathing consumed her. Her soft blue eyes dimmed and then turned a bright blood red…

Chapter End Notes

I know...you are all like "Argggghhhh, WTH! " but stay with me!

Entanglements

Chapter Notes

> Thankyou PinkStorm and LunaTheBlackWolf for your comments. I really enjoy reading them! I updated, it's your turn Pointlessly Poetic. (LOL) Update when your ready, I am just eager to read more of your fic's. So ok, back on topic. This Chapter is long and it is intense. There are moments of gore and a big sex scene that starts at the Line break and ends at the Line break. Off we go on the rollercoaster of emotions, keep your arms and legs tucked in at all times and do not exit the ride until it comes to a full stop.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The prismatic ether shimmered around them, as Finn stood within the ever shifting realities known as the Cross Roads of Worlds. What was, what is and what will be. In constant flux within this celestial realm of possibilities.

Their lanky, fully grown body had become translucent, like glass. Reflecting the evanescence of light pulsing around them. As they had merged themselves to the timestream. Drawing from their source, The Eternal moon, Davoa. They were no longer on Etheria, so it should not affect Sweet Bee. The current wielder of Time magic. Their own time magic was gone, sucked into the void when the Nameless One devoured their timeline. So when they return to the dimension they were reweaving, they would not be able to access that kind of magic without affecting Sweet Bee in some way. As there can only be one Rune Bearer at a time.

Reaching out with both hands, Finn called upon the other half of their powers, Celestial magic. Sourced from the star’s themselves. It bloomed within them, a flowing warmth, unfurling from their soul. Unfurling from their chest like an eight pointed star, the magic trickling like gentle streams of majestic comets across their body. Spiraling down their arms until their fingertips glowed, with

a brilliant, ethereal light. The sharp points of their claws twinkled like stars as they began to work. Slowly sifting through the timelines, slow and cautious to not upset the flow. The fragile, sparkling threads slipped through their fingers like stardust.

Finn slowly traced the diaphanous strands, from where they began to spool at the edge of the loom of time. Thumbing through the endless layers of alternate timelines, as one would flip through a book seeking a certain passage. Drawn to that particular passage again and again, seeking to reread the precious words that held such significance to them.

With their Celestial magic tethered to Etheria's weave once more. Anchoring themselves to the dimension they had already altered. Finger's lightly glide down the various lengths, over the elaborate knots and elegant twists and turns of time. Taking note of the thickness of the threads from the past, to the foggy, wisp-thin strands of the future. Finger's moving deftly, once they identified the nexus points of the thread from the past. That they wished to adjust the course of, within the endless Tapestry. They began to pick apart the timeline, working backwards. From the moment thing's went to hell. Separating the strings of choices from the thread, woven within the eternal weave. With slow, delicate precision.

"Where did you learn how to weave the tapestry?" Razz asked, hovering over the magicat's shoulder. Scrutinizing their work, with a mixed expression of both wonder and trepidation.

"You taught me, Gran." Finn commented, briskly. Far too focused upon their task to speak in any more detail.

Razz clicked her tongue against the top of her mouth, shaking her head ruefully.

"I guess my sisters were not the only ones to meddle with the Universe." As one of the three sisters. She had been entrusted to watch over the Tapestry of Time.

As the Weaver of realities. To guard it forever, to always walk towards the event horizons and witness the shifting timelines for all eternity. As the eon's passed. The past, present and future became muddled in her ancient mind. She grew tired and just allowed the tides to carry her where she was needed most. Now for the first in eon's, she wondered what would have spurned her to try and re-weave reality? The Nameless One was a terrible force, that is for certain. But it was as natural as any of the other eternal forces. As the antithesis to existence itself. Duality was needed to balance the universe. If there is life, then there must be death. If there is light then there must be darkness, If there is a Sun, then there must be a moon.

For the first time, Razz became curious about how the weave was threading. Furrowing her brow in concentration, a flock of white butterflies sparkled into existence to flutter around her head. As her body turned translucent as well. Her eyes began to glow with the same prismatic light as the ether. Reaching out with her own nimble fingers. She began to investigate the flow of the tapestry as well.

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The crackle of the walls of flames roared all around them, as the battle raged. Each one giving their all, for each and every attack. Unyielding, as they defended. Tears of frustration and rage, mixed with desperation and resolve. Flowed from the eyes of both of them, cast to the air like sparkling raindrops in the flurry of their movements.

As they were both fighting for their lives.

Catra was on the defensive, leaping and twisting her agile body out of range of Glimmer's light bursts. As the Queen teleported

every second to gain ground, to move in close to finish her. She had given up on saving Catra, as there was no hope.

The feline was gone…what she had done was unforgivable and Glimmer was now consumed by her rage, determined to end this and quell the bloodshed before it went beyond Nora.

Catra's flame once enshrouding her body was sputtering, more smoke than fire. The right side of her face was scalded by Glimmer's light attack. Her glowing golden eye swollen shut. The fur singed away and exposed skin beneath, a painful blistering red. She looked worn out, the pupil of the blue eye was a pinpoint. Then it expanded for a brief moment before shrinking again, as if she couldn't focus. A few moments before, Glimmer had destroyed the riggings holding the jib of a Cutter's front sail and the boom had swung into the back of Catra's head. Leaving the magicat dazed and definitely concussed. Now she was standing upon the edge of the forward deck of the Cutter's bow, knees knocking and legs trembling as she was on the verge of collapse. But far too stubborn and spiteful to allow it. Hate and betrayal, fueling her resolve to never lose….to never bow down to anybody! Glancing nervously over her shoulder to the shattered bow spirit, jutting out from the front of the ship. Contemplating, if she could escape. Needing to hide and gather her strength, this fight was not going well anymore as she had lost the advantage.

Glimmer had become an unstoppable force of pure wrath, every teleport, every blast of light had been a strategic barrage that attacked every one of her weak points. Leaving her constantly on the defensive, wearing Catra down to the point of exhaustion.

All love between them was gone, Glimmer's compassion for the magicat had evaporated along with the water long ago. Catra knew if she faltered in any way, Glimmer would end her!

"Ha…missed me!" Catra taunted, breathless and heaving for air. Side stepping and backflipping out of range down the bow spirit.

Leaving Glimmer seething and punching the air back on the forward deck.

“How could you!” Glimmer screamed, her voice pitched high in righteous fury. Her clothes were tattered rags barely clinging onto her body. Her short pink hair was singed near the scalp and standing up in odd, wild angles. She had deep cuts along her arms and legs, from Catra claws. The seeping wounds flowing and dripping off her elbows like a river of red. Blood was smeared across her face, oozing from a gash across her forehead. When Catra had snapped her father’s magic staff, the metal shrapnel sliced into the crown of Glimmer’s head. She didn’t care how wounded she was, it never slowed her down. Driven by the need for vengeance, consumed by the intensity of her hate.

Catra barely made it an inch down the broken pole, before Glimmer teleported right into her face. Both hand’s were glowing with a fearsome light, as she double punched Catra square in the nose. The blinding burst of light exploding from her fists was like a tank blast at point blank range.

Catra cried out in alarm, as her nose broke. Her head snapped back at the concussive force of Glimmer’s attack. Blood spraying the air. As she fell backward off her fragile perch.

“You killed them all!” Glimmer howled, rage had long since dissolved any affection she might have had towards the Magicat. Revenge gnawed at her soul, snarling and spitting inside her heart like a wild beast. She wanted Catra to hurt…she wanted to kill her!

The menacing images of Catra drawing the inferno inside herself. Seconds after killing Orion in cold blood. How the others had all clustered towards her in fear. Except for Sea Hawk who remained mesmerized by the fire goddess Catra had become. He stood several yards away, stiff and staring as if under thrall.
“We gotta go!” Bow had shouted, reaching for Glimmer with trembling hands. He was absolutely terrified and that rocked Glimmer’s confidence. He had always been her compass to gauge

the severity of the terrible situations they found themselves in. If he was this scared, then all hope was lost.

They all looked skyward as a deafening roar howled overhead. Watching in spellbound horror as a massive fireball exploded from Catra's hands. Falling upon them, like an unholy meteor. Capable of wiping them all off the face of Etheria.

Mermista's screams of pure agony, echoing behind her as the water princess had not made it under the shield in time. The fetid smell of burnt flesh soured the air. As Glimmer spun and scrambled to get to Bow's side in time to save him. Only to watch as his skin bubbled. Then all the soft tissue sluffed off his bones like melted wax. Before the raw and gory skeleton he had become, incinerated into ash. All in a matter of seconds. Glimmer was stunned, unable to move let alone look to see if little Finn had survived. She knew she was the only survivor, cowering under the magic shield. Trembling with fear and overwhelmed by sorrow… retreating from the tragedy surrounding her into the white hot rage to even the score. She narrowed her eyes, squinting into the inferno. As tears streamed down her cheeks, leaving wet trails in the soot that covered her skin.

She would end this!

She would end her!

Those gory images of her true love being incinerated alive, taunted and traumatized her. As they were on constant repeat in her mind. The revolting smell of burnt flesh, still fresh and staining her nose. Spurning her on to greater and greater heights of rage.

"You attacked me first!" Catra snarled, landing on all fours upon the loose sand below. As Glimmer teleported inches away from her, a predatory smile of triumph twisting her usually kind features. The flickering fire light of the inferno, casting frantic shadow's over them from the shattered bow. Only made Glimmer's sinister smile look even more ferocious.

Adrenaline was the only thing, keeping Catra on her feet right now. Her heart was slamming against her chest, out of breath, scared and desperate to save herself. The feline ducked low, avoiding Glimmer’s magically charged right hook. Ripping her claws through Glimmer's stomach. The Queen gasped in shock, as her guts released from her abdomen. Pooling upon the ground with a slick, wet sound.

Catra paused for just a second, gloating at her win as she straightened up with a smirk.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes ominously. If she was going to die, then Catra was going to go with her! Just as Catra stood up, she slammed both her hands against the sides of the feline's head. Then sent every once of magic she had left straight into her skull.

The feline’s eyes flew wide in horror, as an incredible amount of magic slammed like a wrecking ball through her skull. Her ear pinned back, as her head exploded, bone fragments and brain matter raining down upon Glimmer. Who had only a moment to absorb the brutality of what she had done. Stunned and covered in the gore of her best friend. She whimpered and sank to her knees, before the headless corpse curled upon the sand. Crumpling upon the ground herself as the light faded from her eyes.

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Finn shook their head and pulled the string, allowing it to spool away and weave its own course along another timeline. Blinking away tears, when their vision blurred. Absorbing the horror they had just witnessed and locking it away. Along with the surge of grief and shame at watching their mother die so brutally again. Shoving it all behind an impenetrable wall deep inside their mind. Refusing to dwell on the painful echoes of their own timeline that

howled inside their heart. From witnessing similar tragic events, of their mother's death.

As their sight cleared, they traced backwards along another thread. That was curled around the thicker weave of the main timeline. Continuing to sift and pull away the poor outcomes from the thread. Allowing them spool away on their own course. That always seemed to end in Glimmer and Catra's mutual destruction…but only when Glimmer was unable to teleport the rest of them out of danger.

This Catalyst…would need to be amended upon the new weaving.

Tracing their finger's back along the thread further, containing different choices and thus more different outcomes. Timelines where Glimmer managed to teleport them all away before Catra reappeared. Timelines where Glimmer teleported to get Adora. Timelines where it was only Catra and Glimmer who teleported to Mermista and Orion. In which Orion was the only casualty. Timelines in which Mermista sacrificed herself to save her little brother. Separating the better outcomes and attaching them to their fingertips, leaving the bad outcomes to fall away from the tapestry.

Glimmer's teleport of the group from the skiff….another catalyst… to be adjusted.

The skiff...a crossroads…a twist and turn..an unraveled knot…they continued ever backward.

Until a stray thread pulsed against their skin, like the beat of war drums. They unraveled the string of fate from the thread. Curious and with a centering breath, they allowed themselves to be absorbed by this new timeline. The hum of the deep magic vibrating forlorn and desperate, against the wild, untamed flames of rage and betrayal.

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A fierce world of fire sparks surrounded them. Pulsing with the heartbeats of two soul's forever locked in combat. The fires flared, blinding in their intensity, cacophonous in their consumption of the world around them. As the deep magic countered with a resolute need to quell the pain fueling those flames. Glowing just as intensely, swallowing the flames in cleansing light.

Thus the two eternal forces vying for dominance over the other, continued their war. Righteousness and fury, devouring the entirety of the world.

"Prime!" She-Ra shouted into the wall of flame, it had been years since had used her real name. In her mind Catra was dead, long dead. Her spite and resentments, breaking their already fragile friendship. Her need to prove herself superior, at the cost of everything and everyone around her. Until there was nothing of her left, consumed by her ambition, her greed for power.

Had shattered Adora's hope that she could reach her, save her from herself.

Adora had come to terms with that, mourned her for a time and then moved on…she let her go…

She-Ra stood in her original, armored form. Ice cold blue eyes, glowing with a fearsome light. The golden radiance of her hair pierced through the heavy smoke. Tied back and braided down her back. It resembled a glowing comet, streaking through the darkness as she rushed towards her enemy. Her golden breastplate was dented and stained with blood from enduring one gruesome brutal battle after another. The blue gem glowing faintly within the star crest.

The wings on her battle crown were scratched and bent, the red gem pulsing with her fury. The broader, thicker First Ones sword gripped tight in her fists. The blade was cracked all the way down

to the hilt. Long webbing scars of being reforged marred the once smooth surface. The dull blue gem embedded in the hilt, glinted sharply, in the firelight. As she glowered with a simmering wrath into the fire, jaw clenching, grinding her teeth. Scanning the fire's raging around her for her foe. Her final adversary, once she was dead. Etheria would be cleansed of the Horde.

Her mission would finally be done and she could rest…

But at what cost? Etheria was in ruins…the war had left nothing but death and desolation across the mainland, scorched the sea's and blackened the skies.

Years of fighting and losing everything and everyone she had ever cared about. Had hardened Adora into this…a weapon. Fearsome and unyielding. Always pushing forward, driven by her single purpose for living. Her only reason to keep going, never ceasing in her mission to rid the universe of every fragment of the Horde.

She had long since left her moral's behind, her righteousness was next to follow as well as her sanity. All there was…was the mission…hunt…kill…destroy them all! Every Horde soldier, every sympathizer, every clone…Search and destroy them all…there was no turning back, no rest, no absolution for her own sins, that she had willingly made along the way.

Only the hunt…only vengeance…

"Die! Rebel Scum!" Catra snarled from concealment within the flames. Her voice was strange, staticky and modulated. Too many voices crashing inside her brain.

A Demon born of darkness, had latched on first inside the Portal dimension. Corrupting her magic, before she even knew she had any.

She had come back changed, her fury at the world now twisted into a heinous hunger for even more power. She had killed Hordak and taken over the Horde army. Pushing deeper and deeper into alliance territory all while taking the coast of Salineas. Her war

tactics were flawless, her cruelty unmatched as she decimated one village after another. Leaving no one alive, as she increased the pressure on Bright Moon. Taking territory at a relentless pace. Until the Alliance had lost so much ground and were on the verge of losing the war. Desperate they had sought out a new, untested and limitless source of magic. One they thought would give them the advantage over the new Horde Lord. In the end their stupidity to trust Shadow Weaver had killed them all. With all the princesses devoured by the Heart, nothing would stop Catra from taking over the planet. But her ambition of conquest was stalled… as she was taken prisoner by Prime. He had been quick to chip her and download his consciousness into her mind. Now over a year later, the control chip was now fused with her nervous system. An insidious parasite inside her mind. Prime had sought to take the Heart for themselves and use it to fortify their hold upon the galaxy. The war between Prime and She-Ra upon Ehteria's soil had been devastating. She-Ra was the only resistance left, the rebellion was all dead and the planet was on its own deathbed. All casualties of their vicious war.

As they were always evenly matched…

Prime had sought to obtain even more power when he found out about Catra's connection to fire magic. Pushing her to attune herself to Adarion before she was ready. She was merely a means to an end, she meant nothing. She was just his puppet, his slave… forced to comply, to supplicate herself to his bidding.

So the fire magic was quick to overpower her already fractured sanity and shatter it completely.

She had been suffering for far too many years…

Chaos!

Pain!

(Make it stop)

Becoming this pathetic shell…

Death!!!!

Oblivion!!!

(Kill me)

What was left of her soul, howled and pleaded for it all to end.

Peace!

Freedom!

(Please)

She begged the universe.

Exploding from the swirling storm of smoke rolling around She-Ra.

Catra's body shrouded in flame, malicious pupil's as brilliant as stars. Burning within the depths of her glowing green eyes. Green tendrils webbed across her face. Lips twisted into a vengeful snarl. Her short mane was thin, hanging limp and dull around her ripped and torn ears. Her cheeks were hollow and bruised from corruption. The tan skin is pale and sallow, a walking corpse from too many years of absorbing toxic dark magic. The stench of decay was thick in the air.

She-ra ground her teeth, the sound like sand between her lips. A painful growl of self loathing, rumbled deep in her chest. That she had failed her, failed everyone. She hated fighting her…even knowing that Catra was gone. It was so incredibly painful to see her once vibrant and beautiful body. So broken and abused. But Adora was resigned to the outcome of this fight, the tension of the mutual hate vibrating between them tight like a band ready to snap.

"There is no one left but us…fighting is futile." Prime taunted. "If you kill this vessel, I will just be reborn in another. Far from this place…you can not kill one who is eternal. Why not join me? Be

my champion and aid me in bringing my light to the rest of the universe?”

“Never!” She-Ra, bellowed. Parrying Catra’s claws with the sword of protection and shifting her stance. To swing the sword down in a desperate attempt to cleave her in two. Catra cackled and leaped out of reach.

“Always so slow.” She taunted, curling her finger in a come hither gesture. Then raised her hands and called down a rain of fire upon She-Ra. The fallen champion dissipated her sword and called upon her shield. Crouching low and hiding beneath the wide metal barrier. As the meteors crashed all around her, exploding the ground around her like a barrage of tank fire.

She-Ra held her position, waiting for the attack to ease. Before bursting from her crouch. She-Ra’s speed and power was unmatched, as she covered the few yards between them like a bullet made of flesh and bone. Transforming her shield back into her sword and thrusting it through Catra’s chest before she could even react.

Catra hung off her blade, mouth open and gasping. Her eyes wide in shock and horror at being out maneuvered. This battle had been going on for days, it was only a matter of time before one of them made a mistake. This vessel proved to be unworthy of their essence.

(Disappointing) Prime’s consciousness mused, fading away to claim another vessel elsewhere. The fragment of the Nameless one was disgusted at how weak this living conduit was and departed back into the timeless dimension. Adarion was confused, the Rune Bearer had been broken long before she tried to absorb their full magic. The match was ill fated and their essence returned to the core of the Sun.

A soft, grateful smile pulled upon Catra’s lips, as she watched her blood trickle down the broad blade of She-Ra’s sword.

Finally she had won…she was free….

“Ca…..Catra…” Adora’s voice was breaking with heart rending sobs.

Catra looked up, her mismatched eyes soft and shimmering with tears. Her tattered ears pinning back against her head. As she confronted her long lost best friend. She looked older…far too many scar’s across her face.

Did she do that?

“Hey…Adora…” Catra croaked out weakly, trembling hand reaching up and cupping Adora tenderly on her wet cheek. The blonde looked absolutely devastated to find her best friend skewered upon her sword.

“It’s going to be ok…I got you.” Adora nodded, bravely. Struggling to maintain her She-ra form, she eased Catra to the ground and pulled out her sword. Tossing it away in disgust, it clattered into the smoke and disappeared.

Her transformation dissolved, yet her blue eyes glowed with an inner light all her own.

“We promised to be together at the end of the world…” Catra breathed out in a trembling whisper, as the sword pulled free. Her body sagging against Adora, as blood started to gush out of her chest. Adora was quick to kneel down and cradle Catra naked body, tenderly in her lap.

Adora’s red jacket was soiled with mud and blood, the wing pin lost long ago from her belt. Replaced by a simple metal clip, of an unassuming circle. Catra valiantly, attempted her smart ass smirk. It came off more like a wilting grimace of pain instead. “Never thought, this was how it was going to go.” She groaned, rolling her head into the crook of Adora's neck. Taking a long, comforting sniff of her scent.

It had been so long…since she was this close to the blonde.

Her strong, soothing embrace surrounded her…holding her like she mattered.

"I'll heal you…" Adora whimpered, it was a false promise she knew it. She had never learned how to use She-Ra's magic like that. So focused on only learning how to fight and get stronger.

"Dummy…" Catra chuckled, her tired voice sounding more like a gurgle as she was now drowning in her own blood.

"I'm sorry…" Adora cried, broken heartrending sobs exploding from her chest. "please stay…" A sharp gasp for breath and a shudder, desperately willing the healing light from the depths of her bitter, shriveled heart. "I need you.." She whimpered, hiccuping and holding Catra against her chest. As the feline was growing cold, she could no longer feel the faint breath against her neck. "To…to…to..stay. " Adora stuttered, pleading desperately for the universe to show her mercy. To grant her this one wish, to save her best friend…to bring her back so they could finally mend things…as they were always meant to be together.

"PLEASE…don't leave me again!" Adora raised her face to the smoking sky and screamed. As Catra's dead body hung limp and lifeless in her arms.

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Finn snapped their fingers away from the string as if it was a live wire. Revolted and deeply disturbed by that bleak timeline. They shivered and shook their hands aggressively, seeking to shake off the ill feelings from that timeline from their skin. Then with a resolute nod, they took their claw and severed the thread from the loom. The string fell away, shriveling like a dying vine, turning to stardust and floating way into the ether.

“Finn!” Razz shouted in reprimand, their translucent hand snatching theirs by the wrist. “That is not up to you to decide which timeline should be destroyed.”

Finn narrowed their eyes with consternation. As the fierceness of Razz’s reaction was unexpected.

“It was a cancerous timeline…” Finn defended, “I could not allow it to continue.”

Razz huffed, “You continue to be reckless with your magic…I can not protect you from the repercussions.”

Finn merely shrugged. “That is for Future Finn to deal with.” They had nothing to lose anymore as they had already lost everything. So they were determined to make sure the tapestry was as perfect as possible.

Razz groaned and rolled her eyes. Already the young feline had resurrected their sassy tongue and unearned confidence. Razz would now watch them more closely, as they sifted through the threads.

A peaceful half light surrounded them. As if both dawn and twilight had merged to create some, languid world of in-betweens. A mist hung heavy in the air, thick and impenetrable as a cloud bank. Enshrouding this world in a protective shimmering fog. Soft sounds whispered from within that serene, atmospheric fortress. Voices speaking in low tones of discovery and amazement.

“I found you…Elidor.” Catra’s voice breathed, love lost then reborn stirring within her. As the gentle. tranquility of moonlight, washed over her.

“Adarion…” Glimmer’s voice responded in a trembling hush. Her whole body warmed by the passionate flame of the Sun, once more.

Finn’s stomach knotted, as the timeline unfolded in their mind’s eye.

Trapped on the Velvet Glove for months, with only each other to rely on. Their animosity had slowly turned into a reluctant truce, then silent respect, deepening into a friendship, then twisting into a co-dependency. Both imprisoned but on separate sides of that force field. Always under surveillance, Prime used any means necessary to get what he wanted. The Queen would suffer daily interrogations, her life being threatened, tortured by images of her loved ones back on Etheria fighting for their lives. Prime was slowly, insidiously breaking down the Queen of Bright Moon. While Catra would plead for both their usefulness, spinning half truths and lies about the Ultimate Weapon that lay at the heart of Etheria, keeping them both in Primes good graces. Knowing that he would kill them without remorse if he found no use for them. So months went by. They had kept each other’s spirits up, offering each other reassurance that they would escape, see Etheria again. Catra had promised to find a way for them off the Ship since she had the freedom to walk around the corridors. Glimmer for the first time, began to trust her.

In the end Catra never found a way for both of them to escape. So she had to sacrifice herself to save Glimmer, teleporting her off the ship. Apologizing for everything, pleading for Adora to get Glimmer home. But Glimmer had refused to leave her behind, advocating that Catra had changed, that she only wanted to rid the universe of Prime, the same as them. It was enough to convince her friends and they had gone back for her.

Adora had lost She-Ra when she destroyed the sword. But that never quelled her bravery, she valiantly allowed herself to be taken prisoner. Just so Glimmer could free Catra.

In this timeline, Adora never transformed, she managed to knock the chipped Catra out instead. Then she had carried the limp magicat in her arms back to Darla. Fighting off the clones along the way, with her bow staff. Unfortunately they had lost Adora to Prime during the rescue, as she was eventually overpowered by Primes clones. She had sacrificed herself to hold the clones off long enough for them to escape on Darla. It would take several more months of slow travel across the galaxy to get back to Etheria. During that time, they would uncover Pirmes weakness, retrieve Melog and free Adora from Primes clutches. Entrapta had experience freeing Catra from Primes chip, so getting the chip off Adora was easy.

Catra and Adora were able to heal their friendship but it never went beyond that.

There was just too much heartache between the both of them to want to ever take that next step. By that point, Catra's heart belonged to Glimmer, anyway. Adora was never able to find She-Ra again. So Shadow Weaver took the Failsafe to the Heart and released the magic. Absolving herself of her evil ways by sacrificing herself for Etheria. After Primes defeat, Catra had returned to Bright Moon to help rebuild the planet. It was during those months of reclamation that their affections began its first, awkward steps towards love. The timeline unfurled in a similar manner, as the Princess dealt with the freed magic of Etheria. Catra began her journey to uncover her past and laid claim to her Rune Bearer's heritage. Adora left for Crystal Castle with Entrapta to uncover the secrets of the First Ones. While Glimmer, Bow and Catra continued to travel across the planet uncovering Catra's past and the mysteries of Hybrid magic.

When Catra sought to attune her soul to Adarion. The full magic power was willingly sought… During her time in Bright Moon under King Micah's tutelage she was ready to claim her magic. With confidence and self assurance, no longer burdened by her sins. With Glimmer at her side, they attuned themselves to the Dualities of Light….together.

Becoming the Sun…and the Moon.

Glimmer and Catra stood nude before one another, the shimmer of the air behind them was like that of a looking glass. In which a being of soft moonlight and a being of pure flame stood in the same nervous, uncertain pose as their mortal vessels.

Catra had her trembling hands cupping Glimmer's cheeks, staring down at her with such a profoundly tender expression. It clenched even Finn's chest with the unwavering sincerity of her joy. While Glimmer shivered in Catra's arms, face inclined upward. indigo eyes, moist with unshed tears. The devotion in her loving gaze was unmistakable.

"I am so, so, sorry…the portal was so sudden…I never meant to leave you." Glimmer sobbed, her voice thick with anguish.

"My love for you never ceased. I cradled your light close, casting it through my own body to light the darkness within the shadow dimension we were all trapped in…I became the Day Moon…" She professed, "I kept Etheria…alive in your absence."

Catra sighed, forgiveness and understanding quickly given. "I have missed you. Precious Moon. " Her eyes were intense, searching Glimmer's soft gaze for permission. As she slowly leaned down and pressed her lips tentatively to Glimmer's.

Glimmer responded instantly, curving her entire body into Catra's and eagerly returning the kiss. Catra's mouth was gentle, arms quickly surrounding the shorter woman. Holding her close, stroking up and down her arching back with her claws.

Adarion had longed for their love for so long. Tears stung Catra's eyes, as she once more held her love in her arms. Elidor had been ripped away from them, so suddenly, for over a thousand years. Leaving them lost and so, very, very lonely.

They didn't know what had happened…one moment Etheria was there. Warmed and thriving by their light. Then emptiness…

Adarion pulled away, Elidor's body once supple and bending in her arms now ridgid. Adarion was bewildered by the sudden shift in their love's demeanor.

Glimmer looked up at her, through strands of soft pink hair that had fallen over her shimmering eyes. Her heavy dark eyelashes were sparkling with moisture. Her chin was trembling in Catra's hand, as the feline cradled her face in her palm. Deeply concerned by Elidor's trepidation at her affection.

Catra smiled down at her, lips slightly curved upward. Warm and genuine, disarming Glimmer's reluctance with the purity of her adoration for her. Slowly, Catra's long tail curled around Glimmer's wrist. Offering the shorter woman even more assurances that she was cherished.

The doubt and worry in Elidor's eyes cleared, assured that their abrupt departure from the cosmos had been absolved and that their affections would not be rejected by Adarion.

Glimmer reached out and gently caressed Catra's cheek, tracing the trail of tears with her fingertips. That were tears of relief, that had been flowing, unrestrained. Down from her shimmering mismatched eyes, ever since Glimmer had kissed her.

Glimmer eyes closed at Catra's tender fingers, as she returned the gesture. A breathless hum escaping Glimmer's sweet smile. While Catra admired the gentle beauty of her love. Tracing her claws softly down the tear tracks, rolling down Glimmer's rosy cheeks. Down her arching neck to her collar bone, then downward to between the hollow of her breasts, before finally stopping and drawing her hand back.

Adarion's heart was pounding in her chest, as Elidor slowly opened her eyes. Resting her hand on Catra's chest,. Affirming Adarion's devotion for her, by feeling her powerful heartbeat. Catra drew in a sharp, stuttering breath and began to tremble as well. It had been so long since she had felt Elidor's magic..it was like coming home.

Overwhelmed by the intensity of all the feelings now coursing through her.

Adarion wanted this…had craved this for over a thousand years. The elemental force bound to fire, rose up and flowed outward from her mortal body. Engulfing Glimmer in its warm, passionate embrace.

Glimmer's body in turn began to glow, soft and luminous in its purity in response to the flames. Pulsing with a soft devotion that enveloped Catra.

In that moment of connection, the very fabric of the universe seemed to tremble. The weave responds to the eternal love of dual forces, once more as one.

Giving into mortal desire…

Adarion was so thankful that Elidor was in their arms again, holding them tight. Pressing sweet kisses to their jaw, coming closer towards their trembling lips. Mingling her tears with theirs, as they kissed again, and again and again. Growing more passionate, more demanding. Tongue's swirling and dueling, as they crumpled to the ground. Catra cradled Glimmer slightly beneath her, hovering above her by bracing herself up on one elbow, resting just to the side of her gorgeous face. Catra basked in the beautiful sight. Glimmer's cheeks flushed with arousal, indigo eyes a light with need, lips plump and ready for more affection.

"I love you…" Catra whispered in hushed gasp. Her ear's flickering nervously at the confession, tail curling timidly around her own waist as she laid on her side beside Glimmer.

"Kiss me…" Glimmer responded, turning on her side to lean against Catra's supple body. Reaching up and cupping Catra behind the neck and gently guiding her back down on top of her. The magicat smoothly slotted herself between Glimmer's legs. Tail high and waving happily in the air.

Catra's possessive grin was intoxicating. As she leaned down, kissing her softly. Before nibbling her plump lower lip, coaxing her to open her mouth. When she complied, Catra swept her tongue over hers. Teasing her, with swift, languid strokes. A low, contented purr rumbling from deep in her throat. As she slid her mouth down Glimmer's jaw line, rubbing her wet lips up towards her ear. Where she suckled her earlobe, licking down the shell and then nipping at the sensitive skin of her neck.

"I love you…" Glimmer gasped.

Her purr increased in volume and intensity, as Catra heard her declaration. She became more aroused, more excited by how eagerly Glimmer responded to her affection.

Glimmer moaned and arched against her, beginning to shiver at her feather light touches. As Catra skidded the very tips of her clawed fingers, down and around her bare breast. Smiling with immense satisfaction, as Glimmer shivered more violently. Chill bumps raced over Glimmer's flesh at the teasing caress. Her nipples hardened, brushing sensuously against Catra's bare breasts. Causing the feline to gasp and then widen her smile in delight. As a hungry expression washed over her. Unable to resist, tempted to taste the exquisitely soft skin beneath her. Catra kissed a line down from Glimmer's neck, descending between her breasts and then she lapped at the underswell.

Glimmer cried out in ever mounting pleasure, when Catra finally suckled her nipple.

"Catra…." Glimmer breathed, a pleading sigh, for more.

Catra had unconsciously moved her hand down to cup the sweet heat between Glimmer's legs. She was quick to sheath her claws and hadn't pushed a finger in yet, lingering her palm lightly upon Glimmer's mound. Wanting to take her time, Catra rubbed her longest finger up and down Glimmer's damp folds. Her thumb circled over the willing woman's clit, as Catra's finger tucked itself

barely inside her entrance. A soft tease, that more could be given if she was allowed to explore.

Glimmer response was instant, she cried out and arched upward at the stimulation. Catra chuckled, with pride. Her laughter muffled as she lapped at Glimmer's other nipple. Running her tongue over and round the peak in a leisurely, teasing way. The already hard bud, puckered even more.

Catra trembled, she was close. Just touching Glimmer so intimately had her on the edge. She wasn't going to last much longer, already she was rocking herself against Glimmer's inner thigh. Laying half on top of her, her slight weight pinning the Queen down. As the lusciously supple woman eagerly submitted to her, Catra felt she was trusted, she felt in control. Confident that she was pleasuring Glimmer how she wanted, Catra felt wanted, she knew she was loved…and that was the most meaningful gift she could have ever been given.

Catra nipped gently at the nipple she was suckling, then licked it to ease the sting. Moving to the other waiting breast, sucking the whole crown of the breast into her mouth. Held the suction for a moment, enjoying the taste of the tender flesh.

The beautiful sounds Glimmer was making, as she writhed in pleasure beneath her was intoxicating. There was nothing more exquisite than this! Having her beneath her, touching her, kissing her, exploring her.

Catra barely heard her own moans and breathless pleas, as Glimmer's hands slid into her short mane. Gripping her scalp and digging her nails into the back of her head. Holding her down upon her breast.

"Catra…" Glimmer repeated, again and again as a mantra of mounting pleasure.

The want, the aggressive need…it spurned Catra's thirst to pleasure her to new heights. Catra rolled her hips, pushing her

sex against Glimmer's thigh more aggressively. Seeking that jolt of euphoria that was now just a hair's breadth out of reach.

Glimmer cried out and arched upward, as Catra's finger finally breached her entrance. Thrusting inside of her, as she kissed a path down from her breast to the belly. Glimmer twitched and giggled, when Catra delved her tongue into her navel. It is such a sweet, endearing sound.

"Stars…" Glimmer huffed, grinning down at Catra with a gleefully dazed expression. As breathless moans of rising pleasure stole her voice again.

Catra is mindless with lust now, driven to take their pleasure even further. Kissing her way ever lower, lavishing Glimmer's skin with sweet kisses. As she pushed her finger in and out of her center. Pressing her thumb down on the sensitive nub, enjoying the queen restless bucking. All while she ran her tongue down the inside of her thigh, her lips teasing the now overstimulated flesh between her legs. Pulling out her finger, she rose up on her knees.

Mismatched eyes glazed with desire, a proud grin over her flushed face. As Glimmer huffed in frustration as all her touching abruptly stopped.

"Stop teasing me…" Glimmer pouted. Her full lips, kiss swollen lips thrust out in the cutest most endearing way possible.

"Awww….Sparkles…you know you love it." Catra panted,

" I need you…Catra…" Glimmer pleaded.

Then with a smile of gratification, Catra leaned down, pulling Glimmer's legs up and over her shoulder's. Intent on finally giving the queen what she wanted.

Sinking her sharp teeth lightly into the soft insides of Glimmer's thigh, following it with a soothing swipe of her tongue before grazing her teeth over the queen's clit.

Glimmer sucked in a cold breath, bucking even more violently as Catra's tongue replaced her finger. Catra hummed, delighting in the taste of her. The vibration, sending Glimmer right over the edge. She cried out again, clamping both hands against the back of Catra's head to keep her where she wanted her most.

Catra flicked her tongue over her clit, a rough swipe that had Glimmer bowing off the ground. A sharp, strangled cry erupted from Glimmer's throat. It was urgent, demanding. As she was at the end of her patience and could not handle Catra, teasing her any longer. She is right on the precipice of unraveling completely.

Catra's self satisfied chuckle was muffled when Glimmer pushed her face deeper into her sex. A silent reminder to stay focused. Replaced by a languid sigh of pleasure, acquiescing to the Queen's needs. Glimmer released her head, when Catra thrust two fingers deep inside, enjoying how snug and warm she was. How her walls pulled at them, shivering and trembling around them.

Glimmer pulled her upward by her hair, gently but firmly. Needing her close, desperate to feel her lips once again.

"I want you…" Glimmer sighed, as \Catra crawled up her body, continuing to plunge her fingers in and out of her. When she reached Glimmer's face, smiling in satisfaction at how wild with desire she was. Glimmer yanked her down into a forceful kiss, while Catra was still smiling smugly.

Glimmer's mound bumped against her palm, as Catra pressed her thumb down hard against her clit. Rolling the overstimulated bundle of nerves just enough to feel the walls inside start to clench against her fingers. Catra pumped her fingers in and out at a rapid pace. Pushing them in as far as they could go, curling them and drawing them out. Repeating the erotic movements at a tantalizing rhythm, all while she thrust her tongue deep inside Glimmer's mouth, licking and dueling with hers. As the Queen became completely undone beneath her. Keening in pure euphoria beneath her.

When Glimmer had calmed down and slowly came back to her senses. The hungry, demanding kisses between them turned soft and sweet once more.

“Tell me what you need.” Glimmer panted, breathless and eyes shimmering with affection. Gazing sweetly up at her, as she was slowly coming back to her senses. Catra held herself up, by bracketing the Queen's head between her arms. Her slender feline body was tucked, snugly between Glimmer’s thighs. Long tail lashing happily in the air behind her and her ear’s perked forward at the Queen’s ardent request to please her. Leaning down, a salacious smile upon her feline lips. An errant fang hooking on the side of her mouth.

“You…” Catra responded in husky whisper against Glimmer’s ear. Then began to thrust herself against Glimmer’s core. Staring down at her, eyes glazed with desire. Rubbing herself against Glimmer, at a slow erotic pace. Glimmer moved her hips in sync with hers, locking her ankles behind Catra’s ass. As the hybrid worked herself towards completion. Rocking against her, speeding up her thrusts as she finally felt that delightful flutter inside her core. That soon rippled into spasms and then the euphoric squeeze as her own pleasure convulsed over her body. She curled up, tucking her face into Glimmer’s neck as she cried out, enveloped in the Queen’s intoxicating scent. So soft and alluring, of vanilla and lilac blooms.

The rush of this climax was like nothing she had ever felt before. As the surge of endorphins and magic washed over her. It was painful as much as it was pleasurable. As the element of moonlight within Glimmer, sparked inside Catra’s soul, illuminating all the dark places and casting out all the shadow’s that once lived there. Adarion’s wounded heart healed , once shredded by grief and loneliness was once again whole. Catra’s love flared to life and glowed like a newborn star inside Glimmer’s soul. As Elidor gasped in delight and welcomed them home.

Finn sighed, it wasn't an ideal outcome it definitely would complicate things with their momma. But at least everyone survived…

So they tied the string of fate to the fingertip of their left hand. Before tracing the thread further backward. Until they reached the point of departure from Broland.

They still had the shard then…they still had yet to make plans to the Three Sister's? This…this was the nexus point they would retreat to. Where they could control the catalysts and diverge the timeline towards a more perfect outcome.

"Gran…" Finn turned to the old woman, as their translucent form began to be absorbed by the thread of time. Manipulating the threads course from within, weaving the outcomes tied to their fingertips to knot the new, altered future to the timeline. "I am going to fix things, I promise." They vowed, the strength of determination and commitment to keeping their word was so pure.

Razz was speechless for a time, as she watched them go. Lips thinned to a firm line, resolved that the kitten would have to learn on their own. What the limitations of their magic truly was.

"You find me in the Woods, Dearie, when you are ready to let go. When you are willing to go back to the beginning. " Razz nodded, at the now pulsing thread within the tapestry. She didn't know if the kitten had heard her, but she was confident that in time. They would come to understand the folly of this plan. The old woman turned towards the glowing horizon. Shuffling into the prismatic light and disappearing into the tides of time.

Only time would tell…

Chapter End Notes

One more chapter to go! I decided to break this arc into two or more parts...undecided yet.

Mending

Chapter Notes

> Thank you, PinkStorm, LunaTheBlackWolf and PointlesslyPoetic for your comments. I love reading each and every one. Also thank you to all who left Kudo's.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Finn clutched Peekablue's journal to his chest as they wandered down the beach, headed for the thick forest that crowned the island. The book was freshly reverted to its original state. Thanks to Sweet Bee's magic, she had rolled with Finn's request to fix the waterlogged book. Offering the kitten a small, thin smile. She was worried about Peekablue, but also very angry that he had left her in the dark about his plans. Finn had no answers as to what happened to him after they got separated in the Waste. They were worried too, Skeletor's men were cruel and oftentimes impatient. Resulting in any prisoner getting beaten to a blood pulp, just to extract information. But they had kept that to themselves, if Peekablue did get captured. Sweet Bee did not need to know.

Finn had retreated up to the promontory of the island, as Sweet Bee set sail, upon the King's stolen Galleon. This the highest point upon Broland island and they wanted to be the first one to see their mother's ship close in beyond the Guarding rocks. Mid-morning found them perched upon the canopy of a lone Banyan tree, biding their time with a call from their Auncle DT.

"When we do meet again, kiddo. I expect all my questions answered…I know your hiding things…don't know why, don't really care right now. But know that you will have to come clean about everything eventually. So enjoy yourself for right now." DT advised before cutting the feed.

Finn heaved a huge breath, nodding. They had heard DT tapping their index claw against the metal amulet just out of screen. The chameleon was unraveling their secrets, they would not be able to play obtuse for much longer. Their small hand unconsciously released the side of the pad and flew to the pouch latched around their thigh. Needing to feel the shard, safe and secure in their keeping once again. Taking a quick sniff of the air as a familiar scent wafts in from the neighboring tree further down the hillside. The Pixie's scent had been lurking out of sight, ever since they left the Valley of the Lost. Having followed them across the northern coasts of Etheria up to Sea Worthy. They had also caught the scent on the Galleon here to Broland. So they had been extra vigilant ever since. Finn smiled knowingly, Kei-lee was nearby. No doubt laying in wait for the perfect moment to steal the shard.

"I'll fix things…I promise…" Finn pledged, looking out from the canopy of the lush banyan tree. Towards the far off horizon, the low cloud bank is still glowing with the pastel hues of dawn. As the sky high above was already a soft, warm blue. The sun is shining just above the guardian archway of stone that protects the island. A slow, tender smile pulls upon their lips as they watch their mother's high tech skiff, hovering just beyond the island. The excitement of their reunion. Tempered with the knowledge of what is yet to come. A firm resolve, dims the light in their gentle blue eyes. Steeling the blue into a hard gray tone, so similar to Adora's. When she got serious, determined to always keep her promises. They would make sure that all of their family survived and the cataclysm upon Nora never came to pass.

The late morning sun was hot against their back. As Finn cut the feed to their communication pad after bidding farewell to Double Trouble. Turning and tucking it away in their backpack, they had jammed into a crook of two branches, high up in the sprawling Banyan tree. Then deftly flipping open the pocket, of the small pouch belted to their thigh. That held the shard. Finn pulled it out with nimble fingers, staring at the clear ice blue crystal for a moment. Feigning contemplating their options, as their keen hearing picked up on Kei-Lee's soft bare feet upon the upper branches over their head. Their large dark ear's twitch, slightly, as

their tail curled and swayed beneath the branch they were squatting upon.

“I can’t have, mother taking you this time.” They mumbled, scanning the trunk for a knot they could stash the shard into for safe keeping. Eek crawled out of the hood of their tan cloak. To sun itself atop the fluffy blonde mane of Finn’s head. Flopping their scaly self spread eagle over the top of the child's head with a contented sigh. Fluttering its multicolored wings briefly before tucking them tight to the sides, the lizard's long slender tail coiled around Finn’s dark furred ear. Finn closed their eyes, briefly sending a message to the lizard through their link.

The lizard blinked their third eyelid as they received the child’s visual instructions. Rolling onto their stomach and kneading their tiny claws into Finn’s scalp. Before shimmering invisible and leaping into the air, flying away. Finn grunted, as they found a suitable crack in the bark of the tree. Shoving the shard inside and out of view.

“There…I’ll come back for you soon.” They nodded. Keeping up the ruse, they were oblivious to Kei-Lee’s invisible presence. Now hovering on a branch just above them.

“How’s it going, Lad?” Sea Hawk offered, moving with ease, his steps long memorized in his youth. As he strode beneath the dangling aerial roots, That would one day burrow into the hard packed soil at the base of the tree. To become even more roots for the tree to draw nutrients from the ground. Eventually the shoots would spread down the hillside, sprouting more Banyan sapling’s as the tree spread further into the forest below. This lone, hardy tree that had defied the odds, would one day no longer be alone.

Sea Hawk moved with ease, through the curtain of roots and beneath the crown of branches. Leaning casually against the trunk. Arms crossed over his muscular, well defined chest. One booted foot lifted to balance himself as he leaned his full weight into the tree. Stroking the tip of his mustache as he stared out

between the curtain of leather brown roots. To the endless expanse of frothing waves beyond the cliff.

"Their coming…" Finn muttered, licking their lower lip nervously. As they stared transfixed upon the small boat, floating just beyond the rocks. Their whole body was humming with anticipation.

"Who…" Hawk smiled, feigning ignorance. He knew Finn's story, as outlandish and crazy as it was. The child had confided in him during their journey to Sea Worthy, when Hawk had asked pointedly about the very familiar bandana they wore around their neck. Having memorized that piece of clothing as fondly as a well worn scar. He knew it was his…it was older and far more worn and threadbare than the one in his possession. So he wanted to know how this kitten, who looked so much like two of his good friends, had gained possession of it.

"My Mom's are, Silly!" Finn declared in exasperation, quickly climbing down and snatching Sea Hawk's hand. Eagerly, pulling the red haired pirate away from the tree and back towards the trail that would lead them down to the beach. Cutting their soft blue eyes over their shoulder briefly, when a cloud of sparkles appeared upon the branch they had just vacated. Smiling knowingly, as the first catalyst was rewoven.

Kei-Lee had taken the shard and she would return it to the labyrinth beneath the Oasis. When the Hunter's moon turned red, Finn would be there to complete Peekablue's vision. As soon as they found the Seer's account of it in his diary.

"Ahoy, there friends!" Hawk shouted.

Adora rushed to the starboard side of the front deck, unfurling a rope ladder attached to the side of the railing. As Glimmer disappeared from the command deck, only to reappear in sparkling light beside her on the lower deck. The tell tale chiming

of her magic, announcing her sudden presence. Adora passed her a curt nod and smile, before leaning over the railing.

They found Hawk rowing up to the skiff in a small rowboat, with the blonde kitten standing at the ready on the bow, to climb aboard as soon as they reached the ladder. As their clawed hands curled upon the side of the ladder, they caught sight of Adora, leaning over the side.

Then scrambled up the ladder as fast as they could. Leaping over the railing and into Adora's waiting arms. Eyes bright and moist with tears, a huge gleeful smile spreading over their warm, blushing cheeks. On instinct Adora had opened her arms to catch the leaping kitten. Laughing cheerfully, as the kitten clutched her around the neck with everything they had.

"Momma!" They exclaimed, rubbing their cheek under her jaw in long, enthusiastic swipes. "I missed you…I missed you…I missed you…" They chanted breathlessly with overwhelming joy.

Hawk was startled at first, watching the ladder bang against the hull in Finn's haste to get aboard. Then he merely shrugged, laughing boisterously at the kitten's eagerness to greet their mother.

After he moored the boat to the lower hull of the skiff, he climbed on board. Still chuckling fondly, when he found Finn now standing timidly before Adora and Glimmer. Hands crossed behind their back and shifting on the balls of their feet, staring intently upon the deck. Avoiding answering whatever questions Glimmer had been asking them. While Adora's gaze was transfixed upon the wing pin in their red bandana, that held a deep orange, blue and red crystal fragments embedded into the center. She recognized those shards, as her's and Catra's Runestones…

The ice cold dread that clutched her chest at the sight of the fragments was sobering. All the joy she had felt at meeting her child was washed away, replaced by dark intrigue about what had happened to her and Catra in their future.

Bow was quick to climb down to the main deck and greet Hawk with a joyous shout and firm hug and pat on the back. While Catra remained aloof on the command deck, eyes focused on Finn taking in every detail of the kitten once more. Her mismatched eyes filled with awe and wonder.

"Well, let's get you into the harbor." Hawk clapped Finn on the back, pointing up the main mast. "Get up there and be my eye's, Lad. If we run into trouble let me know."

"Aye, Aye…Uncle!" Finn snapped back. Blue eyes flying wide, eager to be useful. Then they heaved a sigh and scaled the mast with their claws. Climbing up to the top, grateful for the save and able to avoid further questions. Auntie Glimmer was a skilled integrator, at least in their time in the future. Her pointed questions earlier had been, straight forward but also kindly spoken. But they couldn't answer them without compromising their mending of the timeline. Also, her ability to cast a truth spell was definitely a benefit. So they did not want to hang around her too much, in case they ended up on the receiving end of that spell.

Glimmer and Bow were concerned, at the kitten's hasty retreat. Glancing up at Hawk for answers.

"Never meant to intrude, but the cub's got a keen eye and I could use their help, threading the needle is a very precise nautical maneuver." Hawk shrugged, heading to the command deck. Glimmer and Bow accepted his answer for giving the young kitten an excuse to leave.

While Adora took a sharp breath, glancing over her shoulder to Catra. Who was avidly watching the kitten climb up the main mast. They had spent the morning in bed, discussing Finn. The fact that the Finn back in Mystacor had changed, after the island nearly fell out of the sky. How this Finn could not just be a coincidence…that there was something strange going on. Catra had theories, but would need them verified.

When Bow returned to the command deck with Sea Hawk. Catra gave them the helm without a word. Hoping over the railing to the main deck, striding with purpose over to Adora.

"I'm going to get to the bottom of this mystery, Kay." She brushed her hand across Adora's shoulder as she passed by. Her tail curling assuringly around Adora's wrist.

Adora nodded, never taking her eyes off the kitten. Staring up at the tiny metal perch that acted like a crows nest at the very top of the mast. As the cub crouched upon the perch, extending the spyglass then pressing it to their left eye.

When Catra climbed up to stand beside them, the kitten sniffed then stood up stiffly with their back straight. As if Catra had just shouted for them to come to attention. Adora chuckled, at the sight of the two magicats greeting each other so anxiously. The kitten's tail had puffed up, when they smelled Catra. While Catra's long dark tail was flicking in long, agitated swipes. Finn quickly tucked the spyglass in a pocket of their dark shorts. Quick to wrap their offending tail around their waist, and brush down the fur to conceal their panic. As Catra smirked and sat down beside them so they would be relatively the same height.

"Hey, Finn." Catra greeted, softly. Kicking her bare feet over the edge of the platform, keeping her eyes ahead. As the skiff began to slowly float forward towards the largest stone archway with Hawk at the helm.

"Hi…" Finn breathed back, focusing ahead through the spyglass again. As the archway drew near. Obviously avoiding her, as their ability to remain calm and in control of their emotions was very fragile right now. Her tragic fates, through the threads of time still haunting them. Her gentle comforting scent was overwhelming for them.

“I have lots of questions, but I need just one answered for now.” Catra offered.

“Ok…” Finn agreed softly. Swallowing hard, to keep the lump in their throat down and valiantly take the waver out of their voice.

“Back in Old Grimbles barn, you sang a song for me?” Catra began. ”Can you sing it for me now?” She reached up and rubbed their shoulder blades, in small soothing circles. Catra’s eye flew wide in surprise, as her maternal instinct to touch and soothe her kitten surfaced so naturally.

Finn swallowed then smirked, yep. Their mom had it all figured out. That it was ok, that they had lied, disguised themselves as a Thaymorian. That she wasn’t mad, relief overflowed their anxieties and they took a deep breath.

“Grumpy cat, Grumpy cat.”

“She is so very grumpy.”

“You gotta remember, she's got a temper.”

“Scowling and shouting, scaring and snapping, stomping her feet upon the ground.” Finn crooned, with a slowly growing smile of pure happiness. Beaming down at her, baby fangs on full display on their wide grin. While Catra nodded, a tender smile upon her lips, as she stared up at them fondly.

“Causing trouble with everyone, all around.”

“Grumpy cat, Grumpy cat!” Finn finished with a flourish, tossing the spyglass and catching it. Just as the mast passed beneath the archway. As the shadow of the stone passed over them, Finn ticked the spyglass away in their pocket and then sat down beside her. Joyful tears streaming down their cheeks.

“You are definitely my, Finn.” Catra smirked, then wrapped them up in a warm embrace. Combing her claws down their short blonde mane softly, as Finn finally broke. Sobbing uncontrollably

into the front of her white shirt, claws kneading into the fabric just above her heart.

"I'll keep you safe, Mother!" Finn wailed, wrapping their arms around her tight as their small body shook with the force of their wails. Finally after years of grief and loneliness, they could claim their hearts desire. They were once more in the safety and comforting arms of their Mother. That they had lost, the one who had died to protect them. The one they were destined to watch die again and again. They had a second chance to make things right, to save her!

Catra furrowed her eyebrows in confusion, at their blunt and very telling statement. She said nothing, but it was alarming nonetheless. Her cub…this kitten in her arms. They were hurting and so driven to stop whatever tragic fate that lay ahead for her in the future. Sliding her gaze sideways she caught sight of Melog, now sitting at the base of the mast. Their mane was pulsing with blue and white flame, coat dark as coal.

Catra swallowed hard…

The trek down the dock was silent and full of unresolved tension. As Finn marched ahead of them all. Stomping angrily across the deck, with their hands balled into fists at their sides. It was a given the kitten was mad, because Catra was upset as well. She had asked about the shard's whereabouts back atop the crows nest. As soon as they had passed beneath the guardian stones and into the warm light of the bay. Finn had answered as honestly as they could. Stating that they didn't have it anymore, but it was safe. Which was not what Catra had wanted to hear. Their once warm reunion was quick to sour at that point.

Adora kept giving Catra small furtive glances, as Catra fumed silently beside her. Petting Melog's rusty red coat, their mane fluttering like a crimson flame. As she stared pointedly at Finn as they stormed off down the beach. Lost in her anxious worries and never even glancing up at Adora.

“So that's your kid?” Glimmer knocked her shoulder against Catra’s. Jerking the feline out of her tumultuous thoughts.

“Sorta.” Catra hissed.

“I definitely see the resemblance, Horde Scum.” Glimmer responded, with a laughing smile. Catra turned to confront her with an arched eyebrow, silently daring her to finish her obviously caustic statement.

“What pissed them off so quickly?” Bow offered innocently as he came up next to Adora. His blunt comment about Finn’s huffy attitude, unexpectedly completing Glimmer’s statement.

Catra growled threateningly then just rolled her eyes, as Glimmer started to laugh, indigo eyes sparkling with mirth. Bow was confused and his eyebrows furrowed with concern. As he glanced between the two friends. Wondering what social landmine he had just stupidly stepped on?

Adora merely shrugged, the teasing between the two was normal. Glimmer quickly calmed down, when she caught sight of Mermista at the top of the beach. Striding towards the sand to meet the Princess of the Sea, with Bow right on her heels.

Adora gently reached out and took Catra’s hand. Adora’s touch instantly cooled her temper. Catra took a deep breath and then headed after Finn, with Adora.

Finding the kitten sitting atop a large flat rock, jutting out of the edge of the water. The low tide lapped around the stone, as the sea foam rushed in and out. They were kicking their bare feet over the edge. Watching their toe claws cut through the frothing water sending ripples everywhere. The two women silently sat on either side of the kitten. Offering them support and comfort with their presence, not pushing for more.

Catra squirmed and grimaced in disgust, as the wet stone seeped into the fabric against her butt of her black leggings. Adora crossed her legs and leaned forward over her knees,

contemplating the gentle waves crashing around the stone. In time Finn huffed and brushed their hands through their shoulder length blonde mane. It was very Catra, mannerism. Aiming to clear their head and accept the unsavory situation. Stone faced and firm in their resolve to answer their mother's uncomfortable questions. As honestly as they could, without affecting the future too much. They needed the mending to stay the course, lest more knots twist the threads down unforeseen outcomes yet again.

"I'm not from here, exactly." Finn answered breathlessly.

"Then where are you from?" Catra asked, softly. One leg tucked under her wet butt, the other pulled up against her chest. Staring down at the rippling water, crashing against the rock.

"Where or when are you from?" Adora clarified, gently. As she grasped one of Finn's hands. Reassuring them that she wasn't going anywhere no matter the answer.

Finn chuckled and rubbed the back of their head nervously with their other hand. "It's a long…long story…and kinda hard to explain. But for now. Let's just say I am from a different dimension...in time and space..yeah, that sorta fits." The kitten reasoned, nodding in agreement to themselves.

"When we get the time, I want to hear it all. Cause you are honestly freaking me out." Catra retorted bluntly, ruffling their hair playfully.

While Adora squeezed their hand, seeking to ease their anxiety. "We've gotten used to strange stuff happening, but yeah…this is a whole new level of 'strange' for us."

Finn grinned and nodded, content that they were adapting to the concept.

"I promise. " They lied.

"And you will tell me exactly what happened to the Kaydak shard as well." Catra added, bluntly. Adora's eyes flew wide in horror…

what the hell happened to the shard!

“You don’t have it!” Adora exclaimed in fright.

Finn released a long drawn out groan. “It’s safe…I got this…you two just gotta trust me…OK.” They reassured them. Staring back and forth between them with hopeful eyes for understanding.

“I’ll let it go for now.” Catra smirked, leaning back and raising her head to the sky. Acting all casual and nonchalant about the whole thing. Staring up at the warm clear blue sky. Acting all chill about the whole thing. But Adora could see how her right eye twitched, which meant she was literally screaming inside.

While Adora merely sighed heavily, tamping down on her growing anxiety at once again not being in control. Her blue eyes became distant, as she ran endless scenarios in her mind. Her frown deepened, as she furrowed her brows tightly. Eyebrows nearly pressed together. Unconsciously tapping the index’s fingers of both her hands that were braced on the stone behind her in a steady, agitated beat. As she worked it all out. What could they do, honestly…they just met this kid…their kid…who seemed to know them…very well…but to her, they were still a literal stranger. So could she punish them, reprimand them…hold them down until they gave them the shard….or…have Glimmer cast a truth spell… on them?

Catra shot her a pointed look, noticing her very obvious ‘plotting’ face. The blonde had never been very sly, it was apparent she was thinking and thinking hard. Even Finn was growing suspicious by her heavy silence and twisting expression’s of contemplation. The kitten passed Adora a strange glance, then bolted back down the beach.

“Adora!” Catra cried in frustration. Scrambling to her feet, scared the kitten was going to disappear and hide.

“What did I do!” Adora shouted back, indignantly.

“You think too loud! Obviously!” Catra tossed back over her shoulder, intent on catching up to Finn. Adora’s heavy boots thundered up the beach after her.

The blonde was so confused…

Glimmer and Bow were nowhere to be seen, perhaps below deck? Or in the village when they returned to where the skiff was moored. But they found Mermista pacing at the end of the dock, hands on her hips and muttering furiously under her breath. Her brow was furrowed, thinking…strategizing…perhaps. The ocean was churning beneath her feet under the wooden planks, frothing around the thick poles that held the dock in place above the water. The violent agitation of the water gave away that she was obviously brooding over something.

Sea Hawk was nearby, sitting on the frayed top of the worn corner post of the dock, arms crossed and keeping a close eye on the seething water princess. Waiting for his cue to intercede and calm her down. If his timing was off and she found his concern annoying the sea would no doubt retaliate and he would be treading water far out in the bay. Mermista could be as unpredictable and volatile as the sea itself, but he was an experienced sea captain. He could navigate the most treacherous of water’s so dealing with Mermista’s ever changing moods as of late, was child’s play.

At least that’s what he told himself…

Catra was wary and slowed her approach, having been on the receiving end of Mermista’s ire far too often. All earned, she admits bitterly. Adora on the other hand, picked up her pace. Practically jogging up too Mermista to inquire what was going on. Her big heart and tireless courage always pushed her to face any danger head on.

Finn noticed Catra’s unease and easily slipped their hand into her’s. Offering her a warm, reassuring smile when she turned to

regard them. The corner of Catra's mouth pulled up in a soft lopsided smile. At the kid's tender instincts. So much like Adora…

"This is sooooo annoying…" Mermista grumbled, grinding her index fingers in small circles on her temples.

"What's going on?" Adora urged, her tone hard, as if barking a command.

"My father…" Mermista groaned his name like it was a curse. "I had gotten reports that he was rebuilding the Salineas fleet. He only had a handful of ships a few weeks back, basically whatever had survived the war. But now! Now he has a whole damn armada of ships…I have no idea….how he got them built so fast. " Mermista huffed, her story interrupted by the chime of Glimmer's blink. Followed by a massive wall of shimmering sparkles, as a huge amount of stacked crates, barrels and baskets of food appeared on the beach before the dock. Along with Bow, a very short and slight sea elf. She had cyan blue scales and dark teal green fins on her wrists and shins. Simple leather strapped sandals upon her dainty feet, dressed in loose gray slacks and a billowing white collared shirt. A wide, burgundy sash was tied around her waist. She had a black skull cap on her head, hiding if she had any hair or not. A huge dark skinned man, with long dreadlocks. Gold hoops and studs in his ears. Dressed in a dull green, sleeveless vest that was open, showing off his bulky, overly muscular torso. With dark brown pants tucked and folded at the cuffs into thick black leather boots. Standing conspicuously close to Glimmer. The newcomers were both dressed just as roguishly as Sea Hawk…looking even more like pirates…then simple island villager's. Bow was already enamored by them. Staring moon eyed. Up at the large man and his massive bulk of muscle.

The smug smile gracing the Queen of Bright Moon's face was well earned. As she had just proven with her Rune Magic. That it was far more powerful than what the Moon Stone had offered her. By teleporting the entire warehouse of supplies and several people all in one go.

“Bull….Mouse.” Hawk quickly stood up and moved down the dock to greet them.

Mouse moved with a fluid grace, her steps were light and brisk as she walked down the beach. Her large almond shaped eyes were a piercing blue like ice on a clear lake. With a strong, aristocratic beauty to her face, with high cheekbones and a pointed chin. Mouse gave Hawk a curt nod, as she passed by. Heading to the end of an adjacent dock. Pulling out a thin metal chain from around her neck, that now held not only the sharp shell but several other small yet deadly trinkets. From a long razor edged tooth from some kind of Sea beast, two very long, very slender metal picks. She unhooked a hollowed out coin from the necklace and unwound the leather cord that was wrapped around the metal sphere. Spinning the coin high over her head as they reached the end of the dock. The mid morning sun glinted over the metal like a pulsing star, signaling the sloops out in the harbor.

“That was amazing, your majesty.” Bull gushed, moving in even closer to Glimmer’s backside and giving her shoulders a light squeeze of affection. Before swaggering down the dock towards Hawk. Calling out to the man with a thundering roar and pumping a meaty fist over his head. The name Bull suited him in every way. He was a huge man, over six feet tall. With a barrel chest and huge arms, legs as thick as tree trunks.

Glimmer instantly blushed under the large man’s praise. As Bow’s eyes narrowed in irritation. His adoration for the man cooled instantly, as he finally caught on to the man’s ulterior motives to constantly praising and touching Glimmer. Over every little thing she did for the last few hours. The man was obviously attracted to the Queen of Bright Moon and Glimmer so far was soaking up the man’s attention like a thirsty sponge. Bow was not accustomed to dealing with jealousy…his blood was boiling.

Catra, always alert and observant to strangers, caught the less than platonic exchange between the large man and Glimmer as well. Passing Bow a surprised, ‘what the hell’ expression. The archer merely shrugged, grinding his teeth as he turned his back

on them all. Unlatching his tracker pad from his belt and pretending to scroll through some information, as he silently seethed.

Three large sloop's moored themselves to an adjacent dock beside them and a handful of deck hands disembarking from each ship to load them. A lean man with long shoulder length dark brown hair and a scruffy chin. Hopped over the bow of the closest sloop. Wearing only a simple red vest, with black hook and knob buttons. His long, toned arms are covered in island tattoos. Baggy beige shorts tied with a rope, hugging his narrow waist. He was barefoot and wore a severely weathered, brown leather tricorne hat with gold snaps on the wings.

"Monkey!" Bull shouted, as Hawk turned and offered the lanky man a curt nod of greeting. The scruffy pirate tipped his hat, his honeyed hazel eyes alight with mischief as he regarded Hawk and Bull. Heading their way at a quick jog, before Mouse snapped her fingers from the edge of the dock.

"We do not have time for your shenanigans! We need to get these boats loaded and at full sail by high tide!" She commanded, her voice was deep and husky. But soothing, in a silky smooth way. She was heading Monkey's way with brisk steps, her eyes stern. Monkey's shoulders instantly slouched as the playful glint in his eyes dimmed. He nodded and trudged back to the sloops. Taking command of the small brigade of deck hands loading the ships.

"What do you think that old, salty dog had planned?" Bull stood besides Hawk, elbowing him meaningfully.

"Whatever it was, Mouse is keeping him in line for now. But I'd stay on guard if I was you. You are his favorite target." Mermista smirked at Bull.

Bull groaned, "Don't' I know it."

"Those Galleon's and Garracks…they were not newly built." Sea Hawk turned back to the group briefly, getting them all back on

track. Crossing his arms over his chest, as he glanced over to the other dock. Watching as Bull, Monkey and Mouse boarded their sloops. To oversee the supplies getting stashed down in the holds.

Mermista's brief moment of happiness, soured back into a glare towards Hawk. It was then that he promptly fell silent.

"How do you know that?" Adora asked. While Catra and Finn moved past her, something had caught their attention in the water. They cautiously made their way to the edge of the dock. Crouching at the edge, keen feline eyes tracking a flickering shadow moving below the surface. Melog yowled in warning from the deck of their skiff, prowling towards the stern.

Just as Catra and Finn leaned over the edge of the dock to get a better look. A giant splash of water cascaded over them. They hissed and scuttled backward, tail's puffed up to twice their normal size and hackles raised. As sweet melodic giggles echoed from below the dock.

Mermista chuckled softly, her ire forgotten at the sound of mischievous laughter. Passing the two soggy magicats, now sprawled on the dock. She leaned over the edge, her eyes glinting with mirth and her grin was beaming at who floated below.

"Lyra…Ella…you had your fun now get up here. " Mermista called down to the water, with a fake irritated tone.

Adora had her sword drawn the second, Catra and Finn got splashed. Now she watched two teens bobbing in the waves away from the dock. Both had similar tan skin as Mermista, but that was all they had in common. Swimming for shore, their lower half shimmering with the scales and wide fins of mermaids. One tail was a pearly white the other deep aqua blue. Once they reached shore, their tail's faded away as they walked out of the tide. One was slight and overly slender. With long, straight golden hair that had just a hint of curl on the ends. Her clothes were simple, a tight black breast wrap, with a shimmering silver shawl draped

over her shoulder' and pearl blue tights. With a shell pauldron similar to Mermista's tucked under the shawl on her right shoulder, with an elegant harp, carved from pale bleached bones strapped to her back. The other teen was more broad, with toned arms and thick well muscled thighs. Her hair was raven, black. Bouncing near her shoulders in tight ringlets. Wearing flowing sheer blue pants and a deep blue halter top, accented by pearlescent silk draping over each shoulder in a hooded capelet style cape. With shell encrusted bracers on each wrist, a dagger belt hung heavy around her curving hips. The many blades gleaming in the mid-morning sun.

"Who are they?" Adora whispered to Sea Hawk.

"Mermista's younger sisters." Hawk explained with a small smile.

"How many does she have?" Catra whimpered from the dock in dread. As she was now on all fours violently shaking out her mane. Splattering water everywhere, as she shook out her tail as well. Finn quickly followed suit, mimicking their mother's brisk shake. Water droplets misting the air around them. While Adora stood between the two feline hybrids, getting absolutely soaked. Sword lowered in defeat, with a bland, unimpressed look upon her face.

"Well…My dearest Mermista has eight sisters…and four brother's… that I know about." Sea Hawk shrugged, "King Triton was a rather virile merman in his youth and had many liaison's all across the Archipelago." he finished slyly, as Mermista walked briskly down the dock. Her scowl once more firmly in place as she approached her sister's.

Catra whined in dread and flopped onto her back on the dock. Mermista already teased her mercilessly and now it looked like it ran in the family. How was she going to survive…with even more Salineas royalty out to make a fool of her…for their own amusement. Adora was alarmed by Catra's defeatist antic's,

recalling her sword to her wrist before crouching down to console her. Her wet, half deflated hair poof, dripping water on Catra's face. Catra merely sighed, in resignation. Allowing the water to beat upon her forehead for a moment. Before slamming her palms against Adora's cheeks. The blonde's eyes flew wide in surprise, as Catra's eyes gleamed with purpose. Before lunging upward, putting Adora in a head lock and wrestling her down on her knees to the dock.

"You did that on purpose!" Catra accused with an indignant grunt.

"Owww….Catra…" Adora whined, playfully. "I did not."

"Yes, you did, admit it!" Catra grinded her knuckle into the top of Adora's head as punishment for her acting all innocent and obtuse.

Adora merely chuckled knowingly, twisting out of Catra's grasp and dashing away.

Catra heaved a great big breath, casting Finn who was giggling and enjoying the show nearby an endearingly cocky half smile.

"Let's go get that dummy…" Catra commanded, taking Finn's hand and leading them off the dock. To chase after Adora. The group had filed past them during their play fighting and were all now headed up the beach. Finn smiled softly at the tender contact, giving Catra's hand a little squeeze. A low purr of contentment, rumbling from deep in their chest. As their shorter legs pumped faster to keep up with their mother's pace.

They retreated to the open hale for the noontime meal. A large thatch covered patio, attached to a simple cook house in the middle of the beach. The small fishing village was huddled in the softly rolling hills on the top of the beach. The squat huts and larger villa's had similar thatch roofs ascending partially into view behind the curtain of tall grass, fern's and palm trees.

The group sat along simple wooden benches, made of cut pine trunks. Polished and lacquered to withstand the salt water misting up from the shore. The long tables were scavenged planks from sea vessels, gray and weathered. Now covered in platters of freshly grilled fish and roasted vegetables from the village gardens. With baskets of fresh sweet rolls decorated on top with icing that was sweetened with honey and bowls of colorful island fruits lining the center of the table.

Sea Hawk was quick to explain that the local's working around the docks would come here for their meals. Paying a weekly sum, to partake in the cookhouses daily buffet. The hale was thankfully empty, when they had arrived.

Catra was already on high alert, preparing for the worst. Even though she hadn't yet felt any animosity from Sea Hawk's companion's. As they had never interacted and the introductions had been brief. It didn't mean the rest of the local's hadn't heard of her, or know what the Butcher of Salineas looked like. So she strategically took a seat near the end of the table on the outside facing the beach. Needing an easy exit if lunch went violently down hill. Adora instantly dug into the repast, with the vigor of a starving woman. Finn sat between her and Catra, nibbling on a sticky bun lost in thought. As Catra's tail whipped back and forth merrily as she salivated over her large helping of fish. Glimmer and Bow sat on the other side of the table, with Bull and Mouse. Monkey was leaning against a roof pole near the polished wooden island just outside the kitchen. His gaze was non threatening but shrewd. As he slowly took in Hawk's new friends with an air of nonchalant appraisal.

Bow had placed himself beside Bull on purpose, ushering Glimmer beside him and as far away from the muscle bound pirate as he could. Keeping a close eye on the man, in case he tried to flirt with Glimmer again.

Unfortunately it didn't take long for a handful of local fisherman to wander up to the hale. Speaking in low, conspiratorial whispers.

Scrutinizing the group with casual looks, that turned into lingering glares of loathing towards Catra.

On the far side of the table deeper into the hale. Closer to the rest of the inner tables. Sea Hawk sat in veiled boredom, he had an elbow braced on the table, palm cupping his jaw. While his other arm was draped casually over his lap under the table, hand gripping the hilt of his rapier at his hip. He kept a close but discrete eye of the fishermen who had come to retrieve a sandwich or two. Their courage to confront Catra quickly doused, when each one noticed Sea Hawk's hand was on his sword. They left swiftly back to the docks.

Catra had become smaller and more withdrawn as the meal continued. As more and more locals filtered in to gather some food, never staying long. Ear's twitching and tail lashing became more and more aggressive. As Finn began to scratch a claw nervously into the table top. Keeping their eyes downcast, as their ears perked up and tail dropped low as the tension in the hale mounted. Adora was sitting on the other side of Finn, lunch long forgotten. Her back was stiff and biceps twitching, as she rested her crossed arms on the table. Her whole body was primed to strike, if any of the local's made any aggressive moves towards Catra. She would be out of her seat and protecting her in an instant. She couldn't hear the whispered slurs they made towards Catra but she was as observant. Enough to notice how Catra's excitement over her meal had dwindled, how she curled forward towards the table and her ear's constantly flicking towards the steady flow of new arrivals. Glimmer and Bow were sitting across from her and their situational awareness was primed. Bow kept an eye on the more rowdy young men, jostling each other near the kitchen island. Feigning disinterest by slowly chewing on a mango slice. Glimmer fidgeted in her seat, wiggling her butt anxiously whenever one of the fishermen walked too close to the table as they exited the hale.

Mermista kept tonguing her front teeth in agitation, focused on her sister's. Who sat near the end of the table near Sea Hawk, speaking in hushed tones at first. Before Mermista groaned and

crossed her arms on top of the table and slammed her face down into her arms with a dramatic cry of absolute horror and despair.

Which got everyone's attention instantly.

“Care to share with the rest of us?” Catra arched an eyebrow pointedly as she firmly regarded Mermista. Now avidly ignoring the young sailor’s, taunting each other to confront her. She would not retaliate if the villagers decided to attack her. But she would defend herself…so her ear’s remained perked upward listening.

Adora’s mouth was full so all she could do was grunt in agreement. Refusing to let the other unruly patrons disrupt her meal any longer. But her once bright and eager eyes towards the food, had grown hard and wary. Keeping a very close eye on the fishermen as they came and went.

“We’re here to help.” Glimmer offered, “I could call in more princesses if you need?”

“Brojee and Drissi are scavenging abandoned Horde tech around the canyon’s in the Crimson Waste with Darla.” Bow shrugged,”I could have them here asap?”

“No…more people would only draw more attention to us.” Mermista sighed, bracing her chin in a palm as she sulked. “Most of the archipelago hates me already.” she grumbled under her breath.

“We were doing recon, around the Royal Island. Salineas has a very large Meadowland air base. Set up just beyond the rubble of the Sea Gate. We spoke to Aquarius, it seems our father’s new fleet of ships was funded by Meadowlands.” Lyr smiled sadly, brushing her golden hair back behind her ear as she daintily forked up a bite of fish from her plate.

“The Andreenids are xenophobes?” Glimmer stated in shock.

“Why would they care about helping Salineas?” Bow brow furrowed in contemplation.

“Sweet Bee, recognized the ships your father has positioned as a blockade at Sea Worthy.” Sea Hawk added, finally having a chance to explain.. “They are over a thousand years old…once stored in the Meadowlands archives.”

“So King Buzz is now allied with your father?” Glimmer tapped an index finger anxiously against the table.

“I guess…” Mermista shrugged.

“But why…” Adora grumbled, finally chewing enough to swallow her mouthful.

“He wants something…obviously! I just don’t know what…yet.” Mermista heaved herself up from the table. Casting her sister's pointed looks of silent command, who merely nodded and strode away down the beach. Wading into the water and disappearing into the waves.

“Anyway. I’ve got more important things to focus on right now. The resistance has to guard these aid supplies. As we hop islands, for the next few days. We’re headed to the southern arm of the Archipelago.” Mermista explained.

“Resistance?” Glimmer muttered to Bow. Bow merely shook his head just as confused.

“Falcon?’ Mermista turned to Sea Hawk with an inquiring look.

“I met with a couple of his crew back in the valley of the lost, made them your offer. “ Sea Hawk shrugged, non committal to any kind of straight answer.

When Mermista rolled her eyes and groaned in annoyance. Sea Hawk aimed to placate her. “He’ll send word in his own way, if he accepts. Dearest.” He assured her. She merely nodded, resigned to wait as she had no other choice.

“So let's get going, my people can’t rebuild without these supplies.” Mermista declared, heading back towards the dock and

the now fully loaded sloops.

Bow and Glimmer all shared a concerned look, before scrambling after Sea Hawk. The fact that Mermista had formed a Resistance movement against her Father did not bode well. How destabilized was Salineas? Bull and Mouse followed the dethroned Princess of Salineas back to the boats. While Monkey hung back, watching Catra closely. As he slowly finished up the banana he had been eating.

Catra was hesitant to follow, sitting stiffly at the table watching the rest leaving. Her tail curled tightly around her stomach, as she stared forlorn down at her twiddling fingers in her lap. Adora had heard the harsh whispers from the local's but couldn't really make out what they were saying. But Catra had… her ears never stopped twitching and she had barely ate. Whatever had been said, it had hurt and left her wallowing in her regrets once more.

Adora understood how hard this was going to be for her…to be here. Among people who hated her, had every right to despise her for what she had done. To want to seek retribution for the destruction of their homes, the deaths of their loved ones.

Adora was about to reach out and reassure her, when Finn climbed into Catra's lap. Straddling the older magicat and cupping her cheeks in both of their smaller hands. Forcing Catra to look up at them.

"Look at me, Mother. You can't change the past and it hurts. I know. " Finn cringed inwardly at how hypocritical that sounded. Since they had just done that. But they couldn't change everything. Quickly they shrugged off their guilt, some pain and suffering was necessary to mold their mother into the honorable Queen she would one day become. "But you need to move on from it, learn from it. Your future's not set in stone, you have the power to change it. Just like you had the power to change yourself…right?" They declared earnestly, giving her squished cheeks a shake. "This is your chance to make things right, I believe in you…it's time to start carving out your legacy. "

“Finn…” Catra mumbled, pulling their hands off her face gently. “Thank you…” She sighed, offering them a small smile of gratitude. Once again, this kitten, who seemed far wiser than they should be at their age. Put it all into perspective in only a few choice words. She needed to be brave…right now.

Finn nodded and hopped off her lap, dashing for the edge of the open hale and offered their mother a gloved hand.

“Are you coming?” Finn asked with a radiantly adorable grin.

Adora and Catra laughed and quickly left the table. They each took one of the kitten’s hands and swung them playfully between them as they made their way down the beach.

Monkey followed them at a discrete distance.

It was late afternoon before the three sloops were finished being loaded and they were ready to set sail. They had decided to split up, leaving Bow’s high tech skiff at Broland. Finn had made a very observant point, that the skiff would stand out and bring far too much attention to them. The water’s were far more dangerous now, with the Royal fleet absent. Marauder’s and pirates had been far more bold as of late, preying on merchant ships between islands. Taking advantage of the situation, as merchant ships were now unprotected. So they had to be as stealthy as possible while sailing around the islands. Not wanting to draw any attention to the aid shipment. Meant blending in as much as possible to the average shipping traffic. Hence, the plain, unassuming Salinean sloops. They were sleek and they were fast! Agile in tight places around the coves and water breaks they could easily out maneuver larger ships. Able to glide in and out of the barrier rocks along the shallows. But they had no cannon’s…so the Princess and crew would have to defend their decks if they got attacked.

Mermista and Sea Hawk were aboard Bull’s ship heading for Morta, while Glimmer and Bow joined Monkey’s crew for Dewma.

Which left Adora, Catra and Finn to board Mouse's vessel headed for Nora.

Catra stood at the bow of the sloop, as the sun descended slowly towards the horizon. Staring with trepidation down at the sea shell amulet clutched in her hand. That Mermista had given her before boarding the ship.

"Here." Mermista thrust a round, spiral shaped shell at Catra. That was hung upon a long leather string.

"What is this for? Where did you get it?" Catra instinctively answered, her natural mistrust making her not reach out for the piece of jewelry at first.

Mermista groaned, shaking the necklace at her impatiently.

"It's a glamor, I sold my voice to a Sea Witch." She spat sarcastically.

Catra merely arched an eyebrow, offering her a slight lopsided smile of reluctant acquiesce at her lame joke. Before finally reaching for the necklace.

"It's to keep you safe…or whatever." Mermista tossed back, with a flippant wave of her hand as she walked away. "You can't just waltz around Salineas, right now. Cause like, everyone will try and kill you on sight."

Catra groaned and nodded. "Butcher of Salineas, got it." She mumbled sadly and with a heavy sigh stuffed the necklace into the pocket of her leather jacket.

Her gaze fell inward, as she lowered her chin to her chest. Contemplating the coming days as she stared down at the deck. Then heatedly crammed the necklace back in her pocket. Revolted at the idea of having to hide and loathing her past self.

Salineas was in ruins, the largest, sentry island that once protected the rest of the Archipelago was no more. The royal

city's dockyards were gone, the castle had been reduced to rubble, the sea gate destroyed. The villages along the southern and northern coasts, flattened and burned to the ground. The survivor's…thanks to the Princess Alliance evacuation efforts. As the Horde army advanced along the coasts. Were scattered all over Etheria and the smaller islands. Now those islands are overpopulated and are barely surviving. Catra cringed with a massive amount of guilt. Her claws from her crossed arms digging into her biceps. As she cringed, and pinned her ears back in remorse. The Salinean's suffering right now was all her fault. Her ruthless need for power and conquest created the tragic ripples now affecting the Archipelago.

She quickly tamped down on her self loathing, refocusing her resolve towards figuring out ways to make amends instead. Mermista had gathered what aid she could from Plumeria, Dryl and Bright Moon. It was mostly food and medical supplies, some generator's. Basic survival gear. The bulk of the building material and more high tech equipment from Scorpiana was still blocked by the king's fleet. So Mermista had her work cut out for her to protect the Archipelago. The islands loyalties were also divided, most were loyal to Mermista's father as the rightful king of Salineas. While a handful remained loyal to Mermista. The power struggle amid the islands was highly volatile and skirmishes between loyalists and the resistance upon the sea's was a common occurrence.

Catra refused to get involved in that, she caused enough damage. So her highly tactical mind remained focused on planning ways to get Scorpania's aid out of Sea Worthy. With the King's fleet none the wiser. But those schemes would have to wait until Scorpia got back from the Dark Edge. Perhaps she could get Lonnie on the communicator? Work out some alternate supply routes, for the aid currently on standby at the border outpost at the edge of Scorpania, to be transported up to the old Horde Naval base near Scorpion Hills? A freighter could travel down the Serpentine Straight. It wasn't ideal, it was a longer more convoluted route out to the Growling Sea…it would take time but the supplies would eventually reach Broland island. From there they could

divide it up onto a few more sloops. Highly agile vessels, capable of great speeds. Which was why Mermista was using them to transport aid. But they were not armed…not like a Horde Battleship. She would need to take into account the pirates, the marauder's and even the loyalists. That would want to steal the supplies. Salineas had become as unlawful and treacherous as the Crimson Waste since the Sea Gate was destroyed…those sloops would need a tactical escort…how many warships were still functioning back at the Naval base? But how would that go over… Horde ships protecting Resistance sloops… Maybe they could hire a few armed merchant vessels to transport the supplies instead?

Taking a deep breath, as her thought's derailed once more. She slowly raised her gaze from the deck. Staring off to her left, over the stern and to the south. Catra spotted the two other sloops. The sleek boats were cutting through the waves. Beyond those ships, Catra could see the jagged silhouette of Salineas on the far off horizon. The image grew blurry, as her eyes filled with regretful tears. Catra releases a long mournful sigh, closing her eyes as a couple tears escape to fall down her cheeks as she casts her face skyward. The weight of her crushing guilt washed over her. Causing her chest to tighten as her heart ached, taking one shaky breath after another as she struggled to calm down. How did she fix this? So much loss, pain and suffering was caused by her hand…it was too much, how did she move forward and make things right?

When she opened her eyes. She focused on the clouds overhead. Which were thin, bleeding across the sky in glowing pastel hues of pinks and yellows as the sun set. It was time to sing her evening farewell, she could hear Glimmer's voice upon the wind. As she sang upon the deck of the Sloop gliding further to the west. Her tender, melancholy tune drew Catra's attention back to the present. Catra's gaze turned to the main mast of the neighboring sloop. Finding the pink haired queen. Sitting on the narrow metal platform, swathed in her tan cloak from the Waste. Her bare feet swung, lazily over the side, as she greeted her source of magic as the sky darkened. Elidor rose upon the east as Adarion set upon the west. Giving up the throne of the sky to its counterpart. The

regal might of Etheria’s largest moon was halved tonight. The soft light it cast was not as bright making the ocean murky and almost black.

Catra nodded and turned towards the dark ocean, to watch the final ray’s melting upon the endless waves in the distance. Raising her own voice to say farewell, her wordless serenade full of sadness and faint whispers of hope, that she could find absolution for her sins in the days ahead. That somehow she would find a way to heal the wounds she had caused to all the people she had hurt.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that if for this part. Stay tuned for Kingdom of Secrets!

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